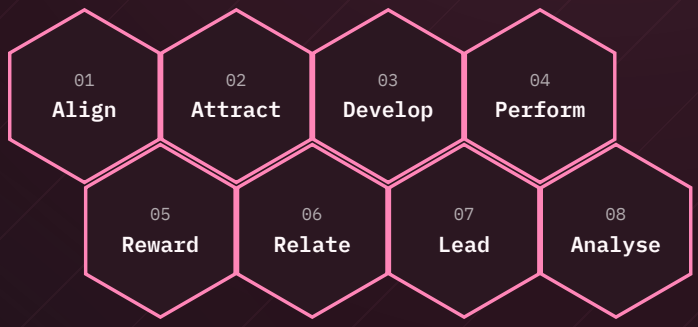
ZHRLS

ZyeemZia™ Human Resource Management and Leadership Specialization

Build the people engine.



ZHRLS

People & Leadership

COURSE BOOK · WORKBOOK · EXAM PREPARATION

8 MODULES · 36 LESSONS · 60 EXAM QUESTIONS

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

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A professional specialization for people who manage and lead people: strategic HR and workforce planning, fair recruitment, talent and learning, performance, reward, employee relations, inclusion and wellbeing, leadership and change, and evidence-based HR analytics with responsible AI.

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Eight-week study plan

WHEN	MODULE	DO THIS	DONE
Week 1–2	m1 Align	Strategic HRM and workforce plan	☐
Week 3–4	m2 Attract	Employer brand and structured selection kit	☐
Week 5	m3 Develop	Onboarding, talent review and learning design	☐
Week 6	m4 Perform	Goals, feedback and PIP practice	☐
Week 7	m5 Reward	Job evaluation and pay structure workbook	☐
Week 8–9	m6 Relate	Employee relations, law, inclusion and wellbeing	☐
Week 10	m7 Lead	Leadership, coaching and change plan	☐
Week 11–12	m8 Analyse	HR metrics dashboard, HR tech and AI policy, capstone, exam	☐

Learner name .....

Start date ..... Target exam date .....

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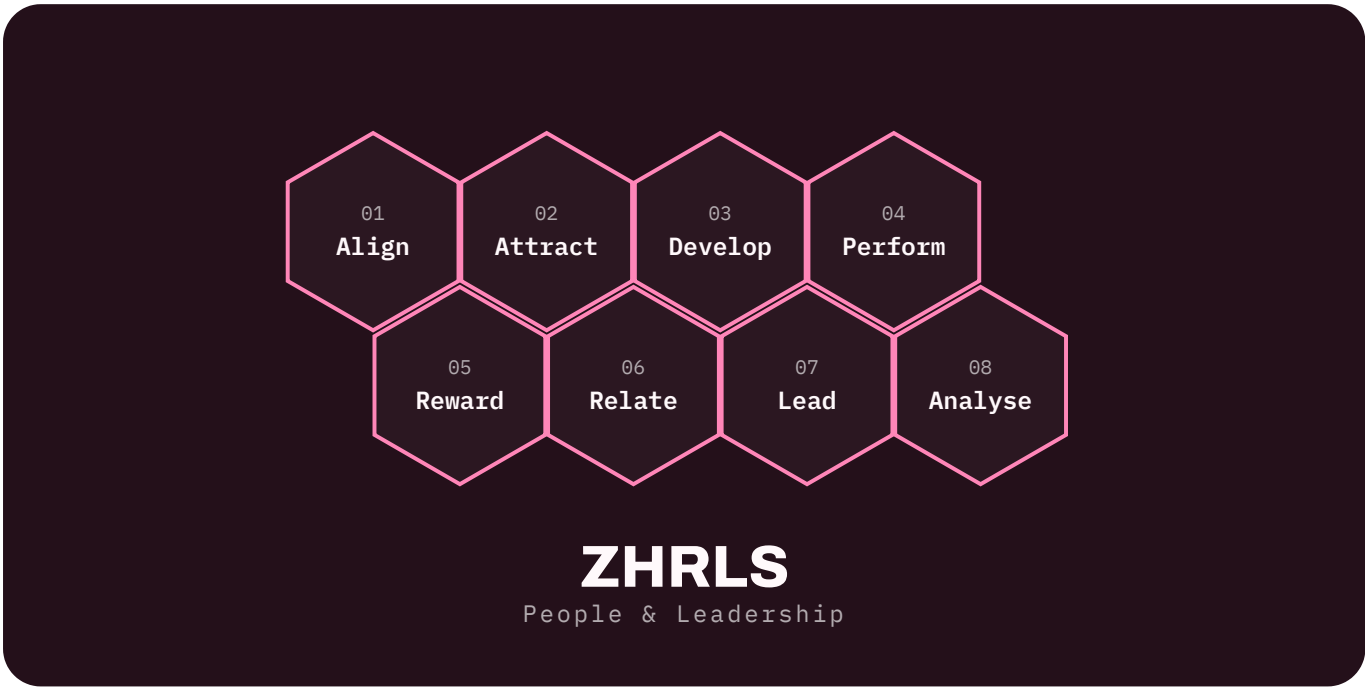
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THE FRAMEWORK

The ZHRLS People Hive

Eight connected cells that together make a healthy people system: align the strategy, attract talent, develop it, manage performance, reward fairly, build trusted relations, lead change and analyse the evidence. A weak cell drains the whole hive; a strong one feeds every other.



01 Align
Align people with strategy: HR's role, people strategy, workforce planning and job design

02 Attract
Attract and select the right people: EVP, sourcing, assessment, structured interviews and fairness

03 Develop
Develop people: onboarding, talent reviews, succession and learning that changes performance

04 Perform
Manage performance: goals, feedback, fair reviews and calibration, and supportive improvement plans

05 Reward
Reward fairly: total rewards, job evaluation, pay structures, incentives, benefits and pay equity

06 Relate
Build trusted relations: voice, engagement, lawful practice, fair procedures, inclusion and wellbeing

07 Lead
Lead people and change: styles, motivation, coaching conversations, change management and culture

08 Analyse
Analyse the evidence: HR metrics and formulas, people analytics, HR systems and responsible AI

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01

MODULE 1 · ALIGN

Strategic HRM and Workforce Planning

Align people with strategy: HR's role, people strategy, workforce planning and job design

BY THE END OF THIS MODULE YOU WILL BE ABLE TO

- Explain the purpose and operating model of modern HR and the role of line managers
- Translate business strategy into a focused people strategy with measures
- Forecast workforce demand and supply and choose build, buy, borrow or bot actions
- Use job analysis, job design and organisation design to define work clearly

LESSONS

1. The Modern HR Function · 22 min
2. Strategic HRM: Linking People to Strategy · 24 min
3. Workforce Planning · 26 min
4. Job Analysis, Job Design and Organisation Design · 24 min

MODULE 1 · ALIGN · LESSON 1 · 22 MIN

The Modern HR Function

What HR is for in 2026, how it is organised and where the ZHRLS People Hive fits

- Explain the purpose of human resource management in value terms
- Describe the main HR operating model roles and how they work with line managers
- Map HR activities to the employee lifecycle
- Name the eight cells of the ZHRLS People Hive

Every organisation, from a 40-person software house in Banani to a 6,000-worker knitwear group in Narayanganj, depends on people turning up, knowing what to do, being able to do it and wanting to do it well. **Human resource management (HRM)** is the discipline that makes this happen deliberately rather than by luck. In 2026 it is less about files and forms and more about designing a people system that helps the business win and treats people fairly, in a world of hybrid work, AI-enabled tools, skills shortages and rising expectations of transparency.

> DEFINITION · HUMAN RESOURCE MANAGEMENT
>
> **Human resource management** is the set of strategies, policies and practices an organisation uses to plan, attract, develop, manage, reward, engage and lead its people so that both the organisation and its people succeed. It is shared work: HR designs and supports the system, **line managers** run most of it day to day.

From personnel administration to people strategy

Traditional personnel

- Keeps records and processes paperwork
- Reacts to requests and problems
- Measures activity: forms processed, courses run
- Policy police: says what is not allowed
- Owns people issues alone

Modern HRM

- Designs a people system linked to strategy
- Anticipates workforce needs with data
- Measures outcomes: retention, capability, engagement, productivity
- Advises and enables managers to decide well
- Shares ownership with line managers and employees

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How the HR function has evolved

EARLY 1900S
Welfare and labour officers
Factory welfare, safety and hiring records

1940S–1970S
Personnel administration
Policies, payroll, industrial relations and compliance

1980S
Human resource management
People seen as a source of advantage and linked to strategy

LATE 1990S
Business partner model
HR business partners, centres of expertise, shared services

2010S
Analytics and experience
People analytics, cloud HR systems, employee experience

2020S
Hybrid, skills and AI
Hybrid work, skills-based practices, AI-enabled HR, new transparency rules

Each stage added to the last rather than replacing it: records and compliance still matter, but HR is now judged on strategy, evidence and employee experience. Dates are approximate and vary by country.

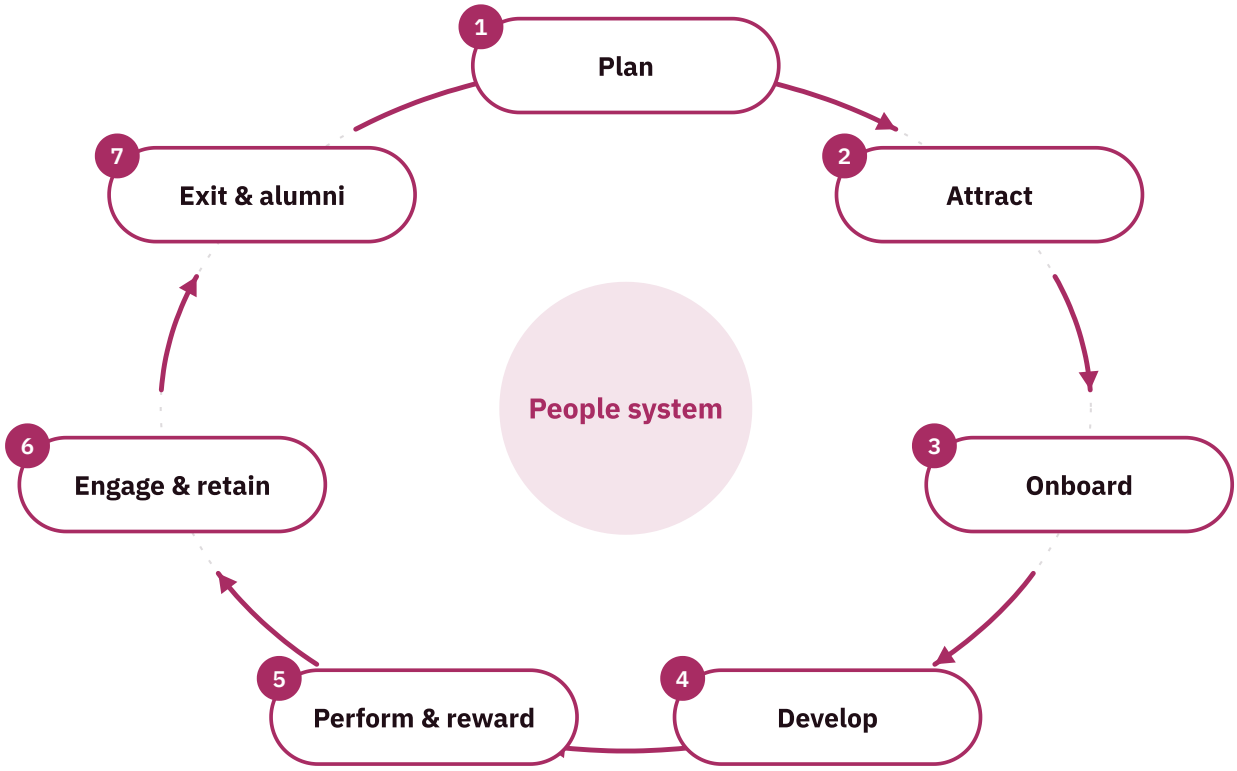
A common HR operating model

Leadership and governance	`Chief people officer or HR head` `People strategy and policy` `Board and executive reporting`
HR business partners	`Embedded with business units` `Translate business plans into people priorities` `Coach senior managers`
Centres of expertise	`Talent acquisition` `Reward` `Learning and development` `Employee relations` `People analytics`
HR shared services	`Payroll and records` `HR helpdesk and self-service` `Onboarding administration`
Line managers and employees	`Hire, coach, review and recognise` `Use self-service tools` `Raise concerns and ideas`

INSIGHT · THE MODEL IS A STARTING POINT, NOT A RULE
Smaller organisations rarely have all five layers. A 200-person NGO may have one HR manager who is business partner, recruiter and payroll officer at once. What matters is that each **role** is covered by someone: strategy, expert advice, efficient administration and capable managers.

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The employee lifecycle



1. **Plan** — Decide what work and skills the strategy needs
2. **Attract** — Brand, source and select
3. **Onboard** — Help new joiners become productive and connected
4. **Develop** — Grow capability and careers
5. **Perform & reward** — Set goals, give feedback, pay fairly
6. **Engage & retain** — Keep good people involved and well
7. **Exit & alumni** — Leave well, learn why, keep the door open

The loop closes because what you learn at exit (why people leave, what alumni say) feeds the next workforce plan and the employer brand. Former employees who return re-enter at Attract.

The ZHRLS People Hive: eight connected cells

1

Align

Link people strategy to business strategy; plan the workforce and design jobs.

2

Attract

Build an employer brand and select people fairly using structured, evidence-based methods.

3

Develop

Onboard well, grow talent, plan succession and design learning that changes performance.

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4

Perform

Set goals, give feedback, review fairly and handle underperformance with care.

5

Reward

Value jobs, build pay structures and benefits, and keep pay fair and transparent.

6

Relate

Build trust through employee relations, engagement, lawful practice, inclusion and wellbeing.

7

Lead

Lead people and change: styles, motivation, coaching and culture.

8

Analyse

Use metrics, analytics, HR technology and AI responsibly to improve decisions.

PRO TIP · WHY A HIVE?

In a hive every cell shares walls with others. Poor recruitment (Attract) creates performance problems (Perform), which create pay disputes (Reward) and conflict (Relate). Fixing one cell usually means checking its neighbours. Use the hive as a diagnostic map whenever a people problem lands on your desk.

EXAMPLE · ONE PROBLEM, MANY CELLS

A Chattogram shipping agent loses 30% of its new customer-service hires within six months. The exit interviews point to unclear job expectations (Align), over-selling the job at interview (Attract), a one-day induction (Develop) and a supervisor who only gives negative feedback (Lead). A pay rise alone (Reward) would not have solved it.

INSIGHT · FIVE FORCES RESHAPING HR IN 2026

Skills: more organisations describe work as skills as well as jobs, so they can redeploy people faster. **AI**: tools now draft, screen, answer and predict, which raises questions of fairness, transparency and human oversight. **Hybrid and flexible work** has changed how teams connect and how managers lead. **Transparency**: pay transparency laws, AI rules and reporting standards expect organisations to explain people decisions with evidence. **Listening**: employees expect to be heard continuously, not once a year. Each force appears in the modules that follow.

HR professional conduct in practice

- **Confidentiality**: personal data, health information and investigation details are shared only with those who need them.
- **Fairness and consistency**: similar cases are treated alike, and differences are explained by evidence.
- **Lawfulness**: practices are checked against current local law, not against habit.
- **Courage**: HR raises concerns with senior leaders even when the message is unwelcome.
- **Evidence**: decisions rest on data and documented facts, not on rumour or seniority.

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SCENARIO · DECIDE · WHO OWNS THE PEOPLE PROBLEM?

A production manager at a Gazipur garment factory emails HR: "Absenteeism on Line 7 is terrible. HR needs to fix it." Line 7 has a new supervisor and absence has doubled in two months. What is the best first response from the HR business partner?

(A) Meet the production manager, look at the absence data together and agree a joint plan in which the supervisor leads, with HR providing data, coaching and policy support.

(B) Issue a factory-wide warning notice about absence and deduct pay from absent workers.

(C) Take over attendance management on Line 7 so the supervisor can focus on output.

(D) Reply that attendance is the supervisor's job, not HR's, and close the request.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

REFLECT

Draw your own organisation's HR operating model. Which roles are covered well, which are missing, and which tasks do line managers carry without enough support?

Key terms

Human resource management (HRM)
The strategies, policies and practices an organisation uses to plan, attract, develop, manage, reward, engage and lead its people.

HR business partner
A senior HR professional embedded with a business unit who links its plans to people priorities and advises its leaders.

HR shared services
A central team, often supported by self-service technology, that handles routine HR transactions such as payroll, records and queries.

Line manager
The person to whom an employee directly reports, who carries day-to-day responsibility for managing that employee.

HR operating model
The way HR roles, structures, processes and technology are arranged to deliver people services and advice.

Centre of expertise
A specialist HR team, such as reward or talent acquisition, that designs policies and gives expert advice across the organisation.

Employee lifecycle
The stages a person goes through with an employer, from planning and attraction to exit and alumni.

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Key takeaways

- HRM designs the people system; line managers run most of it every day.
- Operating models combine business partners, centres of expertise, shared services and capable managers; small organisations cover the same roles with fewer people.
- The employee lifecycle is a loop: what you learn at exit feeds planning and attraction.
- Use the People Hive as a diagnostic map: most people problems have causes in several cells.
- Skills, AI, hybrid work, transparency and continuous listening now shape every cell.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. In a modern HR operating model, who usually runs most day-to-day people management?
   - (A) HR shared services staff
   - (B) The centre of expertise for employee relations
   - (C) Line managers, supported by HR
   - (D) The chief people officer personally
2. Which team would normally design a new grading and pay structure?
   - (A) A reward centre of expertise
   - (B) HR shared services
   - (C) The payroll helpdesk
   - (D) Each line manager separately
3. A key difference between traditional personnel work and modern HRM is that modern HRM:
   - (A) Focuses mainly on processing records
   - (B) Avoids sharing work with line managers
   - (C) Measures success mainly by the number of policies issued and forms processed
   - (D) Measures outcomes such as retention and capability
4. In the ZHRLS People Hive, which cell covers job design and workforce planning?
   - (A) Attract
   - (B) Align
   - (C) Relate
   - (D) Analyse
5. Why does the hive model encourage you to check neighbouring cells when diagnosing a people problem?
   - (A) Because each cell is owned by a different department
   - (B) Because people problems usually have causes in several connected practices
   - (C) Because HR budgets are allocated per cell
   - (D) Because labour law requires every cell of the HR system to be reviewed each year

☐ Lesson complete · Date _____ · Knowledge check score ____ / 5

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MODULE 1 · ALIGN · LESSON 2 · 24 MIN

Strategic HRM: Linking People to Strategy

Turn business goals into a focused, measurable people strategy

- Explain strategic HRM and the difference between best fit and best practice
- Translate business strategy into a small set of people priorities
- Build a one-page people strategy with measures
- Recognise the features of a high-performance work system

A business strategy says where the organisation will compete and how it will win. **Strategic HRM** asks a simple follow-up question: *what must be true about our people, capabilities and culture for that strategy to work?* If a bank plans to move half its customers to digital channels within three years, its people strategy must deal with new digital skills, fewer branch roles, retraining, redeployment and a culture that values experimentation.

DEFINITION · STRATEGIC HRM

Strategic HRM is the deliberate alignment of people policies and practices with the organisation's strategy, so that the workforce has the capability, motivation and opportunity to deliver it. It treats people decisions as investment decisions, with expected returns and risks.

Two schools of thought, used together

Best fit

- HR practices should match the strategy and context
- A low-cost manufacturer and an innovation-led tech firm need different HR
- Strength: realistic and tailored
- Risk: can justify poor treatment as 'fit'

Best practice

- Some practices help almost everywhere
- Examples: careful selection, training, fair pay, voice, job security where possible
- Strength: evidence-based baseline
- Risk: copying without adapting to context

INSIGHT · A PRACTICAL BLEND

Most experienced HR leaders use **best practice as the floor** (fair, lawful, evidence-based basics) and **best fit as the design choice** (which practices to emphasise and how much to invest). A garment exporter competing on reliability and compliance may invest heavily in supervisor training and safety culture; a fintech competing on speed may invest in scarce engineering talent and rapid learning.

From strategy to people priorities

01 **Business strategy** — Where we compete and how we win

→

02 **Critical capabilities** — What we must be able to do better than others

→

03 **Workforce implications** — Roles, skills, numbers, locations, culture

→

04 **People priorities** — Three to five focused areas

→

05 **Initiatives and measures** — Actions, owners, targets and timelines

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Strategy shapes HR emphasis

BUSINESS STRATEGY	PEOPLE EMPHASIS	EXAMPLE HR PRACTICES
Cost leadership	Efficiency, reliability, low error rates	Clear standard work, skills training, attendance incentives, careful span of control
Innovation	Creativity, learning, collaboration	Hiring for learning ability, project-based careers, psychological safety, team rewards
Customer intimacy	Service quality and relationships	Selection for empathy, service training, recognition linked to customer feedback
Rapid growth	Scale hiring without losing quality	Recruitment capacity, onboarding at scale, manager development, culture carriers
Turnaround	Focus, cost control, trust	Transparent communication, fair selection for redundancy, retention of critical talent
AI-enabled transformation	Reskilling, job redesign, trust	Skills mapping, internal mobility, open consultation, responsible-use rules, change leadership

Prioritising people initiatives

IMPACT ON STRATEGIC GOALS →

Plan and resource

- High impact but hard to do
- Phase it; secure budget and a sponsor
- Example: leadership academy

Priorities now

- High impact and doable
- The three to five on the page
- Example: structured hiring for field sales

Drop or park

- Low impact and hard to do
- Example: redesigning the HR intranet

Quick wins, if cheap

- Easy but low impact
- Do only if they free time or build trust
- Example: a new uniform policy

FEASIBILITY (COST, CAPACITY, TIME) →

Score each candidate initiative on both axes with the executive team. The top-right quadrant becomes the people strategy on a page; top-left items need a phased plan; bottom-left items are parked openly so no one wonders why.

High-performance work system: the AMO lens

A

Ability

Practices that build skill: rigorous selection, training, coaching, job rotation.

M

Motivation

Practices that build effort: fair pay, recognition, career prospects, meaningful goals.

O

Opportunity

Practices that let people contribute: involvement, autonomy, teamwork, voice channels.

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PRO TIP · BUNDLES BEAT SINGLE PRACTICES

Research on high-performance work systems consistently suggests that practices work best as **mutually reinforcing bundles**. Training people (ability) without giving them room to use their new skills (opportunity) wastes money and frustrates them.

CASE STUDY · A PEOPLE STRATEGY FOR A GROWING MFS PROVIDER

A mobile financial services company in Dhaka plans to double its merchant base in two years and launch a credit product. It has 900 staff, a 28% annual turnover in its field sales force, weak data-science capability and a culture that rewards individual sales heroics. The CEO asks HR for a people strategy on a page within a month.

1. What critical capabilities does the strategy require?

2. Which three to five people priorities would you choose?

3. How would you measure success for each priority?

4. What risks should you flag to the executive team?

Model answer: module answer key.

TEMPLATE People strategy on a page

Summarise how people priorities support the business strategy, with owners and measures, on one page an executive team can approve.

BUSINESS GOAL	PEOPLE PRIORITY	KEY INITIATIVES	MEASURE AND TARGET	OWNER	TIME LINE
Double merchant base in 2 years	*Stabilise field sales force*	*Structured hiring, 30-day onboarding, revised incentive*	*First-year turnover from 28% to 18%*	*Head of Sales + HRBP*	*Q1–Q4*
Launch credit product	*Build credit-risk capability*	*Hire 6 analysts, internal academy, partner university*	*All critical roles filled; time to productivity under 4 months*	*CRO + Talent lead*	*Q1–Q3*

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BUSINESS GOAL	PEOPLE PRIORITY	KEY INITIATIVES	MEASURE AND TARGET	OWNER	TIME LINE

SCENARIO · DECIDE · CHOOSING PRIORITIES

The executive team of a private hospital in Chattogram asks HR for a people strategy. HR drafts a list of 22 initiatives, from a new uniform policy to a leadership academy. What should HR do next?

(A) Present all 22 initiatives so that leaders can see how much HR is doing.

(B) Rank the initiatives by impact on the hospital's strategic goals and feasibility, and present three to five priorities with measures, parking the rest.

(C) Start with the initiatives that are quickest to finish, to show early wins.

(D) Ask each department head to pick their favourite initiative.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

REFLECT

Write your organisation's strategy in one sentence. Then list the three people capabilities that would most limit it if they were missing.

Key terms

Strategic HRM
The deliberate alignment of people policies and practices with organisational strategy so the workforce can deliver it.

Best practice (HR)
The view that certain HR practices, such as careful selection and training, improve performance in most organisations.

AMO model
A lens stating that performance depends on employees' Ability, Motivation and Opportunity to contribute.

Vertical and horizontal fit
Vertical fit links HR practices to business strategy; horizontal fit makes HR practices consistent with each other.

Best fit
The view that HR practices should be tailored to the organisation's strategy, context and competitive approach.

High-performance work system
A bundle of mutually reinforcing HR practices designed to raise ability, motivation and opportunity to contribute.

People strategy
A focused plan setting out the people priorities, initiatives and measures needed to deliver the business strategy.

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Key takeaways

- Strategic HRM starts from the business strategy: what must be true about people, capabilities and culture for it to work?
- Use best practice as the fair floor and best fit to choose where to invest.
- Build bundles that develop ability, motivation and opportunity together, and keep practices consistent with each other.
- A people strategy on a page has three to five priorities, each with initiatives, owners and measures.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

6. A low-cost manufacturer and an innovation-led software firm adopt very different HR practices. Which idea does this illustrate?

   (A) Best practice
   (B) Horizontal fit only
   (C) Shared services
   (D) Best fit

7. In the AMO model, giving employees voice, autonomy and team involvement mainly builds:

   (A) Opportunity
   (B) Ability
   (C) Motivation
   (D) Compliance with procedures

8. Why do HR practices work better as bundles?

   (A) Because single practices are illegal in most countries
   (B) Because bundles are cheaper to buy from vendors
   (C) Because they reinforce each other, for example training plus room to use new skills
   (D) Because bundles of practices remove the need for line managers to be involved in people decisions

9. What is the most useful size for a people strategy's priority list?

   (A) As many initiatives as HR can list
   (B) One priority for each department head, so every part of the organisation is represented
   (C) A single priority, always recruitment
   (D) Three to five focused priorities with measures

10. Which practice best reflects horizontal fit?

    (A) Matching the organisation's HR practices to its cost-leadership business strategy
    (B) Rewarding the same teamwork behaviours that the selection process screens for
    (C) Benchmarking pay against competitors annually
    (D) Outsourcing payroll to a provider

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MODULE 1 · ALIGN · LESSON 3 · 26 MIN

Workforce Planning

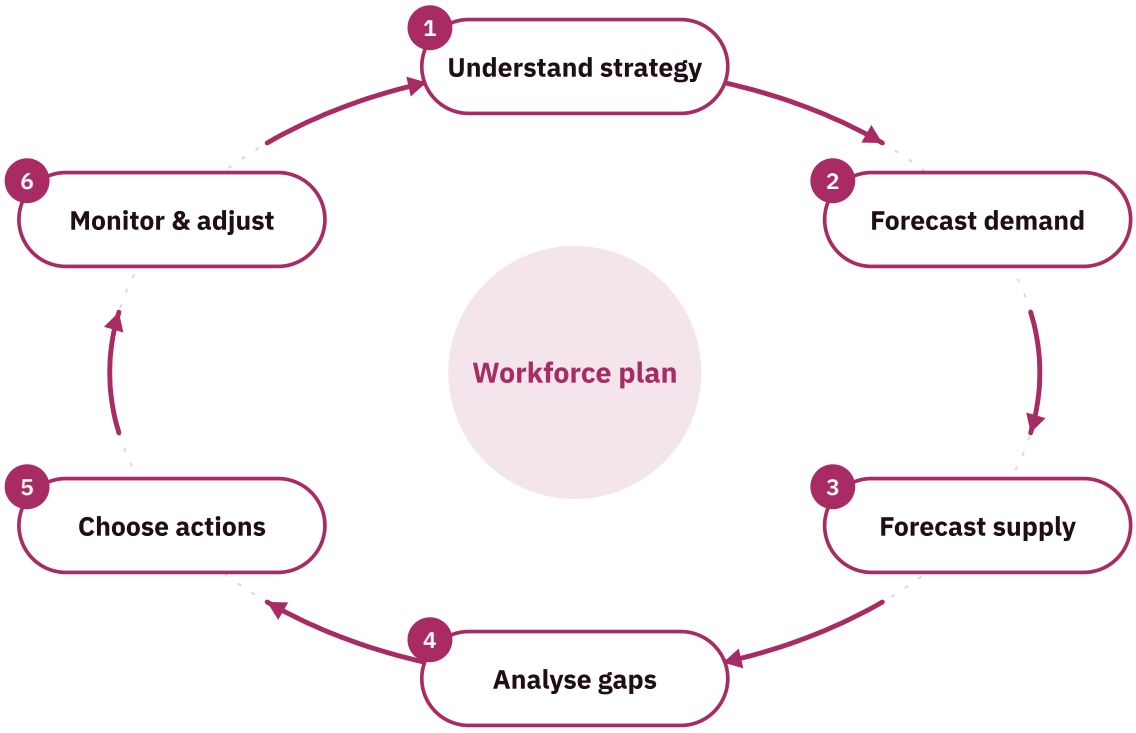
Forecast the people you will need, the people you will have, and close the gap

- Forecast workforce demand and supply using simple, defensible methods
- Calculate a workforce gap in full-time equivalents
- Choose between build, buy, borrow and bot options
- Use scenarios to plan for uncertainty

Workforce planning makes sure the organisation has the right people, with the right skills, in the right places, at the right cost and time. It turns a vague worry ("we'll need more engineers") into numbers, options and decisions. Done well, it is the bridge between the people strategy on a page and the recruitment, learning and reward plans that follow.

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The workforce planning cycle



1. **Understand strategy** — Growth, new products, automation, sites
2. **Forecast demand** — Roles and skills needed
3. **Forecast supply** — Who you will still have
4. **Analyse gaps** — Surplus and shortage by role and skill
5. **Choose actions** — Build, buy, borrow, bot, redeploy
6. **Monitor & adjust** — Review quarterly and update the plan

Planning is a loop, not an annual document: monitoring results and new business signals restart the cycle, often every quarter for critical roles.

Demand forecasting methods

Quantitative

- Workload ratios: output ÷ productivity per FTE
- Trend analysis of past headcount against activity
- Staffing ratios, such as nurses per occupied bed
- Regression on business drivers

Qualitative

- Manager estimates, checked and challenged
- Expert panels for new roles
- Scenario workshops
- Benchmarking similar organisations

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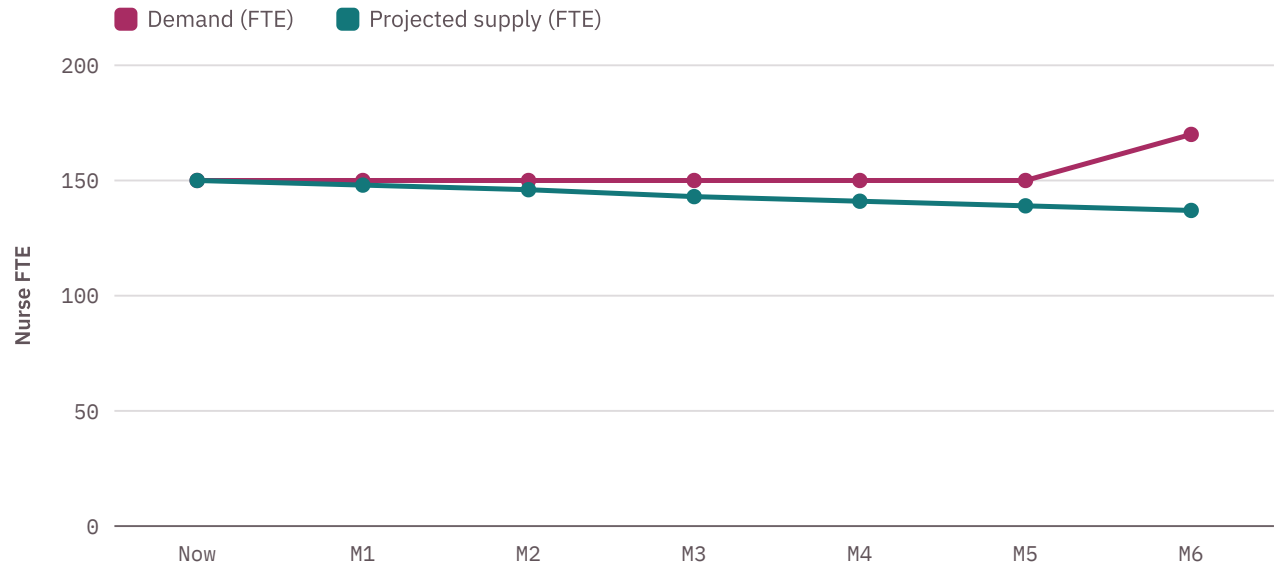
Core workforce planning formulas

MEASURE	FORMULA	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
FTE demand	`Required FTE = forecast workload ÷ (output per FTE per period)`	Turns business volume into people needed. Example: 120,000 calls a month ÷ 2,400 calls per agent = 50 FTE.
Projected supply	`Supply = current FTE − expected leavers − retirements ± internal moves`	Who you will still have at the end of the period if nothing else changes.
Expected leavers	`Leavers = current FTE × annual turnover rate × (months ÷ 12)`	A simple estimate of attrition over the planning period.
Workforce gap	`Gap = demand − projected supply`	Positive means shortage to fill; negative means surplus to manage.
Hiring need with time-to-fill	`Hires needed = gap + leavers expected during the hiring period`	Hiring must also cover people who leave while you recruit.

EXAMPLE · A WORKED EXAMPLE: HOSPITAL NURSING

A 400-bed hospital in Sylhet plans to open a 60-bed wing. Its staffing standard is 1 nurse FTE per 2.5 occupied beds across all shifts, with 85% expected occupancy. Demand for the new wing = 60 × 0.85 ÷ 2.5 = **20.4 FTE**. The current pool of 150 nurses has 18% annual turnover, so over the next 6 months about 150 × 0.18 × 0.5 = **13.5** will leave. If no one is transferred, HR needs roughly 20 + 14 = **34 hires** to open the wing and keep existing wards staffed.

Nurse demand versus projected supply



Numbers follow the worked example, rounded; they are illustrative. The gap opens slowly through attrition and then jumps when the new wing opens, so hiring must start early enough to cover both.

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Closing the gap: the 4B options

B1

Build

Develop existing staff through training, rotation and promotion. Slower, builds loyalty and culture fit.

B2

Buy

Recruit from the external market. Faster for scarce skills, but costly and risky for culture.

B3

Borrow

Use contractors, consultants, agencies or partners. Flexible, but knowledge may leave with them.

B4

Bot

Automate or redesign work with technology and AI. Reduces or reshapes demand, creates new tasks such as checking AI output, and needs change management and reskilling.

Choosing among the 4B options

SITUATION	USUALLY FAVOUR	REASON
Skill needed for years, internal talent available	Build	Lower cost over time, strong retention signal
Urgent need, skill scarce internally	Buy	Time-to-capability matters more than cost
Short project or uncertain demand	Borrow	Avoids long-term commitment
High-volume, rule-based tasks	Bot	Automation removes repetitive workload
Surplus in one area, shortage in another	Build (redeploy and reskill)	Protects jobs and keeps knowledge

INSIGHT · PLAN SKILLS, NOT ONLY HEADCOUNT

A role-based plan counts people; a **skills-based** plan also asks which skills are growing, shrinking or emerging. Map roles to a shared **skills taxonomy**, then look for adjacent skills: a data-entry clerk who already checks documents for errors may be a few months from a quality-analyst role. **Internal talent marketplaces** (platforms or simple processes that match people to projects, gigs and vacancies by skills) make build and redeploy faster. Keep skills data accurate, explain how it is used and let employees see and correct their own profiles.

WATCH OUT · SURPLUS IS A GAP TOO

A negative gap means more people than work. Planning early gives humane options: hiring freezes, redeployment, retraining, voluntary schemes and natural attrition. Leaving it late often forces redundancy, which is costly, legally sensitive and damaging to trust. Always check local law on retrenchment and consultation.

Running a simple scenario plan

1. **Pick two key uncertainties** For example, demand growth (high or low) and automation speed (fast or slow).
2. **Build three or four scenarios** Combine the uncertainties into plausible futures, each with a short name.
3. **Forecast demand per scenario** Estimate FTE by role family in each future.
4. **Find no-regret moves** Actions that make sense in every scenario, such as building data skills.
5. **Set trigger points** Agree what signal will tell you a scenario is unfolding, and what you will do then.

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Four workforce scenarios

DEMAND GROWTH →

Scale up people

- Hire and build at pace
- Protect onboarding quality

Grow and reshape

- Hire fewer for routine work
- Reskill into new roles
- Recruit scarce technical skills

Hold steady

- Tight hiring control
- Cross-train for flexibility

Redeploy and resize

- Hiring freeze
- Redeployment and reskilling
- Humane surplus plans

SPEED OF AUTOMATION →

Two uncertainties give four plausible futures. Actions that appear in every quadrant, such as cross-training and building data skills, are no-regret moves; signals such as order books or automation pilots tell you which quadrant is unfolding.

TEMPLATE

Workforce gap worksheet

Calculate the gap for each critical role family and choose an action.

ROLE FAMILY	CURRENT FTE	EXPECTED LEAVERS	PROJECTED SUPPLY	FORECAST DEMAND	GAP	MAIN ACTION (4B)
Field sales agents	*220*	*62*	*158*	*260*	*+102*	*Buy + Build (structured hiring, sales academy)*
Data analysts	*8*	*2*	*6*	*18*	*+12*	*Buy (6) + Build (6 internal reskilling)*

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SCENARIO · DECIDE · PLANNING FOR A NEW AUTOMATION TOOL

A bank's back office in Motijheel will introduce document-processing automation next year, which is expected to cut manual data-entry workload by about 40%. There are 75 data-entry staff, and annual turnover in the team is 15%. What should the workforce plan recommend?

(A) Keep hiring as normal and deal with the surplus after the tool goes live.

(B) Announce 30 redundancies today so staff have plenty of notice.

(C) Freeze external hiring for the team now, let natural turnover reduce numbers, and launch reskilling for exception handling, quality checks and customer-facing roles.

(D) Cancel the automation to protect jobs.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

REFLECT

Pick one critical role in your organisation. Estimate its demand and supply for next year using the formulas above. What would you do about the gap?

Key terms

Workforce planning
The process of forecasting the people and skills an organisation needs and planning actions to close gaps between demand and supply.

Demand forecasting
Estimating the number and type of people needed to deliver planned work.

Workforce gap
The difference between forecast demand and projected supply for a role or skill.

Scenario planning
Preparing for several plausible futures and identifying actions that work across them.

Full-time equivalent (FTE)
A unit expressing workload or staffing as the number of full-time workers; two half-time staff equal one FTE.

Supply forecasting
Estimating the people who will be available, after expected leavers, retirements and internal moves.

Build, buy, borrow, bot
Four options for closing a workforce gap: develop, recruit, use contingent labour or partners, or automate.

Critical role
A role with outsized impact on strategy that is hard to fill or slow to develop.

Key takeaways

- Forecast demand from business drivers and supply from current staff minus expected leavers; the gap is demand minus supply.
- Hiring need = gap + leavers expected while you recruit.
- Close gaps with build, buy, borrow or bot, and plan surpluses early so humane options remain.
- Plan skills as well as headcount, and use scenarios to find no-regret moves.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

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11. A call centre forecasts 96,000 calls a month. Each agent FTE handles 2,400 calls a month. What is the FTE demand?

(A) 24 FTE
(B) 36 FTE
(C) 40 FTE
(D) 48 FTE

12. A team has 50 FTE and 20% annual turnover. Roughly how many people will leave in the next six months?

(A) 5
(B) 10
(C) 2
(D) 20

13. Which option is usually best for a short, uncertain project needing niche skills?

(A) Borrow
(B) Build
(C) Bot
(D) Buy permanent staff

14. A workforce plan shows a gap of –12 FTE for clerical roles. What does this mean?

(A) The organisation must hire 12 people
(B) Turnover is 12%
(C) There is a surplus of about 12 FTE to manage
(D) Twelve people must be dismissed immediately to balance the budget

15. In scenario planning, what is a 'no-regret move'?

(A) An action that has no cost
(B) An action that makes sense in every plausible scenario
(C) A decision that can never be reversed once leaders have announced it
(D) The scenario leaders like most

16. A skills-based workforce plan differs from a purely role-based plan mainly because it:

(A) Ignores headcount, budgets and the costs of each option
(B) Tracks which skills are growing or shrinking and finds adjacent skills for redeployment
(C) Requires buying a new HR system and an AI forecasting tool before any planning work can begin
(D) Replaces managers' input with an automated forecast

☐ Lesson complete · Date _____ · Knowledge check score ____ / 6

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MODULE 1 · ALIGN · LESSON 4 · 24 MIN

Job Analysis, Job Design and Organisation Design

Define the work clearly before you hire, pay or measure it

- Use job analysis to produce job descriptions and person specifications
- Apply job design principles that motivate and protect people
- Explain how competency frameworks support HR processes
- Evaluate spans of control and organisation structures

Almost every HR process depends on a clear picture of the job. Recruitment needs selection criteria, reward needs job evaluation, performance management needs expectations, and learning needs skill requirements. **Job analysis** produces that picture. Without it, organisations hire for vague qualities, pay by negotiation and argue about what 'good performance' means.

Doing a job analysis

1. **Define the purpose** Hiring, grading, training or redesign? The purpose decides the depth.
2. **Collect information** Interviews with job holders and managers, observation, work diaries, questionnaires and existing documents.
3. **Identify tasks and outcomes** List key responsibilities and the results each one produces.
4. **Identify requirements** Knowledge, skills, abilities, qualifications and behaviours needed to perform well.
5. **Validate** Check the draft with job holders and managers; fix anything that is wishful or outdated.
6. **Document and maintain** Produce the job description and person specification and review them when the job changes.

Job description vs person specification

Job description: the job

- Job title, grade and reporting line
- Purpose of the role in one or two sentences
- Key responsibilities and outcomes
- Scope: budget, team size, decisions
- Working conditions and location

Person specification: the person

- Essential and desirable criteria
- Knowledge and skills
- Experience, described as capability, not years alone
- Behaviours and values
- Legal requirements, such as a licence or registration

WATCH OUT · CRITERIA THAT QUIETLY EXCLUDE

Requirements such as "10 years' experience", "must be under 30", "male candidates preferred" or "degree from a top university" may be unlawful, discriminatory or simply poor predictors of performance. Test every criterion: **is it truly needed to do this job well, and can we assess it fairly?** Many employers now drop degree requirements where the skill can be tested directly.

Job design: features that motivate

V

Skill variety

The job uses a range of skills rather than one repetitive task.

I

Task identity

The worker completes a whole, recognisable piece of work.

S

Task significance

The work clearly matters to customers, patients or colleagues.

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A

Autonomy

The worker has some say in how and when tasks are done.

F

Feedback

The job itself shows how well the work is going.

EXAMPLE · REDESIGNING A SEWING LINE ROLE

A knitwear factory moved some operators from a single repeated operation to small **modular teams** that complete a whole garment section, check their own quality and see daily output against target. Rework fell, and operators learned several machines, which also gave the factory more flexibility when absence was high.

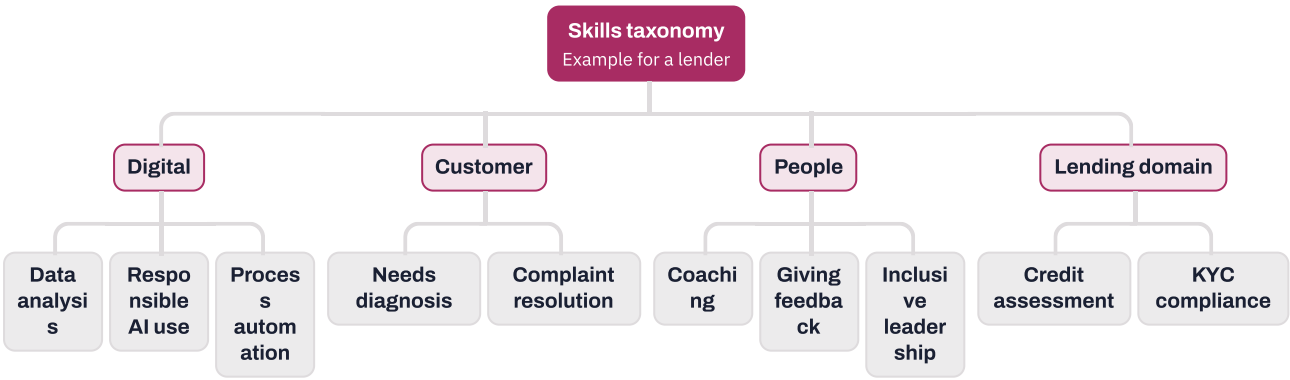
Competency frameworks in practice

- A **competency** is an observable behaviour or capability linked to effective performance, such as 'builds trust with patients' or 'analyses data to solve problems'.
- Good frameworks are short: six to ten competencies, each with behaviour indicators at different levels.
- One framework can link recruitment criteria, performance reviews, learning plans and promotion decisions.
- Keep technical skills (what you know) separate from behavioural competencies (how you work).

DEFINITION · SKILLS-BASED ORGANISATION

A **skills-based organisation** describes work as bundles of skills as well as jobs. It uses a shared **skills taxonomy** (a structured list of skills with definitions and proficiency levels) to write job profiles, hire on demonstrated skills rather than degree or years-of-experience proxies, match people to internal moves and plan learning. It works only if the taxonomy is short enough to use, skills are verified with evidence, and employees can see and challenge what is recorded about them.

Part of a skills taxonomy (example)



Clusters group related skills; each skill then gets a definition and proficiency levels (for example 1–4). The same taxonomy can feed job profiles, selection criteria, learning plans and internal matching, so keep it short and give it an owner.

Organisation structures

STRUCTURE	STRENGTHS	WATCH-OUTS
Functional	Deep expertise, clear careers	Silos, slow cross-functional work

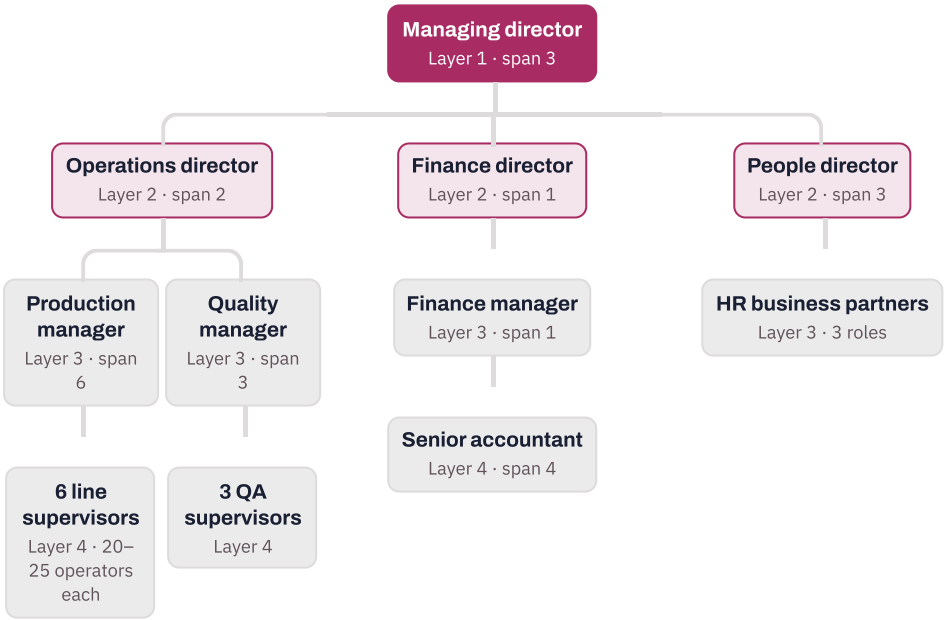
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STRUCTURE	STRENGTHS	WATCH-OUTS
Divisional (product or region)	Customer and market focus	Duplicated functions, internal competition
Matrix	Balances expertise and business focus	Dual reporting, conflict, slower decisions
Team-based or network	Speed and flexibility	Unclear accountability if roles are vague
Flat	Fast communication, fewer layers	Overloaded managers, few promotion steps

Spans and layers

MEASURE	FORMULA	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Span of control	`Span = direct reports ÷ number of managers`	Average number of people each manager leads directly.
Layers	`Layers = number of reporting levels from the top role to the front line`	More layers slow decisions and add cost.
Manager ratio	`Manager ratio = employees ÷ managers`	A quick check on whether the structure is top-heavy.

Counting layers and spans



Count layers from the top role to the front line (four here) and the span at each manager. The finance manager with a single report is the kind of narrow span to question: it may be a title given instead of a career path.

INSIGHT · NO PERFECT SPAN

Spans of 3 can be right for complex specialist work; spans of 25 can work on a stable production line with strong team leaders. Watch for extremes and for managers with spans of one or two, which often signal a title given in place of a career path.

TEMPLATE **Job profile builder**

Capture the essentials of a role so that recruitment, grading and performance management all use the same picture.

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ROLE PURPOSE	KEY RESPONSIBILITIES	OUTCOMES AND MEASURES	ESSENTIAL CRITERIA	DESIRABLE CRITERIA	HOW ASSESSED
Lead a 12-person customer support team to resolve issues quickly and fairly	*Schedule shifts; coach agents; handle escalations; report weekly*	*First-contact resolution ≥ 75%; CSAT ≥ 85%; attrition ≤ 20%*	*Team leadership; clear Bangla and English writing; problem solving*	*MFS or banking experience*	*Structured interview; written exercise; reference check*

SCENARIO · DECIDE · A REQUEST FOR A NEW JOB DESCRIPTION

A department head asks HR to post a job ad for a 'Senior Executive, Operations' tomorrow. The only description is last year's ad from a different department. What should HR do?

(A) Post last year's ad to save time and adjust after the interviews.

(B) Ask the manager to write whatever they want and post it unchanged.

(C) Refuse to post until a full competency framework is built for the department.

(D) Hold a short job analysis conversation with the manager and a current team member to confirm purpose, outcomes and essential criteria before posting.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

REFLECT

Look at your own job description. Which parts still describe what you actually do, and which criteria would you change if you were hiring your replacement?

Key terms

Job analysis
The systematic study of a job to identify its tasks, outcomes and the requirements for performing it well.

Job description
A document describing a job's purpose, responsibilities, scope, reporting line and working conditions.

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Person specification
A statement of the essential and desirable knowledge, skills, experience and behaviours for a role.

Job design
Deciding the content, methods and relationships of a job to meet organisational and individual needs.

Organisation design
Shaping structure, roles, processes and decision rights so an organisation can deliver its strategy.

Skills-based organisation
An organisation that describes and manages work as bundles of skills as well as jobs, so it can hire, develop and redeploy people by demonstrated skill.

Competency framework
A structured set of observable behaviours and capabilities linked to effective performance, used across HR processes.

Span of control
The number of direct reports a manager leads.

Skills taxonomy
A structured list of the skills an organisation uses, with definitions and proficiency levels, shared across job profiles, hiring, learning and mobility.

Key takeaways

- Job analysis gives every HR process the same picture of the job: purpose, outcomes and requirements.
- Test every criterion: is it truly needed, and can we assess it fairly?
- Design jobs with variety, identity, significance, autonomy and feedback.
- Skills taxonomies and competency frameworks link hiring, reviews, learning and mobility, if kept short.
- Check spans and layers: too many layers slow decisions; very narrow spans often hide title inflation.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

17. Which document sets out essential and desirable criteria for the person in a role?

(A) Job description
(B) Organisation chart
(C) Employment contract and offer letter
(D) Person specification

18. A role lets a technician complete a full repair from diagnosis to customer sign-off. Which job design feature does this mainly increase?

(A) Task significance
(B) Span of control
(C) Task identity
(D) Autonomy

19. A department has 4 managers and 52 direct reports in total. What is the average span of control?

(A) 13
(B) 12
(C) 52
(D) 4

20. Why is '10 years' experience required' often a poor selection criterion?

(A) It is always illegal in every country and must be removed from all job advertisements
(B) It makes job ads too long
(C) Experienced people never apply
(D) Years alone predict performance weakly and can exclude capable people unfairly

21. What is a common risk of a matrix structure?

(A) Too little expertise in functions
(B) Dual reporting that creates conflict and slows decisions
(C) No focus on business units or customers at all
(D) It eliminates all managers

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22. An employer replaces "degree required" with a scored work task for a junior data-analyst role. This is an example of:

(A) Market pricing
(B) Forced distribution
(C) Skills-based hiring
(D) Broadbanding of pay grades across several job families

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MODULE 1 · ALIGN

Answer key

Knowledge checks

1. C Line managers hire, coach, review and recognise their teams every day. HR designs the system and supports them.

2. A Centres of expertise hold specialist knowledge such as reward design and apply it across the organisation.

3. D Modern HRM is judged by business and people outcomes, not by administrative activity.

4. B Align links people strategy to business strategy and includes workforce planning and job design.

5. B Hiring, onboarding, leadership, reward and relations affect each other, so a single-cell fix often fails.

6. D Best fit says HR practices should match the strategy and context of each organisation.

7. A Opportunity practices let people use their ability and motivation to contribute.

8. C Practices that build ability, motivation and opportunity together create a stronger combined effect.

9. D A short list focuses resources and makes accountability clear.

10. B Horizontal fit means HR practices are consistent with each other, sending the same message to employees.

11. C 96,000 ÷ 2,400 = 40 FTE.

12. A 50 × 0.20 × (6 ÷ 12) = 5 leavers.

13. A Borrowing through contractors or partners avoids long-term commitment for short or uncertain needs.

14. C A negative gap means supply exceeds demand; plan humane options such as redeployment.

15. B No-regret moves are robust across futures, so they can start now.

16. B Skills-based planning looks beneath job titles at the skills the work needs, which reveals redeployment and reskilling routes. It still uses headcount and cost, and it can start with simple tools.

17. D The person specification describes the person; the job description describes the job.

18. C Task identity means completing a whole, recognisable piece of work.

19. A 52 ÷ 4 = 13 direct reports per manager.

20. D Capability is better described and assessed directly; long tenure requirements may also have discriminatory effects.

21. B Matrix structures balance two dimensions but often cause conflicting priorities between two bosses.

22. C Assessing the skill directly instead of relying on a degree as a proxy is skills-based hiring. It can widen the pool and predict performance better.

Scenarios & case studies

Scenario · Who owns the people problem?
A is best. Best. Absence on one line is a management issue first. HR adds value by bringing evidence and support while keeping the line accountable.

Case study · A people strategy for a growing MFS provider
Critical capabilities include merchant acquisition at scale, credit-risk analytics, regulatory compliance and cross-team collaboration. Sensible priorities: (1) stabilise the field sales force through better selection, onboarding and a fairer incentive scheme, measured by first-year turnover and sales per agent; (2) build data and credit-risk capability through targeted hiring and a learning academy, measured by critical roles filled and time to productivity; (3) develop managers as coaches, measured by engagement scores and internal promotion rate; (4) shift culture from individual heroics to team results, measured by collaboration indicators and incentive mix. Risks: competition for scarce data talent, regulatory changes affecting credit roles, incentive changes triggering short-term attrition, and manager capacity to deliver the changes.

Scenario · Choosing priorities
B is best. Best. Focus is the heart of strategy. A short list with measures gets resources and attention; a long list gets neither.

Scenario · Planning for a new automation tool
C is best. Best. Early planning uses attrition and reskilling to absorb most of the surplus humanely, while building skills the bank still needs.

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Scenario · A request for a new job description

D is best. Best. A brief, focused analysis prevents a poor hire and gives the selection process clear criteria. It can be done in an hour.

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02

MODULE 2 · ATTRACT

Employer Branding, Recruitment and Selection

Attract and select the right people: EVP, sourcing, assessment, structured interviews and fairness

BY THE END OF THIS MODULE YOU WILL BE ABLE TO

- Build an evidence-based EVP and an honest employer brand
- Plan recruitment channels and manage the recruitment funnel with data
- Choose valid, reliable and fair selection methods
- Design and run structured interviews with anchored scales
- Check selection for bias and adverse impact and close offers professionally

LESSONS

1. Employer Branding and the EVP · 22 min
2. Recruitment: Sourcing and Candidate Experience · 24 min
3. Selection Methods and Assessment · 26 min
4. Structured Interviews · 26 min
5. Fair Selection, Decisions and Offers · 24 min

MODULE 2 · ATTRACT · LESSON 1 · 22 MIN

Employer Branding and the EVP

Give the right people a true and compelling reason to join and stay

- Define employer brand and employee value proposition
- Build an EVP from evidence rather than slogans
- Use realistic job previews to improve fit and retention
- Audit how the employer brand appears to candidates

Candidates research employers the way customers research products. Before applying they read reviews, ask friends, scroll social media and judge how quickly and politely you reply. Your **employer brand** already exists whether you manage it or not. The question is whether it is accurate, attractive to the people you need and consistent with what it is really like to work for you.

> DEFINITION · EMPLOYER BRAND AND EVP
> The **employer brand** is the reputation an organisation has as a place to work. The **employee value proposition (EVP)** is the deliberate, honest offer behind it: what people get from working here (pay, growth, purpose, flexibility, culture) in return for what they give.

Five pillars of a strong EVP

P1
Reward
Pay, benefits, bonuses, security and financial wellbeing.

P2
Growth
Learning, career paths, mentoring and challenging work.

P3
Purpose
Mission, social impact and pride in what the organisation does.

P4
Work and life
Flexibility (including hybrid or remote options where the work allows), workload, location, safety and wellbeing.

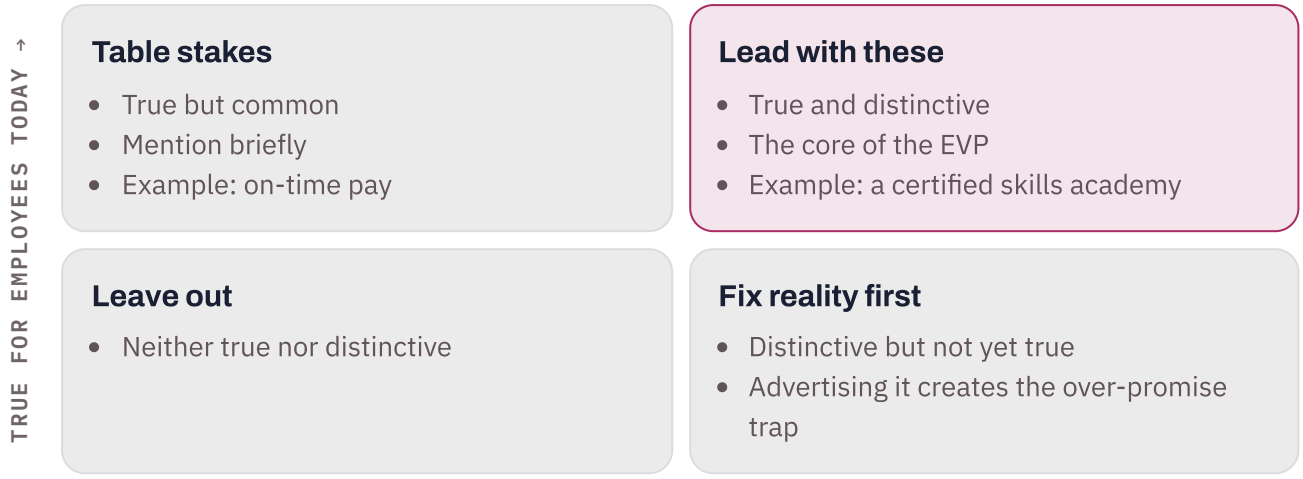
P5
People and culture
Leaders, colleagues, inclusion, recognition and how decisions are made.

Building an EVP from evidence

1. **Listen inside** Run focus groups and surveys with high performers and recent joiners: why did they join, why do they stay?
2. **Listen outside** Review candidate feedback, review sites, decline reasons and exit interviews.
3. **Find the truth and the edge** Identify what is genuinely true and also distinctive compared with competitors for talent.
4. **Write the EVP** A short core statement plus pillar proof points, tailored for key talent segments.
5. **Test it** Check with employees: do they recognise it? Over-promising destroys trust quickly.
6. **Activate and measure** Use it in ads, careers pages, interviews and onboarding; track application quality and early turnover.

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Choosing EVP claims



Sort every claim from your listening exercise into a quadrant. Only top-right claims belong in the headline; bottom-right claims become an improvement plan, not advertising.

WATCH OUT · THE OVER-PROMISE TRAP

An EVP that promises "amazing work-life balance" while staff routinely work late will attract people who then leave angry, and they will post reviews. A brand built on claims that do not match reality costs more than having no brand at all.

Tailoring the EVP to talent segments

SEGMENT	WHAT OFTEN MATTERS MOST	PROOF POINTS TO SHOW
Fresh graduates	Learning, mentoring, first career step	Graduate programme structure, promotion stories, training hours
Experienced engineers	Interesting problems, tools, autonomy, pay	Tech stack, team stories, engineering blog, salary bands
Factory operators	Fair, on-time pay, safety, respect, transport	Payment record, safety statistics, worker testimonials, facilities
Nurses and clinicians	Staffing ratios, shift patterns, professional growth	Ratios, rota policy, CPD support, career ladders
Returners after a career break	Flexibility, support, no penalty for the gap	Returnship programme, flexible roles, peer network

EXAMPLE · REALISTIC JOB PREVIEW IN A CONTACT CENTRE

A Dhaka telecom contact centre added a ten-minute video showing a real shift: angry callers, scheduled breaks, the call-quality dashboard and team celebrations. Some applicants withdrew, but six-month turnover among hires fell noticeably because new joiners knew what they were signing up for.

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Employer brand audit

☐ Search your organisation's name with 'jobs', 'salary' and 'reviews' and read what candidates see

☐ Check the careers page on a mobile phone: does it load fast and show real people and roles?

☐ Count how many days candidates wait for a reply at each stage

☐ Read the last 20 decline reasons and the last 20 exit interview summaries

☐ Ask five recent joiners what surprised them in their first month

☐ Check that job ads use inclusive language and show a pay range (some laws now require pay information before interview)

☐ Confirm that every rejected candidate receives a respectful message

SCENARIO · DECIDE · RESPONDING TO A BAD REVIEW

A former employee posts a detailed negative review of your hospital on a jobs website, claiming nurses are forced to work double shifts without overtime pay. Applications for nursing roles have dropped. What should HR do first?

(A) Investigate whether the claim is accurate, fix any real problem, then post a calm, factual response explaining what has changed.

(B) Ask the website to remove the review as defamatory.

(C) Ask current staff to post positive reviews to push it down the page.

(D) Ignore it; reviews do not matter in healthcare recruitment.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

REFLECT

Write your organisation's EVP in two sentences. Would your newest employees agree it is true? What evidence would you show a sceptical candidate?

Key terms

Employer brand
An organisation's reputation as a place to work, as seen by candidates, employees and the public.

Realistic job preview
Information that shows candidates both the attractive and the difficult parts of a job before they accept it.

Brand ambassador
An employee who willingly shares authentic stories about working at the organisation.

Employer brand audit
A structured review of how the organisation appears to candidates across channels and stages.

Employee value proposition (EVP)
The honest, distinctive offer an employer makes to people in return for their skills, effort and commitment.

Talent segment
A group of current or potential employees with similar skills and priorities, used to tailor the EVP and recruitment.

Candidate persona
A research-based profile of a target candidate group, describing their goals, concerns and where they look for jobs.

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Key takeaways

- The employer brand is your reputation as an employer; the EVP is the honest offer behind it.
- Build the EVP from evidence: why people join, stay, decline and leave.
- Lead with claims that are both true and distinctive; fix reality before advertising it.
- Realistic job previews reduce early turnover by letting people self-select.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. What is the main difference between employer brand and EVP?

   (A) They mean exactly the same thing
   (B) The EVP is only about salary
   (C) The brand is the reputation; the EVP is the deliberate offer behind it
   (D) The brand is set by HR alone, while the EVP is decided by candidates during interviews

2. Why do realistic job previews often reduce early turnover?

   (A) New hires know the hard parts before they accept, so fewer are shocked
   (B) They lower salary expectations
   (C) They reduce the number of interviews needed, so hiring managers save time
   (D) They remove the need for onboarding

3. Which is the best first step when building an EVP?

   (A) Hire an agency to write a slogan
   (B) Copy the careers page of a well-known competitor that already attracts many applicants
   (C) Increase all salaries by 10%
   (D) Gather evidence from current employees and candidates

4. For factory operators, which proof point is likely to matter most?

   (A) An engineering blog
   (B) A record of fair, on-time pay and safety
   (C) Global mobility programmes and international assignments
   (D) Stock options

5. What is the biggest risk of an EVP that over-promises?

   (A) Too many applications to process
   (B) Hires discover the gap, leave quickly and damage the brand further
   (C) Legal action from competitors who say the promises are misleading
   (D) Lower costs per hire

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MODULE 2 · ATTRACT · LESSON 2 · 24 MIN

Recruitment: Sourcing and Candidate Experience

Reach the right candidates through the right channels and treat every one with respect

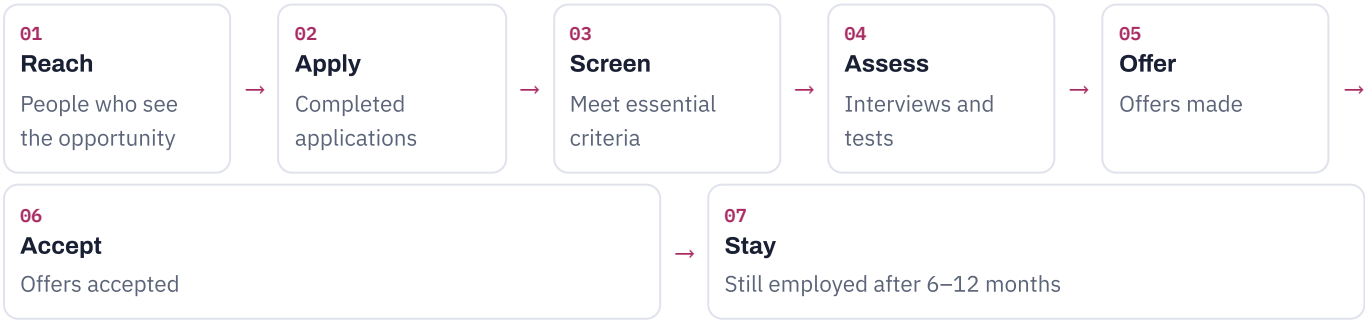
- Choose recruitment channels for different roles and markets
- Write inclusive, effective job advertisements
- Design a recruitment funnel and spot where it leaks
- Improve candidate experience at every stage

Recruitment generates a pool of suitable candidates; **selection** chooses among them. Many hiring problems blamed on selection actually start earlier: the ad attracted the wrong people, the channel missed the best ones, or slow replies made strong candidates accept other offers.

Recruitment channels compared

CHANNEL	BEST FOR	WATCH-OUTS
Internal job posting	Promotion and mobility; retention	Must be genuinely open, not decided in advance
Employee referrals	Fast, good fit, lower cost	Can reduce diversity if networks are similar
Job boards and professional networks	Broad reach for professional roles	High volume, mixed quality
University partnerships and campus drives	Graduate and trainee roles	Seasonal; needs relationship-building
Recruitment agencies and search firms	Scarce or senior roles	Fees; brand control
Community and local channels	Factory, retail and field roles	Needs local partners, notices and word of mouth
Social media and talent communities	Brand building, passive candidates	Requires consistent content and quick replies

The recruitment funnel



Funnel conversion

MEASURE	FORMULA	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Stage conversion rate	`Conversion = candidates moving to next stage ÷ candidates at this stage × 100`	Shows where the funnel leaks. A low screen-to-assess rate may mean the ad attracts the wrong people.

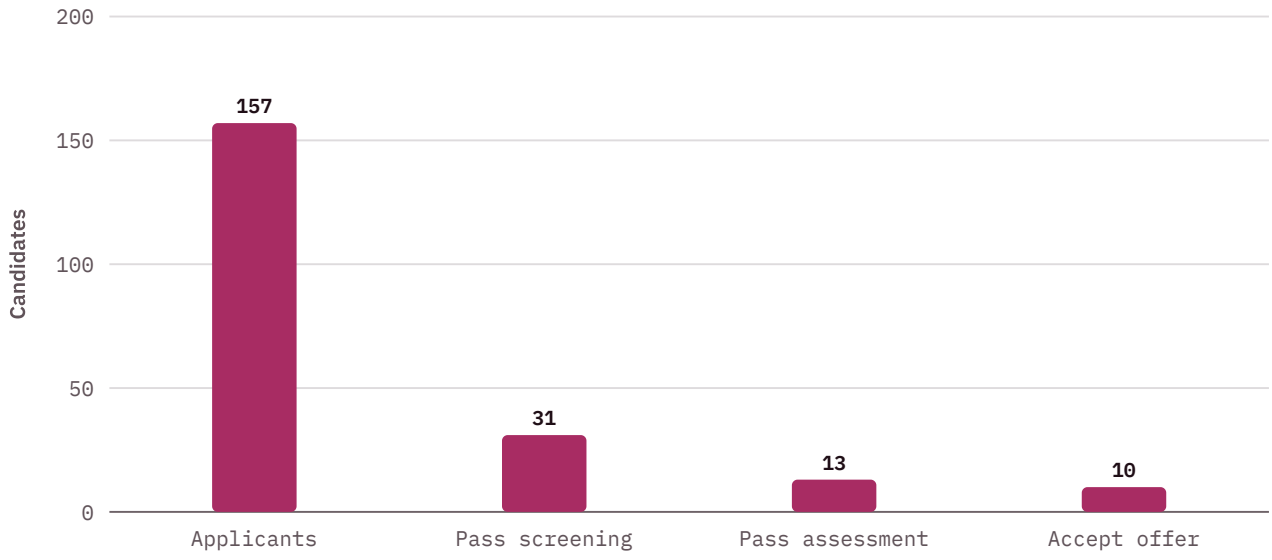
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MEASURE	FORMULA	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Applicants needed	`Applicants needed = hires required ÷ (product of stage conversion rates)`	Works backwards from hires to the size of pool you must attract.
Offer acceptance rate	`Acceptance = offers accepted ÷ offers made × 100`	Low rates point to pay, speed, employer brand or candidate experience problems.

EXAMPLE · WORKING THE FUNNEL BACKWARDS

A Chattogram logistics firm needs 10 warehouse supervisors. Past data: 20% of applicants pass screening, 40% of those pass assessment, 80% of offers are accepted. Applicants needed = 10 ÷ (0.20 × 0.40 × 0.80) = 10 ÷ 0.064 ≈ **157 applicants**. If the usual channel brings 60, HR knows early that it must add channels.

Funnel for 10 warehouse supervisors



Worked-example numbers, rounded. Each stage keeps only a fraction of the one before, so a small hiring target needs a large top of funnel. The steepest drop, at screening, is where to look first if the pool is wrong.

Job ad: weak vs strong

Weak

- "Dynamic rockstar wanted for fast-paced environment"
- Long list of 'must haves', many not essential
- No pay information
- Jargon and internal titles
- Gendered or age-coded wording such as 'young, energetic'

Strong

- Clear title people actually search for
- Purpose of the role and what success looks like
- Five to seven essential criteria, separated from desirable ones
- Pay range, location, working pattern and benefits (pay information is now a legal duty in some places)
- Inclusive wording and an invitation to request adjustments

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INSIGHT · FEWER REQUIREMENTS, MORE APPLICANTS

Long requirement lists discourage capable people, especially those who apply only when they meet every point. Separate **essential** from **desirable** and remove anything you will not actually assess.

WATCH OUT · AI IN SOURCING AND SCREENING

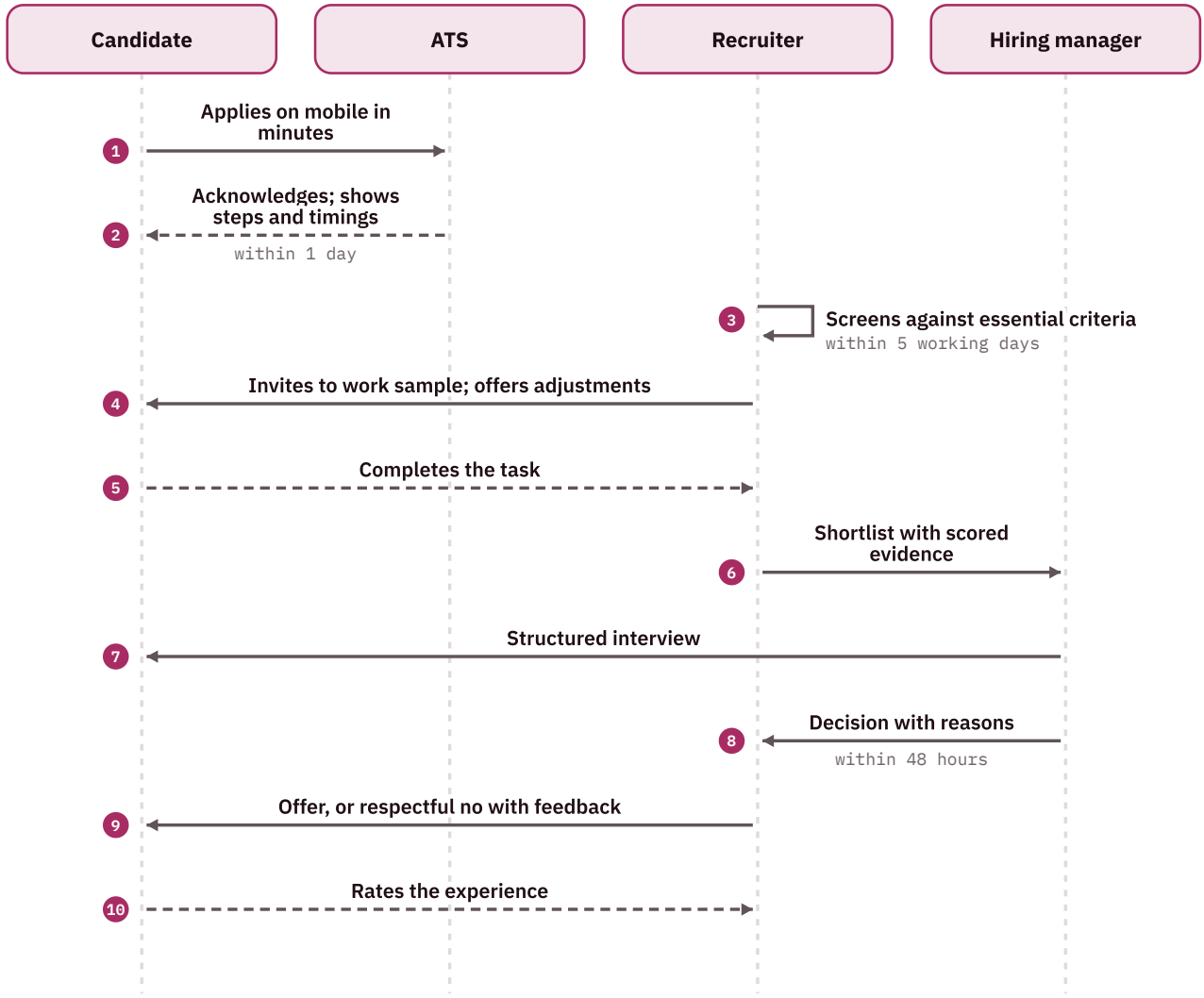
Many applicant tracking systems now use AI to write ads, search talent pools, rank applications and chat with candidates. Candidates also use generative AI to write CVs and cover letters, so polished writing is a weaker signal than it was. Treat AI ranking as a selection method: keep criteria job-related, check outcomes for adverse impact, tell candidates when AI is used and keep a person accountable for decisions. Under the EU AI Act, systems used to target job ads or to filter and evaluate applicants are classed as **high-risk**; their obligations were scheduled to start in August 2026 and EU institutions have proposed postponing part of that timetable, so check the current official dates. Other places have their own rules, such as bias-audit requirements for automated hiring tools in some US cities.

Candidate experience essentials

- Acknowledge every application quickly, ideally automatically and within a day.
- Tell candidates the steps, timings and what each assessment involves.
- Keep application forms short and mobile-friendly; do not ask for data you do not need.
- Give interviewers the candidate's details in advance so no one is asked to repeat themselves.
- Reject with respect: a clear, timely message, and brief feedback where possible.
- Ask candidates, including rejected ones, to rate the process and act on the results.

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A respectful candidate journey



Every arrow is a moment when the candidate judges you. The service levels in the notes are illustrative; agreeing your own turns "good candidate experience" into commitments you can measure.

SCENARIO · DECIDE · REFERRALS DOMINATING HIRING

A software company in Dhaka fills 70% of its engineering roles through employee referrals. Hiring is fast and quality is good, but the engineering team has become very similar in background: mostly men from three universities. What should HR recommend?

(A) Stop the referral programme immediately.

(B) Keep the referral programme but add broader channels such as university partnerships across regions and women-in-tech communities, and track the diversity of each channel's applicants and hires.

(C) Set a rule that referred candidates must score higher than others to be hired.

(D) Do nothing; quality is good so diversity does not matter.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

TEMPLATE **Recruitment channel plan**

Plan which channels to use for a role, the expected yield and cost, and how you will measure them.

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ROLE	CHANNEL	EXPECTED APPLICANTS	COST (BDT)	OWNER	MEASURE
Warehouse supervisor	*Local job board + referrals + community notice*	*160*	*45,000*	*Talent acquisition officer*	*Applicants per channel, hires per channel, 6-month retention*

REFLECT

Map the recruitment funnel for a recent hire in your organisation. At which stage did you lose the most good candidates, and why?

Key terms

Recruitment
The process of attracting a pool of suitable candidates for a role.

Applicant tracking system (ATS)
Software that manages job postings, applications, candidate communication and hiring workflow.

Employee referral programme
A scheme that encourages employees to recommend candidates, often with a reward if the hire succeeds.

Offer acceptance rate
The percentage of job offers that candidates accept.

Sourcing
Actively finding and engaging potential candidates, including people not yet looking for a job.

Recruitment funnel
The stages candidates pass through from first seeing a job to being hired and staying.

Candidate experience
How candidates perceive and feel about every interaction with an employer during hiring.

Key takeaways

- Many hiring problems start in recruitment: the wrong ad, the wrong channel or slow replies.
- Work the funnel backwards from hires to find how many applicants you need and where it leaks.
- Strong ads state purpose, essential criteria and pay; inclusive wording widens the pool.
- AI sourcing and screening tools need the same fairness checks, transparency and human accountability as any method.
- Candidate experience is a set of measurable service levels, including respectful rejections.

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KNOWLEDGE CHECK

6. Past data shows 25% of applicants pass screening and 50% of those pass assessment, and all offers are accepted. How many applicants are needed for 5 hires?

   (A) 20
   (B) 10
   (C) 80
   (D) 40

7. Which change is most likely to widen a narrow applicant pool for a professional role?

   (A) Separate essential from desirable criteria and cut unnecessary requirements
   (B) Add more 'must have' requirements
   (C) Remove the salary information
   (D) Use internal job titles in the ad so applicants understand exactly where the role sits

8. What is a known risk of relying heavily on employee referrals?

   (A) Referrals are always slower than agencies
   (B) Referred hires always perform worse
   (C) The workforce may become less diverse
   (D) Referrals are illegal in most countries

9. A firm makes 40 offers and 28 are accepted. What is the offer acceptance rate?

   (A) 28%
   (B) 40%
   (C) 143%
   (D) 70%

10. Which practice most improves candidate experience for rejected applicants?

    (A) No reply, so they assume the outcome
    (B) A timely, respectful message with brief feedback where possible
    (C) A reply only if they chase HR at least twice, to show genuine interest in the role
    (D) A generic message sent three months later

11. An ATS vendor offers an AI feature that ranks applicants for interview. What should HR do before using it in live hiring?

    (A) Switch off acknowledgement emails so candidates are not distracted by AI notices
    (B) Let the AI make final offer decisions automatically so recruiters can focus on sourcing
    (C) Test its rankings for job relevance and adverse impact on past or pilot data
    (D) Raise the number of applicants needed per hire

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MODULE 2 · ATTRACT · LESSON 3 · 26 MIN

Selection Methods and Assessment

Choose assessments that predict performance fairly and reliably

- Explain reliability and validity in selection
- Compare common selection methods for prediction, fairness and cost
- Design a multi-method assessment process for a role
- Use references and background checks appropriately

Selection is a prediction exercise: from a few hours of evidence, you are forecasting how someone will perform for years. Some methods predict well; others feel convincing but predict little. Professional HR chooses methods on **evidence**, not habit, and combines them so that each covers what the others miss.

Reliability vs validity

Reliability: is it consistent?

- Two assessors give similar scores to the same answer
- A candidate retested would score similarly
- Improved by structure, training and clear scoring guides

Validity: does it predict what matters?

- Scores relate to later job performance
- The assessment content reflects the real job
- A method can be reliable yet not valid, but not valid if unreliable

Selection methods at a glance

METHOD	PREDICTIVE POWER	FAIRNESS RISK	COST AND EFFORT
Structured interview	High; among the strongest in recent re-analyses	Low to moderate if well designed	Moderate
Unstructured interview	Low to moderate	High: bias and inconsistency	Low, but misleading
Work sample or job simulation	High	Low; seen as fair by candidates	Moderate to high
Cognitive ability test	Moderate to high; recent re-analyses suggest older estimates were too high	Can show group differences; use with care	Low per candidate
Personality questionnaire	Modest; best for specific traits	Low to moderate	Low
Situational judgement test	Moderate	Low to moderate	Moderate to build
Assessment centre	Moderate to high	Moderate	High
Years of experience or education alone	Low	Moderate to high	Low

INSIGHT · COMBINE, DO NOT RELY ON ONE

A structured interview plus a short work sample usually beats any single method. Each method samples different evidence, and errors in one are partly balanced by the other. Add more methods only if they add new information.

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Choosing methods: prediction versus cost

PREDICTIVE POWER ↑

Best value
- Structured interview
- Short job-related skills test
- Well-built situational judgement test

Worth it for key roles
- Work sample or simulation
- Assessment centre

Cheap but weak
- Unstructured chat
- Years of experience alone
- CV keyword filters

Avoid
- Long unstructured panels
- Handwriting or "face reading"
- Unvalidated video-analysis tools

COST AND EFFORT PER CANDIDATE →

Placement is approximate and depends on the role and on how well each method is built. Start top-left, add top-right methods for critical or high-volume roles, and drop anything in the bottom half.

Common work samples by role

W1
Accountant
Reconcile a sample ledger with planted errors and explain findings.

W2
Sewing supervisor
Plan a line balance for a new style and handle a simulated absence.

W3
Software engineer
Review a short pull request and suggest improvements.

W4
Customer agent
Handle a role-played complaint call and log it correctly.

W5
HR officer
Draft a reply to an employee's leave query using the policy.

Designing an assessment process

1. **Start from the job profile** List the essential criteria from job analysis.
2. **Map criteria to methods** Choose the best method for each criterion; each criterion assessed at least once, key ones twice.
3. **Set scoring rules** Define what good, acceptable and poor look like before seeing candidates.
4. **Decide the decision rule** Multiple hurdle (must pass each stage) or compensatory (strengths offset weaknesses), or a mix.
5. **Pilot and check** Try the process on current staff; check timing, clarity and accessibility.
6. **Monitor outcomes** Track pass rates by group and later performance of hires.

TEMPLATE **Assessment matrix**

Map each essential criterion to the methods that will assess it, so nothing is missed or double-counted without reason.

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CRITERION	APPLICATION SCREEN	WORK SAMPLE	STRUCTURED INTERVIEW	REFERENCE	WEIGHT
Line planning skill	–	*✓ line balance exercise*	*✓ past example*	–	*30%*
Team leadership	–	*✓ absence simulation*	*✓ behavioural questions*	✓	*30%*

WATCH OUT · REFERENCES AND BACKGROUND CHECKS

References are better at confirming facts (dates, role, conduct concerns) than at predicting performance. Ask structured questions, get the candidate's consent, and contact referees only at the agreed stage. Background checks such as criminal records or credit history should be lawful, proportionate to the role and explained to the candidate.

PRO TIP · GENERATIVE AI AND TAKE-HOME TASKS

Candidates can now complete many take-home exercises with AI help. Decide and state your policy: either allow AI and assess how well candidates use and check it, or use supervised or live tasks where independent skill matters. Ask candidates to talk through their work in the interview; the explanation is much harder to outsource than the output.

EXAMPLE · AN ASSESSMENT CENTRE FOR MANAGEMENT TRAINEES

A Bangladeshi conglomerate selects 15 management trainees from 400 shortlisted graduates using a one-day assessment centre: a group case discussion, an in-tray exercise, a presentation and a structured interview. Trained assessors from different business units score each exercise against four competencies and then meet to agree final ratings using the evidence.

SCENARIO · DECIDE · A MANAGER'S FAVOURITE METHOD

A senior manager insists on hiring sales executives using one long, informal conversation over tea, saying "I can judge people in five minutes." Several recent hires have failed probation. What should HR propose?

(A) Let the manager continue but add a personality test at the end.

(B) Remove the manager from hiring decisions entirely.

(C) Introduce a structured interview and a short role-play sales call, scored against agreed criteria, and show the manager the evidence on prediction.

(D) Lengthen the informal conversation to an hour so the manager has more time.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

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REFLECT

Which selection method does your organisation rely on most? Based on this lesson, what one method would you add to improve prediction for a key role?

Key terms

Reliability
The consistency of an assessment: whether it gives similar results across assessors and occasions.

Work sample test
An assessment in which candidates perform a realistic sample of the job's tasks.

Situational judgement test
A test presenting realistic work dilemmas and asking candidates to choose or rate responses.

Multiple hurdle approach
A decision rule in which candidates must pass each stage to continue, so strengths cannot offset failure at any one stage.

Predictive validity
The degree to which assessment scores predict later job performance.

Cognitive ability test
A standardised test of reasoning, learning and problem-solving ability.

Assessment centre
A process using several exercises and trained assessors to evaluate candidates against defined competencies.

Key takeaways

- Selection is prediction: choose methods on evidence of validity, reliability, fairness and cost.
- Structured interviews and work samples are strong, practical choices; combine methods only when they add new evidence.
- Map every essential criterion to at least one method and set scoring rules before meeting candidates.
- References confirm facts; background checks must be lawful, proportionate and explained.
- Set a clear policy on candidates' use of AI in assessments.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

12. Two interviewers give very different scores to the same answer. Which property of the assessment is weak?
    - (A) Validity only
    - (B) Face validity
    - (C) Reliability
    - (D) Utility

13. Which method is generally among the strongest predictors and is seen as fair by candidates?
    - (A) Work sample test
    - (B) Unstructured interview
    - (C) Handwriting analysis
    - (D) Years of experience alone

14. In a compensatory decision approach:
    - (A) Strong scores in one area can offset weaker scores in another
    - (B) Candidates must pass every stage separately
    - (C) Only the interview score counts
    - (D) The first candidate who meets the minimum standard is hired without comparing the rest

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15. What are references most useful for?

(A) Predicting long-term job performance with a high degree of accuracy

(B) Replacing interviews

(C) Confirming facts such as dates, role and conduct concerns

(D) Assessing technical skills in depth

16. Why should an assessment process be piloted on current staff?

(A) To decide which current staff to dismiss

(B) To check clarity, timing and accessibility before candidates face it

(C) Because employment law requires current staff to take every test used in hiring

(D) To lower the pass mark

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MODULE 2 · ATTRACT · LESSON 4 · 26 MIN

Structured Interviews

Ask the same job-related questions, score against anchors, decide on evidence

- Explain why structured interviews predict better than unstructured ones
- Write behavioural and situational questions linked to criteria
- Build anchored rating scales and use them consistently
- Run a fair interview panel and evidence-based wash-up

The interview is the most widely used selection method in the world and, done casually, one of the least accurate. **Structure** transforms it. When every candidate gets the same job-related questions, and answers are scored against agreed examples of good and poor responses, interviews become far more reliable and predictive, and much fairer.

DEFINITION · STRUCTURED INTERVIEW

A **structured interview** asks all candidates the same pre-planned questions, derived from job analysis, and rates each answer on a defined scale with behavioural anchors. Interviewers take notes, score independently and then compare evidence.

Six elements of structure

S1
Job-based questions
Every question links to an essential criterion from the job profile.

S2
Same questions, same order
All candidates get the same core questions; follow-up probes are planned.

S3
Anchored rating scales
Each score point has a description of what an answer at that level looks like.

S4
Note-taking
Interviewers record evidence, not impressions.

S5
Independent scoring
Each panellist scores before discussion to avoid group pressure.

S6
Trained interviewers
Panellists know the process, the scale and common biases.

Two question types

Behavioural (past)

- "Tell me about a time you had to..."
- Based on the idea that past behaviour predicts future behaviour
- Probe for the situation, task, action and result
- Best for candidates with relevant experience

Situational (future)

- "Imagine that... What would you do?"
- Tests judgement and reasoning in job-like dilemmas
- Works for graduates and career changers
- Score against model answers agreed in advance

Probing with STAR

01 **Situation** — What was the context? →
02 **Task** — What were you responsible for? →
03 **Action** — What did you personally do, and why? →
04 **Result** — What happened, and what did you learn?

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Anchored rating scale: 'Handles conflict constructively'

SCORE	ANCHOR: WHAT THE ANSWER SHOWS
5 – Strong	Addresses the conflict early, listens to both sides, finds the underlying issue, agrees a solution, follows up and reflects on learning
4 – Good	Addresses conflict directly and fairly with a workable outcome; limited follow-up
3 – Acceptable	Resolves the immediate issue but relies on authority or escalation; little exploration of causes
2 – Weak	Avoids the conflict until it escalates or takes sides without hearing both parties
1 – Poor	No relevant example, blames others, or describes behaviour that made things worse

PRO TIP · WRITE THE ANCHORS BEFORE THE INTERVIEWS

Agree anchors with the hiring manager when designing the questions. Writing them after meeting candidates lets impressions of favourite candidates shape the scale.

WATCH OUT · REMOTE INTERVIEWS AND AI TOOLS

Video interviews widen the pool but need the same structure. If you use transcription or AI note-taking, tell candidates and get consent where the law requires it, and keep scoring with trained people using the anchors. Avoid tools that claim to read personality or emotion from faces or voices: the evidence is weak, and AI that infers emotions at work is prohibited in the EU except for medical or safety reasons.

TEMPLATE **Structured interview guide**

Plan questions, probes and scoring for each criterion so every candidate is assessed the same way.

CRITERION	MAIN QUESTION	PLANNED PROBES	STRONG ANSWER SHOWS	WEAK ANSWER SHOWS	SCORE (1–5)
Patient safety focus	*Tell me about a time you noticed a risk to a patient that others had missed.*	*What did you do first? Who did you tell? What changed afterwards?*	*Acted promptly, escalated correctly, followed up on system fix*	*Ignored, delayed or blamed others; no follow-up*	

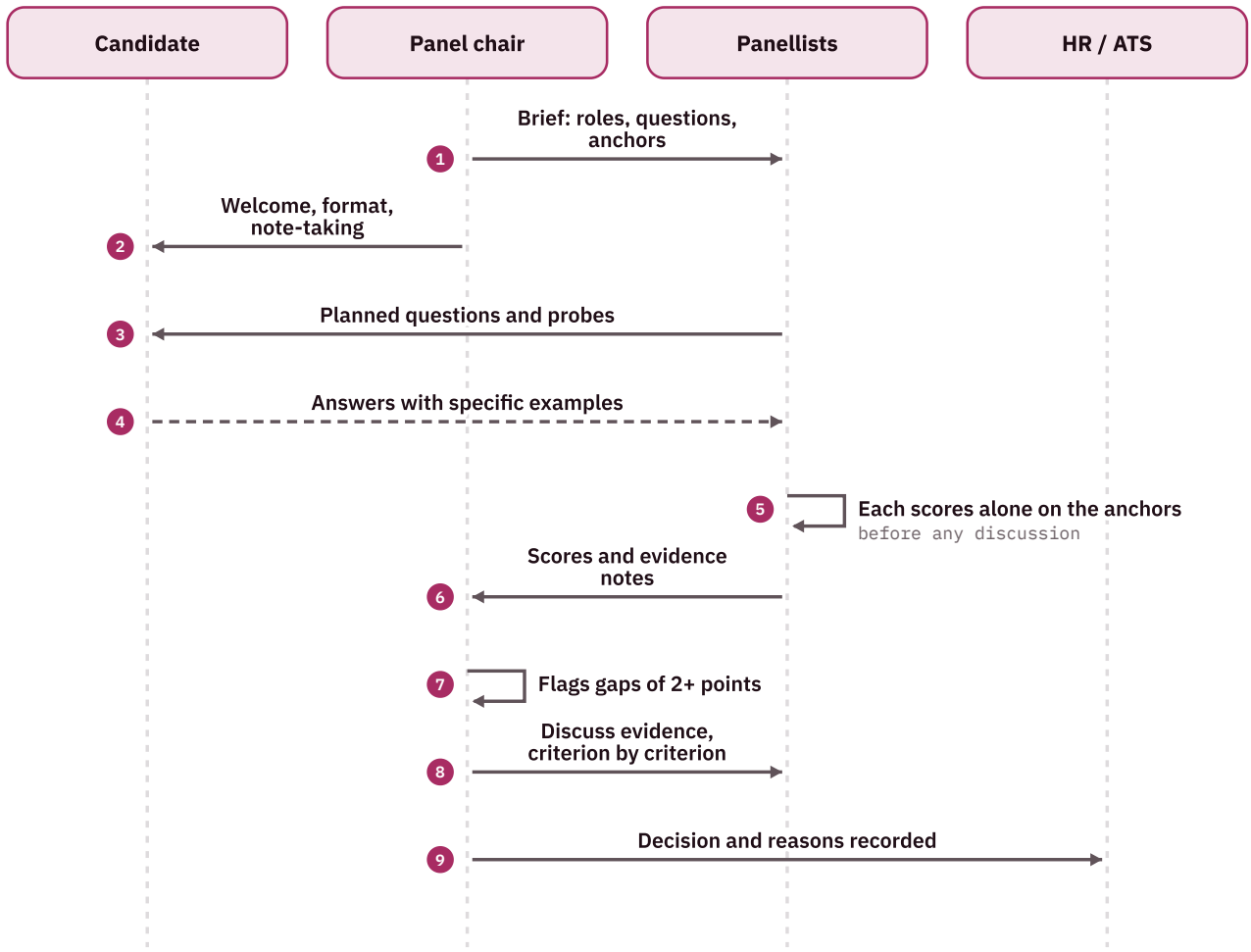
Running the panel and the wash-up

1. **Brief the panel** Agree roles: who asks which questions, who keeps time, who notes.
2. **Open well** Welcome, explain the format and note-taking, invite questions at the end.

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3. **Ask and probe** Stick to the planned questions; use probes to get specific evidence.
4. **Score independently** Each panellist scores immediately after the interview, using the anchors.
5. **Wash-up** Compare scores criterion by criterion; discuss evidence where scores differ by two or more points.
6. **Decide and record** Apply the agreed decision rule and record reasons in the ATS.

From interview to recorded decision



Notice where independence is protected: scores are written before the wash-up, and discussion focuses on criteria where panellists disagree. The record at the end is what makes the decision explainable if it is challenged.

SCENARIO · DECIDE · A CANDIDATE WHO 'JUST FELT RIGHT'

In the wash-up for a finance manager role at a university, two panellists rate Candidate A highest overall because "she was so confident and we got on really well". On the scoring sheets, Candidate B scored higher on four of five criteria. What should the chair do?

(A) Offer the role to Candidate A because two of three panellists prefer her.

(B) Re-interview both candidates informally over lunch.

(C) Ask the panellists to adjust their scores so that they match their overall preference.

(D) Bring the panel back to the evidence for each criterion and decide using the agreed scoring rule, recording the reasons.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

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Interviewer checklist

☐ I have read the job profile and the candidate's application

☐ I know which questions I am asking and the planned probes

☐ I will take evidence notes, not opinions

☐ I will not ask about marital status, pregnancy, religion, age or family plans

☐ I will score each answer immediately using the anchors

☐ I will offer any agreed adjustments for candidates who need them

REFLECT

Think of the last interview you conducted or attended. Which of the six elements of structure were present? What would you change first?

Key terms

Structured interview
An interview using the same job-related questions for all candidates, with answers rated on defined, anchored scales.

Situational question
An interview question presenting a hypothetical job situation and asking what the candidate would do.

STAR
A probing structure covering Situation, Task, Action and Result to get specific behavioural evidence.

Probe
A planned follow-up question used to obtain specific evidence from a candidate's answer.

Behavioural question
An interview question asking candidates to describe how they handled a real past situation.

Behaviourally anchored rating scale (BARS)
A rating scale where each point is described with examples of the behaviour expected at that level.

Wash-up
The post-interview meeting in which panellists compare evidence and scores and reach a decision.

Key takeaways

- Structure (same job-related questions, anchored scales, notes, independent scoring) makes interviews more reliable, valid and fair.
- Use behavioural questions for experienced candidates and situational ones for new entrants; probe with STAR.
- Write anchors before meeting candidates.
- In the wash-up, discuss evidence where scores diverge and decide by the agreed rule, not by rapport.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

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17. Why do structured interviews predict performance better than unstructured ones?

(A) They are shorter
(B) They let experienced interviewers follow their instincts about each candidate's character
(C) They avoid asking about past behaviour
(D) They use consistent, job-related questions scored against defined anchors

18. "Imagine a supplier delivers late on the day of a major shipment. What would you do?" This is a:

(A) Behavioural question
(B) Leading question
(C) Situational question
(D) Closed question

19. In the wash-up, two panellists' scores for one criterion differ by three points. What should happen?

(A) They discuss the specific evidence each recorded before finalising
(B) They average the two scores without discussion to save time and avoid disagreement
(C) The most senior person's score is used
(D) The criterion is dropped

20. Which question should an interviewer NOT ask?

(A) "Tell me about a time you met a tight deadline."
(B) "How would you handle an upset customer?"
(C) "What did you learn from your last project?"
(D) "Are you planning to start a family soon?"

21. When should rating-scale anchors be written?

(A) After the first interview
(B) Before any candidates are interviewed
(C) After all interviews, to fit the best candidate
(D) Only if candidates complain

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MODULE 2 · ATTRACT · LESSON 5 · 24 MIN

Fair Selection, Decisions and Offers

Spot bias, check for adverse impact and close the hiring process professionally

- Recognise common biases in selection and how to reduce them
- Calculate adverse impact using the four-fifths rule of thumb
- Provide reasonable adjustments in selection
- Make, record and communicate hiring decisions and offers

Fairness in selection is both an ethical duty and a business advantage. Biased processes miss talent, invite legal challenge and damage the employer brand. Because bias is mostly automatic, good intentions are not enough: fairness has to be **designed into** the process and **checked with data**.

Common biases in selection

BIAS	WHAT HAPPENS	COUNTERMEASURE
Affinity (similar-to-me)	Favouring people who share our background, school or interests	Structured questions; diverse panels; score on evidence
Halo and horns	One strong or weak feature colours every rating	Score each criterion separately and immediately
First impression	The first minutes decide the outcome	Delay judgement; rely on full evidence
Confirmation	Seeking evidence that supports an early view	Use the same probes for all candidates
Contrast	Rating a candidate relative to the previous one	Score against anchors, not against each other
Stereotyping	Assumptions based on gender, age, religion, region or disability	Training; anonymised screening; job-related criteria only

Checking for adverse impact

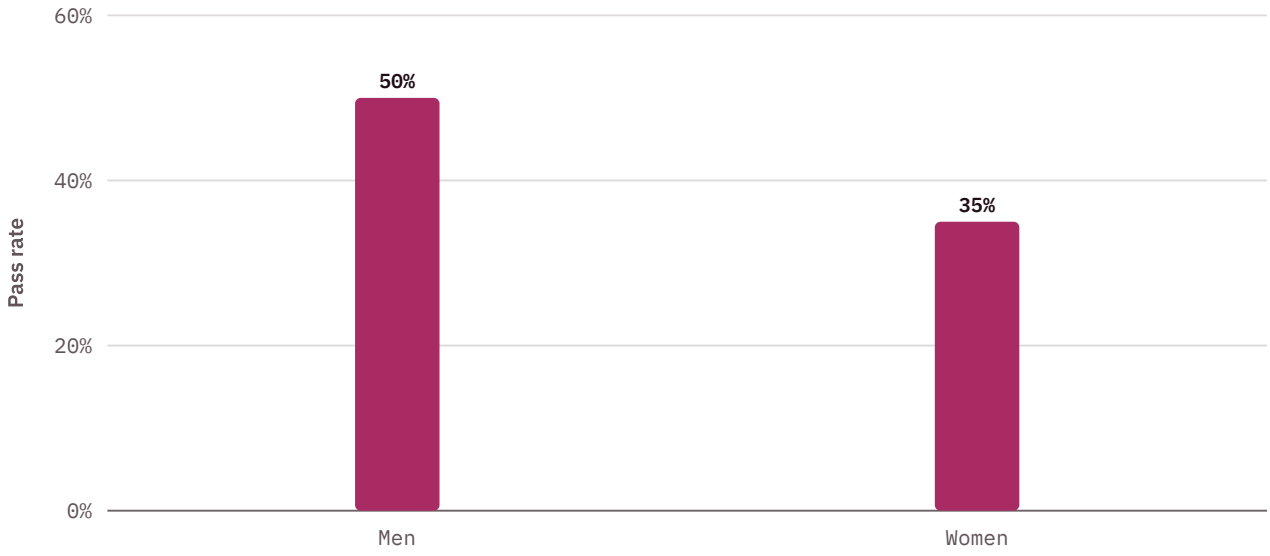
MEASURE	FORMULA	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Selection rate	`Selection rate = number selected from a group ÷ number of applicants from that group`	The share of each group that passes a stage.
Impact ratio	`Impact ratio = selection rate of a group ÷ selection rate of the group with the highest rate`	Compares each group with the most successful group.
Four-fifths rule of thumb	`Flag for review if impact ratio < 0.80`	A screening signal, not proof of discrimination; investigate the stage and method.

EXAMPLE · CALCULATING ADVERSE IMPACT

A bank's online test is taken by 300 men and 200 women. 150 men pass (50%) and 70 women pass (35%). Impact ratio for women = 0.35 ÷ 0.50 = **0.70**, below 0.80. HR should review the test: does it measure something genuinely needed for the job, is there a less-adverse alternative, and are the instructions or time limits creating barriers?

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Pass rates in the bank's online test



Worked-example data. Four-fifths of the highest rate (50%) is 40%; the women's rate of 35% falls below that line, giving an impact ratio of 0.70 and a signal to investigate the test.

WATCH OUT · SMALL NUMBERS MISLEAD

With very small groups, one candidate can swing the ratio wildly. Look at trends over several hiring rounds and use statistical advice where decisions are significant. The rule of thumb is a prompt to investigate, not a verdict.

INSIGHT · SAME CHECKS FOR AUTOMATED TOOLS; NEW RULES AT OFFER STAGE

Apply impact-ratio checks to every stage, including AI screening and automated assessments; some jurisdictions now require independent bias audits and candidate notices for such tools. Rules at the offer stage are changing too: the **EU Pay Transparency Directive**, which member states had to bring into national law by June 2026, requires employers to give candidates the starting pay or its range before interview (for example in the advert) and stops them asking about pay history. Salary-history bans also exist elsewhere. Check what applies where you hire.

Reasonable adjustments in selection

- Invite every candidate to request adjustments, and make it easy and confidential.
- Typical adjustments: extra time, accessible venues, screen-reader-friendly tests, sign-language interpreters, rest breaks, remote interviews.
- Adjust how something is assessed, not the standard itself, unless the standard is not genuinely required.
- Keep adjustment information separate from the decision-makers' scoring where possible.
- Check local law: many countries require adjustments for disabled candidates.

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From decision to day one

01 Decision
Apply the agreed rule; record reasons

→

02 Pre-offer checks
References, right to work, credentials

→

03 Verbal offer
Confirm key terms and answer questions

→

04 Written offer
Pay, start date, conditions, probation

→

05 Acceptance
Signed offer; agree notice period

→

06 Pre-boarding
Welcome and keep in touch until day one

PRO TIP · OFFERS LOST IN THE GAP

Strong candidates often receive several offers. Long silences between final interview and offer, or between offer and start, are where many hires are lost. Agree turnaround times (for example, decision within 48 hours of the final interview) and keep candidates warm.

CASE STUDY · BIAS IN A GRADUATE HIRING DRIVE

A Dhaka-based FMCG company hires 40 management trainees a year. Over three years, 85% of hires came from four private universities in Dhaka, and only 22% were women, although women made up 41% of applicants. Screening is done by line managers who read CVs and pick those they like. Interviews are unstructured. Leaders want to know whether the process is fair and how to improve it.

1. What data would you analyse first?

2. Which stages are most likely to introduce bias?

3. What changes would you recommend, and in what order?

4. How would you know if the changes worked?

Model answer: module answer key.

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SCENARIO · DECIDE · A DISABLED CANDIDATE'S REQUEST

A candidate with a visual impairment applies for an analyst role and asks for the timed numerical test in a screen-reader-compatible format with extra time. The test provider's standard format is not compatible. What should HR do?

(A) Work with the provider to supply an accessible version with extra time, or use an equivalent alternative assessment that tests the same skill.

(B) Skip the test for this candidate and move them straight to interview.

(C) Explain that the test is standard and cannot be changed.

(D) Ask the candidate to bring someone to read the questions aloud.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

REFLECT

If you analysed your last year of hiring by gender, region or university, what do you think the data would show? What is stopping you from checking?

Key terms

Unconscious bias
Automatic, unintended associations that influence judgements and decisions about people.

Affinity bias
The tendency to favour people who are similar to ourselves.

Adverse impact
A substantially lower selection rate for one group compared with another, which may indicate unfair barriers.

Four-fifths rule
A rule of thumb that flags possible adverse impact when a group's selection rate is below 80% of the highest group's rate.

Reasonable adjustment
A change to the way a process or job is done so that a disabled person is not put at a disadvantage.

Compensatory approach
A selection decision rule in which weighted scores are combined so strengths can offset weaknesses.

Conditional offer
A job offer that becomes final only when stated conditions, such as references or credential checks, are met.

Key takeaways

- Bias is mostly automatic, so fairness must be designed into the process and checked with data.
- Impact ratio = group selection rate ÷ highest group rate; below 0.80 is a signal to investigate, not proof.
- Reasonable adjustments change how a skill is assessed, not the standard.
- Apply the same checks to AI and automated tools, and follow pay-information and salary-history rules at offer stage.
- Fast, clear decisions and offers stop strong candidates slipping away.

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KNOWLEDGE CHECK

22. Group X's pass rate is 30% and group Y's is 60%. What is the impact ratio for group X?

(A) 0.30
(B) 0.50
(C) 0.60
(D) 2.00

23. What does an impact ratio below 0.80 mean?

(A) Discrimination has been legally proven
(B) The group must be hired regardless of scores
(C) The test is invalid and must be scrapped immediately for all future hiring rounds
(D) The stage should be investigated for possible unfair barriers

24. An interviewer rates every criterion highly because the candidate went to the same university. This is mainly:

(A) Affinity bias combined with a halo effect
(B) Contrast bias
(C) Confirmation of anchors
(D) Leniency caused by giving the candidate a reasonable adjustment

25. What is the principle behind a reasonable adjustment in selection?

(A) Lower the pass mark for disabled candidates
(B) Skip assessment for disabled candidates
(C) Change how a skill is assessed, not the genuine standard required
(D) Let candidates choose whichever test they feel most comfortable taking

26. Where are strong candidates most often lost late in the process?

(A) During the job advert stage only
(B) When they receive the job description
(C) When references are requested with the candidate's consent after a conditional offer
(D) In long silences between final interview, offer and start date

☐ Lesson complete · Date _____ · Knowledge check score ____ / 5

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MODULE 2 · ATTRACT

Answer key

Knowledge checks

1. C Employer brand is how you are seen; the EVP is what you actually offer in return for people's contribution.

2. A Accurate expectations improve fit; people who would leave early tend to self-select out.

3. D A credible EVP starts with evidence of why people join and stay.

4. B Different segments value different things; for operators, fair pay, safety and respect are core.

5. B Promises that do not match reality cause early turnover and negative word of mouth.

6. D 5 ÷ (0.25 × 0.50 × 1.0) = 5 ÷ 0.125 = 40.

7. A Long requirement lists discourage capable candidates; clarity on essentials widens the pool.

8. C People tend to refer others similar to themselves, which can narrow diversity.

9. D 28 ÷ 40 × 100 = 70%.

10. B Timely, respectful closure protects the brand and treats people with dignity.

11. C An AI ranking tool is a selection method, so it needs evidence that it is job-related and fair before use. Hiding it from candidates or letting it decide alone removes transparency and human accountability.

12. C Inconsistent scores across assessors mean low reliability, which also limits validity.

13. A Work samples closely mirror the job, predict well and feel relevant to candidates.

14. A Compensatory models add weighted scores; multiple hurdle models require passing each stage.

15. C References confirm information but are weak predictors of performance.

16. B Piloting finds practical problems early and helps calibrate scoring.

17. D Consistency and job relevance raise reliability and validity.

18. C Situational questions present a hypothetical job scenario.

19. A Large differences signal different interpretations; discussing evidence resolves them fairly.

20. D Questions about family plans are not job-related and can lead to discrimination.

21. B Writing anchors in advance prevents impressions of candidates from shaping the scale.

22. B 0.30 ÷ 0.60 = 0.50, well below the 0.80 rule of thumb.

23. D The four-fifths rule is a screening signal, not proof.

24. A Shared background triggers affinity, and one positive feature then colours every rating.

25. C Adjustments remove barriers without abandoning job-related standards.

26. D Delays let competitors make offers first; agree and keep to turnaround times.

Scenarios & case studies

> **Scenario · Responding to a bad review**
> **A** is best. Best. Credibility depends on the reality. Fixing the issue and responding transparently protects both staff and the brand.

> **Scenario · Referrals dominating hiring**
> **B** is best. Best. Referrals are valuable; the fix is to widen the pool and monitor outcomes, not to remove a channel that works.

> **Scenario · A manager's favourite method**
> **C** is best. Best. Evidence-based methods improve hiring quality while still involving the manager. Showing data persuades better than arguing.

> **Scenario · A candidate who 'just felt right'**
> **D** is best. Best. Structure only works if the decision follows the evidence. Rapport and confidence are not the criteria.

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Case study · Bias in a graduate hiring drive

Start by calculating selection rates and impact ratios by gender and university type at each stage (screen, test, interview, offer, acceptance) for the last three years. The likely bias points are subjective CV screening and unstructured interviews, where affinity and stereotyping operate unchecked. Recommended changes: define essential criteria from job analysis; use a short, validated online test or work-sample task for initial screening; anonymise CVs at the screening stage; widen campus outreach to public and regional universities; introduce structured interviews with trained, diverse panels and anchored scales; and set turnaround and communication standards. Success measures: impact ratios moving towards parity at each stage, a broader university mix, stable or improved trainee performance and retention, and better candidate-experience ratings.

Scenario · A disabled candidate's request

A is best. Best. This adjusts how the skill is assessed without lowering the standard, which is both fair and, in many countries, a legal requirement.

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03

MODULE 3 · DEVELOP

Onboarding, Talent Management and Learning

Develop people: onboarding, talent reviews, succession and learning that changes performance

BY THE END OF THIS MODULE YOU WILL BE ABLE TO

- Design onboarding that delivers compliance, clarity, culture and connection
- Run fair talent reviews and build succession plans for critical roles
- Analyse learning needs and design learning systematically
- Deliver learning for transfer and evaluate it up to business results and ROI

LESSONS

1. Onboarding That Works · 22 min
2. Talent Management and Succession · 26 min
3. Learning Needs and Learning Design · 24 min
4. Learning Delivery, Transfer and Evaluation · 24 min

MODULE 3 · DEVELOP · LESSON 1 · 22 MIN

Onboarding That Works

Turn a signed offer into a productive, connected and committed colleague

- Distinguish induction from onboarding
- Design pre-boarding, first-day, first-month and 90-day activities
- Use the four outcomes of good onboarding to check a programme
- Measure onboarding with time to productivity and early turnover

Many organisations spend weeks recruiting someone and then hand them a laptop, a policy folder and a desk. The first weeks shape whether new joiners feel they made the right choice. People who have a poor start are far more likely to leave within the first year, and every early leaver wastes the whole cost of hiring.

Induction vs onboarding

Induction

- An event: usually one to three days
- Policies, safety, forms and facilities
- Same for everyone
- Run mainly by HR

Onboarding

- A process: typically 90 days to a year
- Role clarity, relationships, culture and early wins
- Tailored to role and person
- Led by the line manager, supported by HR and a buddy

Four outcomes of good onboarding

C1

Compliance

The basics are done: contract, ID, payroll, safety training, required policies.

C2

Clarity

The person knows what is expected, how success is measured and who to ask.

C3

Culture

They understand the unwritten rules: how decisions are made and what is valued.

C4

Connection

They have relationships: a buddy, a network and a manager who checks in.

INSIGHT · MOST PROGRAMMES STOP AT COMPLIANCE

Forms, policies and safety briefings are necessary but do not make anyone feel welcome or productive. Strong programmes invest just as much in clarity, culture and connection, which are what predict early retention.

PRO TIP · ONBOARDING HYBRID AND REMOTE JOINERS

Connection does not happen by accident when people are not in the same place. Send equipment and test access before day one, plan an early in-person day with the team where possible, give the buddy explicit time for daily check-ins in week one, and keep key "how we work" knowledge in one place. An AI assistant can answer routine questions about policies and systems if it draws only on approved content, but it never replaces the manager's conversations.

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The first 90 days

BEFORE DAY 1
Pre-boarding
Welcome message, paperwork online, equipment and access ready, first-week plan

DAY 1
Welcome
Manager time, workspace and tools working, buddy introduced

WEEK 1
Connect
Key introductions, team norms, a first small task

DAY 30
Clarify
Role goals agreed, training plan, first formal check-in

DAY 60
Adjust
Feedback both ways; extra support where needed

DAY 90
Review
Progress against goals, probation conversation, development plan

Each milestone has an owner and a visible output. Many decisions to leave early form in the first weeks, so the front of the timeline deserves the most care.

TEMPLATE **90-day onboarding plan**

Plan what the new joiner will learn, do and achieve in each phase, and who supports them.

PHASE	LEARN	DO	MEET	SUCCESS BY END OF PHASE	SUPPORT
Days 1–30	*Products, policies, systems, team norms*	*Shadow two senior agents; handle simple queries*	*Team, buddy, quality lead, IT*	*Handles 20 simple queries a day with ≥ 90% quality*	*Buddy daily; manager weekly*
Days 31–60	*Complex cases, escalation rules*	*Handle full query mix with spot checks*	*Compliance and product teams*	*Meets 80% of productivity target*	*Manager fortnightly; quality feedback*

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EXAMPLE · ONBOARDING AT SCALE IN A GARMENT FACTORY

A Gazipur factory hiring 150 operators a month replaced a half-day induction with a two-week 'learning line': operators practise on real machines with a trainer, learn safety and rights (including how to raise grievances), and are paired with an experienced operator for their first month on the floor. Turnover in the first 90 days fell sharply and line efficiency for new operators rose faster.

Measuring onboarding

MEASURE	FORMULA	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Early turnover rate	`Early turnover = hires who left within 90 days (or 12 months) ÷ total hires in the period × 100`	The most direct signal of onboarding and selection quality.
Time to productivity	`Time to productivity = days from start date until the agreed performance standard is reached`	Shows how quickly new joiners add full value; compare across teams.
New-hire satisfaction	`Average rating from 30-day and 90-day pulse surveys`	Early warning before people resign.

Day-one readiness checklist

☐ Contract signed and payroll details captured

☐ Laptop, accounts, ID card and access ready before arrival

☐ Workspace or remote kit prepared

☐ Manager has blocked at least an hour for the new joiner

☐ Buddy assigned and briefed

☐ First-week schedule shared with the new joiner

☐ Team informed and introductions planned

☐ Safety and emergency information ready

SCENARIO · DECIDE · A REMOTE JOINER LEFT ALONE

A data analyst joins a fintech remotely. On day three she messages HR: her laptop has no access to the data platform, her manager is travelling, and no one has explained her first project. What should HR do?

(A) Fix the access issue with IT the same day, arrange a call with a buddy or acting lead, and ask the manager to schedule a proper conversation within the week.

(B) Send her the employee handbook to read while she waits.

(C) Tell her that remote onboarding is always slow and to be patient.

(D) Escalate a complaint about the manager to the CEO.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

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REFLECT

Recall your own first week in your current job. Which of the four outcomes (compliance, clarity, culture, connection) did you get, and which were missing?

Key terms

Onboarding
The process, usually lasting several months, of helping new joiners become productive, connected and committed.

Pre-boarding
Activities between offer acceptance and the first day that welcome and prepare new joiners.

Time to productivity
The time a new joiner takes to reach the agreed performance standard for the role.

Probation period
An initial period of employment during which performance and suitability are reviewed before confirmation.

Induction
A short programme introducing new joiners to policies, safety, facilities and basic information.

Onboarding buddy
An experienced peer assigned to help a new joiner settle in and learn informal norms.

Early turnover
The proportion of new hires who leave within a short period, such as 90 days or the first year.

Key takeaways

- Induction is an event; onboarding is a process of 90 days or more, led by the line manager.
- Check every programme against the four Cs: compliance, clarity, culture and connection.
- Plan milestones from pre-boarding to day 90 with owners; design connection in for remote joiners.
- Measure with early turnover, time to productivity and new-hire pulse surveys.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Which is the key difference between induction and onboarding?
   - (A) They are the same thing
   - (B) Onboarding is only for managers
   - (C) Induction is a short event; onboarding is a longer process
   - (D) Induction is led by the line manager, while onboarding is mainly run by the IT team
2. A new hire knows all the policies but has no idea how her performance will be measured. Which onboarding outcome is weak?
   - (A) Clarity
   - (B) Compliance
   - (C) Connection
   - (D) Culture
3. A firm hired 60 people last year; 9 left within 90 days. What is the 90-day early turnover rate?
   - (A) 9%
   - (B) 6.7%
   - (C) 51%
   - (D) 15%

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4. Who should lead onboarding for a new team member?

(A) Payroll
(B) The line manager, supported by HR and a buddy
(C) The CEO
(D) The recruitment agency that sourced the candidate

5. Which activity belongs in pre-boarding?

(A) The 90-day probation review meeting with the line manager
(B) Sending a welcome message and a first-week plan before the start date
(C) The first performance rating
(D) The exit interview

☐ Lesson complete · Date _____ · Knowledge check score ____ / 5

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MODULE 3 · DEVELOP · LESSON 2 · 26 MIN

Talent Management and Succession

Identify, grow and deploy talent so critical roles are never left empty

- Choose an inclusive or exclusive talent philosophy
- Run a fair talent review using performance and potential
- Build a succession plan with readiness levels
- Use career paths and internal mobility to retain talent

Talent management is the set of practices that identify, develop, deploy and retain people who create the most value, now and in future. It overlaps with recruitment, learning and performance, but its distinctive question is forward-looking: *who will lead and do our most critical work in three to five years, and what are we doing about it today?*

Two talent philosophies

Exclusive

- Focus on a small group of high performers and high potentials
- Concentrates investment where returns may be highest
- Risk: others feel undervalued; labels can be wrong
- Common for leadership pipelines

Inclusive

- Every employee has talent to develop
- Broad development, internal mobility for all
- Risk: investment spread thin
- Common in purpose-driven and public organisations

INSIGHT · MOST ORGANISATIONS BLEND THE TWO

A practical approach is an **inclusive base** (everyone gets development and career conversations) with **targeted pools** for critical roles and leadership. Be transparent about how people enter pools and how they can get there.

The nine-box grid: performance × potential

POTENTIAL / PERFORMANCE	LOWER PERFORMANCE	MODERATE PERFORMANCE	HIGH PERFORMANCE
High potential	Enigma: find the blocker	Growth employee: stretch assignments	Future leader: accelerate, plan moves
Moderate potential	Dilemma: coach and clarify	Core contributor: develop in role	High performer: broaden, retain
Lower potential	Address performance or role fit	Effective in role: recognise	Trusted professional: reward expertise

WATCH OUT · POTENTIAL IS EASY TO MISJUDGE

Ratings of potential are often biased towards people who are visible, confident or similar to senior leaders. Define potential with evidence-based indicators such as **learning agility, drive, judgement and ability to lead others**, and require examples in the talent review. Never share box labels as fixed identities.

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Running a talent review

1. **Prepare evidence** Managers rate performance and potential with examples, and capture aspirations from career conversations.
2. **Calibrate** Managers meet with HR to challenge and align ratings across teams.
3. **Identify risks** Flag flight risks, key-person dependencies and roles with no successor.
4. **Agree actions** Development plans, stretch assignments, moves, retention actions.
5. **Communicate** Managers share development actions with each person; not the box itself.
6. **Follow up** Track actions quarterly; review the grid annually.

Succession and mobility metrics

MEASURE	FORMULA	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Bench strength	`Bench strength = critical roles with at least one ready successor ÷ total critical roles × 100`	How well protected the organisation is against losing key people.
Internal fill rate	`Internal fill rate = vacancies filled internally ÷ total vacancies filled × 100`	A signal of career opportunity and pipeline health.
Successor readiness mix	`Count of successors rated ready now, ready in 1–2 years and ready in 3+ years`	Shows whether the pipeline is deep or thin.

Prioritising succession risk

IMPACT IF THE ROLE IS EMPTY →

Build the bench
- Critical but stable
- Name successors; develop over 1–3 years

Act now
- Critical and at risk
- Ready-now cover, retention talk, knowledge capture

Monitor
- Lower impact and stable
- Review annually

Retain or replace fast
- Lower impact but at risk
- Retention action or a quick external hire

LIKELIHOOD OF LOSING THE INCUMBENT →

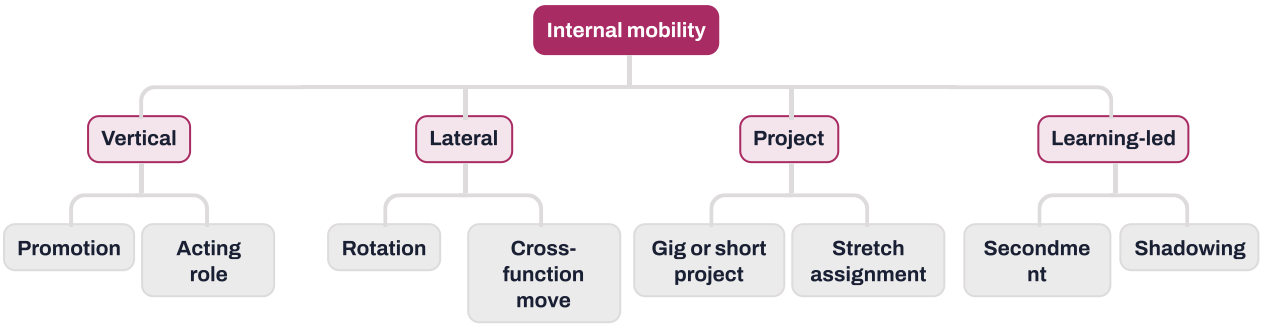
Rate each role, not the person. Top-right roles are where an empty chair hurts most and soonest, as in the university case below, so they get named successors and interim cover first.

DEFINITION · INTERNAL TALENT MARKETPLACE

An **internal talent marketplace** matches employees to open roles, short projects, gigs and mentors by skills and interests, often through a platform with AI matching. It speeds up build and redeploy and lets people grow without leaving. It works when managers agree to release people for moves, opportunities are visible to everyone, the matching logic is explained, and HR checks who gets opportunities by group.

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Routes for internal mobility



Promotion is only one route. Lateral, project and learning-led moves build broader capability and keep people growing when promotion slots are scarce, which is common in flatter structures.

TEMPLATE

Succession plan for critical roles

Record successors and readiness for each critical role and the development needed to close the gap.

CRITICAL ROLE	INCUMBENT RISK	SUCCESSOR	READINESS	DEVELOPMENT GAP	ACTION AND DATE
Head of Production, Chattogram plant	*Retiring in 18 months*	*Deputy production manager*	*Ready in 1–2 years*	*Budgeting; leading supervisors*	*Finance course; acting head during leave, by Q3*

CASE STUDY · NO SUCCESSOR FOR A CRITICAL ROLE

A private university's head of IT resigns with one month's notice. No one internally is ready to step up, the student information system migration is mid-way, and an external search will take four months. A talent review last year listed 'IT leadership' as a risk, but no action was taken.

1. What immediate steps should the university take?

2. What went wrong in the talent process?

3. How should the university strengthen succession for critical roles?

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Model answer: module answer key.

SCENARIO · DECIDE · TELLING SOMEONE THEIR TALENT STATUS

After a talent review at a bank, an employee asks her manager, "Am I a high-potential? A colleague said he is in the top box." What is the best response from the manager?

(A) Confirm that she is not in the top box, so expectations are realistic.

(B) Explain how the talent process works, share the specific development actions agreed for her and discuss her aspirations, without assigning or comparing box labels.

(C) Say that the talent review is confidential and end the conversation.

(D) Tell her she is a high-potential to keep her motivated, even though she is not in that pool.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

REFLECT

Which roles in your organisation would cause the most damage if their holder left tomorrow? Who could step in, and how ready are they?

Key terms

Talent management
Practices that identify, develop, deploy and retain the people who create the most value now and in the future.

Nine-box grid
A talent review tool plotting employees on performance and potential to guide development and succession decisions.

Succession planning
Identifying and developing people to fill critical roles when they become vacant.

Internal mobility
Movement of employees into new roles inside the organisation through promotion, transfer or project assignments.

High-potential employee
An employee assessed as able and willing to grow into significantly bigger or more complex roles.

Talent review
A structured meeting where leaders discuss and calibrate people's performance, potential, risks and development.

Bench strength
The proportion of critical roles that have at least one ready successor.

Internal talent marketplace
A platform or process that matches employees to open roles, projects, gigs and mentors inside the organisation by skills and interests.

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Key takeaways

- Talent management asks who will do the most critical work in three to five years, and what you are doing about it now.
- Blend an inclusive base with targeted pools, and be open about how people enter them.
- Judge potential on evidence, calibrate ratings and share development actions, not box labels.
- Prioritise succession by role impact and vacancy risk; track bench strength and internal fill rate.
- Use lateral, project and marketplace moves as well as promotion to keep people growing.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

6. A company has 20 critical roles; 13 have at least one ready-now successor. What is its bench strength?
   - (A) 13%
   - (B) 35%
   - (C) 54%
   - (D) 65%
7. On the nine-box grid, an employee with high potential but low current performance is often described as:
   - (A) An enigma whose blocker should be found
   - (B) A future leader to accelerate into a bigger role
   - (C) A trusted professional
   - (D) A core contributor
8. What is the main purpose of calibration in a talent review?
   - (A) To reduce everyone's ratings
   - (B) To decide salaries
   - (C) To challenge and align ratings across managers
   - (D) To replace individual performance reviews for the whole year
9. Which indicator is a better basis for judging potential than visibility or confidence?
   - (A) Length of service
   - (B) How often they speak in meetings
   - (C) Similarity to the leadership style of the chief executive
   - (D) Learning agility shown through evidence
10. Vacancies filled last year: 50; filled by internal candidates: 20. What is the internal fill rate?
    - (A) 20%
    - (B) 40%
    - (C) 60%
    - (D) 25%

☐ Lesson complete · Date _____ · Knowledge check score ____ / 5

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MODULE 3 · DEVELOP · LESSON 3 · 24 MIN

Learning Needs and Learning Design

Start from the performance gap, then design learning that sticks

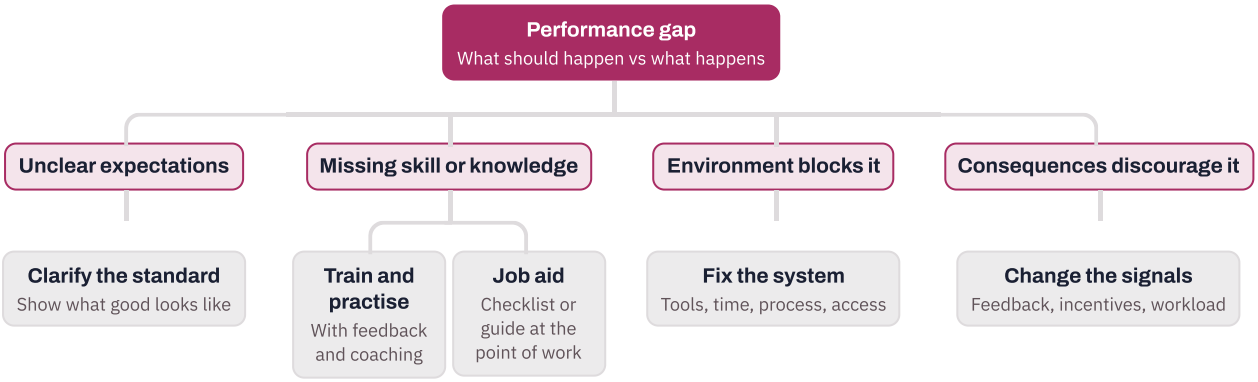
- Run a learning needs analysis at organisation, role and individual level
- Decide when training is, and is not, the right solution
- Apply a systematic design cycle and adult learning principles
- Write clear, measurable learning objectives

Learning and development (L&D) builds the capability the strategy needs. Too often it starts with a course catalogue rather than a problem. The best L&D teams start with a question: *what performance must change, for whom, and why is it not happening now?* Sometimes the answer is training; often it is a process, tool, incentive or management issue.

Three levels of learning needs analysis

Organisation	`Strategy and change plans` `New products, systems, regulation` `Workforce plan gaps`
Role or team	`Job profile and competencies` `Performance data and quality errors` `Customer and audit findings`
Individual	`Performance reviews and career goals` `Self-assessment and manager input` `Assessment results`

Is training the answer?



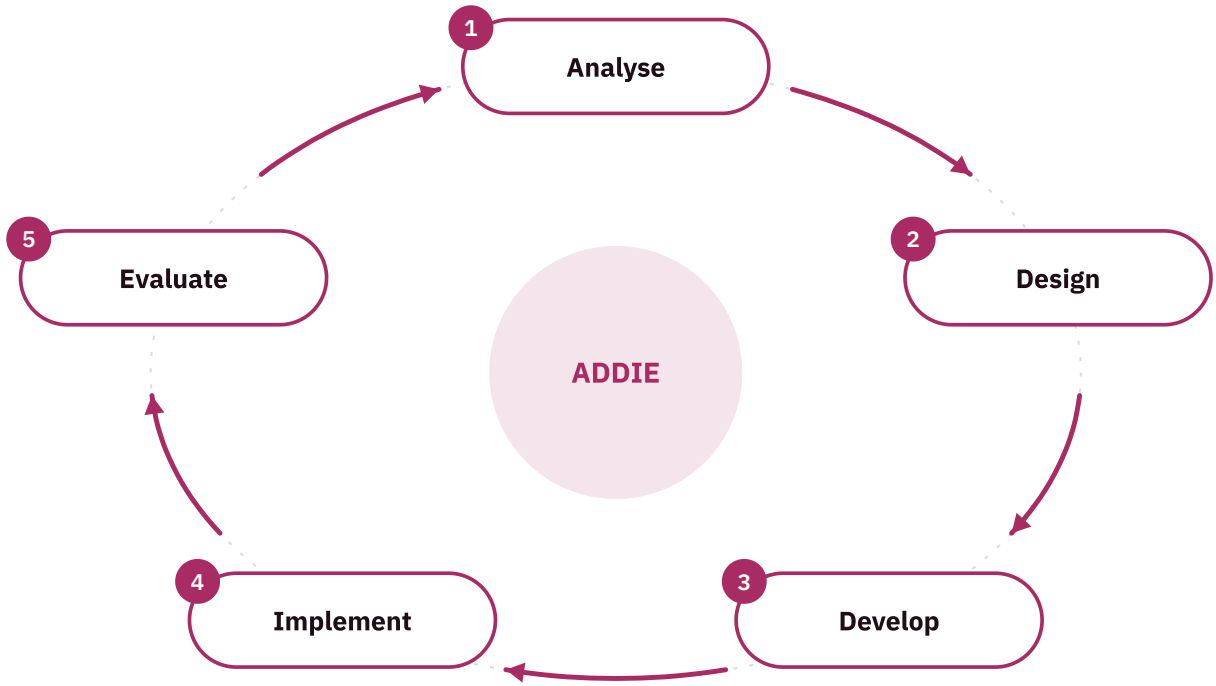
Only one branch leads to training. Check the others first: in the hand-hygiene example below, the cause sat in the environment branch, and fixing it worked without a single course.

EXAMPLE · NOT A TRAINING PROBLEM

A hospital asked L&D for hand-hygiene training because compliance on one ward was 55%. Observation showed staff knew the procedure; the gel dispensers were empty or in awkward places, and no one gave feedback. Moving dispensers, a refill rota and weekly feedback lifted compliance to over 85% without a single course.

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ADDIE: a systematic design cycle



1. **Analyse** — Confirm the need, the audience, the context and the performance goal
2. **Design** — Set objectives, choose methods, plan assessment and sequence
3. **Develop** — Build materials, activities, job aids and digital content; pilot them
4. **Implement** — Deliver, support managers and learners, manage logistics
5. **Evaluate** — Check reaction, learning, behaviour and results; improve the design

Drawn as a loop on purpose: evaluation feeds the next analysis. In practice teams run quick prototype–test–improve loops inside Design and Develop rather than one long waterfall.

PRO TIP · ITERATE, DO NOT WATERFALL

Treat ADDIE as a loop. Build a rough prototype, test it with a few learners, improve it and release in stages. This catches problems early and keeps learning close to real work.

Adult learning principles

- Adults want to know **why** they need to learn something before they invest effort.
- They bring experience: use it in discussion and examples.
- They learn best when content solves **real, current problems**.
- They want some control over pace, path and format.
- Practice with feedback beats listening to explanations.
- Spacing practice over time beats one long session.

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The 70-20-10 guideline

70

Experience

Learning on the job: stretch tasks, projects, rotations, solving real problems.

20

Others

Learning through people: coaching, mentoring, feedback, peer learning.

10

Formal

Courses, workshops, e-learning and reading.

INSIGHT · A GUIDELINE, NOT A FORMULA

The 70-20-10 split is a reminder that formal courses are a small part of how people learn, not a precise ratio. Design formal learning to **launch** on-the-job practice and coaching rather than to replace them.

INSIGHT · AI IN LEARNING DESIGN

AI tools can draft case studies, quiz items and short modules in minutes, and can act as practice partners or tutors. They speed up Develop, but subject experts must check accuracy and bias, and the learning still has to target the performance gap. Skills data can personalise learning paths, provided learners can see why something is recommended to them.

TEMPLATE **Learning needs analysis worksheet**

Turn a business problem into a learning decision with a clear target.

BUSINESS PROBLEM	PERFORMANCE GAP	ROOT CAUSE	IS TRAINING NEEDED?	TARGET AUDIENCE	LEARNING OBJECTIVE
Loan application errors cause 3-day delays	*35% of applications returned for missing data*	*New officers unsure of the checklist; form is confusing*	*Partly: form redesign plus short training*	*42 new loan officers*	*Complete a loan application with zero missing fields using the checklist*

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SCENARIO · DECIDE · A REQUEST FOR LEADERSHIP TRAINING

A CEO asks L&D for a two-day leadership course for all 60 managers because "engagement scores are low". What should the L&D lead do first?

(A) Book the most popular leadership course available and schedule it next month.

(B) Decline, because engagement is not an L&D issue.

(C) Analyse the engagement data and talk to managers and staff to find the specific behaviours and causes behind the low scores before deciding on a solution.

(D) Send managers a reading list on leadership.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

REFLECT

Think of a training programme you attended that changed nothing at work. Which step of the needs diagnostic was skipped?

Key terms

Learning and development (L&D)
The function and activities that build the knowledge, skills and behaviours people need to perform and grow.

Performance gap
The difference between the required and actual level of performance.

70-20-10 guideline
A heuristic that most learning comes from experience, a smaller share from others and the least from formal courses.

Andragogy
Principles of how adults learn, emphasising relevance, experience, self-direction and problem-solving.

Learning needs analysis
A systematic review of organisational, role and individual needs to decide what learning is required.

ADDIE
A design cycle of Analyse, Design, Develop, Implement and Evaluate used to create learning programmes.

Learning objective
A clear statement of what learners will be able to do after learning, under what conditions and to what standard.

Key takeaways

- Start from the performance gap, not the course catalogue; analyse needs at organisation, role and individual level.
- Train only when skill or knowledge is missing; otherwise fix clarity, environment or consequences.
- Use ADDIE as a loop with quick prototypes, and write objectives as observable behaviour with conditions and a standard.
- Design for adults: relevance, experience, practice with feedback and spacing; 70-20-10 is a guideline.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

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11. Staff know the procedure but do not follow it because the equipment is missing. What is the right solution?

(A) Run refresher training
(B) Discipline all staff
(C) Fix the environment, not train them again
(D) Write a longer, more detailed procedure and ask staff to sign it

12. Which ADDIE phase sets learning objectives and chooses methods?

(A) Design
(B) Analyse
(C) Develop
(D) Implement

13. Which is the best-written learning objective?

(A) Process a refund in the system within five minutes with no errors
(B) Understand refunds
(C) Be aware of the refund policy and understand why it matters to customers
(D) Appreciate customer needs

14. According to the 70-20-10 guideline, most learning comes from:

(A) Formal courses
(B) Reading books
(C) On-the-job experience
(D) Coaching from a manager only

15. Which adult learning principle is MOST relevant when a course opens with a real problem learners face this month?

(A) Adults prefer long lectures
(B) Adults learn best when content solves current problems
(C) Adults should not use their experience
(D) Adults learn best when all content is delivered in one long, uninterrupted session

☐ Lesson complete · Date _____ · Knowledge check score ____ / 5

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MODULE 3 · DEVELOP · LESSON 4 · 24 MIN

Learning Delivery, Transfer and Evaluation

Make learning stick at work and prove what it changed

- Choose delivery methods for different needs and audiences
- Design for transfer of learning back to the job
- Evaluate learning at four levels
- Calculate training cost and return on investment

Learning only creates value when people **use** it at work. Many programmes are well rated on the day and forgotten within weeks. Delivery choices, manager support and follow-up practice decide whether learning transfers. Evaluation then shows what changed and whether it was worth the money.

Delivery methods

METHOD	BEST FOR	LIMITATIONS
Instructor-led workshop	Practice, discussion, complex skills	Cost, scheduling, travel
Live virtual session	Dispersed teams, short focused topics	Fatigue; needs strong facilitation
Self-paced e-learning	Knowledge, compliance, scale	Low completion and engagement if long
Microlearning	Refreshers, single skills, job aids	Not enough for complex capability
On-the-job training	Practical, role-specific skills	Depends on trainer quality
Coaching and mentoring	Leadership, behaviour, career growth	Time-intensive; needs skilled coaches
Simulation and role-play	Safety, customer and difficult conversations	Design effort

DEFINITION · BLENDED LEARNING

Blended learning combines methods into one journey, for example: a short online module to build knowledge, a workshop to practise, on-the-job assignments to apply, and coaching to reinforce. Each method does what it is best at.

Designing for transfer

01 **Before** — Manager agrees goals with the learner

→

02 **During** — Realistic practice with feedback

→

03 **Right after** — Action plan and a first application task

→

04 **Weeks 2–8** — Spaced refreshers and coaching check-ins

→

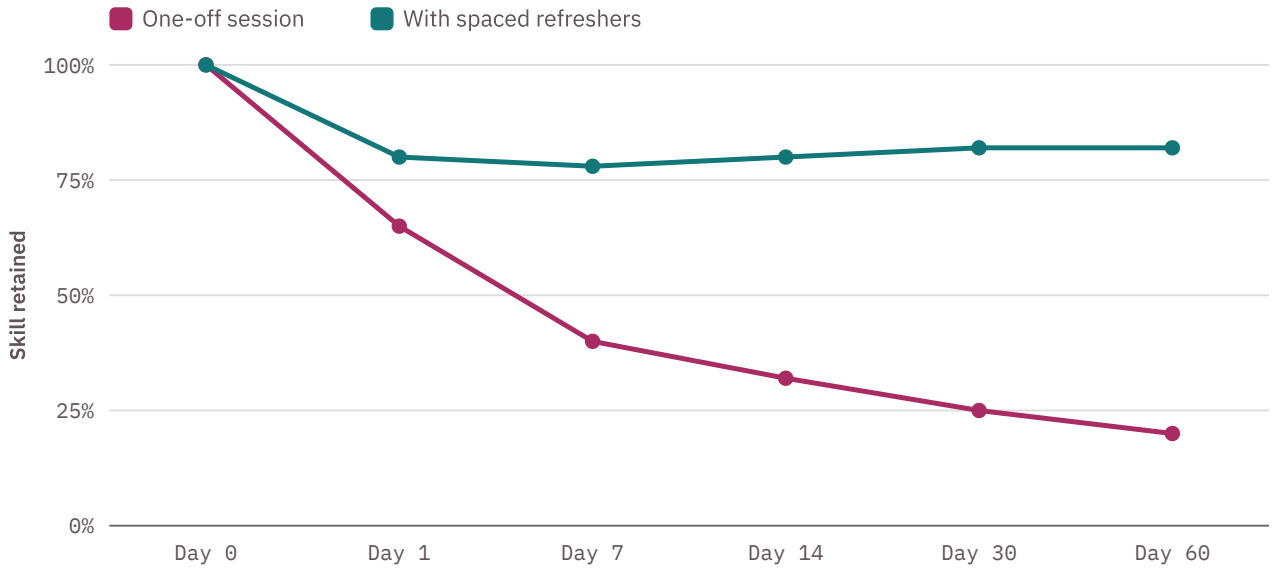
05 **Review** — Manager and learner review results

INSIGHT · MANAGERS ARE THE BIGGEST TRANSFER LEVER

Research consistently finds that what happens before and after the course matters as much as the course. A manager who discusses goals beforehand and asks "how are you using it?" afterwards multiplies the impact.

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Spaced practice and retention



Illustrative curves, not measured data. Without practice much of a one-off session fades within weeks; short spaced refreshers and use on the job (the "Weeks 2–8" step above) keep the skill available.

Four levels of evaluation

L1

Reaction

Did learners find it relevant and engaging? Measured by short surveys.

L2

Learning

Did knowledge and skill increase? Measured by tests, demonstrations and assessments.

L3

Behaviour

Are people doing things differently at work? Measured by observation, manager input and data.

L4

Results

Did business outcomes improve? Measured by quality, safety, sales, retention or cost.

PRO TIP · PLAN EVALUATION BACKWARDS

Start from Level 4: which result should change? Then define the behaviours (Level 3) that drive it, the learning (Level 2) needed, and the experience (Level 1) that helps. Collect a baseline before the programme so change can be shown.

Cost and return

MEASURE	FORMULA	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Training cost per participant	`Cost per participant = total programme cost ÷ number of participants`	Includes design, delivery, materials, venue, travel and participant time.
Training ROI	`ROI % = (monetary benefits − total costs) ÷ total costs × 100`	Positive ROI means the benefits exceeded the costs.

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MEASURE	FORMULA	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Benefit-cost ratio	`BCR = monetary benefits ÷ total costs`	A BCR of 2.0 means two taka of benefit for every taka spent.

EXAMPLE · CALCULATING ROI FOR SUPERVISOR TRAINING

A footwear factory trains 30 supervisors at a total cost of BDT 1,800,000 (including their time). Over the next year, rework falls and absence drops on their lines; finance estimates the savings at BDT 4,500,000, after isolating other factors as far as possible. ROI = (4,500,000 − 1,800,000) ÷ 1,800,000 × 100 = **150%**. BCR = 4.5m ÷ 1.8m = **2.5**.

WATCH OUT · ISOLATE THE EFFECT HONESTLY

Other changes, such as new machines or a seasonal dip in orders, can also move results. Use comparison groups, trend lines or estimates from participants and managers (adjusted for confidence) and state your assumptions. An inflated ROI destroys L&D's credibility.

SCENARIO · DECIDE · EVALUATION REQUEST FROM FINANCE

Finance asks L&D whether a customer-service programme for 120 agents was worth BDT 3 million. L&D only has post-course satisfaction scores averaging 4.6 out of 5. What is the best next step?

(A) Report the 4.6 satisfaction score as proof of success.

(B) Retrain everyone to be safe.

(C) Tell finance that training benefits cannot be measured.

(D) Compare customer satisfaction, complaint rates and first-contact resolution for trained agents before and after the programme, and against agents not yet trained, then estimate the monetary value of the change.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

REFLECT

Choose one programme you run or attended. What Level 3 behaviour should it have changed, and how could you measure it next time?

Key terms

Blended learning
A learning journey combining several methods, such as online modules, workshops, on-the-job practice and coaching.

Transfer of learning
The extent to which people apply what they learned in training to their work.

Training ROI
The net monetary benefit of a learning programme expressed as a percentage of its total cost.

Microlearning
Short, focused learning units, often a few minutes long, targeting a single skill or piece of knowledge.

Four-level evaluation
An evaluation approach measuring reaction, learning, behaviour and results.

Mentoring
A developmental relationship in which a more experienced person guides another's growth and career.

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Spaced practice
Practising a skill in several sessions spread over time, which improves long-term retention.

Key takeaways

- Blend delivery methods so each does what it is best at.
- Transfer depends on what happens before and after: manager goals, practice, spaced refreshers and follow-up.
- Plan evaluation backwards from results (Level 4) and collect a baseline first.
- ROI = (benefits − costs) ÷ costs × 100; isolate the effect honestly with comparison groups.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

16. A programme cost BDT 2,000,000 and produced estimated benefits of BDT 5,000,000. What is the ROI?

(A) 250%
(B) 40%
(C) 300%
(D) 150%

17. Observing whether supervisors now hold daily quality huddles after training measures which level?

(A) Reaction
(B) Learning
(C) Behaviour
(D) Results for the business

18. Which action most improves transfer of learning?

(A) Managers discussing goals before and application after the programme
(B) Making the course longer
(C) Adding more slides
(D) Holding the training off-site so participants are not distracted by daily work

19. What is the main weakness of using only satisfaction scores to evaluate training?

(A) They are too expensive to collect
(B) They measure business results too precisely for most managers to understand
(C) They are illegal to collect
(D) They show learners liked it, not that performance changed

20. A benefit-cost ratio of 3.0 means:

(A) A 3% return
(B) Three units of benefit for every unit spent
(C) The costs of the programme were three times the size of its benefits
(D) The programme ran three times

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MODULE 3 · DEVELOP

Answer key

Knowledge checks

1. C Induction covers basics in days; onboarding builds clarity, culture and connection over months.

2. A Clarity means knowing expectations and how success is measured.

3. D 9 ÷ 60 × 100 = 15%.

4. B Managers shape role clarity and relationships; HR provides the framework.

5. B Pre-boarding happens between acceptance and day one.

6. D 13 ÷ 20 × 100 = 65%.

7. A High potential with low performance suggests a blocker such as poor fit, unclear goals or personal issues.

8. C Calibration reduces inconsistent and biased ratings across teams.

9. D Evidence-based indicators such as learning agility reduce bias in potential ratings.

10. B 20 ÷ 50 × 100 = 40%.

11. C When knowledge exists but the environment blocks performance, training will not help.

12. A Design turns the analysis into objectives, methods and an assessment plan.

13. A Good objectives state observable behaviour, conditions and a standard.

14. C The 70 represents learning through experience and challenging work.

15. B Problem-centred learning motivates adults because the relevance is clear.

16. D (5,000,000 – 2,000,000) ÷ 2,000,000 × 100 = 150%.

17. C Level 3 checks whether people apply what they learned at work.

18. A Manager involvement before and after is a strong transfer lever.

19. D Reaction does not equal learning, behaviour or results.

20. B BCR = benefits ÷ costs, so 3.0 means benefits were triple the costs.

Scenarios & case studies

Scenario · A remote joiner left alone
A is best. Best. HR solves the immediate blocker, restores connection and gets the manager re-engaged. Then it fixes the process so this does not recur.

Case study · No successor for a critical role
Immediately: appoint an interim leader (a senior internal manager with support, or an interim contractor), secure knowledge transfer during the notice period, stabilise the migration project with clear governance, and start the external search. The process failure was that the talent review identified the risk but no owner, action or deadline followed. To strengthen succession: list all critical roles; name at least two potential successors for each with readiness levels; fund development such as acting roles, shadowing and courses; review progress quarterly at leadership meetings; and track bench strength as a measure on the people dashboard.

Scenario · Telling someone their talent status
B is best. Best. Transparency about process and development builds trust, while avoiding fixed labels that can demotivate or be misread.

Scenario · A request for leadership training
C is best. Best. A needs analysis shows whether the issue is skill, workload, policy or something else, and focuses any training on the right behaviours.

Scenario · Evaluation request from finance
D is best. Best. This moves evaluation to behaviour and results, using a comparison group to isolate the effect.

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04

MODULE 4 · PERFORM

Performance Management

Manage performance: goals, feedback, fair reviews and calibration, and supportive improvement plans

BY THE END OF THIS MODULE YOU WILL BE ABLE TO

- Design a continuous performance cycle with aligned SMART goals and OKRs
- Give and receive specific, timely feedback and run effective check-ins
- Reduce rating bias through clear definitions and calibration
- Manage underperformance through diagnosis, support and fair PIPs

LESSONS

1. Performance Management and Goal Setting · 24 min
2. Feedback and Continuous Conversations · 22 min
3. Reviews, Ratings and Calibration · 24 min
4. Managing Underperformance and PIPs · 26 min

MODULE 4 · PERFORM · LESSON 1 · 24 MIN

Performance Management and Goal Setting

Build a performance system people trust, starting with clear, aligned goals

- Explain the purposes of performance management
- Describe a modern, continuous performance cycle
- Write SMART goals and OKRs that align with team and organisation priorities
- Apply goal-setting principles that raise motivation

Few HR processes are as widely disliked as the annual appraisal: a form filled in once a year, a rating that surprises the employee, and a conversation both sides want to end quickly. **Performance management** is meant to be something else entirely: an ongoing way of making sure people know what matters, get help to do it, and are recognised fairly for what they achieve.

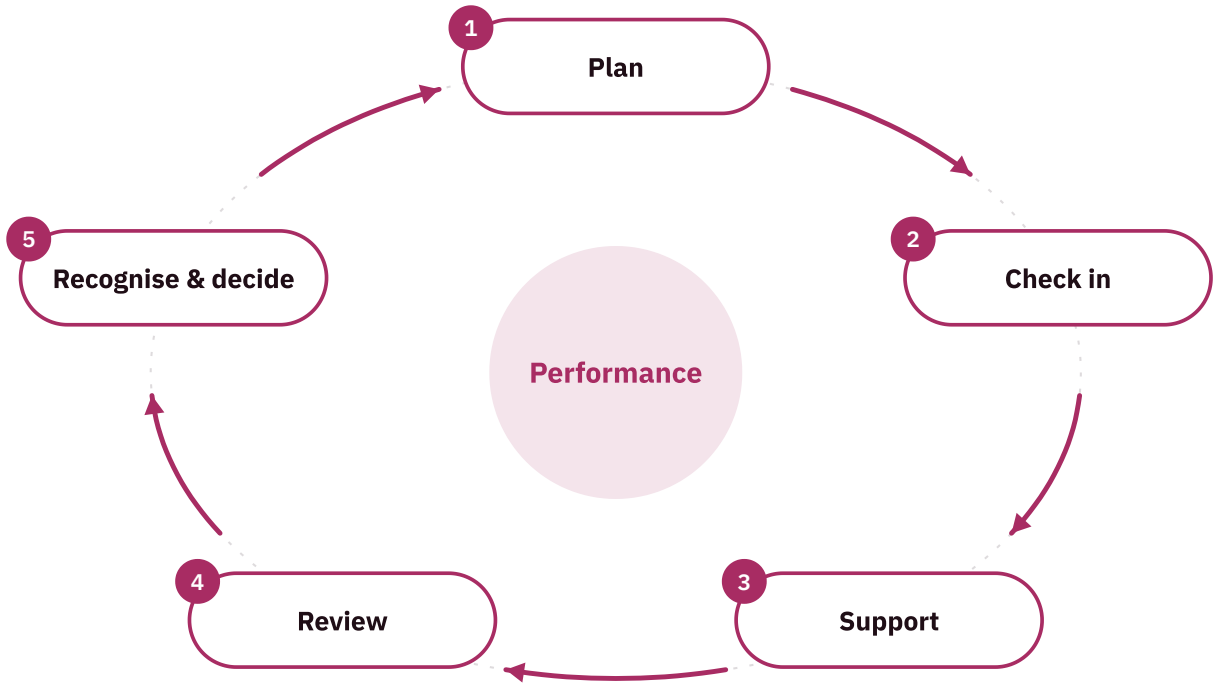
> DEFINITION · PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT
> **Performance management** is the continuous process of setting expectations, supporting and developing people, reviewing progress and recognising results, so that individual work contributes to team and organisational goals.

Why organisations manage performance

- **Direction**: everyone knows the priorities and how their work contributes.
- **Development**: regular feedback grows skills and careers.
- **Decisions**: evidence for pay, promotion, talent and, where needed, capability action.
- **Dialogue**: a regular, structured conversation between manager and employee.
- **Documentation**: a fair record if decisions are later questioned.

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A continuous performance cycle



1. **Plan** — Agree goals, behaviours and development aims
2. **Check in** — Short, frequent conversations on progress and obstacles
3. **Support** — Coaching, resources, learning
4. **Review** — Periodic summary of results and growth
5. **Recognise & decide** — Reward, development and next goals

The cycle turns several times a year: goals are revisited each quarter and every check-in loops back to planning. The formal review is one point on the loop, not the whole system.

Traditional vs continuous performance management

Traditional

- Annual goals set and forgotten
- One review a year
- Rating-centred
- Backward-looking judgement
- Owned by HR forms

Continuous

- Goals reviewed quarterly as priorities shift
- Monthly or fortnightly check-ins
- Conversation-centred; ratings optional or simplified
- Forward-looking coaching
- Owned by managers and employees

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SMART goals

S

Specific

Clear about what will be achieved.

M

Measurable

Progress and completion can be observed or counted.

A

Achievable

Challenging but realistic with available resources.

R

Relevant

Linked to team and organisational priorities.

T

Time-bound

Has a deadline or review date.

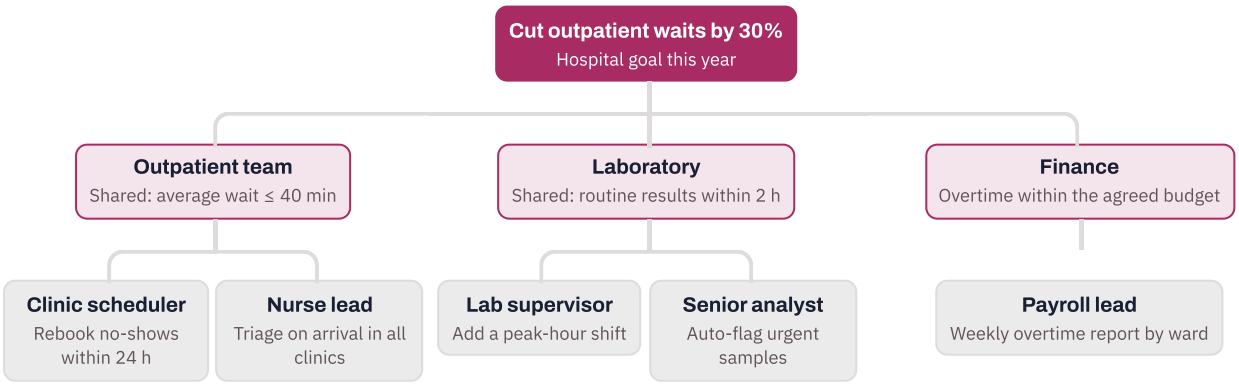
DEFINITION · OKRS

Objectives and key results (OKRs) pair an inspiring, qualitative **objective** with three to five measurable **key results** that show whether it was achieved. OKRs are usually set quarterly, are often public across the organisation and are typically ambitious, so achieving around 70% may be counted as success. Many organisations keep OKRs separate from pay decisions to encourage ambition.

Weak goals made strong

WEAK GOAL	STRONGER VERSION
Improve customer service	Raise first-contact resolution from 68% to 78% by 31 December
Do more training	Complete the line-balancing certificate and apply it on two new styles by end of Q2
Reduce absence	Cut unplanned absence on Line 4 from 7% to 4% by June through return-to-work talks and rota changes
Be a better team player	Run a fortnightly knowledge-share session and review two colleagues' work each month through Q3

Aligning goals across a hospital



Goals cascade down and connect across. Giving outpatients and the laboratory a shared pathway measure removes the conflict in the scenario below, where each team's own goal worked against the other. The figures are illustrative.

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INSIGHT · WHAT GOAL-SETTING RESEARCH SUGGESTS

Specific, challenging goals generally lead to higher performance than vague 'do your best' goals, provided people accept the goal, have the ability and get feedback on progress. For complex, novel tasks, **learning goals** (for example, 'find three ways to cut processing time') often work better than hard output targets.

TEMPLATE **Goal and OKR planner**

Draft aligned goals for one quarter, showing the link to team priorities.

TEAM PRIORITY	INDIVIDUAL OBJECTIVE	KEY RESULT OR MEASURE	BASE LINE	TARGET AND DATE	SUPPORT NEEDED
Faster loan decisions	*Make small-business loan processing faster and simpler*	*Average processing time*	*9 days*	*5 days by 30 Sep*	*Access to the new document checklist; weekly data report*

SCENARIO · DECIDE · GOALS THAT CONFLICT

In a hospital, the outpatient manager's goal is to cut patient waiting time by 30%, while the laboratory's goal is to cut overtime costs by 20%. Lab results are now taking longer and outpatient waits are rising. What should HR suggest?

(A) Bring the two managers together with their director to agree shared goals and measures across the patient pathway, and adjust the individual goals accordingly.

(B) Tell each manager to focus on their own goal; conflict will settle itself.

(C) Remove both goals until the next annual cycle.

(D) Rate both managers lower for failing to cooperate.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

REFLECT

Rewrite one of your current goals using the SMART checklist. Does it clearly connect to a team or organisational priority?

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Key terms

Performance management
The continuous process of setting expectations, supporting people, reviewing progress and recognising results.

SMART goal
A goal that is Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant and Time-bound.

Goal alignment
Ensuring individual and team goals support each other and the organisation's priorities.

Learning goal
A goal focused on discovering strategies or building skills rather than reaching a fixed output.

Performance cycle
The recurring sequence of planning, checking in, supporting, reviewing and recognising performance.

Objectives and key results (OKRs)
A goal method pairing a qualitative objective with a few measurable key results, usually set quarterly.

Stretch goal
A deliberately ambitious goal intended to encourage innovation and extra effort.

Key takeaways

- Performance management is continuous: plan, check in, support, review, recognise.
- Write SMART goals; use OKRs for ambitious, often public, quarterly objectives kept apart from pay.
- Align goals vertically and horizontally so that teams do not work against each other.
- Specific, accepted goals with feedback raise performance; use learning goals for novel, complex work.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Which goal is the most SMART?
   - (A) Be more accurate with invoices
   - (B) Try hard to reduce errors
   - (C) Reduce invoice errors from 6% to 2% by 30 June
   - (D) Improve finance processes across the department as much as possible this year

2. In OKRs, key results should be:
   - (A) Measurable outcomes showing whether the objective is achieved
   - (B) Inspiring but vague statements
   - (C) A list of daily tasks
   - (D) Ratings of the employee's personality and attitude during the quarter

3. Why do many organisations keep OKRs separate from pay decisions?
   - (A) Because OKRs cannot be measured
   - (B) Because pay is illegal to discuss
   - (C) To reduce the number of check-ins managers must hold during the quarter
   - (D) To encourage ambitious goals without fear of losing pay

4. For a novel, complex task, which type of goal often works better than a hard output target?
   - (A) A vague 'do your best' goal
   - (B) A learning goal
   - (C) No goal at all
   - (D) A forced-ranking goal

5. Which is a feature of continuous performance management?
   - (A) One review per year
   - (B) Frequent check-ins and goals reviewed as priorities shift
   - (C) Goals fixed for twelve months and reviewed only at the end of the year
   - (D) Ratings as the main purpose

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MODULE 4 · PERFORM · LESSON 2 · 22 MIN

Feedback and Continuous Conversations

Give and receive feedback that improves performance and builds trust

- Run effective one-to-one check-ins
- Give specific feedback using the SBI model
- Balance recognition and developmental feedback
- Use 360-degree and upward feedback appropriately

Feedback is the fuel of performance, but most people get too little, too late and too vague. "Good job" teaches nothing; "you need to be more professional" teaches even less. Specific, timely, well-intended feedback helps people repeat what works and fix what does not.

SBI: a simple feedback structure

S

Situation

Anchor the feedback in a specific time and place: 'In yesterday's client meeting...'

B

Behaviour

Describe what the person actually did or said, observable and factual: 'you interrupted the client twice...'

I

Impact

Explain the effect on results, people or customers: '...and she stopped sharing her concerns.'

PRO TIP · THEN ASK, DO NOT TELL

After SBI, ask a question: "How did you see it?" or "What could you try next time?" This turns feedback into a conversation, surfaces information you may not have, and builds ownership of the next step.

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An SBI feedback conversation



Notice the turn after Impact: the manager stops telling and starts asking. The employee's view often adds facts the manager did not have, and the next step belongs to the employee.

Feedback that helps vs feedback that hurts

Helps

- Specific and based on observed behaviour
- Timely: within days, not months
- Focused on the work, not the person
- Balanced over time between recognition and development
- Followed by support and a next step

Hurts

- Vague labels: 'lazy', 'negative', 'unprofessional'
- Saved up for the annual review
- Delivered in public to embarrass
- Only negative, or only praise
- No follow-up

A 30-minute check-in

1. **Their agenda first** "What's on your mind? What do you want to cover?"
2. **Progress on goals** Look at key results and recent wins together.

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3. **Obstacles** "What is getting in your way? What do you need from me?"
4. **Feedback both ways** Share one piece of recognition and, if needed, one developmental point; ask for feedback on your support.
5. **Growth** Touch on learning and career goals at least monthly.
6. **Agree actions** Note two or three actions with owners before the next check-in.

INSIGHT · RECOGNITION IS NOT A SOFT EXTRA

Specific recognition ("the way you redesigned the shift plan cut overtime by 15 hours this week") tells people exactly what to repeat. Many engagement studies find that feeling recognised is among the strongest drivers of discretionary effort and retention.

360-degree and upward feedback

USE	WORKS WELL WHEN	RISKS
Development for managers and leaders	Anonymous, at least 5–8 raters, interpreted with a coach	Raters fear identification in small teams
Upward feedback on the manager	Run regularly with action plans shared with the team	Retaliation if trust is low
Input to pay or promotion decisions	Rarely recommended	Raters game scores; friendships and rivalries distort results

EXAMPLE · FEEDBACK CULTURE IN A SOFTWARE TEAM

A Dhaka software company asked team leads to give one specific piece of recognition and one improvement suggestion to each team member every fortnight, and to ask for one piece of feedback on their own leadership. After six months, engagement survey items on 'I know how I am doing' rose by 22 points.

SCENARIO · DECIDE · FEEDBACK ON A SENSITIVE BEHAVIOUR

A capable senior accountant at a university regularly sends sharp, sarcastic emails to junior colleagues, two of whom have complained. His technical work is excellent. What should his manager do?

(A) Wait for the annual review so the feedback is part of a formal record.

(B) Meet him privately soon, describe specific emails and their impact using SBI, ask for his view and agree clear expectations and follow-up.

(C) Forward the complaints to him without comment.

(D) Ignore it because his technical work is excellent.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

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Before giving developmental feedback

☐ Do I have a specific, recent example?

☐ Can I describe the behaviour without labels or assumptions about intent?

☐ Do I know the impact and can I explain it?

☐ Is this a private, unrushed setting?

☐ Am I ready to listen to their view?

☐ Do I know what support I can offer?

REFLECT

When did you last receive feedback that genuinely changed how you work? What made it effective?

Key terms

Check-in
A short, regular one-to-one conversation between manager and employee about progress, obstacles, feedback and growth.

Feedforward
Suggestions focused on what someone could do differently in future rather than on past mistakes.

Upward feedback
Feedback that employees give to their manager about the manager's leadership.

Continuous performance management
An approach that replaces or supplements annual reviews with frequent check-ins and adaptable goals.

SBI model
A feedback structure describing the Situation, the observed Behaviour and its Impact.

360-degree feedback
Feedback on a person collected from several sources such as manager, peers, direct reports and sometimes customers.

Recognition
Timely, specific acknowledgement of a person's contribution or behaviour.

Key takeaways

- Useful feedback is specific, timely, private when developmental and about behaviour, not personality.
- Use SBI, then ask for the other person's view and agree a next step.
- Run regular check-ins that start with the employee's agenda.
- Use 360-degree feedback for development, not pay, and protect raters' anonymity.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

6. "In this morning's handover, you didn't mention the patient's new allergy, and the next nurse nearly gave the wrong drug." Which SBI element is 'nearly gave the wrong drug'?

(A) Situation
(B) Behaviour
(C) Intent
(D) Impact

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7. Which feedback is most useful?

(A) "Your summary slide cut the meeting time in half because the options were so clear."

(B) "Great job as usual."

(C) "You're very professional."

(D) "Keep doing whatever you're doing, because everyone on the team thinks you are great."

8. Why is 360-degree feedback rarely recommended as a direct input to pay?

(A) It is always too expensive

(B) It only includes the manager's view, so it adds nothing new to the review

(C) Raters may game scores and relationships distort results

(D) It is illegal in most countries

9. What should a check-in usually start with?

(A) The manager's list of complaints

(B) A performance rating

(C) A review of the employee handbook and recent policy changes

(D) The employee's own agenda and concerns

10. Why should developmental feedback be given soon after the behaviour?

(A) To create a formal disciplinary record

(B) Memories are fresh and the person can improve quickly

(C) Because annual reviews are illegal

(D) So that HR can be copied in and keep a record for the annual review

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MODULE 4 · PERFORM · LESSON 3 · 24 MIN

Reviews, Ratings and Calibration

Summarise performance fairly and reduce bias in ratings

- Choose a rating approach that fits the organisation
- Recognise and reduce common rating errors
- Run a calibration meeting
- Hold a constructive review conversation

Even organisations with strong continuous feedback usually need a periodic **review**: a summary of results and growth that informs pay, promotion and talent decisions. The challenge is making that summary fair when different managers have different standards and everyone is prone to bias.

Rating approaches

APPROACH	HOW IT WORKS	PROS	CONS
Five-point scale	Ratings from 'unsatisfactory' to 'outstanding'	Familiar; detailed	Central tendency; false precision
Three-point scale	Below, meeting, exceeding expectations	Simpler; easier to calibrate	Less differentiation
No overall rating	Narrative and goal outcomes only	Focus on conversation	Harder to link to pay; ratings may hide in spreadsheets
Forced distribution	Fixed percentages per category	Forces differentiation	Damages teamwork; unfair in strong teams; widely abandoned

Common rating errors

ERROR	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	REDUCE IT BY
Halo or horns	One trait colours all ratings	Rate each goal and behaviour separately with evidence
Recency	The last month outweighs the year	Keep notes from check-ins all year
Leniency	Everyone rated highly to avoid conflict	Calibration; clear definitions
Strictness	Everyone rated low by a tough manager	Calibration across teams
Central tendency	Everyone rated 'average'	Behavioural anchors; ask for evidence
Similar-to-me	Higher ratings for people like the rater	Diverse calibration panel; evidence
Attribution bias	Credit or blame given to the person for factors outside their control	Discuss context and constraints

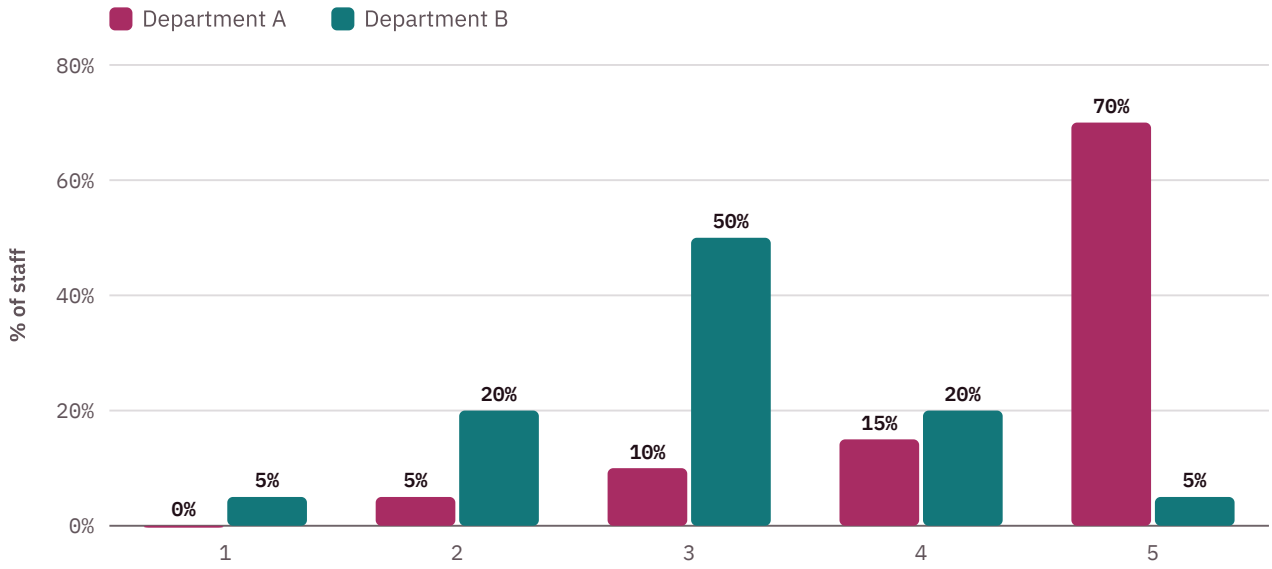
Running a calibration meeting

1. **Prepare** Managers submit draft ratings with two or three evidence points per person.
2. **Set the rules** Review definitions of each rating level; agree confidentiality.

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3. **Review the spread** Look at distributions by team, gender, location and grade to spot patterns.
4. **Discuss edge cases** Focus time on the top, the bottom and ratings that look inconsistent.
5. **Challenge with evidence** Ask "what did they do?", not "do you like them?"
6. **Finalise and record** Record changes and reasons; managers own the final message.

Rating distributions before calibration



Illustrative data in the spirit of the case below (1 = unsatisfactory, 5 = outstanding). Two departments with similar results produce very different spreads; "review the spread" means putting charts like this side by side, by team and by group, before discussing individuals.

WATCH OUT · CHECK OUTCOMES FOR PATTERNS

If women, part-time staff, staff on maternity leave, or one region consistently receive lower ratings, investigate. Patterns may reveal bias in goals, opportunities or rating, and ratings that feed pay can create unequal pay. Pay transparency rules such as the EU directive expect pay progression criteria to be objective and gender-neutral, so biased ratings are a legal as well as an ethical risk.

The review conversation

01	→	02	→	03	→	04	→	05
Prepare		**Open**		**Look back**		**Look forward**		**Close**
Self-review and manager's evidence		Purpose, structure, two-way tone		Results, behaviours, highlights and gaps		Goals, development, career		Summary, rating if used, next steps

WATCH OUT · AI-DRAFTED REVIEWS

Some systems now draft review text from goals, check-in notes and feedback. Treat drafts as a starting point only: check every statement against evidence, remove generic phrases, watch for biased language (for example, different adjectives for women and men), and make sure the manager owns and can explain the final words.

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PRO TIP · SEPARATE THE MONEY CONVERSATION WHERE YOU CAN

When pay is discussed in the same meeting as development, people stop listening once they hear the number. Many organisations hold the development review first and the pay conversation a few weeks later.

A performance year at a glance

JANUARY
Goals set
Team and individual goals agreed

APRIL
Q1 refresh
Goals revisited as priorities shift

JULY
Mid-year review
Progress and development check

OCTOBER
Q3 refresh
Goals adjusted; evidence gathered

NOV–DEC
Review and calibration
Self-review, conversation, ratings aligned across teams

FEBRUARY
Pay conversation
Increases and bonuses decided and explained

An illustrative calendar for a January–December year; check-ins run underneath every milestone. Holding the pay conversation weeks after the development review keeps attention on growth.

TEMPLATE **Performance review summary**

Summarise the year's results and behaviours with evidence and agree the focus for next year.

GOAL OR BEHAVIOUR	EVIDENCE OF RESULTS	SELF-ASSESSMENT	MANAGER ASSESSMENT	AGREED RATING	DEVELOPMENT FOCUS
Cut first-response time in support queue	*Average reduced from 6 hrs to 2.5 hrs (target 3)*	*Exceeded*	*Exceeded; also coached two new agents*	*Exceeding*	*Lead the knowledge-base redesign*

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GOAL OR BEHAVIOUR	EVIDENCE OF RESULTS	SELF-ASSESSMENT	MANAGER ASSESSMENT	AGREED RATING	DEVELOPMENT FOCUS

CASE STUDY · RATINGS THAT DO NOT ADD UP

A Chattogram-based electronics distributor uses a five-point scale. Department A rated 70% of staff 'outstanding' while Department B rated 5% the same, although both met similar targets. Bonuses are tied to ratings. Staff in Department B are angry and two strong performers have resigned.

1. What is causing the problem?

2. What should HR do this cycle?

3. What longer-term changes would you make?

Model answer: module answer key.

SCENARIO · DECIDE · AN EMPLOYEE DISPUTES THE RATING

After a review, a project officer at an NGO says her 'meets expectations' rating is unfair because a major donor report she led was praised by the board. The manager says the report was late. What should happen?

(A) HR overrides the manager and changes the rating to 'exceeds'.

(B) The manager refuses to discuss it; ratings are final.

(C) The manager and employee review the evidence together; if they still disagree, she uses the organisation's review or appeal step, with HR checking that the process was fair.

(D) Both sides wait until next year's review to raise it again.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

REFLECT

Which rating error do you think you are most prone to as a manager or colleague? What habit would counter it?

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Key terms

Performance rating
A summary judgement of performance against expectations over a period, often on a defined scale.

Halo effect
A rating error in which one positive trait or result inflates ratings across all areas.

Central tendency
A rating error in which a rater places most people in the middle of the scale.

Forced distribution
A rating system requiring fixed percentages of employees in each rating category.

Calibration
A meeting where managers compare and align ratings using evidence to apply consistent standards.

Recency bias
A rating error that gives too much weight to recent events over the whole review period.

Leniency bias
A rating error in which a rater gives consistently higher ratings than performance justifies.

Key takeaways

- Choose a rating approach that fits; forced distribution has been widely abandoned.
- Name and counter rating errors: halo, recency, leniency, strictness, central tendency, similar-to-me.
- Calibrate with evidence and review distributions by team and group for patterns.
- Keep year-round notes, separate the pay conversation and offer a route to challenge ratings.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

11. A manager rates an employee lower for the whole year because of one mistake last month. This is mainly:

(A) Leniency bias
(B) Central tendency
(C) Recency bias
(D) Similar-to-me bias

12. What is the main purpose of calibration?

(A) To apply consistent rating standards across managers using evidence
(B) To reduce the bonus budget
(C) To rank every employee from first to last across the whole organisation
(D) To replace check-ins

13. Why have many organisations abandoned forced distribution?

(A) It harms teamwork and is unfair in strong teams
(B) It is too simple
(C) It makes ratings more lenient because managers avoid giving low scores
(D) It requires no manager input

14. A manager rates nearly everyone 'average' to avoid difficult conversations. This is:

(A) Halo effect
(B) Strictness
(C) Central tendency
(D) Attribution bias

15. Why hold the pay conversation separately from the development review?

(A) Pay must always be secret
(B) People stop engaging in development once they hear the pay outcome
(C) Managers are not allowed to discuss pay
(D) Development reviews must be anonymous, so managers cannot discuss pay in them

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MODULE 4 · PERFORM · LESSON 4 · 26 MIN

Managing Underperformance and PIPs

Diagnose, support and act fairly when performance falls short

- Diagnose the causes of underperformance
- Distinguish capability issues from conduct issues
- Design and run a fair performance improvement plan
- Keep documentation and process fair and lawful

Every manager eventually faces someone whose performance is not good enough. Avoiding the issue is unfair to the team, the customer and the employee, who deserves to know where they stand. Rushing to dismissal is unfair too. A good process starts by understanding **why** performance has dropped, gives real support and a fair chance, and only then moves to formal action.

Diagnose before you act

D1
Clarity
Does the person know what is expected and how it is measured?

D2
Capability
Do they have the skills and knowledge? Have they been trained?

D3
Resources
Do they have the tools, time, information and authority?

D4
Motivation
Do consequences and recognition encourage the right behaviour?

D5
Circumstances
Are health, caring responsibilities or personal issues involved?

D6
Fit
Has the role changed beyond the person's strengths?

Capability vs conduct

Capability (cannot)

- The person is trying but not meeting the standard
- Causes: skills, knowledge, aptitude, health
- Response: support, training, time, adjustments, PIP
- Handled under a capability or performance procedure

Conduct (will not)

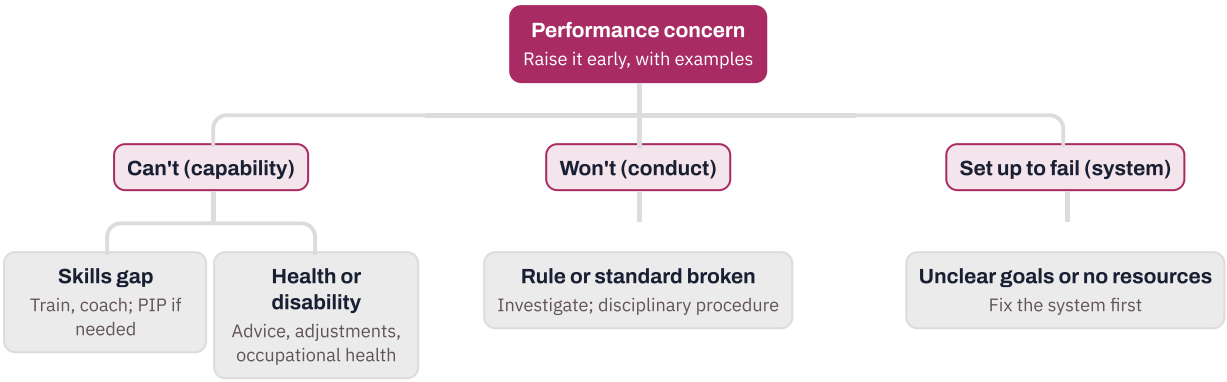
- The person can do it but chooses not to, or breaks rules
- Examples: lateness, refusal of reasonable instructions, misconduct
- Response: investigation and disciplinary procedure
- Handled under a disciplinary procedure

WATCH OUT · HEALTH AND PROTECTED SITUATIONS

If underperformance may relate to illness, disability, pregnancy or another protected situation, take advice, consider adjustments and involve occupational health where available. Treating a health-related issue as simple poor performance can be unfair and unlawful.

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Diagnosing a performance concern



Decide which branch you are on before choosing a procedure. Mixing them, for example using a PIP for misconduct or discipline for a health issue, is a common cause of unfair outcomes.

From concern to outcome

01 Informal talk
Raise the gap early with examples and listen

→

02 Informal support
Coaching, training, clear targets, 4–8 weeks

→

03 Formal PIP
Written plan, support, review meetings

→

04 Review
Improved, extended or not met

→

05 Outcome
Close PIP, redeploy, or formal capability action

What a fair PIP contains

- The specific performance gaps, with examples and data.
- SMART targets that are realistic for the period.
- Support the organisation will provide: training, coaching, resources, adjustments.
- A reasonable period, often 4–12 weeks depending on the role.
- Dates of regular review meetings and who attends.
- The possible outcomes, stated honestly, including what happens if targets are not met.
- The employee's right to comment, be accompanied where policy or law allows, and appeal.

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A six-week PIP

WEEK 0
Plan meeting
Gaps, evidence, SMART targets, support and possible outcomes explained; employee comments

WEEK 2
Review 1
Progress against targets; support adjusted

WEEK 4
Review 2
Trend checked; honest view of the likely outcome

WEEK 6
Final review
Targets met, extension with support, or formal capability outcome

AFTER WEEK 6
Outcome letter
Decision, reasons and right of appeal in writing

Review meetings are fixed in advance and actually held; that rhythm, with notes, is what makes the process fair and defensible. Period lengths vary by role and policy.

TEMPLATE **Performance improvement plan**

Agree clear targets, support and review dates for a formal improvement period.

PERFORMANCE GAP	EVIDENCE	TARGET (SMART)	SUPPORT PROVIDED	REVIEW DATES	PROGRESS NOTES
Loan files submitted with missing documents	*38% of files returned in last 2 months (team average 8%)*	*No more than 10% of files returned over 6 weeks*	*Checklist training; weekly file review with senior officer*	*Weeks 2, 4, 6*	

INSIGHT · A PIP SHOULD BE A GENUINE CHANCE

If everyone who starts a PIP is dismissed, staff will see PIPs as a disguised exit route, and good people will leave when one is mentioned. Track outcomes: a healthy process shows a meaningful share of people improving.

EXAMPLE · A FAIR PROCESS IN A CALL CENTRE

An agent at a Dhaka bank's call centre had call-quality scores of 62% against a standard of 80%. The supervisor found she had joined during a system change and had missed product training. A six-week plan with targeted training and twice-weekly call reviews lifted her score to 84%. The PIP was closed, and the bank changed its onboarding so new joiners never missed product training again.

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SCENARIO · DECIDE · THE PIP THAT WAS ALREADY DECIDED

A manager tells HR: "I want to put Rahim on a PIP for four weeks so we can dismiss him. I've already decided he's not right for the team." What should HR do?

(A) Approve the PIP as requested so the matter is resolved quickly.

(B) Advise the manager to make the targets impossible so failure is certain.

(C) Transfer Rahim to another team without telling him why.

(D) Explain that a PIP must be a genuine opportunity, help the manager diagnose the causes and design realistic targets and support, and keep the outcome open.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

Fair process checklist for underperformance

☐ The gap was raised informally first, with examples

☐ Causes were explored, including health and personal circumstances

☐ Targets are specific, realistic and documented

☐ Support was offered and actually provided

☐ Review meetings were held on the dates agreed, with notes

☐ The employee could respond and, where applicable, be accompanied

☐ Possible outcomes were explained clearly in advance

☐ Local law and the organisation's procedure were followed

REFLECT

Think of an underperformance situation you have seen. Which diagnostic question was never asked, and how might the outcome have changed?

Key terms

Underperformance
Work that consistently falls below the standards reasonably expected for the role.

Conduct issue
A problem caused by an employee's behaviour or rule-breaking, handled through a disciplinary procedure.

Occupational health
Specialist advice on how health affects work and what adjustments or support may help.

Capability procedure
A formal process for managing performance problems caused by lack of ability or health.

Capability issue
A performance gap caused by lack of skill, knowledge, aptitude or health rather than by deliberate behaviour.

Performance improvement plan (PIP)
A formal, time-bound plan setting specific targets, support and reviews to help an employee reach the required standard.

Right to be accompanied
A right, in some jurisdictions and policies, for an employee to bring a colleague or representative to formal meetings.

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Key takeaways

- Diagnose before acting: clarity, capability, resources, motivation, circumstances and fit.
- Separate capability (cannot) from conduct (will not) and use the right procedure.
- A fair PIP has specific targets, real support, scheduled reviews and honestly stated outcomes.
- Take advice whenever health or another protected situation may be involved.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

16. An employee keeps missing targets despite working hard; she was never trained on the new system. This is mainly a:

(A) Conduct issue
(B) Gross misconduct case
(C) Redundancy situation
(D) Capability issue

17. Which element must a fair PIP include?

(A) A guarantee of dismissal if any target is missed by one day
(B) Secret targets known only to the manager
(C) The support the organisation will provide
(D) A ban on asking questions

18. What is the first step when a manager notices a performance gap?

(A) Raise it informally with examples and explore causes
(B) Start a formal PIP immediately so that there is a written record from the beginning
(C) Issue a final written warning
(D) Reduce the employee's pay

19. If nearly everyone placed on a PIP is dismissed, what does this suggest?

(A) The PIP process is working perfectly and managers are identifying the right people
(B) Targets are too easy
(C) Managers are too lenient
(D) PIPs are being used as a disguised exit route rather than a genuine chance

20. Performance has dropped sharply since an employee disclosed a serious illness. What should the manager do?

(A) Start a PIP straight away
(B) Seek advice, consider adjustments and involve occupational health where available
(C) Ignore the illness and focus on targets
(D) Ask colleagues to cover the extra work quietly without telling HR or occupational health

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MODULE 4 · PERFORM

Answer key

Knowledge checks

1. C It is specific, measurable, time-bound and can be checked for achievability and relevance.

2. A Objectives inspire; key results measure.

3. D Linking stretch goals to pay pushes people to set safe targets.

4. B Learning goals focus attention on finding effective strategies.

5. B Continuous approaches focus on regular conversations and adaptable goals.

6. D Impact explains the effect of the behaviour.

7. A Specific recognition tells the person exactly what to repeat.

8. C When pay depends on it, raters' motives change and honesty drops.

9. D Starting with the employee's agenda builds ownership and surfaces real obstacles.

10. B Timeliness makes feedback accurate and actionable.

11. C Recent events are given too much weight.

12. A Calibration aligns standards and reduces individual rater bias.

13. A Forcing a fixed share into low ratings creates internal competition and unfairness.

14. C Central tendency clusters ratings in the middle of the scale.

15. B Separating them keeps attention on growth.

16. D She is trying but lacks the skill; training and support come first.

17. C Fair PIPs pair specific targets with genuine support.

18. A Early informal conversation and diagnosis are fairer and often solve the problem.

19. D A genuine process shows a meaningful share of people improving.

20. B Health-related performance issues need support and may carry legal duties.

Scenarios & case studies

Scenario · Goals that conflict
A is best. Best. Goals must align horizontally as well as vertically; a shared pathway goal removes the conflict.

Scenario · Feedback on a sensitive behaviour
B is best. Best. Specific, private, timely feedback addresses the behaviour while respecting him, and sets a clear standard.

Case study · Ratings that do not add up
The core issue is inconsistent standards: leniency in Department A and possibly strictness in Department B, magnified because bonuses depend on ratings. This cycle, HR should run a cross-department calibration session with clear definitions and evidence for each rating, focusing on the extremes, and review bonus outcomes against actual results. Longer term: define rating levels with behavioural anchors, train managers, hold calibration every cycle, consider a three-point scale, partly link bonuses to team or company results, monitor rating distributions by team and group, and ensure check-in notes provide year-round evidence.

Scenario · An employee disputes the rating
C is best. Best. A fair process lets evidence be re-examined and provides an independent check, which builds trust whatever the outcome.

Scenario · The PIP that was already decided
D is best. Best. A predetermined PIP is unfair, may be unlawful and damages trust. HR's role is to ensure a fair, evidence-based process.

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05

MODULE 5 · REWARD

Compensation and Benefits

Reward fairly: total rewards, job evaluation, pay structures, incentives, benefits and pay equity

BY THE END OF THIS MODULE YOU WILL BE ABLE TO

- Set a reward strategy and pay philosophy balancing equity, competitiveness and affordability
- Evaluate jobs and build job families and grades
- Build pay ranges and use compa-ratio and range penetration
- Design merit, incentive and benefit programmes that drive the right behaviours
- Review pay equity, apply transparency and protect payroll integrity

LESSONS

1. Reward Strategy and Total Rewards · 22 min
2. Job Evaluation · 24 min
3. Pay Structures and Market Data · 28 min
4. Pay Progression, Incentives and Benefits · 26 min
5. Pay Equity, Transparency and Payroll Integrity · 24 min

MODULE 5 · REWARD · LESSON 1 · 22 MIN

Reward Strategy and Total Rewards

Decide what you pay for, how you compare with the market and what the whole package is worth

- Explain the components of total rewards
- Set a pay philosophy and market position
- Balance internal equity, external competitiveness and affordability
- Recognise legal floors such as minimum wages

Pay is one of the most sensitive things an organisation does. It signals what is valued, shapes who joins and stays, and is a large share of cost: often 40–70% of operating expenses in service organisations. A **reward strategy** makes pay decisions deliberate and explainable instead of the result of individual negotiation and history.

Total rewards

Recognition and work experience	`Appreciation and awards` `Meaningful work, autonomy` `Positive culture`
Development and career	`Training and certification` `Career paths and promotion` `Mentoring`
Wellbeing and flexibility	`Flexible hours or hybrid work` `Leave` `Health and wellbeing support`
Benefits	`Health cover` `Provident fund, gratuity or pension` `Insurance, transport, meals`
Pay	`Base salary or wage` `Allowances` `Bonuses, incentives and overtime`

INSIGHT · PEOPLE VALUE THE WHOLE PACKAGE

Two employers paying the same base salary can feel very different: one with reliable bonuses, health cover, training and flexible hours; the other with none. Communicating **total rewards statements** helps people see the full value, which they often underestimate.

Three tensions every reward strategy balances

E1

Internal equity

Jobs of similar value inside the organisation are paid similarly.

E2

External competitiveness

Pay is close enough to the market to attract and keep the people needed.

E3

Affordability

The organisation can sustain the cost through good years and bad.

Market positioning choices

POSITION	MEANING	WHEN IT FITS
Lead	Pay above market median, for example at the 75th percentile	Scarce critical skills; premium brand; high-performance strategy
Match	Pay around the market median	Most roles in most organisations

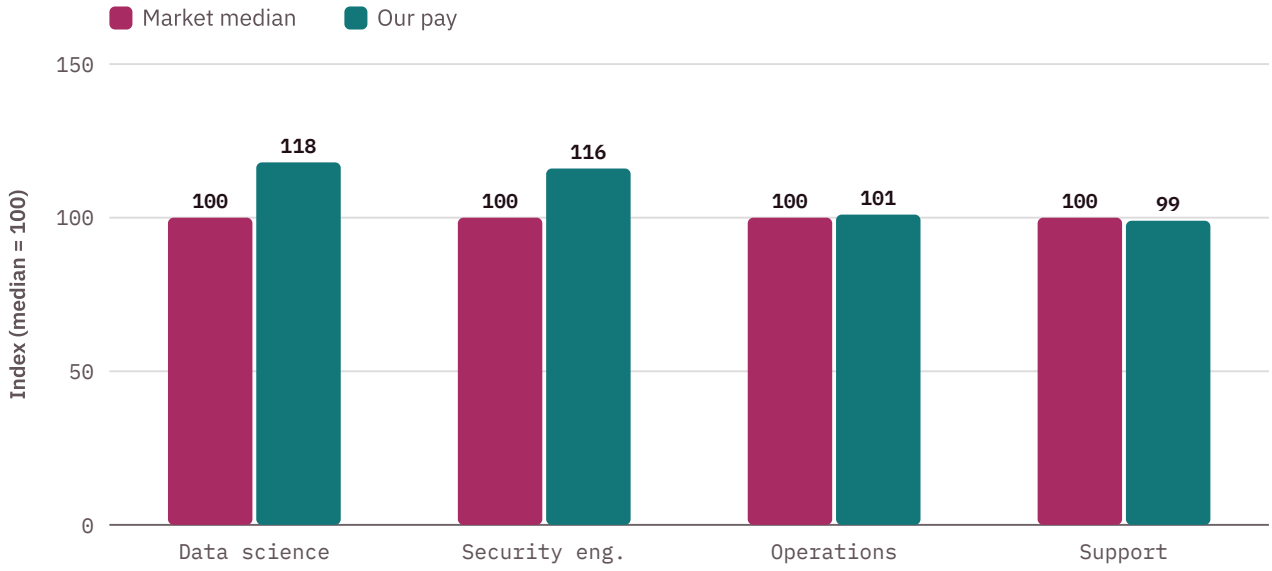
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POSITION	MEANING	WHEN IT FITS
Lag	Pay below median, offset by other rewards	Strong purpose, security, flexibility or learning offer; tight budgets
Mixed	Lead for critical roles, match for others	Common in practice; must be explained transparently

EXAMPLE · A MIXED POSITION AT A FINTECH

A Dhaka fintech pays at the 75th percentile for data scientists and security engineers, where competition is intense, and at the median for operations and support roles. It explains the policy openly and offers all staff the same benefits, learning budget and bonus scheme to keep the package fair.

Pay versus market median by role family



Illustrative index (market median = 100): the fintech leads the market, near the 75th percentile, for scarce critical roles and matches it elsewhere. A mixed position like this must be written down and explained, or it will look like favouritism.

WATCH OUT · LEGAL FLOORS COME FIRST

Minimum wages, overtime rules, mandatory benefits and payment-timing rules set the floor for any reward strategy, and they **vary by country, region and sector**. In Bangladesh, for example, minimum wages for sectors such as ready-made garments are set through a minimum wage board process and revised periodically. Many buyers and investors also ask about **living wages**, which can sit above legal minimums. **Always check the current law and official notifications** before setting or changing pay.

Writing a pay philosophy

1. **State what you pay for** For example: the value of the job, individual contribution and growth in skills.
2. **Choose the market and position** Which markets do you compare with, and where do you aim to be?
3. **Set the mix** Balance of fixed pay, variable pay and benefits by level.
4. **Define fairness principles** Equal pay for equal work, transparency, legal compliance.
5. **Set governance** Who approves pay decisions, budgets and exceptions?

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6. **Communicate** Explain the philosophy to managers and employees in plain language.

INSIGHT · DESIGN FOR TRANSPARENCY

Assume your pay structure will be seen. Pay transparency laws are spreading (see lesson 5 of this module), and employees already compare pay online. A reward strategy that cannot be explained in plain language will not survive being published.

SCENARIO · DECIDE · A RETENTION REQUEST

A strong software engineer at a Chattogram IT firm receives an outside offer 35% above her salary. Her manager wants to match it immediately. Matching would put her well above two peers doing similar work. What should HR advise?

(A) Check market data for the role; if the firm's pay for this role family is behind its stated market position, review the whole group, including her peers, rather than making a one-off counter-offer.

(B) Match the offer for her only and keep it confidential.

(C) Refuse any response because counter-offers never work.

(D) Offer her a promotion title without a pay change.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

REFLECT

Write your organisation's pay philosophy in three sentences. If you cannot, what decisions are currently made case by case?

Key terms

Total rewards
Everything of value an employee receives from work: pay, benefits, wellbeing, development and recognition.

Pay philosophy
A short statement of what an organisation pays for, its market position and its fairness principles.

Internal equity
Fairness of pay between jobs and people inside the same organisation.

Minimum wage
The lowest legal rate of pay for a type of work, set by law or a statutory body.

Reward strategy
A plan setting out how an organisation will use pay and other rewards to support its goals.

Market positioning
Where an organisation chooses to set pay relative to the market, such as leading, matching or lagging.

External competitiveness
How an organisation's pay compares with what other employers pay for similar jobs.

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Key takeaways

- Total rewards include pay, benefits, wellbeing and flexibility, development and recognition.
- Every reward strategy balances internal equity, external competitiveness and affordability.
- Choose and explain a market position: lead, match, lag or mixed.
- Legal floors vary by country and come first; design pay you could explain publicly.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. An organisation pays at about the 75th percentile of the market for its critical roles. This is a:
   - (A) Lag position
   - (B) Match position
   - (C) Lead position
   - (D) Minimum wage position
2. Which of these is part of total rewards but NOT pay?
   - (A) Paid training and career development
   - (B) Base salary
   - (C) Overtime payments
   - (D) Sales commission paid on each contract
3. Two jobs of similar value inside the same company are paid very differently. Which principle is at risk?
   - (A) External competitiveness
   - (B) Affordability
   - (C) Market positioning
   - (D) Internal equity
4. What must be checked before any pay strategy decision?
   - (A) Competitors' office locations
   - (B) Legal floors such as minimum wages and overtime rules
   - (C) Employees' social media activity
   - (D) The personal preferences of the chief executive and board members
5. Why do many employers issue total rewards statements?
   - (A) To replace payslips
   - (B) Employees often underestimate the value of benefits and non-pay rewards
   - (C) Because they are required by law in every country where the company operates
   - (D) To reduce base pay

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MODULE 5 · REWARD · LESSON 2 · 24 MIN

Job Evaluation

Measure the relative value of jobs, not the people in them

- Explain the purpose of job evaluation
- Compare ranking, classification, point-factor and market pricing
- Score jobs with a simple point-factor plan
- Build job families and levels

Before you can pay jobs fairly, you need to know how they compare. **Job evaluation** is the systematic process of judging the relative size or value of jobs, based on what the job requires, not on how well the current holder performs it or how hard they negotiated. It is the foundation of grades, internal equity and equal pay.

> DEFINITION · JOB EVALUATION
> **Job evaluation** compares jobs using consistent criteria such as knowledge, problem-solving, responsibility and working conditions, to place them in a fair order and in grades. It evaluates the **job**, not the person.

Four common methods

METHOD	HOW IT WORKS	STRENGTHS	WEAKNESSES
Ranking	Jobs are placed in order of overall value	Quick and simple for small organisations	Subjective; shows order, not size of differences
Classification (grading)	Jobs are matched to pre-written grade descriptions	Easy to explain; common in public sector	Broad descriptions can force poor fits
Point-factor	Jobs are scored on weighted factors, and points determine grades	Analytical, consistent, defensible for equal pay	Takes time and training; can seem complex
Market pricing	Jobs are valued mainly by survey data for similar jobs	Keeps pay competitive	Imports market biases; poor for unique jobs

A simple point-factor plan

F1
Knowledge and skill
Education, expertise and experience needed to do the job. Weight 30%.

F2
Problem-solving
Complexity of issues and independence of judgement. Weight 25%.

F3
Responsibility
For people, finance, assets and decisions, and the impact of errors. Weight 25%.

F4
Communication
Who the job influences and how complex the interactions are. Weight 10%.

F5
Working conditions
Physical effort, hazards and environment. Weight 10%.

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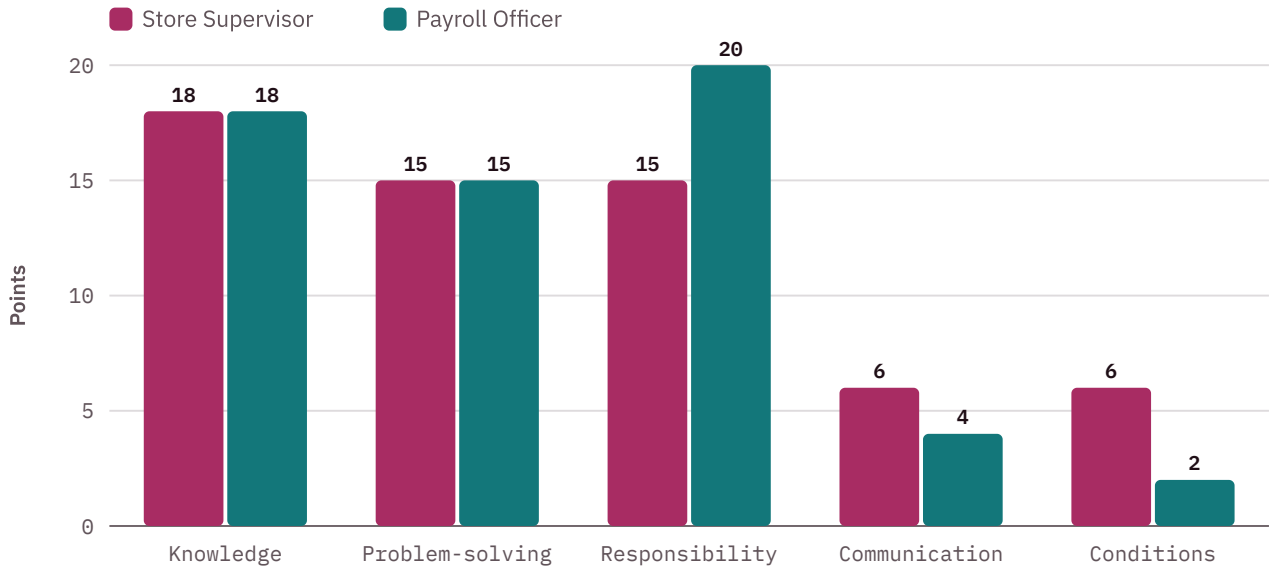
Point-factor scoring

MEASURE	FORMULA	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Factor points	`Factor points = (level score ÷ 5) × factor weight in points`	Converts a level (1–5) into weighted points. With weights adding to 100, a level 5 in a 30-point factor scores the full 30; a level 3 scores 18.
Job total	`Job score = sum of factor points across all factors`	The total ranks jobs and maps them to grades using agreed point bands.
Grade banding	`Grade = the band in which the job score falls, for example 40–49 = Grade 4`	Bands convert scores into a grade structure.

EXAMPLE · SCORING TWO JOBS

Using the plan above with levels 1–5: a **Store Supervisor** is rated knowledge 3, problem-solving 3, responsibility 3, communication 3, conditions 3. Points = 0.6 × (30 + 25 + 25 + 10 + 10) = **60**. A **Payroll Officer** rated 3, 3, 4, 2, 1 scores 0.6×30 + 0.6×25 + 0.8×25 + 0.4×10 + 0.2×10 = 18 + 15 + 20 + 4 + 2 = **59**. The two jobs sit in the same grade band, even though one is on the shop floor and one in an office.

Factor points for two jobs



Worked-example data. The totals are almost equal (60 and 59), but the profiles differ: the payroll officer scores more on responsibility, the supervisor on communication and working conditions. Point-factor plans make these trade-offs visible and explainable.

Running a job evaluation exercise

1. **Set up governance** A panel of trained evaluators from different functions and levels, with an independent chair.
2. **Choose and test the scheme** Agree factors, levels and weights; test on a few benchmark jobs.
3. **Prepare job information** Up-to-date job descriptions from job analysis.
4. **Evaluate** Score benchmark jobs first by consensus, then the rest; record reasons.

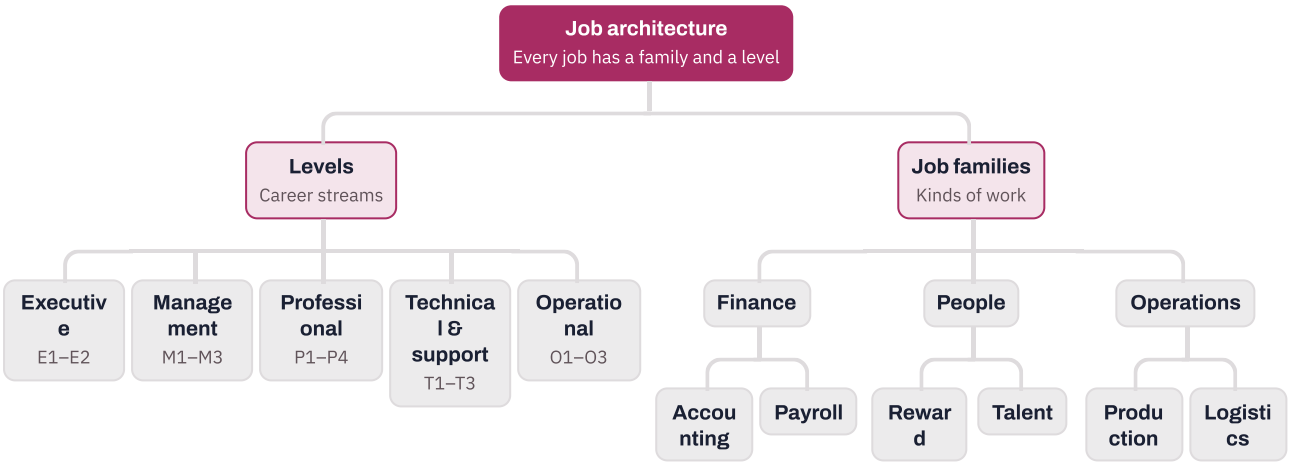
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5. **Check for bias** Look at results for jobs held mostly by women or men; check factors do not undervalue caring, coordination or manual dexterity.
6. **Set grades and appeals** Draw grade boundaries and provide a process for requesting review.

WATCH OUT · HIDDEN BIAS IN FACTORS

Schemes that weight only physical effort, technical qualifications or managing money can undervalue work often done by women, such as caring, emotional labour, coordination and fine manual skill. An analytical scheme checked for bias is a key defence in equal pay for work of equal value. Pay transparency rules, such as the EU directive, expect pay structures to rest on objective, gender-neutral criteria such as skills, effort, responsibility and working conditions.

Job architecture: levels and families



A role's place is where a family (the kind of work) meets a level (its size, set by job evaluation): a payroll specialist might be Finance › Payroll at level P2. A clear architecture is the base that pay transparency and skills-based mobility both build on.

SCENARIO · DECIDE · A MANAGER WANTS A REGRADE

A department head asks HR to regrade her executive assistant two grades higher "because she is the best assistant in the company and might leave". The job itself has not changed. What should HR say?

(A) Regrade the job immediately to keep the assistant.

(B) Explain that grades reflect the job, not the person; offer to re-evaluate if responsibilities have actually grown, and discuss performance-based recognition or development for the individual.

(C) Refuse and tell the manager to stop interfering.

(D) Create a new job title with the same grade.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

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REFLECT

List five jobs in your organisation. Rank them by value using your instinct, then score them with the five factors above. Where do the two orders differ, and why?

Key terms

Job evaluation
A systematic process for determining the relative value of jobs within an organisation.

Job ranking
A simple job evaluation method that places whole jobs in order of overall value.

Market pricing
Valuing jobs mainly by reference to pay data for comparable jobs in the external market.

Job family
A group of jobs with similar type of work and skills, organised into progressive levels.

Point-factor method
A job evaluation method that scores jobs on weighted factors and converts total points into grades.

Job classification
A job evaluation method that matches jobs to written grade descriptions.

Benchmark job
A well-understood job used as a reference point for evaluation or market comparison.

Key takeaways

- Job evaluation sizes the job, not the person.
- Point-factor schemes are analytical and the most defensible for equal-value pay; check the factors for hidden bias.
- Market pricing keeps pay competitive but can import market bias.
- A job architecture places every role in a family and a level.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

6. What does job evaluation assess?

(A) The job holder's performance
(B) The job holder's negotiation skill
(C) The manager's overall opinion of the person doing the job
(D) The relative value of the job, not the job holder's performance

7. Which method is generally the most defensible in an equal-value pay claim?

(A) An analytical point-factor scheme checked for bias
(B) Whole-job ranking
(C) Market pricing alone, using several salary surveys
(D) Manager judgement

8. A factor is worth 25 points and a job is rated level 4 out of 5. Using points = (level ÷ 5) × factor weight, how many points does the job score on this factor?

(A) 25
(B) 16
(C) 20
(D) 100

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9. What is the main weakness of relying only on market pricing?

   (A) It is never competitive

   (B) It ignores external data and focuses only on internal relativities

   (C) It is illegal

   (D) It can import existing market biases and suits unique jobs poorly

10. Why should evaluation panels include people from different functions and levels?

    (A) To make meetings longer

    (B) To reduce bias and improve the credibility of results

    (C) Because the law requires a fixed panel size for every job evaluation exercise

    (D) So that each person can protect their own job

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MODULE 5 · REWARD · LESSON 3 · 28 MIN

Pay Structures and Market Data

Turn job values and market data into grades, ranges and fair individual pay

- Use salary survey data responsibly
- Build grade ranges from midpoints and spreads
- Calculate compa-ratio and range penetration
- Handle pay outside the range

Once jobs are evaluated and grouped into grades, each grade needs a **pay range**: a minimum, a midpoint and a maximum. The range sets limits on what anyone in that grade can be paid, and the midpoint is usually linked to the market rate for a fully competent person in the job. Good structures make pay predictable, fair and affordable.

Using salary survey data

1. **Match jobs carefully** Match on job content and level, not titles; a 'manager' in one firm may be a 'senior officer' in another.
2. **Check the sample** Number of organisations and incumbents, industry, location and size.
3. **Age the data** Survey data is often months old; move it forward using expected market movement.
4. **Use percentiles** Look at the 25th, 50th (median) and 75th percentiles, not just averages.
5. **Blend sources** Combine two or three surveys or sources where possible.
6. **Respect competition law** Do not share or agree pay plans directly with competitors; use proper survey providers.

Pay structure formulas

MEASURE	FORMULA	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Range spread	`Spread = (maximum − minimum) ÷ minimum`	Width of the range. Often 30–40% for operational jobs and 50–80% for senior jobs.
Minimum from midpoint	`Minimum = midpoint ÷ (1 + spread ÷ 2)`	Calculates the range minimum when the midpoint and spread are known.
Maximum from minimum	`Maximum = minimum × (1 + spread)`	Calculates the range maximum.
Midpoint progression	`Progression = (next grade midpoint − this grade midpoint) ÷ this grade midpoint`	Step between grades, often 10–20%.
Compa-ratio	`Compa-ratio = individual pay ÷ range midpoint`	1.00 means paid at midpoint; below 0.90 is low in range, above 1.10 is high.
Range penetration	`Penetration = (pay − minimum) ÷ (maximum − minimum)`	Where pay sits in the range, from 0% at the minimum to 100% at the maximum.

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EXAMPLE · BUILDING A RANGE AND POSITIONING PAY

Grade 6 has a market-based midpoint of BDT 60,000 a month and a 50% spread. Minimum = 60,000 ÷ 1.25 = **48,000**; maximum = 48,000 × 1.5 = **72,000**. An officer paid 54,000 has a compa-ratio of 54,000 ÷ 60,000 = **0.90** and a range penetration of (54,000 − 48,000) ÷ (72,000 − 48,000) = **25%**.

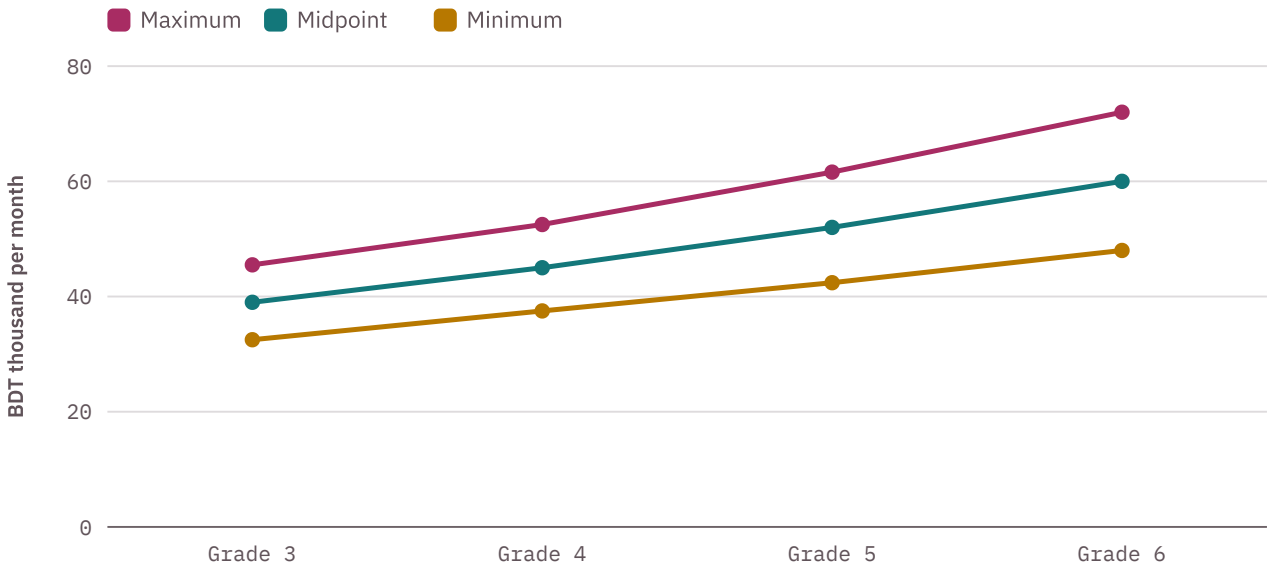
Range maths in a spreadsheet

```
Spreadsheet

# Inputs: B1 = midpoint, B2 = spread (e.g. 0.5), B3 = employee pay
B5 (minimum):      =B1/(1+B2/2)
B6 (maximum):      =B5*(1+B2)
B7 (compa-ratio):  =ROUND(B3/B1,2)
B8 (penetration):  =ROUND((B3-B5)/(B6-B5),2)
# Example: B1=60000, B2=0.5, B3=54000 gives 48000, 72000, 0.90, 0.25
```

The same formulas work in any spreadsheet tool. Keep inputs and formulas on separate rows so reviewers can check them.

Grade ranges: minimum, midpoint and maximum



Illustrative structure built with this lesson's formulas (40% spreads for grades 3–4, then 45% and 50%; midpoints about 15% apart). Notice the overlap: each range maximum sits above the next grade's midpoint, so experienced people can progress without promotion.

Traditional grades vs broadbands

Traditional grades

- Many narrow grades (often 12–20)
- Clear, frequent promotion steps
- Tighter cost control
- Can encourage title-chasing and rigid hierarchy

Broadbands

- Few wide bands (often 4–6)
- Flexibility to reward growth without promotion
- Supports flatter, agile structures
- Needs strong guidelines to avoid inconsistency and pay drift

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Pay outside the range

SITUATION	NAME	TYPICAL HANDLING
Pay below the minimum	Green-circled	Raise to minimum promptly or over a short, defined period
Pay above the maximum	Red-circled	Freeze base pay or give lump-sum increases until the range catches up; never cut pay without legal advice
New hire demanding pay above midpoint	Hiring exception	Allow only with evidence of exceptional skill and approval; check internal equity

PRO TIP · USE COMPA-RATIO TO STEER, NOT TO PUNISH

Compa-ratios help managers see who is underpaid relative to competence and the market. Pair them with performance and time in role: a strong performer at 0.85 deserves attention; a new joiner at 0.85 may be appropriately placed.

Reading pay position against performance

COMPA-RATIO →

Review
- Paid high for results shown
- Smaller or lump-sum increases
- Address performance

Sustain
- High pay, high performance
- Recognise; consider promotion if the job has grown

Develop
- Low in range, still learning
- Normal for new joiners; build capability

Fix first
- Strong performer paid low
- Move towards midpoint; retention risk

PERFORMANCE →

Plot each person's compa-ratio against performance before the pay review. Strong performers low in their range (bottom right) are the biggest retention risk and the first call on the budget.

TEMPLATE Grade structure worksheet

Build ranges for each grade from market midpoints and chosen spreads.

GRADE	MARKET MIDPOINT (BDT)	SPREAD	MINIMUM	MAXIMUM	MIDPOINT PROGRESSION
5	*52,000*	*45%*	*42,449*	*61,551*	*–*
6	*60,000*	*50%*	*48,000*	*72,000*	*15.4%*

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GRADE	MARKET MIDPOINT (BDT)	SPREAD	MINIMUM	MAXIMUM	MIDPOINT PROGRESSION

SCENARIO · DECIDE · PAY COMPRESSION

At a hospital, recently hired staff nurses are paid almost the same as senior nurses with eight years' service because starting salaries were raised to compete in the market. Senior nurses are unhappy. What is the best response?

(A) Reduce the starting salary for new nurses back to the old level.

(B) Give every nurse the same flat increase.

(C) Analyse compa-ratios and market data for both groups, then budget targeted adjustments for experienced nurses in the right range positions, phased if needed.

(D) Tell senior nurses that pay differences are confidential.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

REFLECT

If you know your own grade and range, calculate your compa-ratio and range penetration. What does it tell you, and what would you want your manager to consider?

Key terms

Pay grade
A group of jobs of similar value that share the same pay range.

Pay range
The minimum to maximum pay for a grade, usually built around a market-linked midpoint.

Range midpoint
The middle of a pay range, often set at the market rate for a fully competent job holder.

Range spread
The width of a pay range, calculated as maximum minus minimum divided by minimum.

Compa-ratio
An individual's pay divided by the midpoint of their pay range.

Range penetration
Where an individual's pay sits within the range, from the minimum to the maximum.

Broadbanding
A pay structure that uses a small number of wide bands instead of many narrow grades.

Salary survey
A structured collection of pay data for comparable jobs across organisations.

Red-circled pay
Pay above the maximum of the employee's range, usually frozen until the range catches up.

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Key takeaways

- Match survey jobs on content and level, age the data, use percentiles and respect competition law.
- Build ranges from a market midpoint and a spread; overlap between grades is normal.
- Compa-ratio = pay ÷ midpoint; range penetration = (pay − minimum) ÷ (maximum − minimum).
- Handle green- and red-circled pay deliberately, and read pay position alongside performance.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

11. A range midpoint is BDT 80,000 and an employee earns BDT 88,000. What is the compa-ratio?

(A) 0.91 (B) 1.08
(C) 1.10 (D) 0.88

12. A range has a minimum of 40,000 and a maximum of 60,000. What is its spread?

(A) 50% (B) 33%
(C) 20% (D) 150%

13. Same range (40,000–60,000). An employee earns 45,000. What is the range penetration?

(A) 25% (B) 45%
(C) 75% (D) 11%

14. An employee's pay is above the maximum of the range. This is called:

(A) Green-circled pay (B) Broadbanding
(C) Red-circled pay (D) Compression

15. Why should survey jobs be matched on content rather than title?

(A) Titles are confidential (B) Titles mean different things in different organisations
(C) Content data is always free, while title data must be purchased (D) Surveys never report titles

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MODULE 5 · REWARD · LESSON 4 · 26 MIN

Pay Progression, Incentives and Benefits

Reward contribution fairly and design benefits people actually value

- Use a merit matrix to allocate pay increases
- Choose incentive designs that support the right behaviours
- Design a benefits package for different employee groups
- Distinguish statutory, customary and voluntary benefits, using South Asian examples and a check-local-law approach

Once people are placed in ranges, they need ways to progress. Base pay can grow through **merit** (performance), **skills or competence**, **service** or general **cost-of-living** increases. **Variable pay** such as bonuses and incentives rewards results without permanently raising cost. **Benefits** cover needs such as health, security and saving. Each element should support the strategy and be explainable.

Merit matrix: increase % by performance and position in range

PERFORMANCE	COMPA-RATIO < 0.90	0.90–1.10	> 1.10
Exceeding	9%	7%	4%
Meeting	6%	4%	2%
Partly meeting	2%	1%	0%
Not meeting	0%	0%	0%

INSIGHT · WHY POSITION IN RANGE MATTERS

A merit matrix gives larger increases to strong performers who are low in their range, moving them towards the market rate faster, and smaller increases to people already high in the range. This controls cost and corrects under-payment over time.

Pay budget formulas

MEASURE	FORMULA	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Merit budget	`Merit budget = total eligible base pay × planned average increase %`	Sets the pool managers can allocate.
Bonus pool	`Bonus pool = target bonus pool × company performance factor`	Funds variable pay according to results, for example 0.8 if targets are partly met.
Individual bonus	`Bonus = base pay × target bonus % × company factor × individual factor`	Combines organisational and individual results.
Overtime pay (general form)	`Overtime pay = overtime hours × hourly rate × premium multiplier`	The rate base and multiplier are set by local law; check the current text.

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Incentive designs

Individual

- Sales commission, piece rates, individual bonus
- Clear line of sight
- Risk: gaming, neglect of teamwork, quality or ethics

Team or unit

- Team bonus, gainsharing on productivity savings
- Encourages cooperation
- Risk: free riders; less individual line of sight

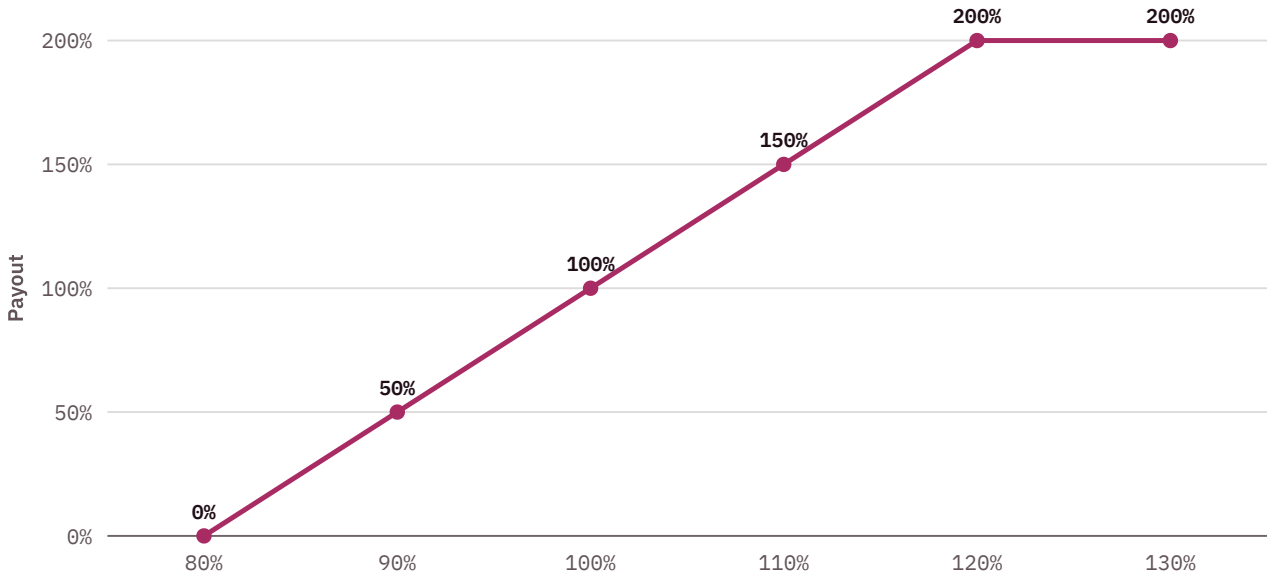
Organisation-wide

- Profit sharing, company bonus, equity
- Builds shared purpose
- Risk: weak link between individual effort and payout

WATCH OUT · INCENTIVES DRIVE BEHAVIOUR, INCLUDING BAD BEHAVIOUR

Sales incentives tied only to volume have led to mis-selling scandals in banking and insurance around the world. Balance volume with quality, compliance and customer outcomes, cap payouts where needed, and include clawback rules for misconduct.

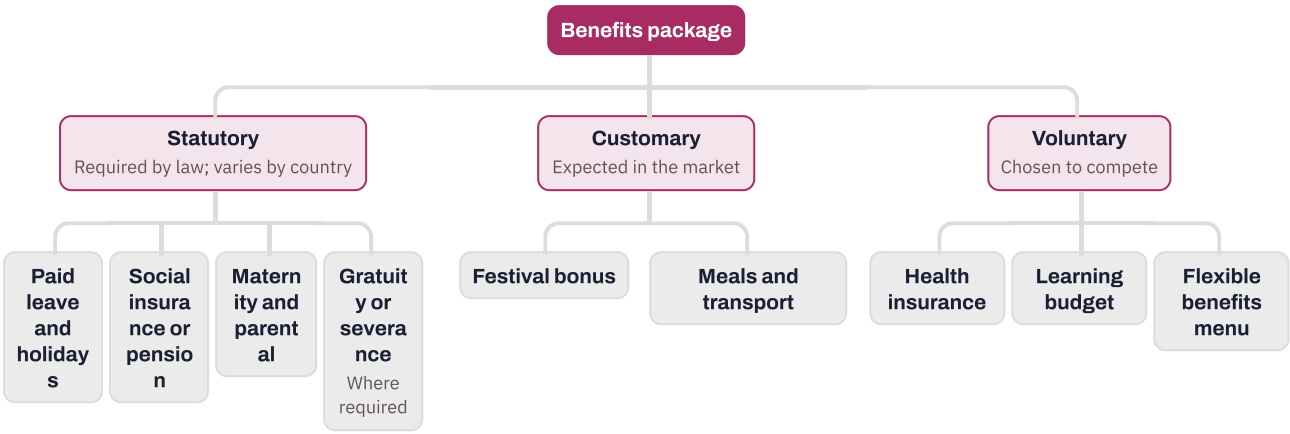
An incentive payout curve



Illustrative design: nothing is paid below a threshold (90% of target, which pays 50%), payout rises steeply to and beyond target, and a cap (200%) limits windfalls and the temptation to game. Quality and compliance gates apply at every point on the curve.

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Three kinds of benefit



Secure the statutory layer first (it differs by country), then match market custom, then choose voluntary benefits by what employees value most, as the NGO scenario below shows. A benefit can be statutory in one country and voluntary in another.

Example: common benefits in Bangladesh and wider South Asia (general overview; rules vary by country)

BENEFIT	WHAT IT IS	NOTES
Festival bonus	Bonus paid around major religious festivals, commonly two a year	Customary and in some sectors required; check the current rules
Provident fund	Savings fund with employee and employer contributions	Often requires approval and rules under the relevant law and tax regime
Gratuity	Lump sum on leaving after qualifying service	Formula and eligibility depend on law and company scheme
Workers' participation and welfare funds	Profit-linked funds for workers in qualifying companies	Applies to certain companies under labour law; seek advice
Group health and life insurance	Medical cover and death or disability benefit	Voluntary but highly valued
Transport, meals, housing	Allowances or provided services	Important for shift and factory workers

PRO TIP · FLEXIBLE BENEFITS

A **flexible benefits** scheme lets employees choose from a menu within a budget, for example more health cover for a parent, or a learning allowance for a graduate. It improves perceived value but needs clear rules, technology and careful tax treatment.

CASE STUDY · AN INCENTIVE SCHEME THAT BACKFIRED

A mobile financial services company pays field agents BDT 50 for every new customer account opened. Account numbers have tripled, but 60% of new accounts have no transaction after 30 days, several agents have opened accounts using customers' details without full consent, and the regulator has asked questions.

1. What went wrong in the incentive design?

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2. How would you redesign the scheme?

3. What immediate risk actions are needed?

Model answer: module answer key.

SCENARIO · DECIDE · CHOOSING A BENEFIT WITH A LIMITED BUDGET

A 250-person NGO in Sylhet has a small budget to add one new benefit. A staff survey shows the top concerns are medical costs for families (62%), transport (21%) and learning (17%). What should HR recommend?

(A) A learning allowance, because development is the most strategic benefit.

(B) Split the budget equally across all three areas.

(C) Give a one-off cash bonus instead.

(D) A group health insurance plan covering employees and dependants, communicated clearly with its value in taka.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

REFLECT

Which part of your own total reward package do you value most, and which do you hardly notice? What does that suggest about how benefits are communicated?

Key terms

Merit increase
A rise in base pay linked to an individual's performance.

Merit matrix
A grid that sets pay increase percentages by performance level and position in the pay range.

Variable pay
Pay that varies with performance or results, such as bonuses and incentives, and must be re-earned.

Commission
Variable pay based on a percentage or amount of sales made.

Gainsharing
A team or unit incentive that shares the financial gains from improved productivity or cost savings.

Flexible benefits
A scheme allowing employees to choose benefits from a menu within an allowance.

Provident fund
A savings scheme into which employers and employees contribute, paid out on retirement or leaving under its rules.

Clawback
A rule allowing an employer to recover incentive pay later found to be unearned, for example because of misconduct.

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Key takeaways

- Base pay can progress by merit, skills, service or cost of living; a merit matrix links increases to performance and position in range.
- Variable pay rewards results without permanent cost; balance volume with quality, compliance and customer outcomes, with caps and clawback.
- Benefits are statutory, customary or voluntary: check local law first, then fund what employees value.
- Flexible benefits raise perceived value but need clear rules, technology and tax advice.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

16. Using the merit matrix in this lesson, what increase does a 'meeting' performer with a compa-ratio of 0.85 receive?

(A) 4%
(B) 2%
(C) 9%
(D) 6%

17. Base pay BDT 600,000 a year, target bonus 10%, company factor 0.8, individual factor 1.2. What is the bonus?

(A) BDT 60,000
(B) BDT 48,000
(C) BDT 57,600
(D) BDT 72,000

18. Which incentive design best encourages cooperation within a production unit?

(A) Gainsharing on productivity savings
(B) Individual piece rates
(C) Individual sales commission
(D) Stock options for executives only, linked to the share price

19. What is the main risk of incentives based only on sales volume?

(A) Too much teamwork
(B) Lower sales
(C) Higher fixed costs, because volume incentives raise base salaries over time
(D) Gaming and mis-selling at the expense of quality and customers

20. Total eligible base pay is BDT 50 million and the planned average merit increase is 5%. What is the merit budget?

(A) BDT 5 million
(B) BDT 2.5 million
(C) BDT 0.5 million
(D) BDT 25 million

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MODULE 5 · REWARD · LESSON 5 · 24 MIN

Pay Equity, Transparency and Payroll Integrity

Prove pay is fair, explain it openly and pay people correctly every time

- Calculate mean and median gender pay gaps
- Distinguish a pay gap from unequal pay for equal work
- Run a pay equity review
- Apply transparency and payroll control principles

Fair pay is a legal requirement in many countries and a basic expectation everywhere. Two related ideas are often confused. **Equal pay** means people doing equal work, or work of equal value, are paid equally. A **pay gap** compares average pay between groups across the organisation, and can exist even when equal pay is respected, for example because women are concentrated in lower-paid roles.

Pay gap formulas

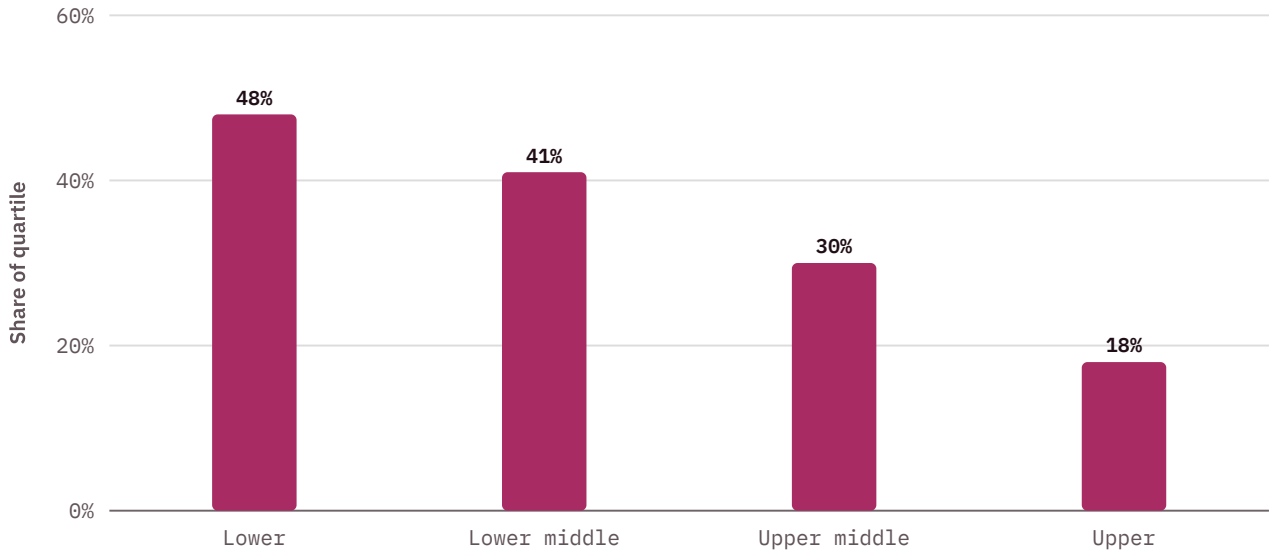
MEASURE	FORMULA	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Mean gender pay gap	`Mean gap % = (mean hourly pay of men − mean hourly pay of women) ÷ mean hourly pay of men × 100`	Sensitive to very high earners at the top.
Median gender pay gap	`Median gap % = (median pay of men − median pay of women) ÷ median pay of men × 100`	Shows the gap for the typical employee; less affected by extremes.
Representation by pay quartile	`Share of women in each quarter of the pay distribution`	Shows where the gap comes from: often few women at the top.
Adjusted gap	`Gap remaining after controlling for grade, role, location, tenure and performance`	The unexplained part needs investigation for possible unequal pay.

EXAMPLE · READING A PAY GAP

A bank's mean hourly pay is BDT 820 for men and BDT 697 for women. Mean gap = (820 − 697) ÷ 820 × 100 = **15%**. Women are 48% of the lowest pay quartile but only 18% of the top quartile. After controlling for grade and role, the adjusted gap is 2%, mostly in one division. The bank needs two actions: help more women progress into senior roles, and investigate the unexplained gap in that division.

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Women's share of each pay quartile



The bank from the example above; the two middle values are illustrative. The falling bars show where the 15% mean gap comes from: women are well represented in lower-paid roles and scarce at the top.

Running a pay equity review

1. **Define scope and protect data** Agree groups to compare (for example gender, location, contract type) and secure the data.
2. **Group comparable work** Use grades or job evaluation to identify equal work and work of equal value.
3. **Compare pay** Compare base pay, allowances, bonuses and benefits within each group.
4. **Explain differences** Check legitimate reasons such as experience, performance or market supplements, with evidence.
5. **Fix unexplained gaps** Budget corrections and fix the processes that caused them, such as starting-pay negotiation.
6. **Repeat and report** Review annually and report progress to leadership.

Pay secrecy vs pay transparency

Secrecy

- Pay ranges and decisions hidden
- Rumours fill the gap
- Bias can go unnoticed
- Negotiation skill drives pay

Transparency

- Ranges published internally and often in job ads
- Clear criteria for progression
- Gaps are visible and must be explained
- Trust grows if the system is fair

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INSIGHT · TRANSPARENCY RULES ARE SPREADING

A growing number of jurisdictions require pay ranges in job ads, ban questions about salary history or require gender pay gap reporting. The most far-reaching example is the **EU Pay Transparency Directive** (2023). Member states had to bring it into national law by **7 June 2026**; several were late, and national details differ, so check each country's current law. Its core elements: pay information for candidates before interview; no salary-history questions; pay-setting and progression criteria available to employees; a right for workers to ask for their own pay level and average pay by sex for the same work or work of equal value; gender pay gap reporting by employers with 100 or more workers; and a **joint pay assessment** with worker representatives where reporting shows a gap of 5% or more in a category of workers that the employer cannot justify and does not fix within six months. Even where none of this is required, publishing ranges internally is a strong test of whether your structure is defensible.

EU Pay Transparency Directive: key dates



MAY 2023
Adopted
Directive (EU) 2023/970; in force from June 2023

7 JUNE 2026
Transposition deadline
National laws due, covering candidates, information rights and pay secrecy

7 JUNE 2027
First gap reports, 150+ workers
Then yearly for 250+ workers and every three years for 150–249

7 JUNE 2031
First reports, 100–149 workers
Then every three years

Dates come from the directive; national laws may add detail or bring some duties forward, and several countries missed the 2026 deadline. Always check the current national timetable.

Payroll integrity controls

- Separate duties: the person who changes pay data is not the person who approves the payroll.
- Reconcile headcount between HR records and payroll every cycle to catch 'ghost' employees.
- Check variances: large changes from the previous month must be explained before payment.
- Keep an audit trail of every change, who made it and why.
- Pay on time: late wages hurt trust quickly and may breach the law.
- Give clear payslips showing every element and deduction.
- Protect payroll data with access controls and secure transfer to banks or mobile wallets.

WATCH OUT · STATUTORY DEDUCTIONS AND CONTRIBUTIONS

Income tax withholding, social contributions, provident fund deductions and similar items depend on national law and change regularly. HR and payroll teams should follow current official guidance and get professional advice, rather than relying on old spreadsheets.

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SCENARIO · DECIDE · AN UNEXPLAINED GAP

A pay equity review at a Dhaka software firm finds that women engineers in the same grade earn 7% less on average than men, after controlling for experience and performance. Most of the difference arises from starting salaries. What should HR do?

(A) Budget adjustments to close the unexplained gap, and change hiring practice by setting starting pay within published ranges based on job level rather than salary history or negotiation.

(B) Keep the finding confidential and review again next year.

(C) Give the affected women a one-off bonus instead of a base pay change.

(D) Train women engineers to negotiate harder.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

TEMPLATE **Pay equity review log**

Record comparisons, explanations and actions for each group of comparable roles.

GRADE OR ROLE GROUP	GROUP A AVG PAY	GROUP B AVG PAY	GAP %	EXPLAINED BY	ACTION AND OWNER
Grade P2 Engineers	*BDT 118,000*	*BDT 109,700*	*7.0 %*	*Experience 1%, unexplained 6% (starting pay)*	*Adjust base pay over 2 cycles; publish starting ranges – Reward lead*

REFLECT

Could you explain to any employee in your organisation why they are paid what they are paid? Which parts of the answer would be uncomfortable?

Key terms

Pay equity
Fair pay for comparable work regardless of gender or other protected characteristics, with differences explained by legitimate factors.

Gender pay gap
The difference between average pay for men and women across an organisation, expressed as a percentage of men's pay.

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Equal pay for work of equal value
The principle that different jobs of the same overall value should receive equal pay.

Pay transparency
Openness about pay ranges, criteria and decisions, inside the organisation and in job ads; increasingly required by law, for example under the EU Pay Transparency Directive.

Ghost employee
A fictitious or departed person kept on the payroll so that pay is wrongly diverted.

Adjusted pay gap
The pay gap remaining after controlling for factors such as role, grade, location and experience.

Pay quartile
One of four equal groups formed by ranking employees by pay from lowest to highest.

Joint pay assessment
Under the EU Pay Transparency Directive, a review carried out with worker representatives when an unjustified gender pay gap of 5% or more in a category of workers is not corrected within six months.

Key takeaways

- Equal pay concerns equal work or work of equal value; a pay gap compares averages across the organisation.
- Report mean and median gaps plus quartile representation, and investigate the unexplained gap.
- Fix unexplained gaps and the processes that caused them, such as negotiated starting pay.
- Pay transparency rules, led by the EU directive, are spreading: build structures you can explain.
- Protect payroll with segregation of duties, reconciliation, variance checks and audit trails.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

21. Men's mean hourly pay is 500 and women's is 450. What is the mean gender pay gap?

(A) 11.1%
(B) 10%
(C) 5%
(D) 50%

22. An organisation has a large pay gap but pays men and women equally for equal work. What is the most likely explanation?

(A) The calculation must be wrong
(B) Equal pay law has been broken and must be reported to the authorities
(C) Women work fewer hours
(D) Women are concentrated in lower-paid roles or grades

23. Why is the median pay gap useful alongside the mean?

(A) It is less affected by a few very high earners
(B) It always shows a larger gap
(C) It excludes women
(D) It is required everywhere by law instead of the mean, so the mean should not be reported

24. Which control best prevents 'ghost' employees on the payroll?

(A) Paying everyone in cash
(B) Letting one experienced person both change and approve payroll to avoid delays
(C) Reconciling HR headcount records with payroll every cycle
(D) Deleting the audit trail monthly

25. Which practice most directly reduces gender gaps in starting salaries?

(A) Asking for salary history
(B) Leaving starting pay fully to individual negotiation with each candidate
(C) Keeping ranges secret
(D) Setting starting pay within published ranges based on job level

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26. Under national laws implementing the EU Pay Transparency Directive, which recruitment practice must employers stop?

(A) Publishing pay ranges on the internal intranet
(B) Asking candidates about their pay history
(C) Using job evaluation to place roles in grades
(D) Running a pay equity review every year with worker representatives

☐ Lesson complete · Date _____ · Knowledge check score ____ / 6

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MODULE 5 · REWARD

Answer key

Knowledge checks

1. C Paying above the market median is a lead strategy.

2. A Development is a non-pay element of total rewards.

3. D Internal equity concerns fairness between jobs inside the organisation.

4. B Legal requirements set the minimum for any reward design.

5. B Showing the full package helps people see its real value.

6. D Job evaluation sizes the job itself.

7. A Analytical schemes compare jobs factor by factor with recorded reasons.

8. C (4 ÷ 5) × 25 = 20 points.

9. D Market rates may reflect historical undervaluation, and unique jobs lack comparators.

10. B Diverse, trained panels give more balanced and trusted evaluations.

11. C 88,000 ÷ 80,000 = 1.10.

12. A (60,000 – 40,000) ÷ 40,000 = 0.50.

13. A (45,000 – 40,000) ÷ (60,000 – 40,000) = 0.25.

14. C Red-circled pay sits above the range maximum.

15. B A 'manager' title in one firm may describe a much smaller job elsewhere.

16. D Meeting expectations and below 0.90 in range gives 6%.

17. C 600,000 × 0.10 × 0.8 × 1.2 = 57,600.

18. A Gainsharing rewards the whole unit for shared improvements.

19. D Single volume measures encourage people to hit numbers in harmful ways.

20. B 50,000,000 × 0.05 = 2,500,000.

21. B (500 – 450) ÷ 500 × 100 = 10%.

22. D Pay gaps often reflect representation across levels rather than unequal pay for the same job.

23. A The median reflects the typical employee.

24. C Reconciliation detects people being paid who are not active employees.

25. D Structured starting pay reduces the effect of negotiation and past pay inequities.

26. B The directive bars employers from asking candidates about their pay history and requires pay information before interview. Publishing ranges, job evaluation and equity reviews all support its aims.

Scenarios & case studies

Scenario · A retention request
A is best. Best. This addresses a likely structural issue fairly and protects internal equity, while still responding to the market.

Scenario · A manager wants a regrade
B is best. Best. This protects the integrity of the grading system while still responding to the retention concern.

Scenario · Pay compression
C is best. Best. Compression is a structural issue; data-led, targeted adjustments restore fairness within budget.

Case study · An incentive scheme that backfired
The scheme rewarded a single volume measure with no quality, compliance or customer-outcome measure, so it encouraged gaming and misconduct. A redesign would pay part of the incentive only when the account becomes active (for example after a set number of genuine transactions), include quality and compliance gates (for example correct KYC and no complaints), cap payouts, add team elements and include clawback for accounts later found to be improper. Immediately: investigate the suspect accounts, protect affected customers, cooperate with the regulator, take fair disciplinary action where misconduct is proven, retrain agents and pause or modify the scheme until the redesign is ready.

Scenario · Choosing a benefit with a limited budget
D is best. Best. It addresses the most widely felt need, protects staff from financial shocks and is highly valued for its cost.

Scenario · An unexplained gap
A is best. Best. It corrects current unfairness and fixes the process that caused it.

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06

MODULE 6 · RELATE

Employee Relations, Engagement, Law, Inclusion and Wellbeing

Build trusted relations: voice, engagement, lawful practice, fair procedures, inclusion and wellbeing

BY THE END OF THIS MODULE YOU WILL BE ABLE TO

- Build trust through employee voice, collective channels and early conflict resolution
- Measure engagement and turn it into retention actions
- Identify the main areas of employment law and check local requirements
- Run fair discipline, grievance and investigation processes
- Advance diversity, equity, inclusion and wellbeing with measurable actions

LESSONS

1. Employee Relations and Voice · 24 min
2. Engagement and Retention · 24 min
3. Employment Law Basics · 26 min
4. Discipline, Grievances, Investigations and Exits · 26 min
5. Diversity, Equity, Inclusion and Wellbeing · 26 min

MODULE 6 · RELATE · LESSON 1 · 24 MIN

Employee Relations and Voice

Build trust between the organisation and its people, individually and collectively

- Explain the psychological contract and why it matters
- Compare unitarist and pluralist views of the employment relationship
- Design channels for employee voice, including collective channels
- Use early conflict resolution and mediation

Employee relations (ER) is the management of the relationship between employer and employees, individually and collectively. Good ER is visible in what does *not* happen: fewer disputes, fewer surprises, fewer resignations after a bad decision. It rests on trust, fair process and real channels for people to be heard.

DEFINITION · PSYCHOLOGICAL CONTRACT

Beyond the written contract, every employee holds an unwritten set of beliefs about what they owe the employer and what the employer owes them: fair treatment, development, recognition, job security, honesty. This **psychological contract** is never signed, but when people believe it has been broken, trust, effort and loyalty fall quickly.

Two views of the employment relationship

Unitarist

- Employer and employees share the same goals
- Conflict is a sign of poor communication or troublemakers
- Prefers direct communication and individual relationships
- Risk: ignores real differences of interest

Pluralist

- Different groups have some legitimately different interests
- Conflict is normal and should be managed through fair institutions
- Accepts unions, bargaining and representative bodies
- Risk: can become adversarial if trust is low

INSIGHT · BOTH LENSES ARE USEFUL

Most organisations share many goals with their people, such as the business surviving and growing, while also having real differences over pay, workload and job security. Recognising both helps leaders build channels where differences can be raised and settled before they escalate.

Channels for employee voice

CHANNEL	TYPE	GOOD FOR
One-to-one check-ins	Individual, direct	Day-to-day concerns and ideas
Team meetings and huddles	Group, direct	Work improvement, local problems
Surveys and pulse polls	Individual, anonymous	Broad sentiment and trends
Suggestion schemes and idea platforms	Individual	Improvement ideas
Employee forums and councils	Representative	Policy consultation in non-union settings

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CHANNEL	TYPE	GOOD FOR
Participation committees	Representative, statutory in some settings	Joint discussion of welfare, productivity and safety
Trade unions and collective bargaining	Representative, collective	Pay, terms and conditions, disputes
Speak-up and whistleblowing lines	Individual, protected	Wrongdoing, safety and ethics concerns

Mapping voice channels

FORMALITY →

Formal, individual
- Grievance procedure
- Speak-up or whistleblowing line

Formal, collective
- Trade unions and bargaining
- Participation committees or works councils
- Safety committees

Everyday, individual
- One-to-ones and check-ins
- Open-door conversations

Everyday, collective
- Team huddles
- Town halls
- Pulse surveys and listening tools

INDIVIDUAL TO COLLECTIVE VOICE →

Healthy organisations use all four quadrants. Most issues should be settled in the bottom row; the top row is the safety net when everyday channels fail or the issue is serious.

EXAMPLE · COUNTRY EXAMPLE: VOICE IN BANGLADESH'S GARMENT SECTOR

Labour law in Bangladesh provides for participation committees and, in qualifying factories, trade unions and collective bargaining agents; safety committees are also required in many factories. Factories that run these bodies genuinely, with elected worker representatives, regular minutes and visible follow-up, tend to resolve issues before they become stoppages. Export processing zones have a separate legal framework, so always check which law applies. Rules on representation differ widely between countries (many European countries, for example, require works councils in larger workplaces), so check which bodies the law requires where you operate.

Resolving conflict early

01 **Notice** — Spot tension early: complaints, withdrawal, sharp emails →

02 **Talk** — Private, informal conversation with each party →

03 **Facilitate** — Joint conversation to agree ways of working →

04 **Mediate** — Neutral trained mediator helps parties find their own solution →

05 **Formal process** — Grievance or disciplinary procedure if needed

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What a good mediator does

- Stays neutral and does not judge who is right.
- Keeps the process voluntary and confidential within agreed limits.
- Lets each party tell their story without interruption.
- Moves the conversation from positions (what people demand) to interests (what they actually need).
- Helps parties write their own specific, realistic agreement.
- Checks in later to see whether the agreement holds.

SCENARIO · DECIDE · A RUMOUR OF A WALKOUT

At a Chattogram footwear factory, supervisors hear that workers on two lines plan to stop work tomorrow because overtime payments were delayed for the second month. What should HR and management do first?

(A) Meet worker representatives today, acknowledge the delay, confirm the facts and a firm payment date, and explain what will prevent it happening again.

(B) Warn workers that anyone who stops work will be dismissed.

(C) Wait to see whether the walkout actually happens.

(D) Identify and transfer the suspected organisers to other sites.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

REFLECT

What does your organisation's psychological contract look like from an employee's point of view? Where might people feel it has recently been broken?

Key terms

Employee relations
The management of the individual and collective relationship between an employer and its employees.

Employee voice
The ways employees express views, raise concerns and influence decisions at work.

Collective bargaining
Negotiation between employers and worker representatives over pay and terms and conditions.

Mediation
A voluntary, confidential process in which a neutral person helps parties in conflict reach their own agreement.

Psychological contract
The unwritten beliefs employees and employers hold about what they owe each other.

Trade union
An organisation of workers that represents members' interests, including in collective bargaining.

Participation committee
A joint body of employer and worker representatives that discusses welfare, productivity and workplace issues.

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Key takeaways

- Good employee relations rest on trust, fair process and real channels to be heard.
- The psychological contract is unwritten but powerful; breaking it damages trust fast.
- Use both unitarist and pluralist lenses, and offer individual and collective, everyday and formal voice.
- Resolve conflict early and use neutral mediation before formal procedures.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. A manager believes workplace conflict only happens because of troublemakers. Which perspective is this?
   - (A) Pluralist
   - (B) Collective bargaining
   - (C) Unitarist
   - (D) Psychological contract
2. Employees expected promotion opportunities that never appeared, and engagement has dropped. Which concept best explains this?
   - (A) A breach of the psychological contract
   - (B) A breach of the written employment contract
   - (C) Leniency bias
   - (D) Market positioning
3. In mediation, who decides the solution?
   - (A) The mediator
   - (B) HR
   - (C) The most senior of the parties involved
   - (D) The parties themselves
4. Which voice channel is best for raising concerns about wrongdoing with protection?
   - (A) A suggestion box for improvement ideas in the canteen
   - (B) A speak-up or whistleblowing line
   - (C) A team huddle
   - (D) A social event
5. A good mediator moves parties from positions to:
   - (A) Legal threats
   - (B) Interests: what each party actually needs
   - (C) Formal disciplinary action against the party who started it
   - (D) Public statements

☐ Lesson complete · Date _____ · Knowledge check score ____ / 5

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MODULE 6 · RELATE · LESSON 2 · 24 MIN

Engagement and Retention

Understand what makes people give their best and stay

- Define engagement and its main drivers
- Design and act on engagement surveys
- Calculate and interpret eNPS
- Use stay interviews and targeted retention actions

Employee engagement describes how committed, energised and absorbed people are in their work and how willing they are to go beyond the minimum. Engaged employees are not simply happy; they care about outcomes and put in **discretionary effort**. Engagement is linked in many studies with lower turnover, better safety and stronger customer outcomes.

Common drivers of engagement

D1
Meaningful work
People see how their work matters.

D2
Capable manager
A manager who sets direction, supports and recognises.

D3
Growth
Opportunities to learn and progress.

D4
Voice
Being heard and seeing ideas acted on.

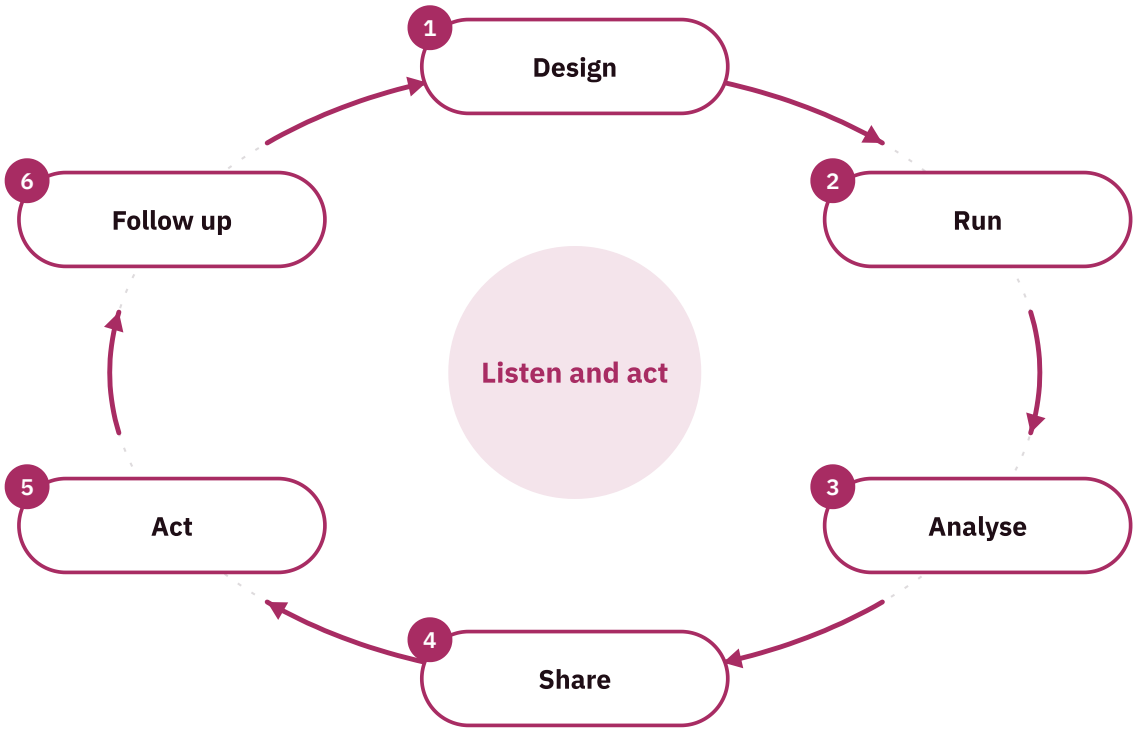
D5
Fairness
Fair pay, fair decisions and respectful treatment.

D6
Wellbeing
Manageable workload, flexibility and safety.

D7
Trust in leaders
Leaders are honest, consistent and competent.

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The engagement survey cycle



1. **Design** — Short, validated items plus a few local questions
2. **Run** — Anonymous, accessible in local languages and offline
3. **Analyse** — Drivers, hotspots, trends; protect anonymity
4. **Share** — Results back to all staff quickly
5. **Act** — Teams choose 1–3 actions
6. **Follow up** — Pulse surveys to check progress

The loop only works if it closes: visible action and a follow-up pulse show people that speaking up changes things, which keeps response rates and honesty high.

WATCH OUT · SURVEYS WITHOUT ACTION DO HARM

Asking people for their views and then doing nothing visible is worse than not asking. Response rates fall and cynicism grows. Commit before the survey to sharing results within weeks and to at least one visible action per team.

INSIGHT · FROM ANNUAL SURVEY TO LISTENING SYSTEM

Many organisations now run **continuous listening**: a short annual or twice-yearly survey, frequent pulses, lifecycle surveys (after onboarding, promotion or exit), open comment channels and, increasingly, AI text analytics to find themes in thousands of comments. More data helps only if it leads to action. Keep anonymity thresholds, explain what is collected and why, avoid covert "passive listening" on emails or chats unless it is lawful, proportionate and openly explained, and never use comments to identify individuals.

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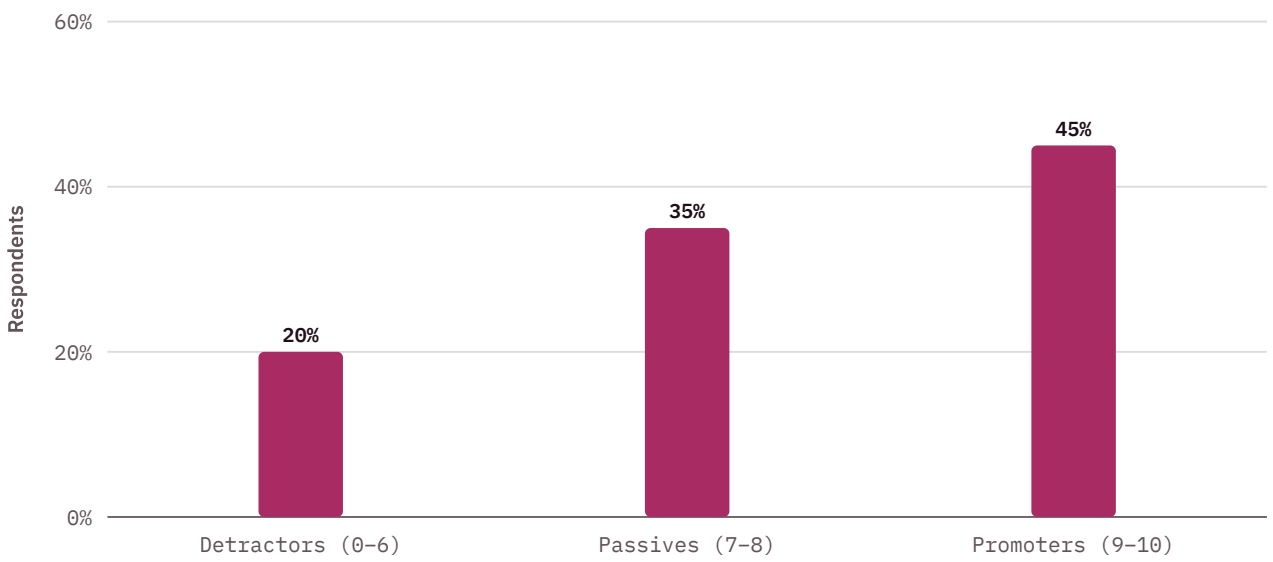
Engagement and retention metrics

MEASURE	FORMULA	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
eNPS	`eNPS = % promoters (9–10) − % detractors (0–6)`	Answers to 'How likely are you to recommend this organisation as a place to work?' Ranges from −100 to +100.
Engagement index	`Average favourable % across the core engagement items`	Track trends and compare teams; avoid league tables that shame managers.
Response rate	`Responses ÷ invited employees × 100`	Low rates may signal distrust or access barriers.
Voluntary turnover	`Voluntary leavers ÷ average headcount × 100`	Leavers who chose to go; the main retention signal.

EXAMPLE · CALCULATING ENPS

At a Dhaka software company, 200 people answer the recommend question: 90 score 9–10, 70 score 7–8 and 40 score 0–6. Promoters = 45%, detractors = 20%. eNPS = 45 − 20 = **+25**. Passives (7–8) count in the total but not in the score.

eNPS example: 200 responses



Worked-example data: eNPS = 45 − 20 = +25. Passives (35%) do not enter the score, but they are often the easiest group to move.

Exit interview vs stay interview

Exit interview

- Held when someone is leaving
- Explains why they left
- Too late to keep that person
- Useful for spotting patterns

Stay interview

- Held with current valued employees
- Asks why they stay and what might make them leave
- Early enough to act
- Builds the relationship with the manager

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Good stay interview questions

- What do you look forward to most when you come to work?
- What are you learning here, and what would you like to learn?
- What frustrates you most about your job?
- If you were thinking about leaving, what would be the reason?
- What could I do differently as your manager to support you?

TEMPLATE

Team engagement action plan

Turn survey results into a small number of owned, visible actions.

SURVEY FINDING	ROOT CAUSE (FROM TEAM DISCUSSION)	ACTION	OWNER	BY WHEN	HOW WE WILL KNOW
Only 41% feel recognised	*Recognition only from senior leaders, rarely specific*	*Weekly team shout-outs; manager gives one specific recognition per person each fortnight*	*Team lead*	*Start next week*	*Recognition item ≥ 60% in next pulse*

SCENARIO · DECIDE · A TEAM WITH LOW SCORES

An engagement survey at a hospital shows one ward with scores 30 points below average. The ward manager is upset and asks HR who wrote the negative comments so she can 'talk to them'. What should HR do?

(A) Share the names privately so the manager can resolve the issues one to one.

(B) Refuse to identify anyone, protect anonymity, and help the manager hold a facilitated team discussion to understand the issues and agree actions.

(C) Exclude the ward from the survey results so they do not distort the average.

(D) Replace the manager immediately.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

REFLECT

Which three engagement drivers are strongest in your team, and which one is weakest? What one action could you take this month?

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Key terms

Employee engagement
The degree to which people are committed to, energised by and absorbed in their work and organisation.

Engagement driver
A factor, such as manager support or growth, that research or analysis shows influences engagement.

Employee net promoter score (eNPS)
Percentage of promoters minus percentage of detractors when employees rate how likely they are to recommend the employer.

Flight risk
An assessment that a valued employee is likely to leave in the near future.

Discretionary effort
Effort people choose to give beyond what is strictly required.

Pulse survey
A short, frequent survey that tracks a few key measures between full surveys.

Stay interview
A structured conversation with a valued employee about why they stay and what might make them leave.

Continuous listening
Gathering employee views through a mix of short surveys, pulses, lifecycle surveys and open channels throughout the year, and acting on them.

Key takeaways

- Engagement is energy and discretionary effort; managers, fairness, growth, voice and wellbeing drive it.
- Close the listening loop: share results quickly and act visibly, or cynicism grows.
- eNPS = % promoters − % detractors; track trends and protect anonymity.
- Use stay interviews to act before valued people leave.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

6. Of 100 respondents, 30 are promoters, 50 passives and 20 detractors. What is the eNPS?
   - (A) +30
   - (B) −20
   - (C) +50
   - (D) +10

7. What is the main advantage of a stay interview over an exit interview?
   - (A) It happens early enough to act
   - (B) It is always anonymous
   - (C) It replaces surveys
   - (D) It is required by law in most countries for every employee

8. What usually happens if survey results are not acted on?
   - (A) Engagement rises automatically
   - (B) Turnover drops
   - (C) Cynicism grows and response rates fall
   - (D) Nothing happens; surveys are mainly kept for compliance records

9. Which driver is typically among the strongest influences on day-to-day engagement?
   - (A) Office décor
   - (B) The company logo
   - (C) The design of the annual report
   - (D) The immediate manager

10. A manager asks HR to identify survey respondents who left negative comments. HR should:
    - (A) Provide the names confidentially
    - (B) Protect anonymity and support a team discussion instead
    - (C) Delete the comments
    - (D) Ask the ward's staff to re-take the survey with their names attached this time

☐ Lesson complete · Date _____ · Knowledge check score ____ / 5

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MODULE 6 · RELATE · LESSON 3 · 26 MIN

Employment Law Basics

Know the main areas of employment law and when to check the details

- Identify the main areas of employment law HR must manage
- Describe in general terms how one national framework covers these areas, using Bangladesh as a country example
- Build a simple compliance calendar and record system
- Know when to seek legal advice

WATCH OUT · CHECK LOCAL LAW

This lesson is **general education, not legal advice**. Employment law differs by country, state, sector and even by zone, and it changes through amendments, rules, court decisions and government notifications. Always check the current official text, and take qualified legal advice for specific cases.

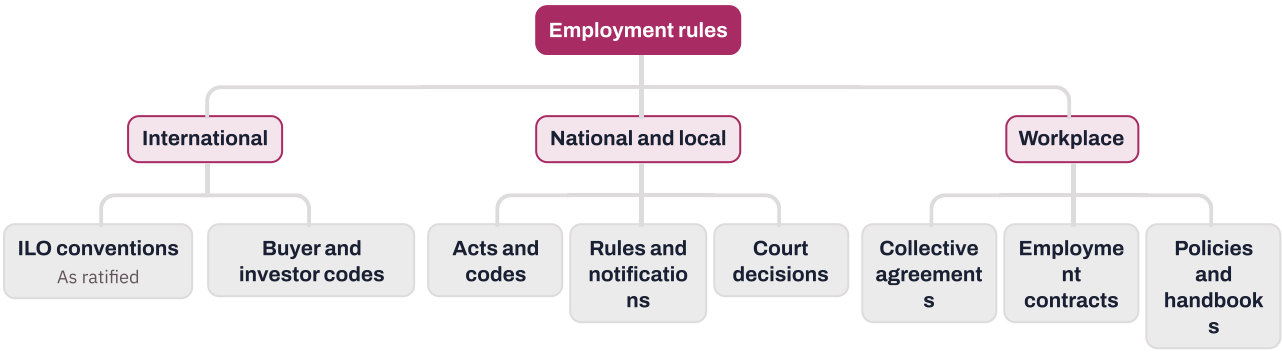
Employment law sets the minimum standards for how people are hired, paid, treated and dismissed. HR does not need to be a lawyer, but it must know **which areas of law apply**, recognise when a decision carries legal risk, and keep records that show the organisation acted lawfully and fairly.

The main areas of employment law

Ending employment	`Notice and resignation` `Dismissal and its grounds` `Retrenchment or redundancy` `Final settlement and certificates`
Conduct and process	`Disciplinary and grievance procedures` `Investigations and hearings` `Harassment and whistleblowing`
Equality and dignity	`Discrimination` `Harassment` `Maternity and family rights` `Disability`
Pay and time	`Minimum wage` `Wage payment timing and deductions` `Working hours, rest and overtime` `Leave and holidays`
Health, safety and welfare	`Safe workplace` `Safety committees` `Welfare facilities` `Accident reporting and compensation`
Starting employment	`Right to work and age limits` `Contracts and appointment letters` `Probation` `Records and identity`

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Where employment rules come from



Several layers apply at once. Generally a contract or policy cannot give less than the law requires but can give more, and buyer codes may ask for more again. Which international instruments bind an employer depends on what its country has ratified and how it applies them.

Every country organises these areas differently. The table below uses Bangladesh as a worked country example; if you work elsewhere, build the same table for your own jurisdiction from official sources.

Country example: Bangladesh labour-law themes in general terms

THEME	WHAT THE FRAMEWORK GENERALLY COVERS	HR ACTION
Coverage	A main labour act with implementing rules covers most private-sector establishments; export processing zones have a separate labour law; the act has been amended several times, including recent reforms	Confirm which law applies to each site and category of worker, using the latest amended text
Appointment and records	Written appointment letters, identity cards, service records and registers	Issue letters and IDs on joining; keep records current
Working hours and overtime	Daily and weekly hour limits, rest intervals, a weekly holiday and overtime at a premium rate	Track hours accurately; pay overtime correctly and on time
Leave	Several leave types, such as casual, sick, annual and festival leave	Publish a leave policy aligned with current entitlements
Maternity	Paid maternity leave and protections for women workers	Apply entitlements and protect against dismissal for pregnancy
Wages	Payment within set time limits, minimum wages for notified sectors, limits on deductions	Pay on schedule; check gazette notifications for minimum wages
Termination	Different routes such as resignation, retrenchment, discharge, dismissal for misconduct and termination with notice, each with process and payment rules	Follow the correct route, notice and settlement; get advice
Collective rights	Trade unions, collective bargaining agents and participation committees in qualifying establishments	Respect freedom of association; run committees properly
Safety and welfare	Safety committees, fire safety, welfare facilities and compensation for workplace injury	Maintain committees, drills, records and facilities

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INSIGHT · RULES ARE THE FLOOR, NOT THE GOAL

Legal compliance is the minimum. Many organisations, especially exporters supplying international brands, are also audited against buyer codes of conduct and international labour standards, which may go further than local law.

TEMPLATE **HR compliance calendar**

Track recurring legal and policy obligations so that deadlines are not missed.

OBLIGATION	LEGAL OR POLICY SOURCE	FREQUENCY OR DEADLINE	OWNER	EVIDENCE KEPT	STATUS
Pay wages for the monthly wage period	*Labour law wage payment rules*	*Within the legal time limit after period end*	*Payroll lead*	*Bank or wallet transfer records, payslips*	*On track*
Participation committee meeting	*Labour law and company procedure*	*At the required interval*	*HR manag er*	*Minutes signed by members*	*Due next month*

Records that protect everyone

- Signed appointment letters and any changes to terms.
- Attendance, hours, overtime and leave records.
- Payroll records and payslips.
- Training records, especially safety training.
- Investigation notes, hearing records and outcome letters.
- Accident and incident reports.
- Committee minutes and notices.

DEFINITION · DATA PROTECTION IN HR

HR holds sensitive personal data: health, family details, bank accounts, disciplinary records. Most countries now have data protection laws, such as the GDPR in the European Union, and several countries, including in South Asia, have recently introduced or strengthened theirs. Good practice everywhere: collect only what is needed, restrict access, keep it secure, tell people how it is used and delete it when no longer needed.

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SCENARIO · DECIDE · WHEN TO CALL A LAWYER

An HR officer at a Dhaka-based distribution company plans to dismiss a warehouse worker for repeated lateness. The worker has just told his supervisor he has a chronic illness and is a union office-holder. What should the HR officer do?

(A) Proceed quickly with dismissal before the situation gets more complicated.

(B) Drop the matter entirely because the worker is a union office-holder.

(C) Pause, review the facts and the illness disclosure, check the procedure and protections that apply, and take legal advice before deciding.

(D) Ask the supervisor to handle it informally without records.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

REFLECT

Which area of employment law is your organisation most exposed in today? What one record or process would reduce that risk?

Key terms

Employment contract
The legal agreement between employer and employee, including written, implied and statutory terms.

Implied term
A contract term not written down but treated as part of the contract, such as mutual trust and confidence.

Retrenchment
Termination of employment because the work is no longer needed, also known as redundancy in some countries.

Data protection
Rules and practices that govern how personal data is collected, used, stored, shared and deleted.

Statutory right
A right given to workers by law that cannot be removed by contract.

Notice period
The time an employer or employee must give before ending employment, set by law, contract or both.

Unfair dismissal
A dismissal without a valid reason or fair procedure under applicable law.

Key takeaways

- Employment law covers starting work, pay and time, equality, health and safety, conduct and process, and ending employment; the details vary by country.
- Several layers of rules apply at once; contracts and policies can give more than the law, not less.
- Use a compliance calendar and keep the records that prove lawful, fair practice.
- Treat the law as the floor and take legal advice for specific cases.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

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11. What is the safest approach to employment law details such as overtime rates and leave entitlements?

(A) Use last year's policy without checking
(B) Copy another company's handbook
(C) Check the current official text and take advice when unsure
(D) Rely on what experienced supervisors remember about the rules from previous years

12. A factory sits inside an export processing zone. What should HR check first?

(A) Which labour law framework applies to the zone
(B) Only buyer codes of conduct
(C) Only the company handbook
(D) Nothing; every site in the country follows exactly the same labour rules

13. Which record would best help defend a dispute about unpaid overtime?

(A) Accurate attendance, hours and payroll records
(B) A list of team birthdays
(C) The marketing plan
(D) Exit interview notes from other staff who worked on the same shift

14. A good data protection principle for HR is to:

(A) Share all records with all managers
(B) Keep everything forever
(C) Collect only the personal data needed and restrict access
(D) Store health data in shared folders so managers can find it quickly when needed

15. Why is legal compliance described as 'the floor, not the goal'?

(A) Laws are optional
(B) Law sets minimum standards; good practice and buyer codes may go further
(C) Compliance has no business value
(D) Good practice always conflicts with the law, so companies must choose between them

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MODULE 6 · RELATE · LESSON 4 · 26 MIN

Discipline, Grievances, Investigations and Exits

Handle conduct, complaints and departures with fairness and dignity

- Apply principles of fair procedure in discipline and grievance
- Plan and run a workplace investigation
- Respond properly to harassment complaints and whistleblowing
- Manage exits respectfully and learn from them

Discipline and grievance procedures are where fairness becomes visible. Employees watch closely how colleagues are treated when something goes wrong. A fair process protects the person accused, the person complaining and the organisation, and it makes outcomes far more likely to stand if challenged.

Principles of fair procedure

F1
Know the case
The employee is told clearly what is alleged and sees the evidence.

F2
Be heard
They have a real chance to respond before any decision.

F3
Neutral decision-maker
The person deciding is not the investigator or a witness, and has no conflict of interest.

F4
Consistency
Similar cases receive similar outcomes.

F5
Proportionality
The sanction fits the seriousness and the person's record.

F6
Timeliness
Matters are dealt with promptly, without undue delay.

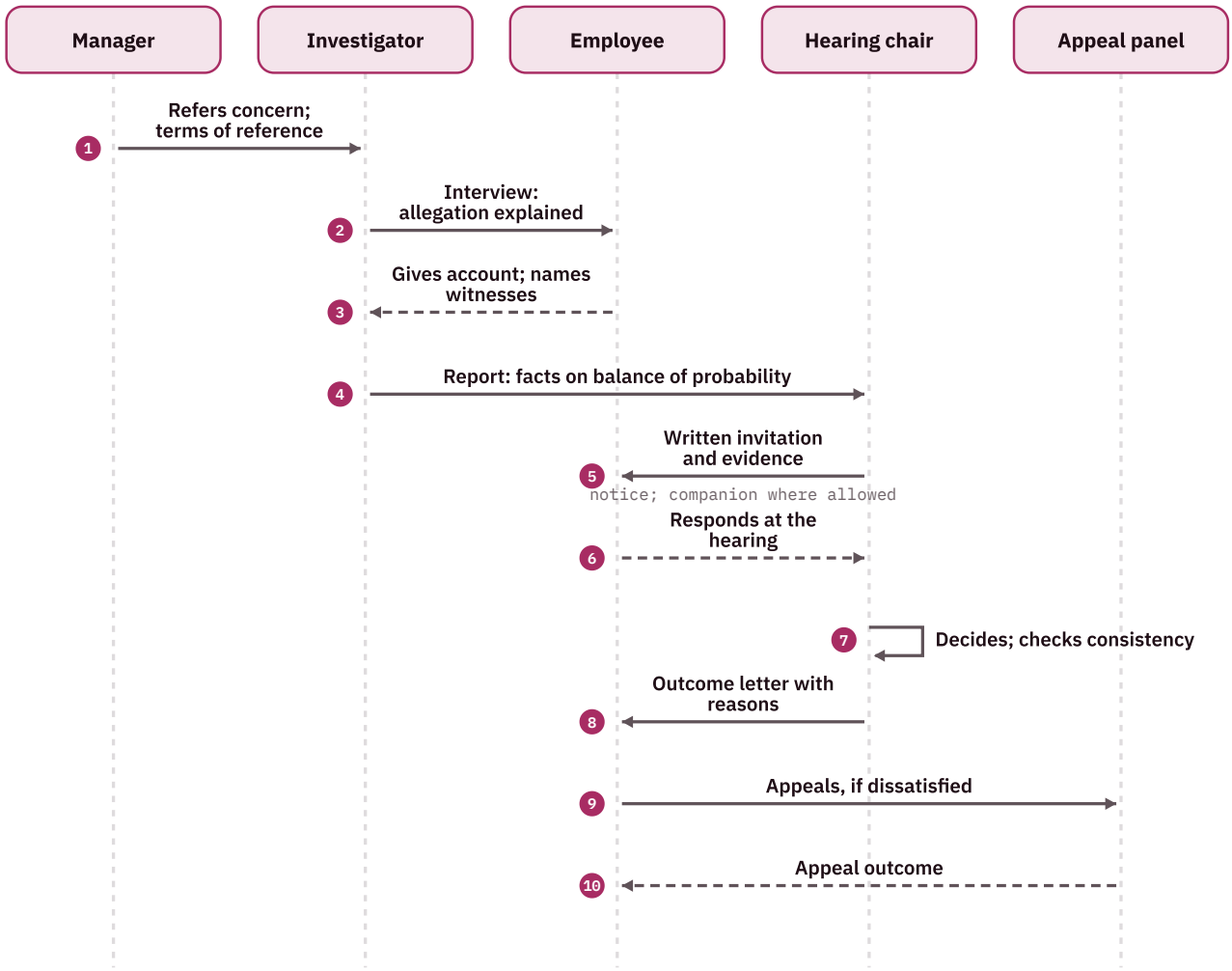
F7
Appeal
There is a route to challenge the outcome.

Planning and running an investigation

1. **Decide whether to investigate** Is the allegation serious and specific enough? Is suspension needed, and if so is it neutral and short?
2. **Appoint an investigator** Trained, impartial and with time to do it properly.
3. **Set terms of reference** The questions to answer, scope and timescale.
4. **Gather evidence** Documents, CCTV or system logs where lawful, and interviews with the complainant, the person accused and witnesses.
5. **Keep records** Notes of every interview, ideally signed or confirmed by the interviewee.
6. **Write the report** Facts found, on the balance of probabilities, with reasons; recommend whether a hearing is needed.
7. **Protect confidentiality** Share information only on a need-to-know basis.

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A fair disciplinary process



Four roles, ideally four people: the manager raises the concern, the investigator finds facts, the chair decides and an appeal panel reviews. Keeping them separate makes the outcome impartial; the right to be accompanied depends on law and policy.

Sanctions and their uses

OUTCOME	TYPICAL USE
No action or informal guidance	Allegation not proven, or very minor issue
Verbal or first written warning	First minor conduct issue
Final written warning	Repeated or more serious misconduct
Demotion or transfer (where allowed)	Alternative to dismissal, if lawful and agreed in policy
Dismissal	Gross misconduct, or further misconduct after a final warning, following the legal process

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WATCH OUT · HARASSMENT COMPLAINTS NEED SPECIAL CARE

Sexual and other harassment complaints require prompt, sensitive and impartial handling, protection from retaliation, and support for the complainant. The ILO Violence and Harassment Convention (No. 190, 2019) sets an international standard that a growing number of countries have ratified. Many countries have specific laws or court guidance; in Bangladesh, for example, High Court guidelines issued in 2009 call on workplaces and educational institutions to prevent sexual harassment and set up complaint committees led by women. Check what applies and train the people who handle complaints.

DEFINITION · WHISTLEBLOWING

Whistleblowing is raising a concern about wrongdoing such as fraud, safety breaches, corruption or legal violations, usually in the public interest. Good organisations provide confidential channels, investigate concerns, and protect whistleblowers from retaliation. Some laws set specific duties: EU rules, for example, require organisations with 50 or more workers to run internal reporting channels, acknowledge reports within seven days and give feedback within three months.

A respectful exit

01 **Notice** — Confirm the departure and dates in writing →

02 **Handover** — Knowledge transfer plan →

03 **Settlement** — Final pay, dues and certificates on time →

04 **Access** — Remove system access on the last day →

05 **Exit interview** — Learn why, with an independent interviewer →

06 **Alumni** — Keep the door open where appropriate

CASE STUDY · AN INVESTIGATION IN A UNIVERSITY

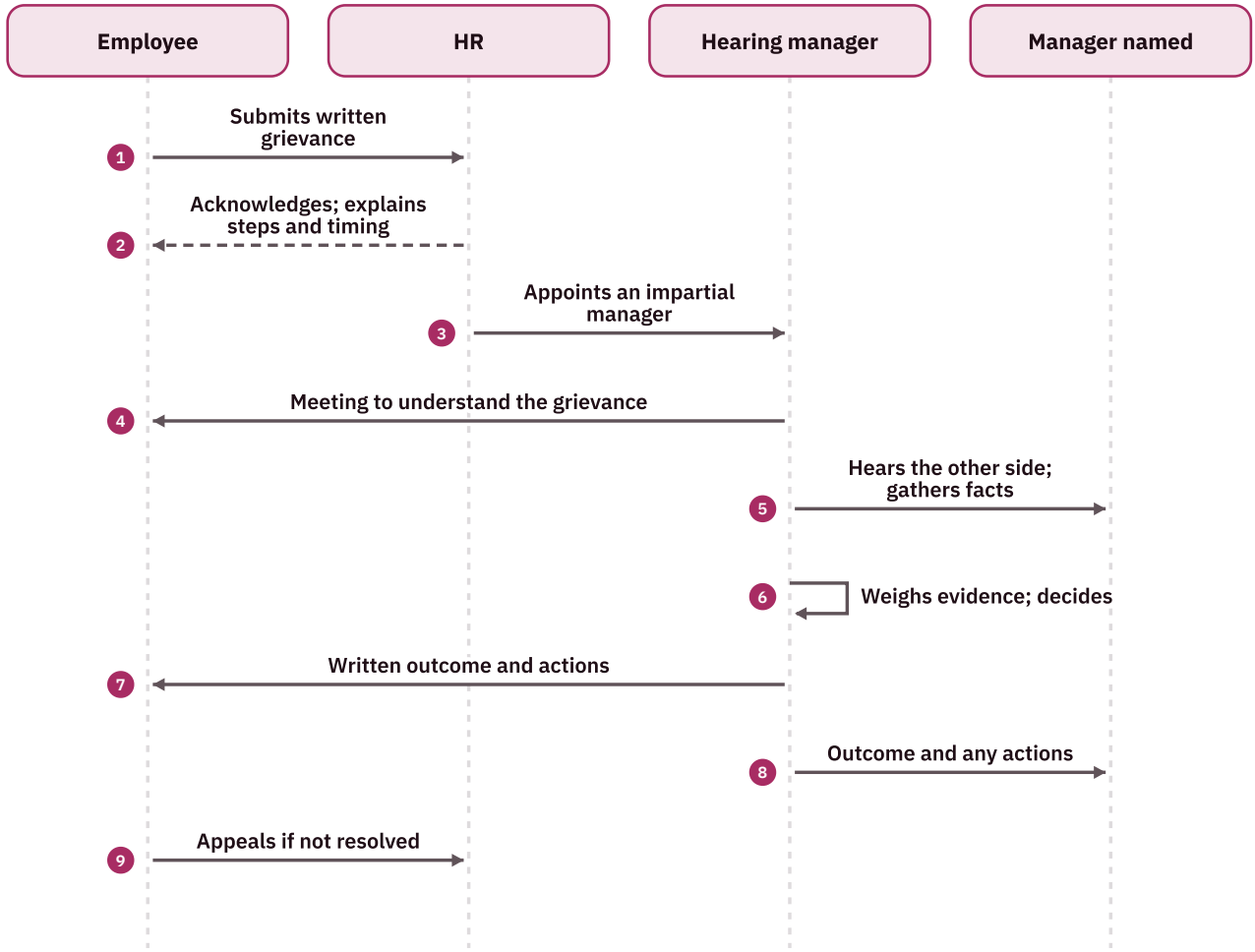
A junior lecturer at a private university complains that a senior professor repeatedly made sexual comments in department meetings and sent late-night messages. The professor is influential and brings in large research grants. The head of department suggests 'a quiet word' to settle it.

1. Why is a quiet word not enough?
2. How should the university handle the complaint?
3. How can it protect the complainant during the process?
4. What wider actions might be needed?

Model answer: module answer key.

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Handling a written grievance



The person hearing the grievance sits outside the reporting line, as the scenario below requires. Informal resolution can be offered first, but a written grievance gets a fair hearing, a reasoned decision and a route to appeal.

SCENARIO · DECIDE · A GRIEVANCE ABOUT THE MANAGER

An employee raises a written grievance that her manager regularly shouts at her in front of customers. The manager says she is exaggerating. Who should hear the grievance?

- (A) The manager who is the subject of the grievance, since he knows the situation best.
- (B) A colleague of the employee, so she feels supported.
- (C) No one; she should resolve it directly with her manager.
- (D) A manager outside the reporting line who is impartial, supported by HR, after a fair investigation of the facts.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

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REFLECT

If an employee in your organisation wanted to report harassment by a senior leader, would they know where to go, and would they trust the process?

Key terms

Disciplinary procedure
A written process for dealing fairly with misconduct, from investigation to hearing, outcome and appeal.

Workplace investigation
An impartial fact-finding process into an allegation or complaint, ending in a written report.

Gross misconduct
Behaviour so serious, such as theft, violence or serious safety breaches, that it may justify dismissal for a first offence after a fair process.

Exit interview
A conversation or survey with a departing employee to understand their reasons and experience.

Grievance
A formal complaint by an employee about work, colleagues, management or conditions.

Natural justice
Basic fairness principles: knowing the case, being heard and an unbiased decision-maker.

Whistleblowing
Raising a concern about wrongdoing, often in the public interest, through protected channels.

Key takeaways

- Fair procedure: know the case, be heard, a neutral decision-maker, consistency, proportionality, timeliness and appeal.
- Separate investigator, decision-maker and appeal roles, and decide on the balance of probabilities.
- Handle harassment and whistleblowing promptly and impartially, with protection from retaliation.
- Exit people respectfully: settle dues on time, remove access and learn from exit interviews.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

16. Which is a core principle of fair procedure?

(A) The investigator always makes the final decision, because they know the evidence best
(B) Hearings happen without notice
(C) Appeals are only for managers
(D) The employee knows the case against them and can respond before a decision

17. Why should the investigator and the decision-maker be different people where possible?

(A) To make the process longer
(B) Because investigators cannot write reports
(C) To keep the decision impartial
(D) So the employee cannot appeal

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18. A complainant fears retaliation from the senior person she reported. What should the organisation do?

(A) Take protective steps such as changing reporting arrangements and monitoring for retaliation

(B) Transfer the complainant to a worse job

(C) Tell her to resolve it herself

(D) Delay the investigation until she decides whether she really wants to continue with the complaint

19. What standard of proof is usually used in workplace investigations?

(A) Beyond reasonable doubt

(B) Absolute certainty

(C) Majority vote of colleagues

(D) Balance of probabilities

20. Which step should happen on an employee's last day?

(A) Start a PIP

(B) Remove system access

(C) Run a calibration meeting

(D) Publish their exit interview

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MODULE 6 · RELATE · LESSON 5 · 26 MIN

Diversity, Equity, Inclusion and Wellbeing

Build a workplace where different people can contribute fully and stay well

- Distinguish diversity, equity and inclusion
- Design practical inclusion actions and measures
- Identify psychosocial risks and signs of burnout
- Build a layered wellbeing strategy

Organisations draw on people of different genders, ages, religions, ethnicities, regions, disabilities, social backgrounds and ways of thinking. Diversity on its own is a fact; whether it becomes a strength depends on **equity** (fair access and treatment) and **inclusion** (people feeling respected and able to contribute). Wellbeing completes the picture: people cannot give their best if work is damaging their health.

Diversity, equity and inclusion

Diversity

- Who is in the organisation
- Differences in identity, background and thinking
- Measured by representation at each level

Equity

- Fair access to opportunity
- Removing barriers; adjusting for different starting points
- Measured by outcomes in hiring, pay, promotion and exits

Inclusion

- How people experience work
- Respect, belonging, voice and influence
- Measured by survey items and behaviour

Practical inclusion actions across the lifecycle

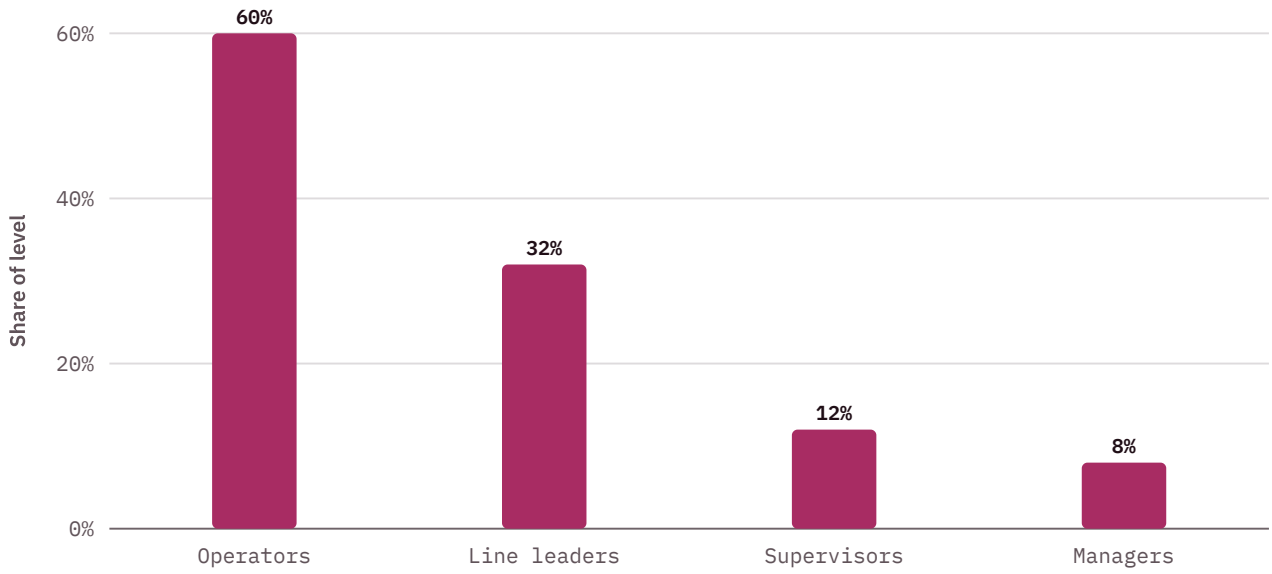
STAGE	ACTION
Attract	Inclusive job ads, diverse sourcing, published pay ranges, adjustments offered
Select	Structured interviews, diverse panels, adverse impact checks
Develop	Fair access to stretch assignments, sponsorship programmes, transparent promotion criteria
Perform and reward	Calibration with pattern checks, pay equity reviews
Work environment	Accessible facilities, safe transport for night shifts, prayer and lactation rooms, flexible work
Lead	Inclusive leadership training, accountability for inclusion measures

EXAMPLE · WOMEN SUPERVISORS IN GARMENT FACTORIES

Women make up a large share of operators in Bangladesh's garment industry but a much smaller share of supervisors. Several factories have run supervisor development programmes for women operators, combined with changes to promotion criteria and support from line managers. Participants have often matched or outperformed comparison supervisors on line efficiency, and factories gained a stronger internal pipeline.

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Women's share by level



Illustrative pattern, typical of the garment example above: representation falls sharply at the first promotion step. Analyse each step (who applies, who is selected, who leaves) to find where the pipeline leaks.

WATCH OUT · TOKENISM AND BACKLASH

Inclusion efforts fail when they are symbolic (a poster, a one-off workshop) or when people feel targets are imposed without fair process. Focus on removing barriers, using fair processes for everyone and measuring outcomes. Explain the purpose openly.

INSIGHT · A CHANGING LANDSCAPE

The legal and political climate for diversity programmes differs sharply between countries and has shifted in recent years. In some places, notably the United States since 2025, many employers have reviewed or renamed programmes and moved away from practices that could be seen as preferential; elsewhere, as in the EU, duties to report and act on pay gaps have grown. Whatever the label, the durable core is the same: fair, job-related processes for everyone, accessible workplaces, inclusive leadership and outcome data checked for barriers. Check what the law allows and requires where you operate.

A layered wellbeing strategy

Organisational	`Workload and staffing` `Fair policies and job design` `Leadership behaviour`
Team	`Manager check-ins` `Reasonable hours and rotas` `Psychological safety`
Individual support	`Employee assistance programme or counselling` `Health checks` `Financial education`
Crisis response	`Clear routes for urgent mental health concerns` `Trained first responders` `Return-to-work support`

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INSIGHT · FIX THE WORK BEFORE THE WORKER

Yoga sessions and wellness apps help some people, but they cannot offset chronic overload, unclear roles, poor management or harassment. Psychosocial risks such as excessive workload, low control, poor support and conflict should be assessed and managed like any other workplace hazard. The international guideline ISO 45003 (2021) describes how to manage psychosocial risks within an occupational health and safety system.

Signs of burnout to watch for

- Persistent exhaustion that rest does not fix.
- Growing cynicism or detachment from work and colleagues.
- Falling effectiveness and more mistakes.
- Increased absence, irritability or withdrawal.
- Long hours that have become normal for the team.

TEMPLATE **Wellbeing and inclusion action plan**

Set targeted actions with measures across inclusion and wellbeing.

ISSUE (EVIDENCE)	ACTION	GROUP AFFECTED	OWNER	MEASURE	REVIEW DATE
Night-shift nurses report unsafe travel home (survey)	*Contracted transport after night shifts*	*Night-shift staff, mostly women*	*Facilities + HR*	*Safety item score; night-shift turnover*	*Quarterly*

SCENARIO · DECIDE · A MANAGER DISMISSES WELLBEING CONCERNS

A team lead in a software firm says: "My team is fine. They work until midnight because they are passionate, and we gave everyone a meditation app." HR data shows sick leave in the team has doubled and two people have resigned citing burnout. What should HR do?

(A) Share the data with the team lead, explore workload and staffing causes together, and agree changes such as re-prioritising work, setting reasonable hours and checking in with team members.

(B) Buy a premium version of the meditation app for the team.

(C) Accept the team lead's view because passion is good for performance.

(D) Run a stress management workshop and tell the team to attend after work.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

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REFLECT

Who in your organisation might feel least able to speak up or progress? What evidence do you have, and what barrier could you remove first?

Key terms

Diversity
The range of differences among people in an organisation, including identity, background and ways of thinking.

Inclusion
A work environment in which people feel respected, valued and able to contribute and influence.

Burnout
A state resulting from chronic workplace stress, marked by exhaustion, cynicism and reduced effectiveness.

Employee assistance programme (EAP)
A confidential service offering counselling and advice to employees on personal and work issues.

Equity (workplace)
Fair access to opportunities and outcomes, achieved by removing barriers and adjusting for different needs.

Microaggression
A subtle, often unintended comment or action that communicates bias towards a group.

Psychosocial risk
A work-related hazard to mental health, such as excessive workload, low control, poor support or harassment.

Key takeaways

- Diversity is who is here; equity is fair access; inclusion is how people experience work.
- Remove barriers across the lifecycle and measure outcomes at each step, not symbols.
- Laws on diversity programmes differ by country; fair, job-related processes for everyone are the durable core.
- Manage psychosocial risks like other hazards: fix workload, control and support before offering individual coping tools.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

21. Women are 60% of operators but only 10% of supervisors. Which aspect of DEI does this mainly raise?

(A) Diversity of the whole workforce
(B) Equity of access to progression
(C) Wellbeing
(D) Data protection

22. Which measure best indicates inclusion?

(A) Total headcount
(B) Number of diversity posters displayed around the workplace
(C) Payroll cost
(D) Survey items on respect, belonging and being heard

23. What is the most effective first step for reducing burnout in an overloaded team?

(A) Address workload, staffing and priorities
(B) Offer a meditation app
(C) Hold a team party
(D) Extend working hours for a month to catch up

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24. Which is an example of a psychosocial risk?

(A) A wet floor
(B) Loud machinery
(C) Excessive workload with little control
(D) Poor lighting in a rarely used store room

25. Why do inclusion efforts that are only symbolic often fail?

(A) They are too expensive
(B) They are illegal
(C) They always reduce diversity because they create backlash from majority groups
(D) They do not change the barriers or processes people experience

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MODULE 6 · RELATE

Answer key

Knowledge checks

1. C Unitarists see shared goals and treat conflict as abnormal.

2. A Unmet unwritten expectations damage trust and effort.

3. D Mediators facilitate; the parties own the agreement.

4. B Speak-up channels are designed to protect people raising concerns about wrongdoing.

5. B Focusing on underlying interests opens room for solutions.

6. D 30% − 20% = +10.

7. A Stay interviews surface risks while the person is still there.

8. C People conclude that speaking up is pointless.

9. D Managers shape clarity, support, recognition and fairness daily.

10. B Anonymity is the foundation of honest survey data.

11. C Laws and rules change; current official sources are the reliable reference.

12. A Zones may have a separate labour law with different rules.

13. A Accurate time and pay records show what was worked and paid.

14. C Minimisation and access control protect employees and the organisation.

15. B Organisations should meet the law and often aim higher.

16. D Knowing the case and being heard are central to fairness.

17. C Separating roles reduces bias and pre-judgement.

18. A Protection from retaliation is essential for a fair, trusted process.

19. D Workplace findings are typically based on what is more likely than not.

20. B Removing access protects data and systems.

21. B Representation drops sharply at one level, suggesting barriers to progression.

22. D Inclusion is about experience, so it is measured through perception and behaviour.

23. A Burnout is mainly caused by work conditions, which must be fixed first.

24. C Psychosocial risks affect mental health through how work is designed and managed.

25. D Real change requires fair processes and measured outcomes.

Scenarios & case studies

Scenario · A rumour of a walkout
A is best. Best. Prompt, honest engagement through representative channels addresses a legitimate grievance and lowers the risk of a stoppage.

Scenario · A team with low scores
B is best. Best. Anonymity protects trust in the survey; facilitation turns results into improvement rather than blame.

Scenario · When to call a lawyer
C is best. Best. Health and union status may bring additional protections; a short pause for advice prevents an unlawful decision.

Case study · An investigation in a university
A quiet word does not establish the facts, does not protect the complainant, and signals that influential people are treated differently, which damages trust and may breach legal duties and the university's own policy. The complaint should go to the designated complaints committee or an impartial investigator, with clear terms of reference, interviews with all parties and witnesses, review of messages and a written report. During the process, the complainant should be protected from retaliation, for example by changing reporting lines or meeting arrangements, offered support, and kept informed. The professor should be told the allegations and given a fair chance to respond. If the allegations are upheld, a proportionate sanction must follow regardless of grant income. Wider actions: refresh policy and training, check whether others were affected, review how complaints are raised, and report patterns to leadership.

Scenario · A grievance about the manager
D is best. Best. An impartial decision-maker who is not involved in the matter is a core principle of fair procedure.

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Scenario · A manager dismisses wellbeing concerns

A is best. Best. It addresses the organisational causes of burnout rather than individual coping, and engages the manager with evidence.

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07

MODULE 7 · LEAD

Leadership, Motivation, Coaching, Change and Culture

Lead people and change: styles, motivation, coaching conversations, change management and culture

BY THE END OF THIS MODULE YOU WILL BE ABLE TO

- Adapt leadership style to people, situations and cultural context
- Apply motivation theories to design work and rewards
- Coach people using structured conversations and powerful questions
- Lead organisational and individual change and handle resistance
- Diagnose culture and build psychological safety in teams

LESSONS

1. Leadership Foundations and Styles · 24 min
2. Motivation at Work · 24 min
3. Coaching for Performance and Growth · 24 min
4. Leading Change · 26 min
5. Culture, Teams and Psychological Safety · 24 min

MODULE 7 · LEAD · LESSON 1 · 24 MIN

Leadership Foundations and Styles

Understand what leadership is and adapt your style to people and situations

- Distinguish leadership from management
- Compare major leadership approaches and styles
- Adapt leadership style to a person's competence and commitment
- Lead effectively in high power-distance and multicultural settings

Every HR practice in this course is delivered, or undermined, by leaders. A fair pay structure can still feel unfair if a manager explains it badly; a great onboarding plan fails if the manager is never available. **Leadership** is the ability to influence people towards shared goals, and it is a skill that can be learned, not a title.

Management and leadership

Management

- Plans, budgets and organises
- Controls and solves problems
- Produces order and predictability
- Focus: doing things right

Leadership

- Sets direction and vision
- Aligns and inspires people
- Produces change and commitment
- Focus: doing the right things

INSIGHT · YOU NEED BOTH

In practice the best line managers switch between the two many times a day: setting a rota (management), then explaining why a new quality standard matters (leadership). Organisations that are over-managed and under-led become rigid; under-managed and over-led ones become chaotic.

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How thinking about leadership has evolved

EARLY 1900S
Traits
Are leaders born with special qualities?

1940S–1960S
Behaviours
What do effective leaders do? Task and people focus

1960S–1970S
Situational
Which style fits which situation and follower?

LATE 1970S
Transformational
How do leaders inspire change and growth?

1990S–2000S
Shared, servant, authentic
Leadership spread across teams and grounded in service and values

2020S
Inclusive and hybrid
Leading dispersed, diverse teams and AI-enabled work

Each wave added a lens rather than replacing the last, and the dates are approximate. Practitioners today borrow from all of them: behaviours can be learned, style should fit the situation, and purpose and inclusion sustain commitment.

Six practical leadership styles

STYLE	TYPICAL PHRASE	WORKS WELL WHEN	OVERUSE RISK
Directive	"Do it this way, now."	Crisis, safety emergency, very new staff	Fear, low initiative
Visionary	"Here is where we are going and why."	Change needs a clear direction	Vague if not linked to action
Coaching	"What do you think you could try?"	Developing capable, willing people	Slow in a crisis
Affiliative	"People come first."	Repairing trust, healing after conflict	Poor performance goes unaddressed
Participative	"What is your view? Let's decide together."	Buy-in and expertise needed	Endless meetings, slow decisions
Pacesetting	"Do it as I do, fast."	Highly skilled, motivated team, short bursts	Burnout, dependency on the leader

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Transactional vs transformational

Transactional

- Clear exchange: rewards for performance
- Monitors and corrects deviations
- Good for stable, routine work

Transformational

- Inspires with a compelling purpose
- Stimulates people to think differently
- Gives individual attention and development
- Models the behaviour expected

Matching style to development level

L1

New and keen

High enthusiasm, low skill: give clear direction and close guidance.

L2

Learning, discouraged

Some skill, falling confidence: direct and coach, explain why, encourage.

L3

Capable, unsure

Good skill, variable confidence: support, involve and build confidence.

L4

Expert and committed

High skill and commitment: delegate, stay available, recognise.

Matching style to the person

COMMITMENT AND CONFIDENCE →

Direct

- New and keen
- Clear steps, demonstration, close guidance

Delegate

- Expert and committed
- Hand over, stay available, recognise

Coach

- Learning but discouraged
- Direct, explain why, encourage

Support

- Capable but unsure
- Involve, listen, build confidence

SKILL FOR THIS TASK →

Diagnose the person for the specific task, not in general: the same analyst may need delegation on reporting and direction on a new system. Move round the grid as skill and confidence grow.

EXAMPLE · LEADING IN A HIGH POWER-DISTANCE CULTURE

In many South Asian workplaces, people expect clear hierarchy and may hesitate to disagree with a senior manager. A Dhaka bank's new branch manager found her team rarely raised problems. She began asking juniors to speak first in meetings, thanked people publicly for reporting issues, and acted visibly on their input. Within a quarter, more problems were raised early and complaints fell.

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PRO TIP · INCLUSIVE LEADERSHIP IN DAILY BEHAVIOUR

Inclusive leaders invite quieter voices first, share stretch work fairly, give credit by name, notice who is missing from decisions and check their own patterns: whom do I mentor, promote or interrupt? In hybrid teams they make sure remote members are heard as clearly as those in the room. These behaviours can be observed, so they can be built into manager expectations and upward feedback.

PRO TIP · SERVANT LEADERSHIP IN PRACTICE

Servant leaders ask "what do you need from me to succeed?" and remove obstacles: they chase IT for access, protect the team from conflicting demands and share credit. This does not mean weak leadership; standards stay high, but the leader's job is to enable others.

SCENARIO · DECIDE · CHOOSING A STYLE

A newly hired graduate trainee at a power plant is enthusiastic but has never operated the control-room monitoring system. A shift supervisor must get him ready in two weeks. Which style is most appropriate at first?

(A) A directive style: clear step-by-step instruction, demonstration and close supervision, with explanation of safety reasons.

(B) Full delegation, because enthusiastic people learn best alone.

(C) A participative style, asking him how he would like to run the system.

(D) A pacesetting style: show him once at full speed and expect him to keep up.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

REFLECT

Which leadership style do you default to under pressure? When has it served you well, and when has it backfired?

Key terms

Leadership
The ability to influence individuals and groups towards shared goals.

Transformational leadership
Leadership that inspires people with purpose, challenges their thinking and develops them.

Situational leadership
Adapting leadership style to a person's competence and commitment for a specific task.

Pacesetting style
A leadership style in which the leader sets very high standards and models fast performance personally.

Transactional leadership
Leadership based on clear exchanges of reward for performance and correction of deviations.

Servant leadership
A leadership approach focused on serving and enabling others to grow and perform.

Power distance
The extent to which people accept and expect unequal distribution of power in organisations and society.

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Key takeaways

- Leadership is influence towards shared goals; good managers switch between managing and leading.
- No single style fits all: match direction and support to the person's skill and confidence for the task.
- Transformational and servant approaches build commitment; transactional clarity still has a place.
- In high power-distance and hybrid settings, deliberately invite voice and share opportunities fairly.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. During a fire alarm in a factory, which style is most appropriate?
   - (A) Participative
   - (B) Affiliative
   - (C) Directive
   - (D) Coaching
2. A skilled, committed analyst asks to lead a project. Which approach fits best?
   - (A) Delegate, stay available and recognise
   - (B) Close step-by-step direction and daily checks
   - (C) Pacesetting
   - (D) Ignore the request
3. Which is a feature of transformational leadership?
   - (A) Monitoring deviations from targets and correcting them through rewards and sanctions only
   - (B) Rewarding only short-term targets
   - (C) Avoiding change
   - (D) Inspiring people with a compelling purpose and developing them individually
4. Why might team members in a high power-distance culture rarely challenge their manager?
   - (A) They have no opinions
   - (B) They expect hierarchy and may see disagreement as disrespectful
   - (C) They are legally prohibited
   - (D) Managers in such cultures never make mistakes worth challenging
5. What is the main overuse risk of the affiliative style?
   - (A) Too many rules
   - (B) Poor performance may go unaddressed
   - (C) Excessive directive control
   - (D) Too little focus on relationships and team harmony

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MODULE 7 · LEAD · LESSON 2 · 24 MIN

Motivation at Work

Use motivation science to design work and rewards that energise people

- Distinguish intrinsic and extrinsic motivation
- Apply self-determination, expectancy, two-factor and equity theories
- Diagnose low motivation using a simple formula
- Choose practical levers managers can use

Motivation is the energy that drives effort, direction and persistence. Managers often assume money is the main lever, but research and everyday experience suggest otherwise. Pay must be fair and adequate, yet once that is in place, factors such as **autonomy, mastery, purpose, recognition and fairness** often matter more for sustained effort.

Intrinsic and extrinsic motivation

Intrinsic

- Doing work because it is interesting, meaningful or satisfying
- Sustains effort in complex, creative work
- Fed by autonomy, mastery and purpose

Extrinsic

- Doing work for an external outcome: pay, bonus, praise, avoiding sanctions
- Effective for simple, routine, measurable tasks
- Can crowd out intrinsic motivation if it feels controlling

Self-determination theory: three needs

N1

Autonomy

Feeling some choice and ownership over how work is done.

N2

Competence

Feeling capable and growing in skill.

N3

Relatedness

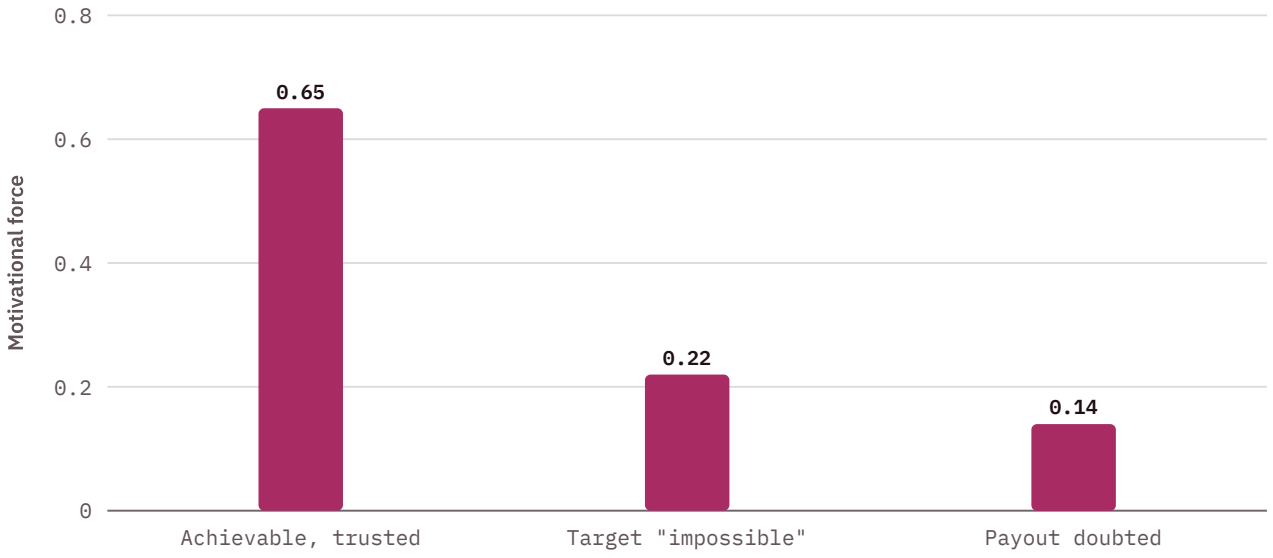
Feeling connected to and respected by others.

Expectancy theory

MEASURE	FORMULA	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Motivational force	`Motivation = Expectancy × Instrumentality × Valence`	If any factor is close to zero, motivation collapses, because the factors multiply.
Expectancy	`E = belief that effort leads to performance (0–1)`	"If I try hard, can I actually hit the target?"
Instrumentality	`I = belief that performance leads to the outcome (0–1)`	"If I hit the target, will I really get the reward?"
Valence	`V = how much the person values the outcome`	"Do I even want that reward?"

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Motivational force in three situations



Illustrative values on 0–1 scales: 0.9 × 0.9 × 0.8, then 0.3 × 0.9 × 0.8, then 0.9 × 0.2 × 0.8. Because the factors multiply, one weak link cuts motivation more than a bigger bonus can restore, as in the logistics example below.

EXAMPLE · DIAGNOSING AN INCENTIVE THAT DID NOT MOTIVATE

A Chattogram logistics company offered a quarterly bonus for zero delivery errors. Drivers believed the target was impossible because the address data was poor (low expectancy), and last year's bonus was cancelled after targets were met (low instrumentality). Fixing the address data and paying a smaller, reliable bonus raised motivation more than doubling the bonus would have.

Two-factor theory

Hygiene factors (prevent dissatisfaction)

- Pay and job security
- Working conditions
- Company policies
- Relationships with supervisors

Motivators (create satisfaction)

- Achievement
- Recognition
- Responsibility
- Growth and advancement
- The work itself

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Hygiene factors and motivators together

MOTIVATORS (RECOGNITION, GROWTH, THE WORK ITSELF) →

Engaged but frustrated

- Love the work, unhappy with pay or conditions
- Fix hygiene before people leave

Motivated and settled

- The aim: fair basics and meaningful work

Demotivated and dissatisfied

- Urgent: fix both

Not unhappy, not inspired

- Fair pay, little meaning
- Add recognition, responsibility, growth

HYGIENE FACTORS (PAY, CONDITIONS, POLICIES) →

The two sets of factors act on different scales: fixing pay moves people to the right, not up. The university in the scenario below sits bottom-right after its pay rise.

INSIGHT · EQUITY THEORY: FAIRNESS IS RELATIVE

People compare their ratio of inputs (effort, skill, time) to outcomes (pay, recognition, opportunities) with that of others. If they feel under-rewarded, they may reduce effort, ask for more, or leave. This is why pay transparency and consistent decisions matter so much for motivation.

Practical motivation levers for managers

- Explain the purpose: who benefits from this work?
- Give choice over how, when or in what order work is done where possible.
- Set goals that are challenging but achievable, and show progress.
- Recognise specific contributions promptly.
- Provide learning and stretch opportunities.
- Keep promises about rewards and be consistent.
- Remove obstacles that make effort feel pointless.

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SCENARIO · DECIDE · UNMOTIVATED AFTER A PAY RISE

A university gave all administrative staff a 10% pay rise last year, but a survey shows motivation is still low. Staff say their ideas are ignored, processes are rigid and no one notices good work. What should the HR director recommend?

(A) Give another pay rise this year.

(B) Focus on motivators such as recognition, involvement in improving processes and growth opportunities, since pay is now adequate.

(C) Introduce stricter attendance rules to increase effort.

(D) Accept that administrative work is inherently unmotivating.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

REFLECT

Think of a time you were highly motivated at work. Which of autonomy, competence and relatedness were present? Which was missing during a time you were demotivated?

Key terms

Motivation
The forces that drive the direction, intensity and persistence of a person's effort.

Extrinsic motivation
Motivation driven by external outcomes such as pay, praise or avoiding sanctions.

Expectancy theory
A theory that motivation depends on expectancy, instrumentality and valence multiplied together.

Equity theory
A theory that people compare their inputs and outcomes with others and act to restore perceived fairness.

Intrinsic motivation
Motivation that comes from the work itself being interesting, meaningful or satisfying.

Self-determination theory
A theory that motivation thrives when needs for autonomy, competence and relatedness are met.

Hygiene factors
Job conditions such as pay and policies that prevent dissatisfaction but do not by themselves motivate.

Key takeaways

- Fair, adequate pay is necessary; autonomy, mastery, purpose, recognition and fairness sustain effort.
- Self-determination theory: support autonomy, competence and relatedness.
- Expectancy theory: motivation = E × I × V, so fix the weakest link.
- Hygiene factors prevent dissatisfaction, motivators create satisfaction, and fairness is judged by comparison.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

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6. A salesperson values the bonus and trusts it will be paid, but believes the target is impossible. Which expectancy theory factor is low?
   - (A) Instrumentality
   - (B) Valence
   - (C) Relatedness
   - (D) Expectancy

7. In two-factor theory, which is a motivator rather than a hygiene factor?
   - (A) Recognition for achievement
   - (B) Salary
   - (C) Working conditions
   - (D) Company policies and administration

8. If E = 0.9, I = 0.2 and V is high, what happens to motivation?
   - (A) It is high because expectancy is high
   - (B) It is unaffected by instrumentality
   - (C) It is low because the factors multiply and instrumentality is weak
   - (D) It equals the average of the three factors, so it is still moderately high

9. Giving a team freedom to decide how to meet a quality target mainly supports which need?
   - (A) Relatedness
   - (B) Hygiene
   - (C) Valence
   - (D) Autonomy

10. An employee learns a colleague doing the same job is paid much more and reduces effort. Which theory best explains this?
    - (A) Two-factor theory
    - (B) Equity theory
    - (C) Goal-setting theory
    - (D) Situational leadership

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MODULE 7 · LEAD · LESSON 3 · 24 MIN

Coaching for Performance and Growth

Help people find their own answers and build capability through conversation

- Distinguish coaching from mentoring and managing
- Run a coaching conversation using the GROW model
- Use listening and powerful questions
- Build a coaching culture in teams

When someone brings a problem, the fastest response is to give the answer. Over time this creates dependency: people stop thinking and wait to be told. **Coaching** builds capability by helping people think for themselves, take ownership of decisions and learn from experience. For managers, coaching is a style used in everyday conversations, not only in formal sessions.

Coaching, mentoring and managing

ASPECT	COACHING	MENTORING	MANAGING
Focus	Unlocking the person's own thinking and action	Sharing experience and advice for career growth	Getting work done to standard
Main tool	Questions and listening	Stories, guidance and networks	Direction, feedback and resources
Who has the answer?	Mostly the coachee	Often the mentor shares options	Often the manager decides
Typical length	Short conversations or a series of sessions	Long-term relationship	Ongoing

The GROW model

G

Goal

What do you want to achieve from this conversation and beyond?

R

Reality

What is happening now? What have you tried? What is in your control?

O

Options

What could you do? What else? What would someone you admire do?

W

Way forward

What will you do, by when? What support do you need? How committed are you, on a scale of 1–10?

PRO TIP · RESIST THE URGE TO FIX

When a coachee pauses, managers often jump in with advice. Count to five silently. The pause is usually where the best thinking happens. If you do have a useful idea, offer it as one option among others: "One option might be... what do you think?"

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Three levels of listening

Level 3: Global	`Notices tone, energy, body language and what is not said` `Hears emotions and values`
Level 2: Focused	`Full attention on the other person` `Reflects back and clarifies`
Level 1: Internal	`Listening while thinking about your own reply` `Judging, preparing advice`

Questions that help vs questions that hinder

Help

- "What would success look like?"
- "What have you already tried?"
- "What is stopping you?"
- "What else could you do?"
- "What will you do first?"

Hinder

- "Why didn't you do it properly?" (blaming)
- "Have you tried asking IT?" (advice disguised as a question)
- "Don't you think you should...?" (leading)
- Several questions at once

EXAMPLE · A FIVE-MINUTE COACHING CONVERSATION

A nurse supervisor in Sylhet says: "My night team keeps missing handover details." Her manager asks: "What would a good handover look like?" (Goal) "What happens now?" (Reality) "What could change it?" (Options: a written template, a two-minute huddle, pairing new staff.) "Which will you try this week?" (Way forward). The supervisor chooses the huddle, owns it, and reports back the following week.

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A five-minute GROW conversation



The manager speaks only in questions; every idea and the final choice come from the supervisor, which is why she owns the result. The four questions map one-to-one to GROW.

TEMPLATE Coaching session plan

Prepare and record a coaching conversation using GROW.

GOAL	REALITY (KEY FACTS)	OPTIONS GENERATED	CHOSEN ACTION	BY WHEN	SUPPORT NEEDED
Run shorter, more decisive team meetings	*Meetings last 90 minutes; few decisions recorded*	*Agenda in advance; time limits; decision log; stand-up format*	*Send agenda 24 hours ahead and keep a decision log*	*Next two meetings*	*Template from HR; feedback from one team member*

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GOAL	REALITY (KEY FACTS)	OPTIONS GENERATED	CHOSEN ACTION	BY WHEN	SUPPORT NEEDED

Building a coaching culture

☐ Train managers in a simple model such as GROW and practise it

☐ Ask leaders to model coaching questions in meetings

☐ Include coaching behaviours in manager expectations and reviews

☐ Use peer coaching circles for managers

☐ Recognise managers whose teams grow and are promoted

☐ Offer professional coaches for senior leaders and key transitions

When to coach and when to tell

CAPABILITY FOR THIS TASK →

Coach

- Capable person, time to think
- Ask, listen, let them choose

Ask briefly, then act

- Capable person, urgent issue
- One quick question, decide together, debrief later

Teach, then coach

- Still learning, no rush
- Show how, then hand over with questions

Direct now, coach later

- Low experience, high risk
- Clear instructions first; debrief afterwards

URGENCY OR RISK →

Coaching is the default when there is time and the person can find the answer; urgency and risk push you to the right. The turbine-alarm scenario below sits firmly bottom-right.

SCENARIO · DECIDE · WHEN NOT TO COACH

A junior engineer at a power plant asks his supervisor what to do because a turbine temperature alarm is rising quickly. The supervisor has been learning coaching and is tempted to ask, "What do you think you should do?" What is the best response?

(A) Ask a series of coaching questions so he learns to solve it himself.

(B) Tell him to look it up in the manual.

(C) Give clear, immediate instructions to make the situation safe, then use coaching afterwards to review what happened and what he learned.

(D) Take over completely and never discuss it again.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

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REFLECT

Think of a problem someone brought you this week. What question could you have asked instead of giving the answer?

Key terms

Coaching
A conversation-based approach that helps people clarify goals, think through options and take ownership of action.

Active listening
Fully concentrating on, understanding and reflecting back what another person says and means.

Leading question
A question that suggests the answer the asker wants.

Debrief
A structured review after an event to understand what happened and what to learn.

GROW model
A coaching structure covering Goal, Reality, Options and Way forward.

Open question
A question that cannot be answered with yes or no and invites reflection, such as 'what' or 'how' questions.

Coaching culture
An organisation where coaching conversations are a normal way of developing people and solving problems.

Key takeaways

- Coaching draws out the person's own thinking; mentoring shares experience; managing directs.
- Use GROW: Goal, Reality, Options, Way forward.
- Listen at levels 2 and 3, ask open questions and resist the urge to fix.
- Coach when there is time and capability; in urgent, high-risk moments direct first and debrief later.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

11. "What have you already tried?" belongs to which stage of GROW?

(A) Goal
(B) Options
(C) Reality
(D) Way forward

12. What is the main difference between coaching and mentoring?

(A) Coaching draws out the person's own answers; mentoring shares the mentor's experience
(B) Coaching is always paid for and delivered by external professionals, while mentoring is always free
(C) Mentoring uses only questions
(D) There is no difference

13. Which is an example of level 1 (internal) listening?

(A) Planning your advice while the other person is still speaking
(B) Reflecting back their words and feelings
(C) Noticing a change in their tone
(D) Asking a clarifying question about what the person meant by a particular phrase

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14. "Don't you think you should talk to your manager?" is a:

(A) Open question
(B) Goal question
(C) Leading question
(D) Scaling question

15. When is coaching the wrong first response?

(A) When an employee wants to develop a skill
(B) In an urgent safety situation needing immediate action
(C) When someone is unsure about a career choice
(D) When a capable person is stuck on a problem and wants help thinking it through

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MODULE 7 · LEAD · LESSON 4 · 26 MIN

Leading Change

Help people through change so the organisation actually lands it

- Explain why many change initiatives fail
- Use organisational and individual change models
- Analyse and respond to resistance
- Build a change and communication plan

Organisations change constantly: new systems, mergers, restructures, automation, new ways of working. Many change efforts fall short of their goals, and the most common reasons are human ones: unclear purpose, weak sponsorship, poor communication, ignoring how people feel, and declaring victory too early. HR and leaders together own the **people side of change**.

A classic three-stage view

01
Unfreeze
Create readiness: show why the current state cannot continue

→

02
Change
Move to new ways of working with support and training

→

03
Refreeze
Embed the change in systems, measures and habits

Eight steps for leading organisational change

1
Urgency
Build a shared understanding of why change is needed now.

2
Coalition
Form a credible group of leaders and influencers to guide it.

3
Vision
Describe a clear, simple picture of the future and the strategy to get there.

4
Communicate
Explain the vision often, through many channels, and listen.

5
Remove barriers
Fix systems, structures and behaviours that block the change.

6
Quick wins
Deliver visible early successes and celebrate them.

7
Build on it
Use credibility from wins to tackle bigger changes.

8
Anchor
Embed new ways in culture, hiring, promotion and routines.

Individual change: five building blocks

A
Awareness
Do people understand why the change is happening?

D
Desire
Do they want to take part and support it?

K
Knowledge
Do they know how to change?

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A

Ability

Can they actually do it in their daily work?

R

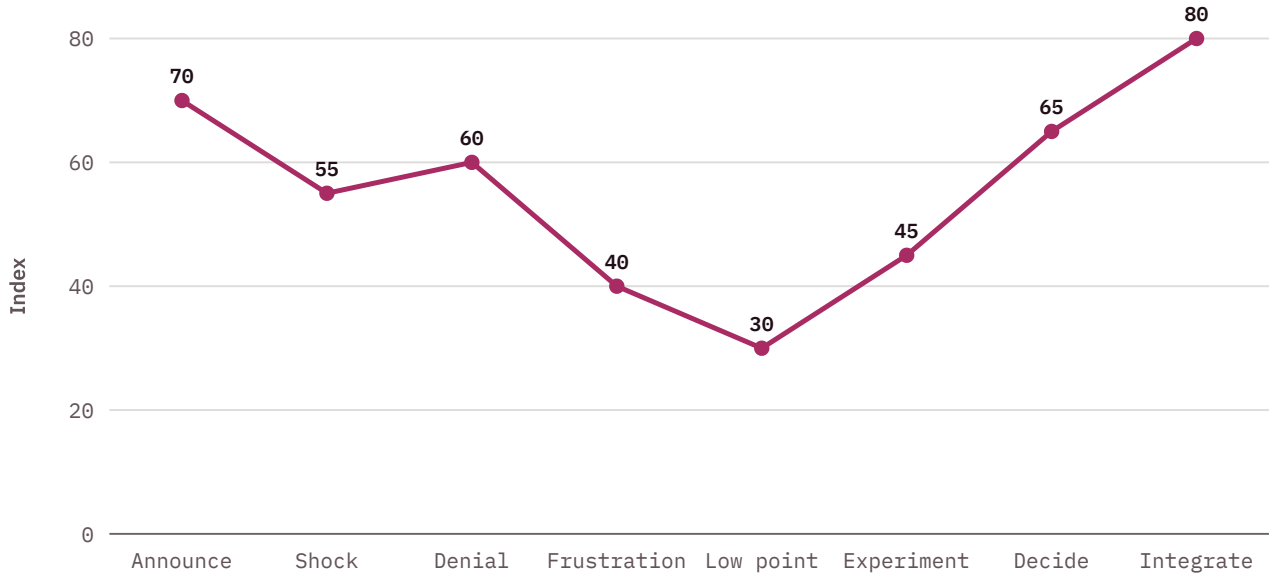
Reinforcement

Is the change recognised and sustained so people do not slip back?

INSIGHT · FIND THE BLOCKED BUILDING BLOCK

When a change stalls, ask which block is missing for the people affected. Training (knowledge) will not help if people do not understand why the change matters (awareness) or do not want it (desire). Each gap needs a different response.

A typical change curve



Illustrative curve adapted from research on how people react to loss: many dip before they recover, at different speeds. Match support to the stage: information early, listening in the dip, practice and quick wins on the way up.

Why people resist and what helps

SOURCE OF RESISTANCE	WHAT IT SOUNDS LIKE	HELPFUL RESPONSE
Loss of control	"Nobody asked us."	Involve people in designing how the change works
Uncertainty	"What happens to my job?"	Share what is known and unknown honestly; give dates
Competence concerns	"I can't use the new system."	Training, practice time, floor support
More work	"This is extra on top of everything."	Remove old tasks; adjust targets during transition
Past experience	"The last change failed too."	Acknowledge history; show what is different now
Real threats	"I will lose my allowance."	Be honest; consider transition support or protection

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PRO TIP · RESISTANCE IS INFORMATION

People who object often see risks that leaders miss. Treat resistance as feedback to explore, not opposition to crush. Listening carefully can improve the change and convert critics into champions.

INSIGHT · LEADING AI-DRIVEN CHANGE

Bringing AI into work is a people change before it is a technology change. Employees worry about job security, surveillance and being judged by a machine. Effective leaders explain honestly what will and will not change, involve users in redesigning tasks, consult worker representatives where law or agreements require it (EU rules, for example, require employers to inform representatives and affected workers before using high-risk AI systems at work), fund reskilling before roles shrink, set clear rules for responsible use and build AI literacy across the workforce. Measure adoption and trust, not just licences issued.

An AI rollout people plan

3 MONTHS BEFORE
Case for change
Purpose, benefits, risks and what will not change; consult representatives

2 MONTHS BEFORE
Co-design
Users help redesign tasks; risk assessment; responsible-use rules

1 MONTH BEFORE
Skills and champions
AI literacy training; a champion in each team

GO-LIVE
Launch with support
Floor support and a quick feedback channel

MONTHS 1–3
Reinforce
Adoption by team; fix pain points; recognise early adopters

MONTH 6
Review
Benefits, job impacts, fairness and trust; adjust

Most of the people work happens before go-live. Timings are illustrative; consultation periods may be set by law or collective agreements.

CASE STUDY · ROLLING OUT A NEW HRIS IN A HOSPITAL GROUP

A hospital group with four sites in Dhaka and Chattogram is replacing paper leave forms and spreadsheets with an HR information system, including self-service leave requests on mobile phones. Six weeks after go-live, only 35% of staff use it; nurses say they have no time, ward managers keep approving paper forms, and some older staff fear making mistakes. The CEO is frustrated.

1. Which individual change building blocks are missing?

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2. What should the change team do in the next month?

3. How should leaders reinforce the change?

Model answer: module answer key.

TEMPLATE **Change and communication plan**

Plan who is affected, what they need at each stage and how you will communicate.

STAKEHOLDER GROUP	IMPACT OF CHANGE	MAIN CONCERN	KEY MESSAGE	CHANNEL AND MESSENGER	TIMING
Ward nurses	*Leave and shift requests move to mobile self-service*	*No time; fear of mistakes*	*Faster approvals; see your balance anytime; help is on the ward*	*Nurse champions at handover; posters; short video*	*Two weeks before go-live and weekly for six weeks*

SCENARIO · DECIDE · A RESTRUCTURE ANNOUNCEMENT

A bank plans to merge two departments, affecting 80 staff, with some roles changing and a few possibly at risk. Leaders want to announce it by email on a Friday evening to 'avoid disruption'. What should HR advise?

(A) Send the email as planned so people have the weekend to absorb it.

(B) Wait until every detail is final before saying anything.

(C) Tell only managers and ask them to keep it secret.

(D) Announce it in person early in the week, with managers briefed in advance to answer questions, clear information on what is known, what is not and when, plus support and consultation as required.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

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REFLECT

Think of a change you lived through that went badly. Which of the five individual building blocks was missing for you?

Key terms

Change management
A structured approach to moving people and organisations from a current state to a desired future state.

Change sponsor
A senior leader who champions a change, provides resources and holds people accountable.

Resistance to change
Reluctance or opposition to change, often rooted in loss, uncertainty or competence concerns.

Change readiness
The extent to which people and the organisation are prepared and able to make a change.

Unfreeze, change, refreeze
A three-stage view of change: create readiness, make the change, then embed it.

Change champion
A respected employee who supports peers through a change and feeds back concerns.

Change curve
A model of the emotional stages people often move through during change, from shock to acceptance.

Key takeaways

- Change efforts fail mostly for human reasons; HR and leaders own the people side.
- Use organisational steps (urgency, coalition, vision, quick wins, anchoring) and individual building blocks (awareness, desire, knowledge, ability, reinforcement).
- Treat resistance as information and respond to its source.
- In AI-driven change, be honest about impacts, involve users, consult where required and reskill early.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

16. Staff know how to use the new system and agree it is useful, but managers still accept paper forms, so people slip back. Which building block is missing?

(A) Awareness
(B) Knowledge
(C) Desire to change
(D) Reinforcement

17. In the eight-step approach, why are quick wins important?

(A) They replace the vision
(B) They end the change programme
(C) They build credibility and momentum for bigger changes
(D) They avoid the need for regular communication about the vision

18. A staff member says, 'Nobody asked us.' What is the most helpful response?

(A) Involve people in designing how the change will work
(B) Repeat the announcement louder
(C) Mark the person as a resister
(D) Offer a one-off bonus to anyone who stops complaining about the change

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19. Which stage of the three-stage view involves embedding the change in systems and habits?

(A) Unfreeze
(B) Change
(C) Urgency
(D) Refreeze

20. Why should resistance be treated as information?

(A) It is always irrational
(B) It may reveal real risks leaders have missed
(C) It proves the change is wrong
(D) It can be ignored safely once the leadership team has approved the change

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MODULE 7 · LEAD · LESSON 5 · 24 MIN

Culture, Teams and Psychological Safety

Shape the shared assumptions that drive how work really gets done

- Describe the levels of organisational culture
- Diagnose culture using evidence
- Build psychological safety in teams
- Lead teams through development stages, including hybrid teams

Culture is often summed up as "the way we do things around here". It shapes how people behave when no policy covers the situation and no manager is watching. Culture can be a powerful advantage or a hidden barrier: a strategy that conflicts with the culture usually loses.

Three levels of culture

Artefacts	What you see and hear: office layout, dress, rituals, stories, how meetings run Easy to observe, hard to interpret
Espoused values	What the organisation says it values: values statements, policies, slogans May or may not match behaviour
Basic assumptions	Deep, unspoken beliefs about how things work: 'mistakes get punished', 'seniority decides' Hard to see, but drive behaviour

EXAMPLE · WHEN VALUES AND ASSUMPTIONS COLLIDE

A financial services firm in Dhaka listed 'innovation' as a core value. Yet every new idea needed five signatures, and a manager whose pilot failed was moved to a lesser role. Staff learned the real assumption: *failure is dangerous*. Innovation only grew after leaders publicly celebrated well-run experiments, including those that failed, and cut approval layers.

Diagnosing culture with evidence

1. **Observe** Watch meetings, decisions and how people talk about customers and colleagues.
2. **Listen to stories** Which stories do people tell about heroes, villains and turning points?
3. **Follow the rewards** Who gets promoted, praised or let go, and why?
4. **Check the data** Engagement items, exit reasons, speak-up reports and grievance patterns.
5. **Compare to the strategy** Which assumptions help the strategy and which block it?
6. **Choose a few shifts** Define two or three behaviour shifts in 'from… to…' terms.

DEFINITION · PSYCHOLOGICAL SAFETY

Psychological safety is a shared belief in a team that it is safe to take interpersonal risks: to ask questions, admit mistakes, raise concerns and offer ideas without fear of humiliation or punishment. Research on high-performing teams repeatedly points to it as a key factor in learning and performance, especially in complex or safety-critical work.

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How leaders build psychological safety

- Frame work as learning: "We haven't done this before, so we will need everyone's input."
- Admit your own mistakes and uncertainty.
- Ask genuine questions and listen to the answers.
- Respond to bad news with thanks and curiosity, not blame.
- Make it normal for junior people to speak first.
- Hold high standards: safety is not lowering the bar.

Psychological safety and standards



Adapted from research on team learning: high standards without safety push teams into the anxiety zone, where errors go unreported, as in the pharmaceutical scenario below. Leaders aim for the learning zone by raising both together.

Team development stages

01	→	02	→	03	→	04	→	05
Forming		**Storming**		**Norming**		**Performing**		**Adjourning**
Polite, unclear roles, dependent on the leader		Conflict over roles, priorities and approaches		Agreed ways of working, growing trust		High autonomy and results		Closing the team and recognising contributions

PRO TIP · LEADING HYBRID AND DISTRIBUTED TEAMS

In hybrid teams, culture is built deliberately: agree team norms for response times and meeting habits, make sure remote members get equal voice, use shared documents for decisions, and plan regular in-person time for relationships. Judge people on outcomes, not on visibility in the office, and watch for **proximity bias**: the tendency to rate and promote people who are seen more often.

TEMPLATE **Culture shift plan**

Define a small number of behaviour shifts and how leaders will drive them.

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FROM (CURRENT BEHAVIOUR)	TO (DESIRED BEHAVIOUR)	WHY IT MATTERS FOR STRATEGY	LEADER ACTIONS	SYSTEMS TO CHANGE	EVIDENCE OF PROGRESS
Problems hidden until escalated	*Problems raised early by anyone*	*Patient safety and quality*	*Leaders thank people for raising issues; weekly safety huddle*	*Incident reporting simplified; no-blame review*	*Near-miss reports up; serious incidents down*

SCENARIO · DECIDE · A MISTAKE IN A TEAM MEETING

In a team meeting at a pharmaceutical company, a junior quality analyst admits she missed an error in a batch record, which was later caught by another check. The department head responds sharply in front of everyone. Afterwards, two analysts tell HR they will think twice before admitting mistakes. What should HR advise the department head?

(A) Acknowledge to the team that the analyst did the right thing in speaking up, focus on improving the process, and handle any individual coaching privately.

(B) Issue a formal warning to the analyst to show standards matter.

(C) Say nothing; the team will forget about it.

(D) Ban discussion of mistakes in meetings to avoid embarrassment.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

REFLECT

What is one basic assumption in your organisation's culture that no one says aloud? Does it help or hinder your strategy?

Key terms

Organisational culture
The shared values, beliefs and assumptions that shape how people in an organisation think and behave.

Espoused values
The values an organisation states publicly, which may or may not match actual behaviour.

Artefacts
The visible elements of culture, such as layout, rituals, dress and stories.

Basic assumptions
Deep, often unspoken beliefs that drive behaviour in an organisation.

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Psychological safety
A shared belief that a team is safe for interpersonal risk-taking such as speaking up or admitting mistakes.

Hybrid working
An arrangement in which people split work time between a shared workplace and remote locations.

Team development stages
A model describing how teams move through forming, storming, norming, performing and adjourning.

Proximity bias
The tendency to rate, reward or promote people more favourably because they are seen more often, for example in the office rather than working remotely.

Key takeaways

- Culture works at three levels; basic assumptions, revealed by what is rewarded, drive behaviour.
- Diagnose culture with evidence and choose two or three "from... to..." shifts.
- Psychological safety plus high standards puts teams in the learning zone.
- Lead hybrid teams with explicit norms, equal voice and outcome-based judgement, and watch for proximity bias.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

21. A company's values poster says 'we welcome challenge', but people who disagree with the CEO are sidelined. The real driver of behaviour is the:

(A) Espoused value
(B) Basic assumption that challenging the CEO is dangerous
(C) Artefact
(D) Team development stage the company is in

22. Which leader behaviour most builds psychological safety?

(A) Criticising mistakes publicly so that everyone understands the standard expected
(B) Always speaking first in meetings
(C) Avoiding discussion of failures
(D) Thanking people for raising problems and responding with curiosity

23. A new team argues about roles and priorities. Which stage is it most likely in?

(A) Storming
(B) Forming
(C) Norming
(D) Performing

24. Which is the best way to judge performance in a hybrid team?

(A) Hours seen at a desk
(B) Speed of replying to messages and emails late at night
(C) Outcomes and contribution, not visibility in the office
(D) Number of meetings attended

25. Does psychological safety mean lowering standards?

(A) Yes; people must never be challenged
(B) Yes; mistakes should not be discussed
(C) No; it means no one is held accountable for their performance or mistakes
(D) No; it combines high standards with safety to speak up

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MODULE 7 · LEAD

Answer key

Knowledge checks

1. C Emergencies require fast, clear direction.

2. A High skill and commitment call for delegation.

3. D Transformational leaders inspire, stimulate and develop.

4. B Cultural expectations shape willingness to speak up.

5. B Prioritising harmony can mean avoiding difficult conversations.

6. D Expectancy is the belief that effort can achieve the required performance.

7. A Recognition creates satisfaction; hygiene factors only prevent dissatisfaction.

8. C Multiplication means one weak factor drags the whole result down.

9. D Choice over how work is done meets the need for autonomy.

10. B Perceived unfairness in input-outcome ratios leads people to restore balance.

11. C Reality explores the current situation and what has been tried.

12. A Coaches mainly ask; mentors often advise from experience.

13. A Level 1 listening is focused on your own thoughts.

14. C It suggests the answer the asker wants.

15. B Urgent risks need direction; coaching can follow afterwards.

16. D Without reinforcement, people return to old habits.

17. C Visible early successes show the change works.

18. A Loss of control is reduced by involvement.

19. D Refreezing stabilises the new ways of working.

20. B Exploring objections often improves the change.

21. B Unspoken assumptions override espoused values.

22. D How leaders react to bad news shapes whether people speak up.

23. A Storming is marked by conflict over roles and approaches.

24. C Outcome-based measures are fairer for remote and on-site members.

25. D Safety and accountability work together for high performance.

Scenarios & case studies

Scenario · Choosing a style
A is best. Best. A keen beginner with low skill in a safety-critical setting needs clear direction first; coaching and delegation come later.

Scenario · Unmotivated after a pay rise
B is best. Best. Pay addressed a hygiene factor; motivation now depends on autonomy, recognition and meaningful involvement.

Scenario · When not to coach
C is best. Best. In an urgent safety situation, direction comes first; coaching is valuable afterwards for learning.

Case study · Rolling out a new HRIS in a hospital group
Awareness and desire are weak (staff do not see the benefit to them), knowledge and ability are uneven (older staff and busy nurses lack confidence and time), and reinforcement is missing because ward managers still accept paper forms. In the next month: explain the benefits for staff (faster approvals, seeing leave balances on their phone); recruit respected nurse champions on each ward; run short on-ward demonstrations at shift handovers; provide a simple Bangla and English guide; offer help-desk support at each site; set a date after which paper forms will no longer be accepted, and ask ward managers to approve only through the system. Leaders should visibly use the system, share adoption figures by ward, recognise wards that adopt quickly, and fix usability problems that staff report.

Scenario · A restructure announcement
D is best. Best. Face-to-face, honest communication with prepared managers reduces anxiety, builds trust and meets consultation duties.

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Scenario · A mistake in a team meeting

A is best. Best. This restores psychological safety while keeping quality standards high; hidden mistakes are far more dangerous than reported ones.

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08

MODULE 8 · ANALYSE

HR Analytics, Technology and Responsible AI

Analyse the evidence: HR metrics and formulas, people analytics, HR systems and responsible AI

BY THE END OF THIS MODULE YOU WILL BE ABLE TO

- Calculate and interpret core HR metrics with consistent definitions
- Run question-led people analytics projects and present insights ethically
- Select, implement and drive adoption of HR technology securely
- Govern AI in HR with fairness checks, transparency and human oversight

LESSONS

1. HR Metrics and Formulas · 26 min
2. People Analytics and Evidence-Based Decisions · 26 min
3. HR Technology and Systems · 24 min
4. AI in HR, Used Responsibly · 28 min

MODULE 8 · ANALYSE · LESSON 1 · 26 MIN

HR Metrics and Formulas

Measure the people system with a small set of well-defined metrics

- Calculate core HR metrics accurately
- Define metrics consistently so they can be compared over time
- Choose a balanced set of metrics for a people dashboard
- Avoid common calculation and interpretation mistakes

You cannot improve what you do not measure, and you cannot trust a measure that is defined differently every month. **HR metrics** turn people activity into numbers leaders can track: how many people leave, how fast and at what cost roles are filled, how often people are absent, how engaged they are. Good HR teams agree **one definition** per metric, calculate it the same way every time, and explain what it means.

Core workforce metrics

MEASURE	FORMULA	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Average headcount	`Average headcount = (headcount at start + headcount at end) ÷ 2`	Simple version; a monthly average is more accurate when numbers change a lot.
Turnover rate	`Turnover % = leavers in period ÷ average headcount × 100`	Split into voluntary and involuntary, and regrettable and non-regrettable.
Annualised turnover	`Annualised % = period turnover % × (12 ÷ months in period)`	Lets you compare a quarter or half-year with annual figures.
Retention rate	`Retention % = employees present for the whole period ÷ headcount at start × 100`	Different from 100 minus turnover, because new hires who leave are excluded.
Absence rate	`Absence % = working days lost to absence ÷ total available working days × 100`	Usually counts unplanned absence only.
Bradford factor	`B = S² × D, where S = number of separate absence spells and D = total days absent`	Highlights frequent short absences, which are often more disruptive. Use with care and never as an automatic trigger.

Recruitment and cost metrics

MEASURE	FORMULA	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Cost per hire	`Cost per hire = (external costs + internal costs) ÷ number of hires`	External: ads, agency fees, tests, travel. Internal: recruiter time, interviewer time, referral bonuses.
Time to fill	`Time to fill = days from approved vacancy to accepted offer`	Measures process speed; time to hire (from candidate entry to acceptance) measures candidate experience.
Revenue per employee	`Revenue per FTE = total revenue ÷ average FTE`	A broad productivity indicator; compare within an industry.

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MEASURE	FORMULA	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
HR-to-employee ratio	`HR ratio = HR FTE ÷ total FTE × 100`	Indicates HR capacity; varies widely with size, sector and outsourcing.

EXAMPLE · WORKED EXAMPLE: A GARMENT GROUP

A garment group starts the year with 4,800 workers and ends with 5,200. During the year 1,500 leave, of whom 1,200 resign voluntarily. Average headcount = (4,800 + 5,200) ÷ 2 = **5,000**. Turnover = 1,500 ÷ 5,000 = **30%**; voluntary turnover = 1,200 ÷ 5,000 = **24%**. If recruitment cost BDT 6,000,000 for 1,900 hires, cost per hire ≈ **BDT 3,158**.

Turnover by department in a notebook

Python notebook

```
import pandas as pd
df = pd.read_csv('employees.csv', parse_dates=['start_date', 'exit_date'])
start, end = pd.Timestamp('2026-01-01'), pd.Timestamp('2026-12-31')
active_start = df[(df.start_date <= start) & (df.exit_date.isna() | (df.exit_date > start))]
active_end = df[(df.start_date <= end) & (df.exit_date.isna() | (df.exit_date > end))]
leavers = df[df.exit_date.between(start, end)]
avg_hc = (active_start.groupby('dept').size() + active_end.groupby('dept').size()) / 2
turnover = (leavers.groupby('dept').size() / avg_hc * 100).round(1)
print(turnover.sort_values(ascending=False))
```

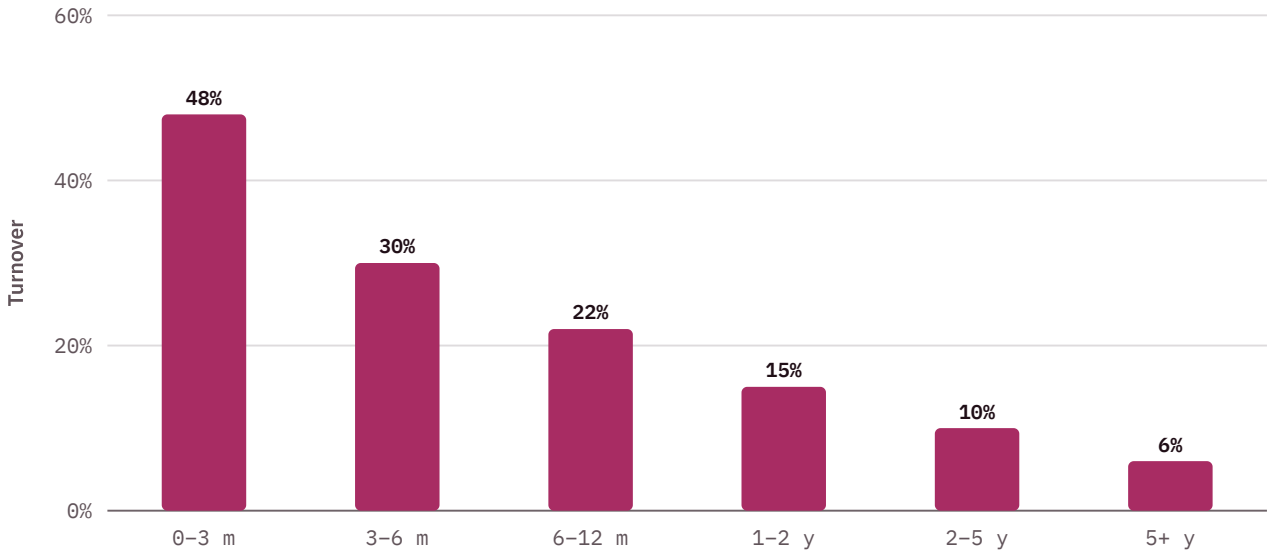
Use anonymised or pseudonymised data, store the file securely and agree the definition of a leaver (for example, whether internal transfers count) before running the numbers.

WATCH OUT · COMMON METRIC MISTAKES

Mixing headcount and FTE; counting internal transfers as leavers; comparing a quarterly rate with an annual one; reporting averages that hide hotspots; and celebrating low turnover when the wrong people are staying. Always segment: by department, grade, tenure band, performance, gender and location.

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Turnover by tenure band



Illustrative data: one headline rate hides the fact that most leavers go in their first months, a pattern that points to selection, onboarding and supervision rather than pay. Segment by tenure, team and performance before acting.

A balanced people dashboard

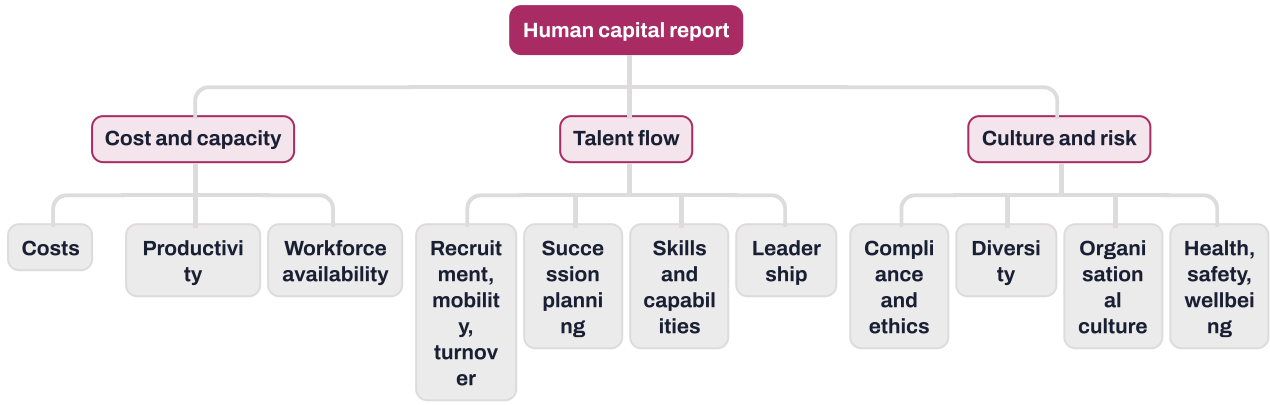
AREA	EXAMPLE METRICS
Workforce	Headcount and FTE, span of control, contingent workforce %
Attract	Time to fill, cost per hire, offer acceptance, quality of hire
Retain	Voluntary and regrettable turnover, early turnover, retention of high performers
Develop	Training hours, internal fill rate, bench strength
Engage and well	eNPS, engagement index, absence rate, safety incidents
Reward and fairness	Compa-ratio distribution, gender pay gap, promotion rates by group
Efficiency	HR cost per employee, HR ratio, revenue per FTE

DEFINITION · HUMAN CAPITAL REPORTING STANDARDS

ISO 30414 is the international standard for human capital reporting, for internal use and for investors and other outside readers. It covers areas such as compliance and ethics, costs, diversity, leadership, organisational culture, health, safety and wellbeing, productivity, recruitment, mobility and turnover, skills and capabilities, succession planning and workforce availability. First published in 2018, it has since been revised, so check the current edition. Sustainability reporting rules in some regions also ask for workforce data, which makes consistent metric definitions even more important.

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Human capital reporting areas, grouped



The eleven areas are grouped into three themes here for teaching; the standard lists them separately and distinguishes metrics suited to internal use from those suited to public reports.

INSIGHT · REGRETTABLE TURNOVER MATTERS MORE

A 15% turnover rate may be healthy if most leavers were low performers in easily filled roles, and alarming if they were your best engineers. Tag leavers as **regrettable** or **non-regrettable** at the time they resign, using agreed criteria.

SCENARIO · DECIDE · A METRIC THAT LOOKS GOOD

A BPO company in Dhaka reports that annual turnover fell from 45% to 32%. The COO wants to celebrate. HR notices that hiring was frozen for six months, so few new joiners (the group most likely to leave) were employed. What should HR do?

(A) Report the improvement alongside segmented figures, such as turnover by tenure band and regrettable turnover, and explain the effect of the hiring freeze before drawing conclusions.

(B) Celebrate the result; turnover is clearly under control.

(C) Stop reporting turnover until hiring restarts.

(D) Recalculate turnover using a different definition to show a bigger improvement.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

REFLECT

Which three people metrics would your leadership team most want each month? Are they defined in writing, and would two analysts calculate them the same way?

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Key terms

HR metric
A defined, repeatable measure of an aspect of the workforce or HR activity.

Retention rate
The percentage of employees present at the start of a period who are still employed at the end.

Cost per hire
Total internal and external recruitment costs divided by the number of hires.

Absence rate
Working days lost to absence as a percentage of total available working days.

Human capital reporting
Structured reporting of workforce data, such as costs, turnover, skills, diversity and wellbeing, to leaders or outside stakeholders; ISO 30414 is the international standard.

Turnover rate
The number of leavers in a period divided by average headcount, expressed as a percentage.

Regrettable turnover
Departures of employees the organisation would have preferred to keep, such as strong performers in critical roles.

Time to fill
The number of days from vacancy approval to offer acceptance.

Bradford factor
An absence measure, $S^2 \times D$, that gives extra weight to frequent short spells of absence.

Key takeaways

- Agree one definition per metric and calculate it the same way every time.
- Turnover uses average headcount; annualise partial periods; retention is not simply 100 minus turnover.
- Segment by tenure, team, performance and group; regrettable turnover matters most.
- Build a balanced dashboard; standards such as ISO 30414 help structure human capital reporting.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. A team starts the year with 90 people and ends with 110. Fifteen people left. What is the turnover rate?
   - (A) 13.6%
   - (B) 16.7%
   - (C) 15%
   - (D) 20%
2. An employee had 4 separate absence spells totalling 6 days. What is the Bradford factor?
   - (A) 96
   - (B) 24
   - (C) 36
   - (D) 100
3. Recruitment costs were BDT 900,000 external and BDT 300,000 internal for 40 hires. What is the cost per hire?
   - (A) BDT 22,500
   - (B) BDT 7,500
   - (C) BDT 40,000
   - (D) BDT 30,000
4. Quarterly turnover is 5%. What is the simple annualised rate?
   - (A) 5%
   - (B) 20%
   - (C) 15%
   - (D) 60%
5. Why should turnover be segmented by tenure band and performance?
   - (A) Segmenting is required by law everywhere
   - (B) Averages can hide hotspots and the loss of strong performers
   - (C) It always reduces the turnover figure
   - (D) Because headcount cannot be averaged across different departments and grades

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MODULE 8 · ANALYSE · LESSON 2 · 26 MIN

People Analytics and Evidence-Based Decisions

Move from reporting numbers to answering business questions with evidence

- Describe the levels of analytics maturity
- Run a question-led people analytics project
- Avoid common errors such as confusing correlation with causation
- Present insights as a clear story with actions, ethically

Metrics tell you *what* is happening. **People analytics** asks *why* it is happening, *what will happen next* and *what we should do*. It combines HR data with business data, such as sales, quality, safety and customer scores, to answer questions leaders care about. It works best when it starts from a real business question, not from the data that happens to be available.

Analytics maturity

Prescriptive	`What should we do?` `Optimisation and scenario models` `Example: best mix of hiring and overtime`
Predictive	`What is likely to happen?` `Statistical and machine learning models` `Example: attrition risk by segment`
Diagnostic	`Why did it happen?` `Segmentation, correlation, root cause` `Example: drivers of early turnover`
Descriptive	`What happened?` `Reports and dashboards` `Example: monthly turnover by site`

A question-led analytics project

01 Question — Agree a business question and the decision it informs →

02 Hypotheses — List possible explanations to test →

03 Data — Collect, clean and join HR and business data →

04 Analyse — Segment, compare, test, model →

05 Insight — What is true, how sure are we, what does it mean? →

06 Act and measure — Pilot an action and track the result

Data quality dimensions

DIMENSION	QUESTION	TYPICAL HR PROBLEM
Accuracy	Is the value correct?	Wrong grades or managers in the HRIS
Completeness	Is anything missing?	Exit reasons blank for half of leavers
Consistency	Is it defined the same everywhere?	Sites count contract workers differently
Timeliness	Is it up to date?	Leavers entered weeks late
Uniqueness	Are there duplicates?	Rehired staff with two employee IDs

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WATCH OUT · CORRELATION IS NOT CAUSATION

Teams with more training hours may have higher engagement, but perhaps good managers both encourage training and engage their teams. That hidden factor is a **confounding variable**. Where decisions matter, use comparison groups, pilots or before-and-after designs with controls before claiming one thing causes another.

CASE STUDY · EARLY ATTRITION AT A CONTACT CENTRE

A contact centre in Dhaka loses 40% of new agents within 90 days. Leaders believe pay is the cause and propose a 15% starting-pay increase costing BDT 30 million a year. The people analytics team has six weeks to test the assumption using HR, scheduling, quality and survey data.

1. Which hypotheses should the team test?

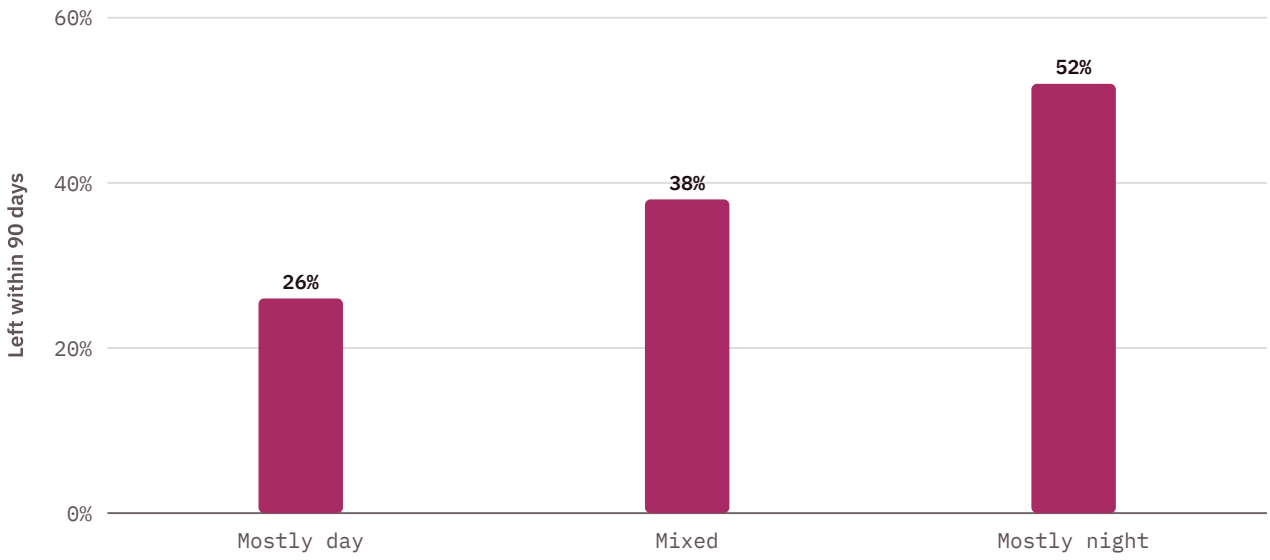
2. What data and comparisons would help?

3. How should results be presented to leaders?

4. What would a sensible pilot look like?

Model answer: module answer key.

90-day attrition by first-month shift pattern



Illustrative result in line with the case: new agents given mostly night shifts leave at twice the rate of day-shift starters. A chart like this tests the leaders' pay hypothesis cheaply before a large pay increase is approved.

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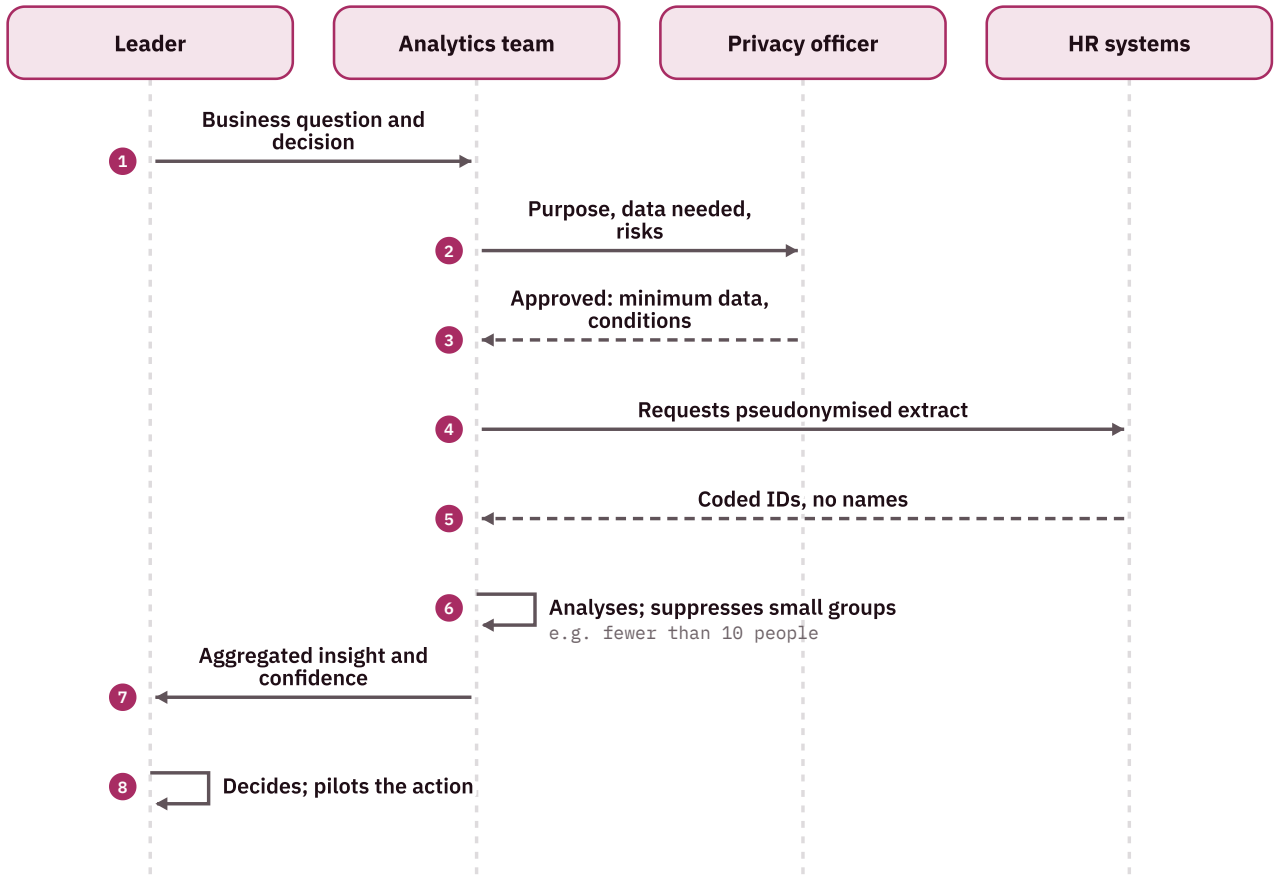
Telling the story with data

- Start with the business question and the answer in one sentence.
- Show the two or three charts that prove the point; move the rest to an appendix.
- Say how confident you are and what the data cannot tell you.
- Translate into money, risk or customer impact where possible.
- End with specific options, a recommendation and how success will be measured.

PRO TIP · ETHICS AND PRIVACY BY DESIGN

Use the minimum data needed, aggregate results so individuals cannot be identified (for example, never report groups smaller than five or ten people), tell employees how their data is used, and do not use analytics to target individuals for adverse action without a fair human process. Check data protection laws before combining datasets.

A privacy-safe analytics request



Privacy is built into the steps, not added at the end: purpose and data are checked before extraction, names never leave the source system, and results are reported only for groups large enough to protect individuals. Thresholds vary; five or ten is common.

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SCENARIO · DECIDE · A REQUEST FOR INDIVIDUAL RISK SCORES

A CEO asks the analytics team for a list naming every employee with a high predicted risk of leaving, so managers can 'deal with them'. What is the best response?

(A) Send the full list immediately; the CEO has authority.

(B) Offer segment-level insights and drivers to guide retention actions such as stay interviews, and propose a governed approach with clear limits before any individual-level use.

(C) Refuse to do any attrition analysis at all.

(D) Send the list but remove names, leaving employee ID numbers.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

REFLECT

Write one business question your leaders care about that people data could help answer. What data would you need and what decision would it inform?

Key terms

People analytics
The use of people and business data, statistics and modelling to improve decisions about the workforce.

Predictive analytics
Analysis that uses historical data and models to estimate what is likely to happen.

Confounding variable
A hidden factor that affects both variables in a relationship, creating a misleading correlation.

Minimum group size
A rule that results are only reported for groups large enough to prevent identifying individuals.

Descriptive analytics
Analysis that summarises what has happened, through reports and dashboards.

Data quality
The accuracy, completeness, consistency, timeliness and uniqueness of data.

Data storytelling
Communicating analytical findings as a clear narrative with evidence, implications and actions.

Key takeaways

- People analytics moves from what happened to why, what next and what to do.
- Start with a business question and hypotheses, and check data quality before analysis.
- Correlation is not causation: use pilots and comparison groups.
- Build privacy in: minimum data, pseudonymisation, minimum group sizes and no individual targeting without a fair process.
- Tell the story with the answer first, a few charts, stated confidence and clear options.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

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6. A model estimating which teams are likely to have high turnover next year is an example of:

   (A) Descriptive analytics
   (B) Prescriptive analytics
   (C) Data cleaning
   (D) Predictive analytics

7. Teams with more training hours show higher engagement. What is the most careful conclusion?

   (A) They are related, but a factor such as manager quality may explain both
   (B) Training causes engagement, so training hours should be increased in every team
   (C) Engagement causes training
   (D) The data must be wrong

8. Half of leavers have no exit reason recorded. Which data quality dimension is weak?

   (A) Accuracy
   (B) Uniqueness
   (C) Completeness
   (D) Timeliness of updates

9. Where should a people analytics project start?

   (A) With all the data available
   (B) With the most advanced machine learning algorithm available
   (C) With a dashboard design
   (D) With a business question and the decision it will inform

10. Why do analysts set a minimum group size for reporting?

    (A) To make charts look better
    (B) To prevent individuals being identified
    (C) To increase sample bias
    (D) Because small groups never matter for decisions made at organisation level

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MODULE 8 · ANALYSE · LESSON 3 · 24 MIN

HR Technology and Systems

Choose, implement and integrate HR systems that people actually use

- Describe the main categories of HR technology
- Write requirements and evaluate vendors objectively
- Plan implementation, data migration and integration
- Drive adoption and protect HR data

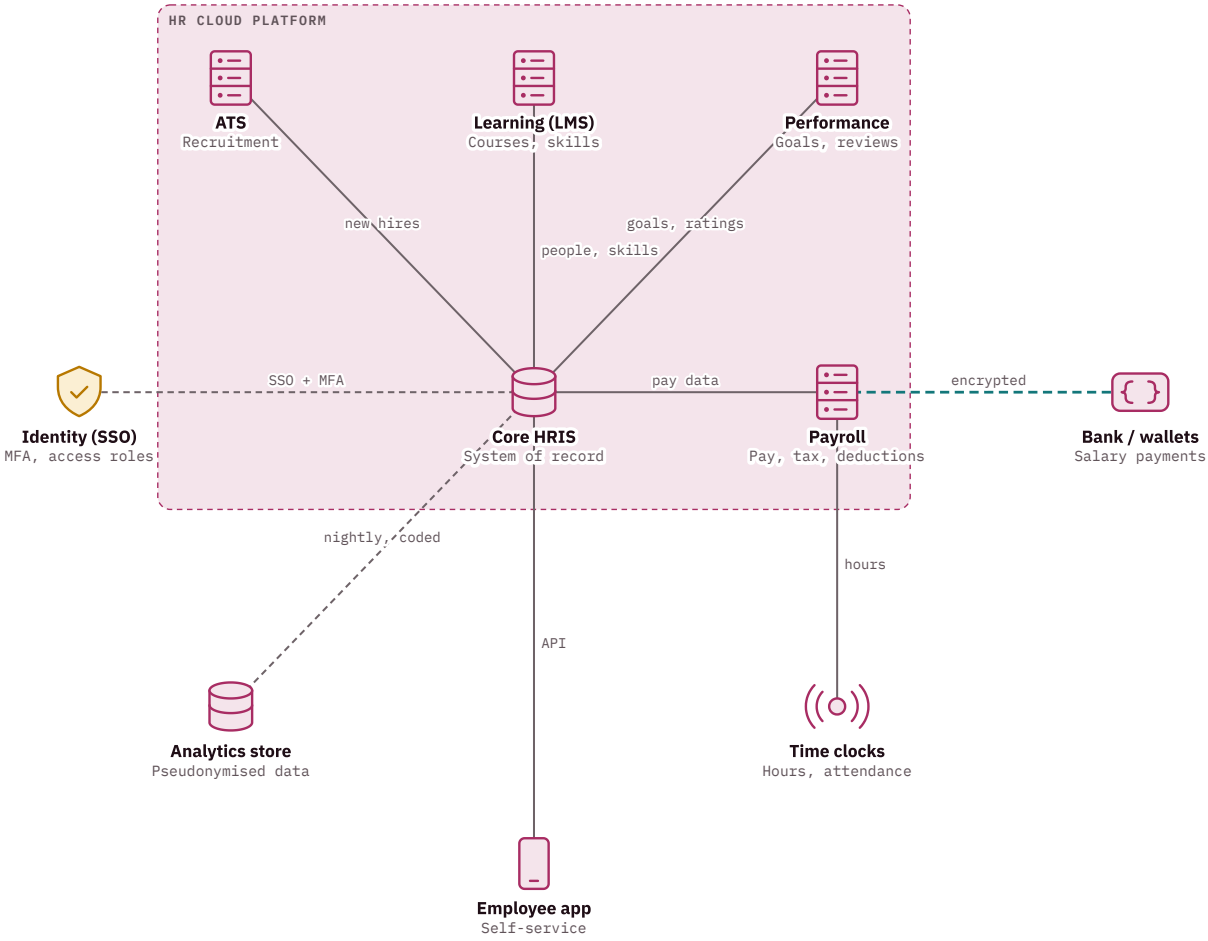
HR technology has moved from on-premise payroll software to cloud platforms covering the whole employee lifecycle, often used from a mobile phone. The right technology removes manual work, improves data quality and gives employees and managers self-service. The wrong choice, or a poor implementation, locks in bad processes at great cost.

The HR technology landscape

Experience layer	`Mobile app and employee portal` `AI assistant grounded in approved policies` `Self-service for employees and managers`
Talent applications	`Applicant tracking` `Onboarding` `Performance and goals` `Learning (LMS or learning experience platform)`
Core HR and payroll	`Employee records (system of record)` `Organisation structure` `Time, attendance and leave` `Payroll and benefits`
Data and integration	`APIs and integration platform` `Data warehouse and analytics` `Identity and access management`

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How HR systems connect (example)



The core HRIS is the single system of record: other systems read from it or write to it through integrations, and identity controls sign-in to all of them. Analytics data leaves in pseudonymised form on a schedule. Every line is an interface to build, test and secure.

Selecting an HR system

1. **Map processes first** Document current and desired processes; fix obvious waste before buying software.
2. **Write requirements** Separate must-haves from nice-to-haves, including local payroll and tax rules, local-language support and mobile use if needed.
3. **Shortlist vendors** Three to five that fit size, budget and region.
4. **Run scripted demos** Give each vendor the same realistic scenarios to demonstrate.
5. **Score objectively** Use a weighted matrix agreed in advance; include total cost of ownership.
6. **Check references and security** Talk to similar customers; review security certifications, data location and exit terms.

TEMPLATE

Vendor evaluation matrix

Score shortlisted systems against weighted requirements.

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REQUIREMENT	WEIGHT	VENDOR A SCORE (1–5)	VENDOR B SCORE (1–5)	EVIDENCE FROM DEMO	NOTES
Local payroll rules and tax updates	*20%*	*4*	*2*	*A handled festival bonus and provident fund scenario*	*B needs custom work*
Mobile self-service for factory workers	*15%*	*3*	*5*	*B app works offline and in Bangla*	*Pilot with one site*

Implementation journey

01 Plan
Scope, governance, budget, project team

→

02 Design
Configure processes, roles, approvals

→

03 Migrate data
Cleanse, map, load and reconcile

→

04 Integrate
Connect payroll, finance, identity, time clocks

→

05 Test
Scenario testing and parallel payroll runs

→

06 Launch
Training, support and hypercare

→

07 Improve
Measure adoption and fix pain points

WATCH OUT · DATA MIGRATION IS WHERE PROJECTS SLIP
Old data is often incomplete, duplicated or inconsistent. Clean it before migrating, reconcile record counts and key totals after loading, and run at least one or two parallel payrolls to compare old and new results before switching over.

Protecting HR data in systems

- Role-based access: people see only what their role requires.
- Strong authentication, ideally multi-factor, especially for HR and payroll administrators.
- Audit logs of who viewed or changed sensitive records.
- Clear data retention and deletion rules.
- Contracts that define data location, security duties, breach notification and return of data at exit.
- Regular access reviews when people change roles or leave.

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INSIGHT · AI INSIDE HR PLATFORMS

Most HR platforms now embed AI: drafting, search, skills inference from profiles, matching people to roles and, increasingly, agents that complete multi-step tasks such as scheduling interviews. Switch features on deliberately: check what data each one uses, whether it makes or supports decisions about people, how it has been tested for bias and whether it can be turned off. Treat any feature that ranks or recommends people as a selection or decision tool, with the governance described in the next lesson.

EXAMPLE · SELF-SERVICE FOR 12,000 WORKERS

A knitwear group introduced kiosk and mobile self-service so workers could view payslips, leave balances and attendance in Bangla. Queries to HR offices fell by more than half, and errors in overtime were spotted and fixed faster because workers could see their own records.

SCENARIO · DECIDE · A SYSTEM NOBODY USES

Six months after launching a performance management module, only 20% of managers have entered goals. Managers say the system is slow and has too many fields. What should HR do first?

(A) Make goal entry mandatory and report non-compliant managers to the CEO.

(B) Replace the vendor immediately.

(C) Gather specific feedback from managers, simplify the configuration to the essential fields and steps, and relaunch with short training and visible leadership use.

(D) Return to paper forms.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

REFLECT

Which HR process in your organisation still depends on spreadsheets or paper? What would a good system need to do to replace it?

Key terms

HR information system (HRIS)
Software that stores employee records and supports core HR processes, often the system of record for people data.

Employee self-service
Technology that lets employees view and update their own information and make requests without HR help.

Learning experience platform
A learning tool that curates and recommends content from many sources, personalised to each learner.

Data migration
Moving data from old systems to a new one, including cleansing, mapping, loading and reconciling.

System of record
The authoritative source for a type of data, which other systems treat as correct.

Learning management system (LMS)
Software that delivers, tracks and reports on formal learning.

Application programming interface (API)
A defined way for software systems to exchange data automatically.

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Key takeaways

- Map processes before buying; write must-have requirements and use scripted demos with weighted scoring.
- One system of record, integrated with payroll, identity and other tools, prevents conflicting data.
- Migrations slip on data quality: cleanse, reconcile and run parallel payrolls.
- Drive adoption by simplifying and supporting users; protect data with role-based access, MFA and audit logs.
- Switch on embedded AI features deliberately and govern those that rank or recommend people.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

11. Which should come first when selecting an HR system?

(A) Signing a contract with the cheapest vendor
(B) Choosing the system with the most features
(C) Mapping current and desired processes
(D) Migrating all data

12. Why use scripted demos?

(A) So each vendor demonstrates the same realistic scenarios for fair comparison
(B) To shorten the contract
(C) To avoid involving users
(D) Because vendors prefer them and are more likely to offer discounts

13. What is the main purpose of running parallel payrolls during implementation?

(A) To compare old and new results before switching over
(B) To pay employees twice
(C) To test the internet connection between the HR office and the bank
(D) To train new hires

14. Which control best limits who can view salary data?

(A) Shared administrator passwords
(B) Emailing reports to all managers
(C) Role-based access
(D) Storing data on personal laptops

15. Managers say a new system is slow and has too many fields. What does low adoption most likely indicate?

(A) Managers are lazy
(B) Design and support issues that need fixing
(C) The organisation does not need goals or a performance system at all
(D) Adoption cannot be improved

☐ Lesson complete · Date _____ · Knowledge check score ____ / 5

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MODULE 8 · ANALYSE · LESSON 4 · 28 MIN

AI in HR, Used Responsibly

Gain the benefits of AI in people processes while protecting fairness, privacy and trust

- Identify valuable and risky uses of AI across the employee lifecycle
- Assess AI tools for bias, transparency and privacy
- Apply human oversight and governance to AI in HR
- Write a responsible-use policy for HR technology and AI

AI is now built into many HR tools: drafting job descriptions, screening applications, scheduling interviews, answering policy questions, recommending learning, summarising survey comments and predicting attrition. Used well, it saves time and improves consistency. Used carelessly, it can discriminate at scale, invade privacy and erode trust. Because employment decisions shape people's lives, many regulators treat AI in hiring and people management as **high-risk**.

AI use cases by risk

USE CASE	TYPICAL VALUE	RISK LEVEL	KEY SAFEGUARDS
Drafting job ads and policies	Faster writing, inclusive language checks	Lower	Human review for accuracy and tone
HR policy chatbot	Instant answers to common questions	Moderate	Grounded in approved policies; clear escalation to a person; accuracy checks
Summarising survey comments	Themes from thousands of comments	Moderate	Protect anonymity; validate themes by sampling
Learning recommendations	Personalised development	Moderate	Explain recommendations; allow choice
CV screening and candidate ranking	Handle high volume	High	Bias audit, job-related criteria, human review, candidate notice
Video or voice analysis of candidates	Claimed personality or emotion insight	Very high or prohibited	Weak scientific basis; inferring emotions at work is banned in the EU except for medical or safety reasons; avoid
Performance, promotion or dismissal decisions	Consistency claims	High	Human decision-maker, explanation, appeal route
Employee monitoring and productivity scoring	Visibility of activity	High	Proportionality, transparency, consultation, legal check

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WATCH OUT · HOW AI LEARNS BIAS

A screening model trained on past hiring decisions learns the patterns in those decisions. If the organisation historically hired few women engineers, the model may learn to downgrade signals associated with women, such as certain universities, activities or career gaps, even when gender is removed from the data. Removing a protected attribute does not remove **proxies** for it.

Principles for responsible AI in HR

R1
Purpose and proportionality
Use AI only where it solves a real problem and the benefits justify the risks.

R2
Fairness
Test for adverse impact before and after deployment; fix or stop biased tools.

R3
Transparency
Tell candidates and employees when AI is used and how it affects them.

R4
Human oversight
Meaningful human review for decisions with significant effects on people.

R5
Privacy and security
Minimum data, clear retention, secure processing, no feeding confidential data into unapproved tools.

R6
Accountability
Named owners, documentation, audit trails and a route for people to challenge outcomes.

Where AI belongs in HR decisions

IMPACT ON A PERSON'S LIVELIHOOD →

Decision support, governed
- CV shortlisting with human review
- Inputs to promotion or pay
- Bias audit, notice, appeal

Avoid or prohibited
- Automatic rejection or dismissal
- Emotion or personality inference
- Covert productivity scoring

Low risk, human-checked
- Drafting job ads and policies
- Summarising anonymised comments

Automate with checks
- Interview scheduling
- Policy chatbot with escalation

AUTOMATION (ASSISTS → DECIDES) →

The greater the impact on someone's job or income, the more a person must decide and the more evidence the tool needs. Moving any use case to the right (more automation) needs a fresh risk assessment.

Checking an AI screening tool for bias

MEASURE	FORMULA	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Selection rate by group	`Rate = candidates advanced by the tool from a group ÷ candidates from that group`	Calculate for each relevant group, such as gender or region.

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MEASURE	FORMULA	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Impact ratio	`Impact ratio = group selection rate ÷ highest group selection rate`	The same check used for any selection method; below 0.80 should trigger investigation.
Agreement with expert review	`Agreement % = cases where tool and trained reviewers agree ÷ cases reviewed × 100`	Shows whether the tool matches job-related human judgement on a sample.

INSIGHT · THE REGULATORY DIRECTION IS CLEAR

Rules are moving fast. The **EU AI Act** entered into force in August 2024. Bans on certain practices, including AI that infers emotions in the workplace (outside medical or safety uses), have applied since February 2025. AI used for recruitment and selection, decisions on promotion and termination, allocating tasks based on behaviour or personal traits, and monitoring or evaluating workers is classed as **high-risk**. Employers using such systems must follow the provider's instructions, assign trained people to oversee them, keep the logs, monitor how they work and inform workers' representatives and affected workers before use. These high-risk duties were scheduled to apply from August 2026, and in late 2025 the European Commission proposed delaying them, so **check the current official timetable**. Elsewhere, some US jurisdictions require bias audits and candidate notices for automated hiring tools, and many countries, including in South Asia, are introducing or updating data protection laws. Check the rules in every country where you hire or employ people.

EU AI Act: dates that matter for HR

AUG 2024 — In force
Regulation published; duties phase in

FEB 2025 — Bans and AI literacy
Prohibited practices, including emotion inference at work; staff AI literacy

AUG 2025 — General-purpose AI
Rules for providers of general-purpose models; governance and penalties

AUG 2026 — High-risk, as scheduled
Original start for listed uses, including employment

UP TO LATE 2027 — High-risk, if delayed
A 2025 proposal would push the start back; check the adopted timetable

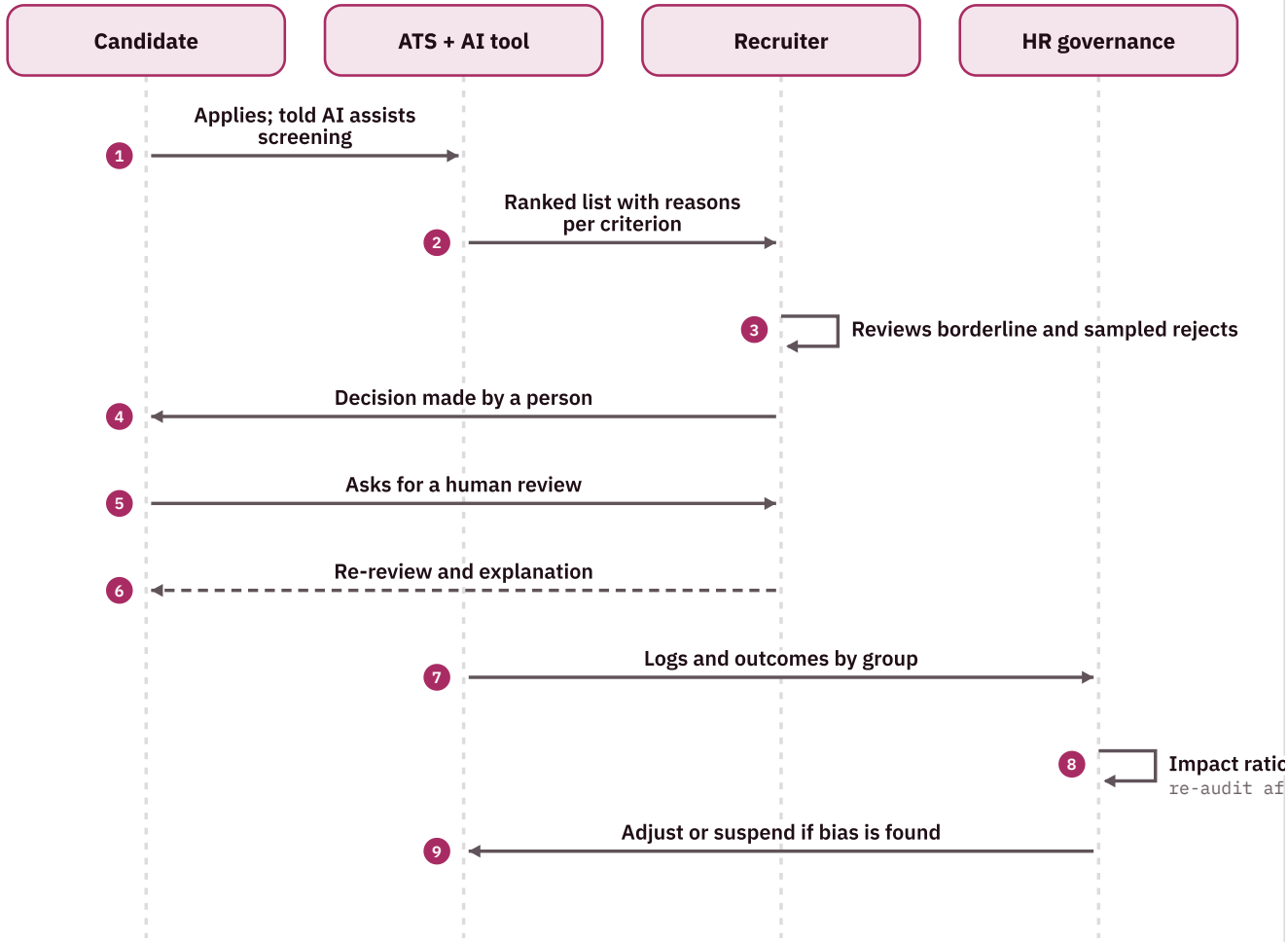
Dates from the regulation as adopted, plus a proposed change that was still being decided at the time of writing. Plan to meet high-risk duties for hiring and people-management tools whatever the final date.

Governing an AI tool in HR

1. **Define the use case** What decision does it support, who is affected and what could go wrong?
2. **Do an impact assessment** Assess fairness, privacy, transparency, legal and employee-relations risks.
3. **Due diligence on the vendor** Ask how the model was built, tested for bias and validated, and where data is stored.
4. **Pilot with monitoring** Run alongside the current process; compare outcomes and impact ratios.
5. **Set human oversight** Decide what humans review, with authority and time to overrule the tool.
6. **Inform and consult** Tell candidates and employees; consult representatives where appropriate.
7. **Monitor and re-audit** Track performance and bias regularly and after any model change.

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AI-assisted screening with real human oversight



Oversight is designed into the flow: candidates are told, a person makes and can explain each decision, people can ask for a review, and governance checks outcomes by group every round, not once a year.

TEMPLATE **AI use-case risk assessment**

Assess an HR AI use case before approval.

USE CASE	DECISION AFFECTED	DATA USED	MAIN RISKS	SAFEGUARDS	OWNER AND REVIEW DATE
CV screening for graduate trainee roles	*Who moves to the online test*	*CV text, education, skills*	*Proxy bias by university and region; opaque ranking*	*Job-related criteria only; impact ratio check each round; human review of all rejections near the cut-off; candidate notice*	*Head of Talent; review every intake*

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Responsible-use policy essentials for HR AI

☐ List approved tools and approved uses; ban unapproved tools for personal data

☐ Never paste confidential employee or candidate data into public AI tools

☐ Require human review for any decision with significant effects on a person

☐ Tell candidates and employees when AI is used and how to ask for human review

☐ Run bias and accuracy checks before launch and at least annually

☐ Keep records of model versions, audits and decisions

☐ Train HR staff and managers on limitations, including fabricated or wrong answers

☐ Name an owner and a route for complaints and appeals

SCENARIO · DECIDE · A VENDOR PROMISES UNBIASED HIRING

A vendor offers an AI tool that scores video interviews and claims it is 'completely free of bias' because it does not see names or photos. Recruitment volumes at your bank are high and leaders are keen. What should HR do?

(A) Buy it; removing names and photos removes bias.

(B) Reject all AI tools in recruitment permanently.

(C) Use the tool but do not tell candidates, to avoid complaints.

(D) Ask for evidence of validation and independent bias audits, test the tool on your own data for adverse impact and job relevance, check legal requirements, and only pilot with human oversight if the evidence holds up.

Circle your choice. Answer and feedback: module answer key.

REFLECT

Which HR task in your organisation would benefit most from AI, and what is the worst thing that could happen if the tool got it wrong? What safeguard would you put in place first?

Key terms

Algorithmic bias
Systematic unfairness in the outputs of an algorithm, often learned from biased data or proxies.

Human-in-the-loop
A design in which a person reviews and can override an automated output before it takes effect.

Bias audit
An assessment of whether an automated tool's outcomes differ unfairly between groups.

Proxy variable
A data item, such as postcode or university, that indirectly signals a protected characteristic.

Explainability
The ability to describe in understandable terms how an AI system reached an output.

AI impact assessment
A structured review of the benefits, risks and safeguards of an AI use case before deployment.

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Employee monitoring
Collecting data on employees' activities, location or communications, which must be lawful, proportionate and transparent.

High-risk AI system
Under the EU AI Act, an AI system in a listed sensitive use, including recruitment, promotion, termination, task allocation and worker monitoring, that must meet strict duties on oversight, logging and transparency.

Key takeaways

- AI can save time in HR but can also discriminate at scale; many regulators treat employment uses as high-risk.
- Removing protected attributes does not remove proxies: test outcomes with impact ratios before and after launch.
- Keep meaningful human oversight: reviewers with authority, time and information, and a route for people to challenge.
- Track the rules: the EU AI Act bans emotion inference at work and sets high-risk duties for hiring and people-management tools.
- Govern each use case with an impact assessment, vendor evidence, a pilot, transparency and re-audits.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

16. An AI screening tool advances 40% of men and 28% of women. What is the impact ratio for women?

(A) 0.28
(B) 0.12
(C) 1.43
(D) 0.70

17. Why does removing gender from training data not guarantee a fair model?

(A) Models ignore all data
(B) Gender is never relevant to bias
(C) Other data items can act as proxies for gender
(D) Removing data always improves accuracy, so the model becomes fairer automatically

18. Which HR use of AI is generally the lowest risk?

(A) Drafting a job advert that a human reviews
(B) Ranking candidates automatically
(C) Scoring video interviews for personality traits
(D) Recommending dismissals

19. What does meaningful human oversight require?

(A) A person clicking 'approve' on every output so that a human is formally involved
(B) Reviewing outputs once a year
(C) Letting the vendor decide
(D) Reviewers with the authority, time and information to overrule the tool

20. An HR officer wants to paste employee grievance details into a public AI chatbot to draft a reply. What should the policy say?

(A) It is fine if the reply is good
(B) Do not enter confidential personal data into unapproved tools
(C) Only remove the employee's first name before pasting the details into the tool
(D) Use it only after office hours

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21. A company in an EU member state plans to use a high-risk AI system to allocate shifts based on workers' past behaviour. Which duty applies to it as the employer using the system?

(A) Publish the model's source code on the company intranet

(B) Let the vendor make every allocation decision without review

(C) Stop recording any logs so that worker privacy is protected

(D) Inform workers' representatives and affected workers before putting it into use

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MODULE 8 · ANALYSE

Answer key

Knowledge checks

1. C Average headcount = (90 + 110) ÷ 2 = 100; 15 ÷ 100 = 15%.

2. A $S^2 \times D = 4^2 \times 6 = 16 \times 6 = 96$.

3. D (900,000 + 300,000) ÷ 40 = 30,000.

4. B 5% × (12 ÷ 3) = 20%.

5. B Segmentation reveals where and whom you are losing.

6. D Predictive analytics estimates future outcomes.

7. A Correlation does not establish causation; confounding variables may be at work.

8. C Missing values reduce completeness.

9. D Question-led projects produce useful, actionable insight.

10. B Small groups can reveal individual responses and breach confidentiality.

11. C Process clarity defines requirements and avoids automating waste.

12. A Scripted demos make comparisons objective.

13. A Parallel runs catch configuration and data errors safely.

14. C Access should match the role's genuine need.

15. B Usability and support drive adoption.

16. D 0.28 ÷ 0.40 = 0.70, below 0.80, so the tool should be investigated.

17. C Proxies such as activities or career gaps can carry the same pattern.

18. A Drafting with human review has limited direct effect on decisions.

19. D Rubber-stamping is not oversight.

20. B Confidential data must only go into approved, secure tools.

21. D Employers deploying high-risk AI at work must inform workers' representatives and affected workers before use, assign human oversight and keep logs. Handing all decisions to the vendor or deleting logs breaches these duties, and publishing source code is not required.

Scenarios & case studies

Scenario · A metric that looks good
A is best. Best. Segmentation shows whether the improvement is real or a side effect of fewer new joiners.

Case study · Early attrition at a contact centre
Hypotheses could include pay, shift patterns (for example night shifts assigned to new joiners), supervisor quality, training length, commute distance, recruitment source and realistic job preview. The team should join hire and exit records with schedules, supervisor IDs, training records, quality scores, location and 30-day pulse surveys, then compare 90-day attrition across these segments, using simple models to control for overlapping factors. Suppose new agents assigned mostly night shifts in their first month leave at twice the rate, and attrition varies threefold between supervisors, while pay differences explain little. The presentation should lead with the business question, the main finding, the confidence level and the cost comparison, then propose a pilot: day-shift-first scheduling and supervisor coaching for half of the next intake, compared with the other half, before committing to a large pay increase.

Scenario · A request for individual risk scores
B is best. Best. Segment-level insight supports action while protecting privacy and avoiding unfair treatment of individuals based on uncertain predictions.

Scenario · A system nobody uses
C is best. Best. Low adoption usually reflects poor design or support; simplifying and engaging users fixes the cause.

Scenario · A vendor promises unbiased hiring
D is best. Best. Claims of zero bias need evidence; local testing, legal checks and oversight protect candidates and the bank.

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REFERENCE

Glossary

3

360-degree feedback Feedback on a person collected from several sources such as manager, peers, direct reports and sometimes customers. (Perform)

7

70-20-10 guideline A heuristic that most learning comes from experience, a smaller share from others and the least from formal courses. (Develop)

A

Absence rate Working days lost to absence as a percentage of total available working days. (Analyse)

Active listening Fully concentrating on, understanding and reflecting back what another person says and means. (Lead)

ADDIE A design cycle of Analyse, Design, Develop, Implement and Evaluate used to create learning programmes. (Develop)

Adjusted pay gap The pay gap remaining after controlling for factors such as role, grade, location and experience. (Reward)

Adverse impact A substantially lower selection rate for one group compared with another, which may indicate unfair barriers. (Attract)

Affinity bias The tendency to favour people who are similar to ourselves. (Attract)

AI impact assessment A structured review of the benefits, risks and safeguards of an AI use case before deployment. (Analyse)

Algorithmic bias Systematic unfairness in the outputs of an algorithm, often learned from biased data or proxies. (Analyse)

AMO model A lens stating that performance depends on employees' Ability, Motivation and Opportunity to contribute. (Align)

Andragogy Principles of how adults learn, emphasising relevance, experience, self-direction and problem-solving. (Develop)

Applicant tracking system (ATS) Software that manages job postings, applications, candidate communication and hiring workflow. (Attract)

Application programming interface (API) A defined way for software systems to exchange data automatically. (Analyse)

Artefacts The visible elements of culture, such as layout, rituals, dress and stories. (Lead)

Assessment centre A process using several exercises and trained assessors to evaluate candidates against defined competencies. (Attract)

B

Basic assumptions Deep, often unspoken beliefs that drive behaviour in an organisation. (Lead)

Behavioural question An interview question asking candidates to describe how they handled a real past situation. (Attract)

Behaviourally anchored rating scale (BARS) A rating scale where each point is described with examples of the behaviour expected at that level. (Attract)

Bench strength The proportion of critical roles that have at least one ready successor. (Develop)

Benchmark job A well-understood job used as a reference point for evaluation or market comparison. (Reward)

Best fit The view that HR practices should be tailored to the organisation's strategy, context and competitive approach. (Align)

Best practice (HR) The view that certain HR practices, such as careful selection and training, improve performance in most organisations. (Align)

Bias audit An assessment of whether an automated tool's outcomes differ unfairly between groups. (Analyse)

Blended learning A learning journey combining several methods, such as online modules, workshops, on-the-job practice and coaching. (Develop)

Bradford factor An absence measure, $S^2 \times D$, that gives extra weight to frequent short spells of absence. (Analyse)

Brand ambassador An employee who willingly shares authentic stories about working at the organisation. (Attract)

Broadbanding A pay structure that uses a small number of wide bands instead of many narrow grades. (Reward)

Build, buy, borrow, bot Four options for closing a workforce gap: develop, recruit, use contingent labour or partners, or automate. (Align)

Burnout A state resulting from chronic workplace stress, marked by exhaustion, cynicism and reduced effectiveness. (Relate)

C

Calibration A meeting where managers compare and align ratings using evidence to apply consistent standards. (Perform)

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Candidate experience How candidates perceive and feel about every interaction with an employer during hiring. (Attract)

Candidate persona A research-based profile of a target candidate group, describing their goals, concerns and where they look for jobs. (Attract)

Capability issue A performance gap caused by lack of skill, knowledge, aptitude or health rather than by deliberate behaviour. (Perform)

Capability procedure A formal process for managing performance problems caused by lack of ability or health. (Perform)

Central tendency A rating error in which a rater places most people in the middle of the scale. (Perform)

Centre of expertise A specialist HR team, such as reward or talent acquisition, that designs policies and gives expert advice across the organisation. (Align)

Change champion A respected employee who supports peers through a change and feeds back concerns. (Lead)

Change curve A model of the emotional stages people often move through during change, from shock to acceptance. (Lead)

Change management A structured approach to moving people and organisations from a current state to a desired future state. (Lead)

Change readiness The extent to which people and the organisation are prepared and able to make a change. (Lead)

Change sponsor A senior leader who champions a change, provides resources and holds people accountable. (Lead)

Check-in A short, regular one-to-one conversation between manager and employee about progress, obstacles, feedback and growth. (Perform)

Clawback A rule allowing an employer to recover incentive pay later found to be unearned, for example because of misconduct. (Reward)

Coaching A conversation-based approach that helps people clarify goals, think through options and take ownership of action. (Lead)

Coaching culture An organisation where coaching conversations are a normal way of developing people and solving problems. (Lead)

Cognitive ability test A standardised test of reasoning, learning and problem-solving ability. (Attract)

Collective bargaining Negotiation between employers and worker representatives over pay and terms and conditions. (Relate)

Commission Variable pay based on a percentage or amount of sales made. (Reward)

Compa-ratio An individual's pay divided by the midpoint of their pay range. (Reward)

Compensatory approach A selection decision rule in which weighted scores are combined so strengths can offset weaknesses. (Attract)

Competency framework A structured set of observable behaviours and capabilities linked to effective performance, used across HR processes. (Align)

Conditional offer A job offer that becomes final only when stated conditions, such as references or credential checks, are met. (Attract)

Conduct issue A problem caused by an employee's behaviour or rule-breaking, handled through a disciplinary procedure. (Perform)

Confounding variable A hidden factor that affects both variables in a relationship, creating a misleading correlation. (Analyse)

Continuous listening Gathering employee views through a mix of short surveys, pulses, lifecycle surveys and open channels throughout the year, and acting on them. (Relate)

Continuous performance management An approach that replaces or supplements annual reviews with frequent check-ins and adaptable goals. (Perform)

Cost per hire Total internal and external recruitment costs divided by the number of hires. (Analyse)

Critical role A role with outsized impact on strategy that is hard to fill or slow to develop. (Align)

D

Data migration Moving data from old systems to a new one, including cleansing, mapping, loading and reconciling. (Analyse)

Data protection Rules and practices that govern how personal data is collected, used, stored, shared and deleted. (Relate)

Data quality The accuracy, completeness, consistency, timeliness and uniqueness of data. (Analyse)

Data storytelling Communicating analytical findings as a clear narrative with evidence, implications and actions. (Analyse)

Debrief A structured review after an event to understand what happened and what to learn. (Lead)

Demand forecasting Estimating the number and type of people needed to deliver planned work. (Align)

Descriptive analytics Analysis that summarises what has happened, through reports and dashboards. (Analyse)

Disciplinary procedure A written process for dealing fairly with misconduct, from investigation to hearing, outcome and appeal. (Relate)

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Discretionary effort Effort people choose to give beyond what is strictly required. (Relate)

Diversity The range of differences among people in an organisation, including identity, background and ways of thinking. (Relate)

E

Early turnover The proportion of new hires who leave within a short period, such as 90 days or the first year. (Develop)

Employee assistance programme (EAP) A confidential service offering counselling and advice to employees on personal and work issues. (Relate)

Employee engagement The degree to which people are committed to, energised by and absorbed in their work and organisation. (Relate)

Employee lifecycle The stages a person goes through with an employer, from planning and attraction to exit and alumni. (Align)

Employee monitoring Collecting data on employees' activities, location or communications, which must be lawful, proportionate and transparent. (Analyse)

Employee net promoter score (eNPS) Percentage of promoters minus percentage of detractors when employees rate how likely they are to recommend the employer. (Relate)

Employee referral programme A scheme that encourages employees to recommend candidates, often with a reward if the hire succeeds. (Attract)

Employee relations The management of the individual and collective relationship between an employer and its employees. (Relate)

Employee self-service Technology that lets employees view and update their own information and make requests without HR help. (Analyse)

Employee value proposition (EVP) The honest, distinctive offer an employer makes to people in return for their skills, effort and commitment. (Attract)

Employee voice The ways employees express views, raise concerns and influence decisions at work. (Relate)

Employer brand An organisation's reputation as a place to work, as seen by candidates, employees and the public. (Attract)

Employer brand audit A structured review of how the organisation appears to candidates across channels and stages. (Attract)

Employment contract The legal agreement between employer and employee, including written, implied and statutory terms. (Relate)

Engagement driver A factor, such as manager support or growth, that research or analysis shows influences engagement. (Relate)

Equal pay for work of equal value The principle that different jobs of the same overall value should receive equal pay. (Reward)

Equity (workplace) Fair access to opportunities and outcomes, achieved by removing barriers and adjusting for different needs. (Relate)

Equity theory A theory that people compare their inputs and outcomes with others and act to restore perceived fairness. (Lead)

Espoused values The values an organisation states publicly, which may or may not match actual behaviour. (Lead)

Exit interview A conversation or survey with a departing employee to understand their reasons and experience. (Relate)

Expectancy theory A theory that motivation depends on expectancy, instrumentality and valence multiplied together. (Lead)

Explainability The ability to describe in understandable terms how an AI system reached an output. (Analyse)

External competitiveness How an organisation's pay compares with what other employers pay for similar jobs. (Reward)

Extrinsic motivation Motivation driven by external outcomes such as pay, praise or avoiding sanctions. (Lead)

F

Feedforward Suggestions focused on what someone could do differently in future rather than on past mistakes. (Perform)

Flexible benefits A scheme allowing employees to choose benefits from a menu within an allowance. (Reward)

Flight risk An assessment that a valued employee is likely to leave in the near future. (Relate)

Forced distribution A rating system requiring fixed percentages of employees in each rating category. (Perform)

Four-fifths rule A rule of thumb that flags possible adverse impact when a group's selection rate is below 80% of the highest group's rate. (Attract)

Four-level evaluation An evaluation approach measuring reaction, learning, behaviour and results. (Develop)

Full-time equivalent (FTE) A unit expressing workload or staffing as the number of full-time workers; two half-time staff equal one FTE. (Align)

G

Gainsharing A team or unit incentive that shares the financial gains from improved productivity or cost savings. (Reward)

Gender pay gap The difference between average pay for men and women across an organisation, expressed as a percentage of men's pay. (Reward)

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Ghost employee A fictitious or departed person kept on the payroll so that pay is wrongly diverted. (Reward)

Goal alignment Ensuring individual and team goals support each other and the organisation's priorities. (Perform)

Grievance A formal complaint by an employee about work, colleagues, management or conditions. (Relate)

Gross misconduct Behaviour so serious, such as theft, violence or serious safety breaches, that it may justify dismissal for a first offence after a fair process. (Relate)

GROW model A coaching structure covering Goal, Reality, Options and Way forward. (Lead)

H

Halo effect A rating error in which one positive trait or result inflates ratings across all areas. (Perform)

High-performance work system A bundle of mutually reinforcing HR practices designed to raise ability, motivation and opportunity to contribute. (Align)

High-potential employee An employee assessed as able and willing to grow into significantly bigger or more complex roles. (Develop)

High-risk AI system Under the EU AI Act, an AI system in a listed sensitive use, including recruitment, promotion, termination, task allocation and worker monitoring, that must meet strict duties on oversight, logging and transparency. (Analyse)

HR business partner A senior HR professional embedded with a business unit who links its plans to people priorities and advises its leaders. (Align)

HR information system (HRIS) Software that stores employee records and supports core HR processes, often the system of record for people data. (Analyse)

HR metric A defined, repeatable measure of an aspect of the workforce or HR activity. (Analyse)

HR operating model The way HR roles, structures, processes and technology are arranged to deliver people services and advice. (Align)

HR shared services A central team, often supported by self-service technology, that handles routine HR transactions such as payroll, records and queries. (Align)

Human capital reporting Structured reporting of workforce data, such as costs, turnover, skills, diversity and wellbeing, to leaders or outside stakeholders; ISO 30414 is the international standard. (Analyse)

Human resource management (HRM) The strategies, policies and practices an organisation uses to plan, attract, develop, manage, reward, engage and lead its people. (Align)

Human-in-the-loop A design in which a person reviews and can override an automated output before it takes effect. (Analyse)

Hybrid working An arrangement in which people split work time between a shared workplace and remote locations. (Lead)

Hygiene factors Job conditions such as pay and policies that prevent dissatisfaction but do not by themselves motivate. (Lead)

I

Implied term A contract term not written down but treated as part of the contract, such as mutual trust and confidence. (Relate)

Inclusion A work environment in which people feel respected, valued and able to contribute and influence. (Relate)

Induction A short programme introducing new joiners to policies, safety, facilities and basic information. (Develop)

Internal equity Fairness of pay between jobs and people inside the same organisation. (Reward)

Internal mobility Movement of employees into new roles inside the organisation through promotion, transfer or project assignments. (Develop)

Internal talent marketplace A platform or process that matches employees to open roles, projects, gigs and mentors inside the organisation by skills and interests. (Develop)

Intrinsic motivation Motivation that comes from the work itself being interesting, meaningful or satisfying. (Lead)

J

Job analysis The systematic study of a job to identify its tasks, outcomes and the requirements for performing it well. (Align)

Job classification A job evaluation method that matches jobs to written grade descriptions. (Reward)

Job description A document describing a job's purpose, responsibilities, scope, reporting line and working conditions. (Align)

Job design Deciding the content, methods and relationships of a job to meet organisational and individual needs. (Align)

Job evaluation A systematic process for determining the relative value of jobs within an organisation. (Reward)

Job family A group of jobs with similar type of work and skills, organised into progressive levels. (Reward)

Job ranking A simple job evaluation method that places whole jobs in order of overall value. (Reward)

Joint pay assessment Under the EU Pay Transparency Directive, a review carried out with worker representatives when an unjustified gender pay gap of 5% or more in a category of workers is not corrected within six months. (Reward)

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L

Leadership The ability to influence individuals and groups towards shared goals. (Lead)

Leading question A question that suggests the answer the asker wants. (Lead)

Learning and development (L&D) The function and activities that build the knowledge, skills and behaviours people need to perform and grow. (Develop)

Learning experience platform A learning tool that curates and recommends content from many sources, personalised to each learner. (Analyse)

Learning goal A goal focused on discovering strategies or building skills rather than reaching a fixed output. (Perform)

Learning management system (LMS) Software that delivers, tracks and reports on formal learning. (Analyse)

Learning needs analysis A systematic review of organisational, role and individual needs to decide what learning is required. (Develop)

Learning objective A clear statement of what learners will be able to do after learning, under what conditions and to what standard. (Develop)

Leniency bias A rating error in which a rater gives consistently higher ratings than performance justifies. (Perform)

Line manager The person to whom an employee directly reports, who carries day-to-day responsibility for managing that employee. (Align)

M

Market positioning Where an organisation chooses to set pay relative to the market, such as leading, matching or lagging. (Reward)

Market pricing Valuing jobs mainly by reference to pay data for comparable jobs in the external market. (Reward)

Mediation A voluntary, confidential process in which a neutral person helps parties in conflict reach their own agreement. (Relate)

Mentoring A developmental relationship in which a more experienced person guides another's growth and career. (Develop)

Merit increase A rise in base pay linked to an individual's performance. (Reward)

Merit matrix A grid that sets pay increase percentages by performance level and position in the pay range. (Reward)

Microaggression A subtle, often unintended comment or action that communicates bias towards a group. (Relate)

Microlearning Short, focused learning units, often a few minutes long, targeting a single skill or piece of knowledge. (Develop)

Minimum group size A rule that results are only reported for groups large enough to prevent identifying individuals. (Analyse)

Minimum wage The lowest legal rate of pay for a type of work, set by law or a statutory body. (Reward)

Motivation The forces that drive the direction, intensity and persistence of a person's effort. (Lead)

Multiple hurdle approach A decision rule in which candidates must pass each stage to continue, so strengths cannot offset failure at any one stage. (Attract)

N

Natural justice Basic fairness principles: knowing the case, being heard and an unbiased decision-maker. (Relate)

Nine-box grid A talent review tool plotting employees on performance and potential to guide development and succession decisions. (Develop)

Notice period The time an employer or employee must give before ending employment, set by law, contract or both. (Relate)

O

Objectives and key results (OKRs) A goal method pairing a qualitative objective with a few measurable key results, usually set quarterly. (Perform)

Occupational health Specialist advice on how health affects work and what adjustments or support may help. (Perform)

Offer acceptance rate The percentage of job offers that candidates accept. (Attract)

Onboarding The process, usually lasting several months, of helping new joiners become productive, connected and committed. (Develop)

Onboarding buddy An experienced peer assigned to help a new joiner settle in and learn informal norms. (Develop)

Open question A question that cannot be answered with yes or no and invites reflection, such as 'what' or 'how' questions. (Lead)

Organisation design Shaping structure, roles, processes and decision rights so an organisation can deliver its strategy. (Align)

Organisational culture The shared values, beliefs and assumptions that shape how people in an organisation think and behave. (Lead)

P

Pacesetting style A leadership style in which the leader sets very high standards and models fast performance personally. (Lead)

Participation committee A joint body of employer and worker representatives that discusses welfare, productivity and workplace issues. (Relate)

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Pay equity Fair pay for comparable work regardless of gender or other protected characteristics, with differences explained by legitimate factors. (Reward)

Pay grade A group of jobs of similar value that share the same pay range. (Reward)

Pay philosophy A short statement of what an organisation pays for, its market position and its fairness principles. (Reward)

Pay quartile One of four equal groups formed by ranking employees by pay from lowest to highest. (Reward)

Pay range The minimum to maximum pay for a grade, usually built around a market-linked midpoint. (Reward)

Pay transparency Openness about pay ranges, criteria and decisions, inside the organisation and in job ads; increasingly required by law, for example under the EU Pay Transparency Directive. (Reward)

People analytics The use of people and business data, statistics and modelling to improve decisions about the workforce. (Analyse)

People strategy A focused plan setting out the people priorities, initiatives and measures needed to deliver the business strategy. (Align)

Performance cycle The recurring sequence of planning, checking in, supporting, reviewing and recognising performance. (Perform)

Performance gap The difference between the required and actual level of performance. (Develop)

Performance improvement plan (PIP) A formal, time-bound plan setting specific targets, support and reviews to help an employee reach the required standard. (Perform)

Performance management The continuous process of setting expectations, supporting people, reviewing progress and recognising results. (Perform)

Performance rating A summary judgement of performance against expectations over a period, often on a defined scale. (Perform)

Person specification A statement of the essential and desirable knowledge, skills, experience and behaviours for a role. (Align)

Point-factor method A job evaluation method that scores jobs on weighted factors and converts total points into grades. (Reward)

Power distance The extent to which people accept and expect unequal distribution of power in organisations and society. (Lead)

Pre-boarding Activities between offer acceptance and the first day that welcome and prepare new joiners. (Develop)

Predictive analytics Analysis that uses historical data and models to estimate what is likely to happen. (Analyse)

Predictive validity The degree to which assessment scores predict later job performance. (Attract)

Probation period An initial period of employment during which performance and suitability are reviewed before confirmation. (Develop)

Probe A planned follow-up question used to obtain specific evidence from a candidate's answer. (Attract)

Provident fund A savings scheme into which employers and employees contribute, paid out on retirement or leaving under its rules. (Reward)

Proximity bias The tendency to rate, reward or promote people more favourably because they are seen more often, for example in the office rather than working remotely. (Lead)

Proxy variable A data item, such as postcode or university, that indirectly signals a protected characteristic. (Analyse)

Psychological contract The unwritten beliefs employees and employers hold about what they owe each other. (Relate)

Psychological safety A shared belief that a team is safe for interpersonal risk-taking such as speaking up or admitting mistakes. (Lead)

Psychosocial risk A work-related hazard to mental health, such as excessive workload, low control, poor support or harassment. (Relate)

Pulse survey A short, frequent survey that tracks a few key measures between full surveys. (Relate)

R

Range midpoint The middle of a pay range, often set at the market rate for a fully competent job holder. (Reward)

Range penetration Where an individual's pay sits within the range, from the minimum to the maximum. (Reward)

Range spread The width of a pay range, calculated as maximum minus minimum divided by minimum. (Reward)

Realistic job preview Information that shows candidates both the attractive and the difficult parts of a job before they accept it. (Attract)

Reasonable adjustment A change to the way a process or job is done so that a disabled person is not put at a disadvantage. (Attract)

Recency bias A rating error that gives too much weight to recent events over the whole review period. (Perform)

Recognition Timely, specific acknowledgement of a person's contribution or behaviour. (Perform)

Recruitment The process of attracting a pool of suitable candidates for a role. (Attract)

Recruitment funnel The stages candidates pass through from first seeing a job to being hired and staying. (Attract)

Red-circled pay Pay above the maximum of the employee's range, usually frozen until the range catches up. (Reward)

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Regrettable turnover Departures of employees the organisation would have preferred to keep, such as strong performers in critical roles. (Analyse)

Reliability The consistency of an assessment: whether it gives similar results across assessors and occasions. (Attract)

Resistance to change Reluctance or opposition to change, often rooted in loss, uncertainty or competence concerns. (Lead)

Retention rate The percentage of employees present at the start of a period who are still employed at the end. (Analyse)

Retrenchment Termination of employment because the work is no longer needed, also known as redundancy in some countries. (Relate)

Reward strategy A plan setting out how an organisation will use pay and other rewards to support its goals. (Reward)

Right to be accompanied A right, in some jurisdictions and policies, for an employee to bring a colleague or representative to formal meetings. (Perform)

S

Salary survey A structured collection of pay data for comparable jobs across organisations. (Reward)

SBI model A feedback structure describing the Situation, the observed Behaviour and its Impact. (Perform)

Scenario planning Preparing for several plausible futures and identifying actions that work across them. (Align)

Self-determination theory A theory that motivation thrives when needs for autonomy, competence and relatedness are met. (Lead)

Servant leadership A leadership approach focused on serving and enabling others to grow and perform. (Lead)

Situational judgement test A test presenting realistic work dilemmas and asking candidates to choose or rate responses. (Attract)

Situational leadership Adapting leadership style to a person's competence and commitment for a specific task. (Lead)

Situational question An interview question presenting a hypothetical job situation and asking what the candidate would do. (Attract)

Skills taxonomy A structured list of the skills an organisation uses, with definitions and proficiency levels, shared across job profiles, hiring, learning and mobility. (Align)

Skills-based organisation An organisation that describes and manages work as bundles of skills as well as jobs, so it can hire, develop and redeploy people by demonstrated skill. (Align)

SMART goal A goal that is Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant and Time-bound. (Perform)

Sourcing Actively finding and engaging potential candidates, including people not yet looking for a job. (Attract)

Spaced practice Practising a skill in several sessions spread over time, which improves long-term retention. (Develop)

Span of control The number of direct reports a manager leads. (Align)

STAR A probing structure covering Situation, Task, Action and Result to get specific behavioural evidence. (Attract)

Statutory right A right given to workers by law that cannot be removed by contract. (Relate)

Stay interview A structured conversation with a valued employee about why they stay and what might make them leave. (Relate)

Strategic HRM The deliberate alignment of people policies and practices with organisational strategy so the workforce can deliver it. (Align)

Stretch goal A deliberately ambitious goal intended to encourage innovation and extra effort. (Perform)

Structured interview An interview using the same job-related questions for all candidates, with answers rated on defined, anchored scales. (Attract)

Succession planning Identifying and developing people to fill critical roles when they become vacant. (Develop)

Supply forecasting Estimating the people who will be available, after expected leavers, retirements and internal moves. (Align)

System of record The authoritative source for a type of data, which other systems treat as correct. (Analyse)

T

Talent management Practices that identify, develop, deploy and retain the people who create the most value now and in the future. (Develop)

Talent review A structured meeting where leaders discuss and calibrate people's performance, potential, risks and development. (Develop)

Talent segment A group of current or potential employees with similar skills and priorities, used to tailor the EVP and recruitment. (Attract)

Team development stages A model describing how teams move through forming, storming, norming, performing and adjourning. (Lead)

Time to fill The number of days from vacancy approval to offer acceptance. (Analyse)

Time to productivity The time a new joiner takes to reach the agreed performance standard for the role. (Develop)

Total rewards Everything of value an employee receives from work: pay, benefits, wellbeing, development and recognition. (Reward)

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Trade union An organisation of workers that represents members' interests, including in collective bargaining. (Relate)

Training ROI The net monetary benefit of a learning programme expressed as a percentage of its total cost. (Develop)

Transactional leadership Leadership based on clear exchanges of reward for performance and correction of deviations. (Lead)

Transfer of learning The extent to which people apply what they learned in training to their work. (Develop)

Transformational leadership Leadership that inspires people with purpose, challenges their thinking and develops them. (Lead)

Turnover rate The number of leavers in a period divided by average headcount, expressed as a percentage. (Analyse)

U

Unconscious bias Automatic, unintended associations that influence judgements and decisions about people. (Attract)

Underperformance Work that consistently falls below the standards reasonably expected for the role. (Perform)

Unfair dismissal A dismissal without a valid reason or fair procedure under applicable law. (Relate)

Unfreeze, change, refreeze A three-stage view of change: create readiness, make the change, then embed it. (Lead)

Upward feedback Feedback that employees give to their manager about the manager's leadership. (Perform)

V

Variable pay Pay that varies with performance or results, such as bonuses and incentives, and must be re-earned. (Reward)

Vertical and horizontal fit Vertical fit links HR practices to business strategy; horizontal fit makes HR practices consistent with each other. (Align)

W

Wash-up The post-interview meeting in which panellists compare evidence and scores and reach a decision. (Attract)

Whistleblowing Raising a concern about wrongdoing, often in the public interest, through protected channels. (Relate)

Work sample test An assessment in which candidates perform a realistic sample of the job's tasks. (Attract)

Workforce gap The difference between forecast demand and projected supply for a role or skill. (Align)

Workforce planning The process of forecasting the people and skills an organisation needs and planning actions to close gaps between demand and supply. (Align)

Workplace investigation An impartial fact-finding process into an allegation or complaint, ending in a written report. (Relate)

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CAPSTONE

Capstone: Design a people strategy through the ZHRLS People Hive

Choose a real organisation from your work, or a realistic one (for example: a 3,000-worker garment exporter in Gazipur and Chattogram, a fast-growing mobile financial services company in Dhaka, a private university or a 400-bed hospital). Take it through all eight cells of the ZHRLS People Hive and produce a people strategy pack that an executive team could approve and line managers could put into practice.

Deliverables

☐ People strategy on a page linked to business goals, with a workforce plan and gap analysis

☐ Employer value proposition and a structured selection process for one critical role, with interview guide and scoring rubric

☐ Onboarding plan for the first 90 days and a talent review with a succession plan for two key roles

☐ Learning needs analysis and a blended learning design with an evaluation plan

☐ Performance management cycle: goal template, check-in guide, calibration rules and a PIP template

☐ Reward framework: job evaluation approach, grade structure with ranges, a pay equity check and a pay transparency readiness review

☐ Employee relations and engagement plan, including grievance and discipline procedures checked against local law

☐ Inclusion and wellbeing actions with measurable targets

☐ Leadership and change plan for one major change, including a coaching approach for managers

☐ HR metrics dashboard with formulas, plus a responsible-use policy for HR technology and AI with human oversight and bias checks

Self-assessment rubric

CRITERION	DEVELOPING	PROFICIENT	EXCELLENT
Strategic alignment	○ HR activity listed without business link	○ Priorities linked to business goals	○ Workforce plan with scenarios, gaps and measurable outcomes
Attraction & selection	○ Unstructured hiring	○ Structured process with criteria	○ Validated, fair and monitored for adverse impact
Talent & learning	○ Ad hoc training	○ Needs-based plan and onboarding	○ Talent pipeline, succession and evaluated learning
Performance	○ Annual rating only	○ Goals, check-ins and reviews	○ Calibrated, fair and development-focused with clear PIP process
Reward	○ Pay set case by case	○ Grades and ranges defined	○ Evaluated, market-aligned and equity-checked
Relations, law & inclusion	○ Reactive	○ Policies and procedures in place	○ Voice, fairness, inclusion and wellbeing built in and legally checked
Leadership & change	○ Change announced	○ Change plan with communication	○ People-centred change with coaching, resistance handling and culture measures
Analytics & technology	○ No metrics	○ Core metrics reported	○ Evidence-based insights with responsible, audited technology and AI

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CAPSTONE

Planning pages

Sketch your design, timeline or architecture here.

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EXAM PREPARATION

Practice exam · 60 questions

The official online exam draws 40 questions at random from a separate, secret bank that tests the same skills, with a 60-minute limit and a 80% pass mark. Practise with these questions first: time yourself, mark your answers, then check the key and read every explanation, including for the questions you got right.

Align — Strategic HRM and Workforce Planning

1. The board of a commercial bank approves a strategy to move most retail customers to digital channels within three years, which will shrink branch networks. The head of HR is asked to prepare a people strategy. What should HR do FIRST?

   (A) Identify the capabilities, roles and numbers the strategy needs and compare them with today's workforce

   (B) Launch a digital skills e-learning course for every employee in the bank straight away so nobody is left behind by the change

   (C) Freeze all branch hiring and announce that branch roles will be reduced

   (D) Benchmark the HR policies of two digital banks and copy the most attractive ones

2. A pharmacy chain will open 12 new outlets next year, each needing 3 pharmacist FTE, on top of its existing 80 pharmacist posts. It currently employs 80 pharmacists and expects 15% annual turnover. How many pharmacists must it hire over the year, assuming no internal moves?

   (A) 36

   (B) 12

   (C) 116

   (D) 48

3. A power company must staff a new generating unit with six experienced control-room engineers within four months. Few internal staff have the skills, and training someone from scratch takes about two years. Which workforce approach is most appropriate?

   (A) Rely on developing internal staff only, and delay the unit's commissioning until they are fully trained

   (B) Recruit experienced engineers now and start an internal development programme for future needs

   (C) Use short-term consultants indefinitely so no permanent commitment is ever made

   (D) Automate the control room fully so no engineers are needed

4. A 600-person distribution company has a three-person HR team that spends most of its day answering payslip and leave-balance questions. Managers complain they never get HR advice on people problems. Which change would help MOST?

   (A) Hire two more HR officers so that payslip and leave questions are answered faster and managers can then be given more time

   (B) Introduce self-service and standard processes for routine queries, freeing HR to advise managers

   (C) Ask managers to stop contacting HR unless there is a legal emergency

   (D) Outsource the whole HR function, including advice to managers, to an agency

5. After a new loan-processing system was installed, the role of 'credit officer' at a microfinance institution changed significantly, yet the job description is five years old. The institution wants to regrade the role and recruit two more officers. What should HR do before either step?

   (A) Advertise the old job description and update it after the new officers start

   (B) Use the job description of a similar role from another microfinance institution

   (C) Ask the finance department to set a new grade based on the available budget

   (D) Carry out a job analysis with current job holders and their manager

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6. A 60-person engineering unit has five management layers, and eight of its managers have only two or three direct reports each. Staff complain that decisions take weeks. What should the organisation design review MOST likely recommend?

   (A) Add a coordinator layer to speed up communication between managers

   (B) Give every manager the title of senior manager to improve morale

   (C) Keep the structure but require managers to reply to emails within one day

   (D) Reduce layers and widen spans of control where the work allows

7. The owner of a knitwear factory that competes on low cost and reliable delivery wants to copy the HR practices of a famous technology company, including unlimited leave and stock options. What is the best advice from HR?

   (A) Copy the technology company's practices exactly, because practices that work for a leading employer will work in any organisation and sector

   (B) Avoid any investment in HR practices because the strategy is low cost

   (C) Keep evidence-based basics such as fair pay, safety and training, tailored to the factory's strategy

   (D) Introduce stock options only, as they are the most motivating reward

8. A workforce plan shows the HR department of a large insurer will have about 40 more clerical staff than needed in 18 months, once claims processing is digitised. There are 200 clerical staff and annual turnover is 12%. What should HR recommend now?

   (A) Announce 40 retrenchments immediately so that the affected people have as much notice as possible to find new jobs elsewhere

   (B) Pause external clerical hiring, plan redeployment and reskilling, and track attrition

   (C) Take no action until the digital system has gone live

   (D) Transfer the 40 newest clerical staff to an outsourcing partner

Attract — Employer Branding, Recruitment and Selection

9. A Dhaka fintech is struggling to hire engineers. Its careers page says only 'great culture, great people'. Leaders ask HR to strengthen the employer brand. What is the best first step?

   (A) Commission a design agency to create a new logo, slogan and video for the careers page that will stand out from competitors

   (B) Ask recent engineering joiners and decliners what is genuinely true and distinctive

   (C) Raise all engineering salaries by 20% and advertise the increase

   (D) Copy the careers page of the market's best-known technology employer

10. A hospital needs 6 new pharmacists. Past data shows 30% of applicants pass screening, 50% of those pass assessment, and 50% of offers are accepted. Roughly how many applicants does the hospital need?

    (A) 80

    (B) 40

    (C) 24

    (D) 120

11. A logistics company's offer acceptance rate has fallen from 80% to 45%. Declining candidates say they had accepted other offers during the three weeks they waited to hear back after the final interview. What should HR do FIRST?

    (A) Set and enforce a short turnaround from final interview to offer

    (B) Increase the advertised salary range for all roles by 15% so that offers become more attractive than those of competing employers

    (C) Add an extra interview round to improve candidate fit

    (D) Stop asking candidates why they decline offers

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12. At a university, each member of a hiring panel asks candidates whatever questions come to mind, and scores are given as an overall impression at the end. Hiring decisions are often disputed. Which change would improve the process MOST?

(A) Use common job-related questions, anchored scales and independent scoring

(B) Let the most senior panel member make the final decision alone, since disputes come from having too many opinions on the panel

(C) Extend each interview from 45 to 90 minutes

(D) Replace interviews with reference checks only

13. A bank's aptitude test is passed by 120 of 200 applicants from urban universities and 36 of 90 applicants from regional universities. What should HR conclude?

(A) The ratio is above 0.80 because both groups pass at reasonable rates, so there is no concern to investigate further

(B) Discrimination is proven and the test must be scrapped today

(C) Regional applicants should be given extra marks automatically

(D) The impact ratio is about 0.67, so the test needs review for job relevance

14. A garment factory must hire 120 sewing machine operators a month. Current selection is a short chat with a supervisor, and many new operators cannot meet basic quality standards. Which selection approach is best?

(A) A written general-knowledge test in English, to make sure operators can understand written instructions and safety notices

(B) A personality questionnaire completed online

(C) Selecting only applicants recommended by current supervisors

(D) A scored practical machine trial plus a brief structured interview

15. A candidate with dyslexia asks for extra time on a written case exercise for a policy analyst role. Writing clear briefs is an essential part of the job. What should HR do?

(A) Agree extra time, keeping the same task and scoring standard

(B) Excuse the candidate from the written exercise entirely and rely on the interview to judge writing ability instead

(C) Refuse, because the role requires writing

(D) Let the candidate submit any writing sample they choose instead

16. In the wash-up for a sales manager role, the hiring manager wants to appoint the candidate who 'will fit the team best', even though another candidate scored higher on four of five agreed criteria. What should the HR adviser do?

(A) Support the hiring manager, because they will manage the person every day and team harmony matters more than scores

(B) Suggest appointing both candidates to avoid conflict

(C) Return to the evidence for each criterion and apply the agreed rule

(D) Ask the candidates to attend an informal dinner to decide

Develop — Onboarding, Talent Management and Learning

17. A private hospital loses 35% of newly hired nurses within 90 days. Exit comments mention 'no one to ask', unclear ward routines and feeling isolated on night shifts. What should HR prioritise?

(A) A higher joining bonus paid only after six months of service, so that nurses have a financial reason to stay through the difficult early period

(B) A longer one-day induction lecture covering every hospital policy

(C) Structured onboarding with a buddy, ward orientation and regular check-ins

(D) Stricter selection to find nurses who do not need support

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18. A bank wants to know whether a redesigned onboarding programme for loan officers works. Which measure would be MOST useful?

(A) The number of policies and slides covered in the new induction presentation, compared with the old version
(B) Time to reach the productivity standard, compared with earlier cohorts
(C) How many managers attended the programme launch
(D) The total hours HR spent designing the programme

19. In a talent review, one director rates almost every high-potential candidate from his own division as people who share his background and style. Other directors privately question the ratings. What should HR do?

(A) Require evidence against agreed indicators and calibrate across directors
(B) Accept the ratings, because each director knows the people in his own division far better than other directors or HR
(C) Remove potential ratings from the talent review entirely
(D) Ask the CEO to choose the high-potentials personally

20. An electricity distribution company has 30 critical roles; only 9 have a successor rated 'ready now'. Several holders are near retirement. What should HR do FIRST?

(A) Run a company-wide leadership course for all staff
(B) Recruit external deputies for all 30 critical roles immediately so that every role has a ready replacement within the year
(C) Prioritise the highest-risk critical roles and name successors with development actions
(D) Ask the retiring staff to postpone their retirement

21. Sales at a consumer goods distributor have fallen for two quarters. The sales director asks L&D for a three-day selling skills course for all 200 sales representatives. What should L&D do FIRST?

(A) Book the course for next month, because selling skills always decline over time and refreshers are needed regularly anyway
(B) Replace the course with a sales podcast series
(C) Ask representatives to rate their own selling skills
(D) Check whether the gap is about skills or about pricing, stock or incentives

22. A power plant ran safety training for all shift workers. Management asks whether it reduced incidents. Which evaluation approach best answers that question?

(A) Report the average satisfaction score from the training feedback forms, since workers who valued the course will apply it
(B) Count how many workers passed the end-of-course quiz
(C) Compare incident rates before and after, against shifts not yet trained
(D) Ask trainers whether they think the course worked

23. A leadership programme cost BDT 1,200,000. Finance estimates its measurable benefits at BDT 3,000,000 after isolating other factors. What is the training ROI?

(A) 250%
(B) 40%
(C) 150%
(D) 180%

Perform — Performance Management

24. At a microfinance institution, loan officers are rewarded for loan volume while the risk team is rewarded for low default rates. The two teams constantly clash and portfolio quality is falling. What should HR recommend?

(A) Agree shared goals balancing growth and portfolio quality
(B) Rate the loan officers lower this year, because their pursuit of volume is what is causing the conflict with the risk team
(C) Remove all goals until the conflict settles
(D) Let each team keep its goal and escalate disputes to the CEO

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25. A department head gives no feedback all year, then presents a long list of criticisms in the annual review. Staff say the reviews feel like an ambush. What should HR do?

(A) Ask staff to accept that annual reviews are meant to be critical and to stop taking the feedback so personally
(B) Coach the manager to hold regular check-ins with timely feedback
(C) Cancel annual reviews in that department
(D) Move all feedback to anonymous written forms

26. One manager rated 90% of her team 'exceeds expectations', while comparable teams average 20%. Ratings drive bonuses. What should HR do?

(A) Cut all of her team's ratings by one level so that the distribution matches the other teams in the department
(B) Test the ratings against evidence in a calibration session
(C) Accept the ratings because she knows her team
(D) Remove bonuses from her team this year

27. An officer did excellent work for ten months but made a visible error in month eleven. His manager plans to rate him 'below expectations' for the year. What is the best advice?

(A) Accept the rating, because the most recent work is the best guide to how the officer will perform next year
(B) Give no rating this year to avoid the issue
(C) Use evidence from the whole year so the rating reflects the full period
(D) Ask colleagues to vote on his rating

28. A previously strong accountant's performance has dropped sharply over three months. In a check-in she mentions she has been caring for a seriously ill parent and is sleeping little. What should her manager do?

(A) Explore support such as flexible hours or leave and agree realistic expectations
(B) Start a formal PIP immediately to protect the organisation, while telling her that personal matters cannot affect the targets
(C) Ignore the personal issue and repeat the targets
(D) Tell her to resign and reapply later

29. A draft PIP states: 'Improve attitude and be more professional within four weeks.' What is the main problem?

(A) Four weeks is always too short for any PIP, whatever the role, so the plan must run for at least six months
(B) PIPs should never mention behaviour
(C) The PIP does not mention salary
(D) The targets are vague and cannot be measured fairly

30. A skilled machine operator who has been fully trained repeatedly removes a safety guard to work faster, despite warnings. How should this be handled?

(A) As a capability matter, arranging further safety training and closer supervision until the habit stops
(B) With a PIP focused on output
(C) As a conduct matter under the disciplinary procedure, after investigation
(D) By ignoring it if output targets are met

Reward — Compensation and Benefits

31. A private hospital pays all nursing roles at the market median. It cannot fill ICU nurse vacancies because competing hospitals pay ICU nurses about 20% more. What is the most appropriate reward response?

(A) Raise pay for every nursing role in the hospital by 20% so that no group of nurses feels treated differently from the ICU team
(B) Keep pay at the median and advertise the hospital's mission more strongly
(C) Offer ICU nurses a higher job title without changing their pay
(D) Pay a transparent market supplement for ICU nurses, reviewed each year

32. An officer earns BDT 42,500 a month. The midpoint of her pay range is BDT 50,000. What is her compa-ratio, and what does it suggest?

(A) 0.85: she is paid well below the midpoint
(B) 1.18: she is paid well above the midpoint for her grade
(C) 0.85: she is paid above the market rate
(D) 1.00: she is paid exactly at the midpoint of the range

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33. A grade has a market midpoint of BDT 90,000 and a planned range spread of 40%. What are the range minimum and maximum?

(A) BDT 75,000 and BDT 105,000
(B) BDT 54,000 and BDT 126,000
(C) BDT 72,000 and BDT 108,000
(D) BDT 81,000 and BDT 99,000

34. A job evaluation at an NGO places community health worker roles, held mostly by women, two grades below driver roles, held mostly by men. The scheme gives heavy weight to physical effort and none to caring or communication responsibilities. What should HR do?

(A) Review the factor plan for bias and re-evaluate the jobs
(B) Accept the results because the scheme was applied consistently to every job in the organisation
(C) Move the health workers up one grade without changing the scheme
(D) Replace job evaluation with whatever the market pays for each job

35. Under the company's merit matrix, a top performer whose pay is at a compa-ratio of 1.15 receives a smaller percentage increase than a top performer at 0.85. He complains this is unfair. What is the best explanation?

(A) The matrix rewards length of service rather than performance
(B) The matrix is designed to discourage people from staying in the same grade
(C) His pay is already high in the range, so increases move lower-paid strong performers towards the market rate faster
(D) Managers can choose any percentage, so the difference is a matter of opinion

36. A bank's field sales staff receive a bonus for each insurance policy sold. Complaints about policies sold to customers who did not understand them have tripled. What change to the incentive design is MOST important?

(A) Increase the bonus per policy so staff can afford to spend more time with each customer
(B) Add quality, compliance and customer-outcome conditions with clawback for misconduct
(C) Remove all incentives and pay only base salary
(D) Cap the number of policies each person can sell per month

37. In a technology firm, the mean hourly pay of men is BDT 1,000 and of women BDT 850. What is the mean gender pay gap?

(A) 15%
(B) 17.6%
(C) 8.5%
(D) 150%

38. An internal audit finds that one payroll officer can add new employees, change bank details and approve the monthly payroll alone. What is the main control weakness?

(A) Too few employees are on the payroll for an audit to be meaningful
(B) Payslips are not printed on paper
(C) Payroll is processed monthly rather than weekly
(D) Lack of segregation of duties

Relate — Employee Relations, Engagement, Law, Inclusion and Wellbeing

39. An IT company promised all graduate hires a funded professional certification in their first year. Budget cuts cancelled it without explanation, and engagement among graduates dropped sharply. What best explains the drop?

(A) A breach of the written employment contract that must go to court
(B) Central tendency in engagement survey ratings
(C) A perceived breach of the psychological contract
(D) The graduates' lack of resilience in a difficult market

40. An engagement survey at a university receives 250 responses: 100 promoters, 90 passives and 60 detractors. What is the eNPS?

(A) +40
(B) +16
(C) +4
(D) −24

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41. Last year's engagement survey at a textile mill produced detailed results, but nothing was shared or changed. This year's response rate fell from 78% to 39%. What should HR do before the next survey?

(A) Make the next survey compulsory for every employee so that the response rate returns to its previous level

(B) Share last year's results and act visibly on a few priorities

(C) Shorten the survey to five questions

(D) Offer a prize draw to everyone who responds

42. At a footwear factory, the participation committee has not met for eight months because managers say they are too busy. Workers have started raising complaints directly with buyers' auditors. What should HR do?

(A) Tell workers that complaints must not be raised with buyers' auditors under any circumstances

(B) Replace the committee with a suggestion box

(C) Ask supervisors to nominate the worker members of the committee

(D) Restart regular committee meetings with genuine worker representatives and follow-up on issues

43. A warehouse manager finds stock missing and wants to dismiss the suspected worker the same afternoon without speaking to him. What should HR advise?

(A) Dismiss him at once, since theft is gross misconduct and speed sends a strong message

(B) Investigate fairly, let the worker respond to the evidence, then decide; consider a short neutral suspension if needed

(C) Issue a final written warning without investigation

(D) Transfer him quietly to another site

44. A junior officer files a sexual harassment complaint against a senior director at a pharmaceutical company. The CEO suggests HR 'keep it small' because the director is key to a product launch. What should HR do?

(A) Arrange an informal apology from the director and close the matter quickly so the launch is not affected

(B) Wait until after the product launch to start the investigation

(C) Use the formal complaints process with an impartial investigator and protect the complainant

(D) Move the complainant to another department immediately

45. An HR officer at a manufacturer is unsure whether the company's maternity leave policy matches the current law, as she heard the rules may have changed. What should she do?

(A) Check the current official text and rules, and take legal advice if unclear

(B) Rely on what other HR managers say in an online professional group

(C) Keep the existing policy until an employee complains

(D) Copy the policy of a multinational company operating in another country

46. In a software company's support team, working past midnight has become normal, sick leave has doubled and two strong engineers resigned citing exhaustion. The company has already offered a wellness app. What should HR recommend?

(A) Upgrade the wellness app to the premium version and add evening yoga sessions for the support team

(B) Review workload, staffing and priorities with the team lead and agree limits on hours

(C) Hire replacements and keep the current working pattern

(D) Run a resilience workshop so staff cope better with pressure

Lead — Leadership, Motivation, Coaching, Change and Culture

47. An experienced accounts officer has learned a new reporting system and can use it well, but has become hesitant and keeps asking for reassurance after a mistake last month. Which leadership approach fits best?

(A) Directive: give step-by-step instructions and check every report closely until no further mistakes occur

(B) Delegating: leave her alone to recover

(C) Pacesetting: show her how quickly you can do it

(D) Supportive: involve her, encourage and build confidence

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48. A logistics firm offers drivers a large bonus for zero late deliveries. Drivers believe congestion makes the target impossible, so they ignore it. In expectancy terms, what is the problem?

(A) Low valence, because drivers do not value money
(B) Low instrumentality, because bonuses are never paid
(C) Low expectancy
(D) High relatedness

49. After a pay increase, staff in a government-linked research institute say they still feel demotivated: ideas are ignored and there is no recognition. According to two-factor theory, what should leaders focus on next?

(A) Further pay increases, because pay is the strongest motivator for professional staff in every type of organisation
(B) Motivators such as recognition, responsibility and growth
(C) Stricter attendance policies
(D) Better office furniture

50. In a coaching conversation, a team leader has described his goal and the current situation in detail. His manager wants to help him generate possibilities without giving advice. Which question fits best?

(A) "Why did you let the situation get this bad in the first place?"
(B) "Have you thought about asking HR to sort it out for you?"
(C) "When exactly will you do it?"
(D) "What could you try?"

51. A hospital trained every ward clerk on a new patient booking system. Two months later, many still use paper diaries because they 'don't see why the change matters'. Which part of individual change is missing?

(A) Awareness and desire
(B) Knowledge, so the clerks need another full round of system training
(C) Ability only
(D) Reinforcement only

52. During a restructure, staff repeatedly ask, 'What will happen to my job?' Leaders do not yet know the final structure. What is the best response?

(A) Say nothing until every detail is final so that no incorrect information is ever given to staff
(B) Promise that no jobs will be affected
(C) Tell staff to focus on their work and stop asking
(D) Share what is known and unknown honestly, with dates for the next update

53. At a chemical plant, near-miss reports fell by 70% after a supervisor publicly reprimanded a worker who reported his own error. Incidents have not fallen. What is the most likely explanation?

(A) Safety has improved so much that near misses no longer happen on any shift at the plant
(B) The reporting form is too long
(C) Psychological safety has dropped, so people are hiding near misses
(D) Workers have become more skilled

Analyse — HR Analytics, Technology and Responsible AI

54. A department starts the year with 400 employees and ends with 360. During the year 76 people left. What is the annual turnover rate?

(A) 19%
(B) 21.1%
(C) 10%
(D) 20%

55. An HR report shows annual turnover of 25% and retention of 88% for the same year. A director says the numbers contradict each other. What is the best explanation?

(A) Retention tracks starters' survival; turnover also counts new hires who left
(B) One of the two figures must contain a calculation error
(C) Retention always equals 100% minus turnover
(D) Turnover only counts involuntary leavers

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56. Analysis shows teams with flexible working have higher engagement. The CEO wants to roll flexible working out company-wide immediately, saying it 'causes' engagement. What should the analytics lead advise?

(A) Agree, because a strong correlation proves that flexible working causes higher engagement in every team

(B) Test it with a pilot and comparison group before claiming cause

(C) Reject flexible working because the data cannot be trusted

(D) Collect another year of data before doing anything

57. Four factory sites record exit reasons in free text, using different words for the same reasons. Leaders cannot compare why people leave across sites. Which fix is best?

(A) Ask each site to send a written summary of exit reasons every quarter so that leaders can read them together

(B) Stop recording exit reasons

(C) Introduce a standard list of exit reason codes used by all sites

(D) Use only the reasons from the largest site

58. During HRIS selection, one vendor gives an impressive demo of features the company did not ask for, but avoids showing its local payroll capability, which is a must-have. What should the selection team do?

(A) Choose the vendor with the most impressive demo, since local payroll can be customised later

(B) Drop local payroll from the requirements

(C) Require every vendor to demonstrate the same scripted scenarios, including local payroll, and score them

(D) Ask the vendor for a discount

59. Before launching an AI tool that shortlists applicants, HR runs a test on last year's applications. The tool would have advanced 45% of male and 27% of female applicants. What should HR do?

(A) Launch the tool, because a 27% pass rate for women is still quite reasonable for a competitive role

(B) Do not launch; investigate the impact ratio of 0.60 and the job relevance of the tool's criteria

(C) Launch it but stop collecting gender data

(D) Launch it and review the results after a year

60. An HR chatbot built on generative AI sometimes gives wrong answers about leave entitlements. Employees have started acting on them. What is the best response?

(A) Keep the chatbot as it is and add a note that employees use it at their own risk for all leave decisions

(B) Switch it off permanently and ban AI in HR

(C) Ask employees to check every answer with their manager

(D) Restrict answers to approved policies, add escalation to a person and monitor accuracy

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EXAM PREPARATION

Practice exam answers & explanations

1. A A people strategy starts from the capabilities and workforce implications of the business strategy. Training everyone, freezing hiring or copying other banks are actions that may follow, but only once the gaps are understood.

2. D Demand = 80 + 36 = 116. Supply = 80 − (80 × 0.15) = 68. Gap = 116 − 68 = 48. Thirty-six covers only the new outlets, 12 only the leavers, and 116 is total demand, not hiring need.

3. B Urgent, scarce skills favour buying, while a parallel build programme reduces future dependence. Building alone is too slow, permanent borrowing loses knowledge, and full automation of a safety-critical control room is unrealistic.

4. B Self-service and streamlined transactions free HR capacity for advisory work, which is the shared-services logic of the HR operating model. More officers keep HR stuck in transactions, refusing contact abandons managers, and outsourcing advice loses business knowledge.

5. D Grading and recruitment both depend on an accurate picture of the job. An old or borrowed description misleads candidates and evaluators, and budget alone is not a basis for grading.

6. D Many layers and very narrow spans slow decisions and add cost. Adding a layer worsens the problem, title changes do not alter structure, and email rules treat a symptom.

7. C Best practice provides a fair floor, while best fit tailors the bundle to the strategy. Wholesale copying ignores context, under-investing hurts reliability, and stock options alone do not fit a factory workforce.

8. B With 12% turnover, natural attrition over 18 months is about 36 people, so a hiring pause plus redeployment can absorb most of the surplus humanely. Early retrenchment is premature, waiting removes options, and forced transfers ignore fairness and law.

9. B An EVP must be built on evidence of why people join, stay and decline. Branding work, blanket pay rises or copying others may miss the real reasons and can over-promise.

10. A 6 ÷ (0.30 × 0.50 × 0.50) = 6 ÷ 0.075 = 80 applicants. The other figures leave out one or more conversion stages or apply them incorrectly.

11. A The evidence points to delay, so speeding up decisions addresses the cause. Pay rises may be unnecessary, extra rounds make delays worse, and ignoring decline reasons removes useful data.

12. A Structure, anchors and independent scoring raise reliability, validity and fairness. A single decider increases bias, longer unstructured interviews remain unstructured, and references alone predict poorly.

13. D Pass rates are 60% and 40%, so the ratio is 0.40 ÷ 0.60 ≈ 0.67, below the 0.80 rule of thumb. That calls for investigation, not automatic conclusions or arbitrary score changes.

14. D A work sample directly tests the skill the job needs and is seen as fair, while a short structured interview covers reliability and attitude. The other methods are poorly related to sewing performance or narrow the pool.

15. A A reasonable adjustment changes how the skill is assessed, not the standard. Removing or replacing the exercise loses evidence, and refusing may be unfair and unlawful.

16. C Undefined 'fit' invites affinity bias. The decision should follow recorded evidence and the agreed rule. Appointing both or adding an informal stage avoids the issue rather than resolving it.

17. C The comments point to weak clarity and connection, which structured onboarding and buddies address. Bonuses may delay exits without fixing causes, longer lectures add compliance only, and every new joiner needs support.

18. B Time to productivity directly shows whether onboarding helps people become effective faster. The other measures describe effort, not results.

19. A Calibration with evidence-based indicators reduces similar-to-me bias. Accepting ratings uncritically lets bias stand, removing potential loses useful information, and one person's choice adds a different bias.

20. C Bench strength is 30%. Prioritising the highest-risk roles gives the fastest protection. A broad course is unfocused, hiring 30 deputies is costly and slow, and postponing retirement is not a plan.

21. D A needs analysis checks whether training is the right solution. If the cause is pricing, stock or incentives, a course will not help. Self-ratings alone are a weak diagnostic.

22. C Incident reduction is a results-level question, so it needs business data and, ideally, a comparison group. Satisfaction, quiz scores and trainer opinions measure earlier levels or opinions.

23. C ROI = (3,000,000 − 1,200,000) ÷ 1,200,000 × 100 = 150%. The benefit-cost ratio would be 2.5, which is not the same as ROI.

24. A The conflict comes from misaligned goals, so shared goals fix the system. Penalising one side, removing goals or escalating every dispute leave the cause untouched.

25. B Regular check-ins with specific feedback remove surprises. Asking staff to cope ignores the cause, cancelling reviews removes a useful summary, and anonymous forms do not replace manager dialogue.

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26. B Calibration tests ratings against evidence and common standards. Arbitrary cuts are unfair to genuine high performers, accepting them risks leniency bias, and cancelling bonuses punishes the team.

27. C This is recency bias. Year-round evidence gives a fair view. Avoiding a rating or voting does not solve the bias.

28. A Diagnosing circumstances comes before formal action, and support often restores performance. A PIP or ignoring the issue would be unfair and may breach policy or law.

29. D Fair PIPs need specific, observable targets and stated support. Length depends on the role, behaviour can be addressed if it is described concretely, and salary is not required.

30. C He can follow the procedure but chooses not to, which is conduct, not capability. Safety breaches cannot be traded off against output.

31. D A targeted, transparent supplement addresses a specific market shortage while protecting affordability and internal equity. A blanket rise is costly, mission messaging alone will not close a 20% gap, and a title without pay does not compete.

32. A 42,500 ÷ 50,000 = 0.85, below the midpoint. Whether that is right depends on her competence and time in role, but it flags a possible under-payment to review.

33. A Minimum = 90,000 ÷ (1 + 0.40 ÷ 2) = 75,000; maximum = 75,000 × 1.40 = 105,000. The other pairs apply the spread incorrectly around the midpoint.

34. A Consistent application of a biased scheme still produces biased results. The factors must capture caring and communication demands. A one-off regrade hides the problem, and market pricing can import the same undervaluation.

35. C Merit matrices vary increases by position in range, controlling cost and correcting under-payment over time. They are not service-based or arbitrary. He may also be a candidate for promotion if his job has grown.

36. B The scheme rewards volume alone, which encourages mis-selling. Quality gates and clawback align pay with good outcomes. Bigger bonuses intensify the pressure, removing incentives may be unnecessary, and caps do not address quality.

37. A (1,000 – 850) ÷ 1,000 × 100 = 15%. Dividing by women's pay gives 17.6%, which is not the standard method.

38. D One person controlling changes and approval creates fraud and error risk, such as ghost employees. Separating duties is the key fix.

39. C Graduates believed the employer owed them development; breaking that unwritten promise without explanation damages trust. It may not be a written-contract breach, and it is not a rating error or a personal weakness.

40. B Promoters are 40% and detractors 24%, so eNPS = 40 – 24 = +16. Passives are counted in the total but not in the score.

41. B The fall reflects lost trust after no action. Visible follow-through rebuilds credibility. Compulsion, shorter surveys or prizes treat the symptom.

42. D A functioning committee gives workers a legitimate channel and may be a legal requirement. Blocking complaints, swapping in a box or management-picked members undermine genuine voice.

43. B Even for possible gross misconduct, fair procedure requires investigation and a chance to respond. Instant dismissal, warnings without evidence or quiet transfers are unfair and risky.

44. C Harassment complaints need prompt, impartial handling and protection from retaliation regardless of seniority. Informal closure, delay or moving the complainant against her wishes harm her and expose the company.

45. A Employment law changes through amendments and rules, so current official sources and qualified advice are the reliable reference. Informal opinions, waiting for complaints or copying foreign policies risk non-compliance.

46. B Burnout is mainly driven by work conditions; fixing workload addresses the cause. More apps, yoga or resilience training place the burden on individuals, and replacing people without change repeats the cycle.

47. D Capable but unsure people need support to rebuild confidence. Close direction undermines her competence, leaving her alone ignores her need, and pacesetting adds pressure.

48. C Drivers doubt that effort can achieve the target, which is expectancy. Nothing suggests they do not value money or distrust payment.

49. B Pay is a hygiene factor; once adequate, satisfaction comes from motivators. Policies and furniture are also hygiene factors.

50. D An open options question widens thinking. Blaming questions shut people down, the HR question is advice disguised as a question, and 'when' belongs to the Way forward stage.

51. A Training built knowledge, but clerks do not understand or accept the reason for the change. More training will not fix missing awareness and desire.

52. D Honest, regular communication reduces uncertainty and builds trust. Silence breeds rumours, false promises destroy credibility, and dismissing concerns increases resistance.

53. C Fewer reports with no fall in incidents suggests under-reporting after a punitive response. Leaders must restore safety to speak up.

54. D Average headcount = (400 + 360) ÷ 2 = 380; 76 ÷ 380 = 20%. Dividing by the start or end headcount gives a different, inconsistent figure.

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55. A Retention measures how many people present at the start are still there; turnover includes all leavers, including new joiners who left in the same year. Both can be correct.

56. B Other factors, such as manager quality or role type, may explain both. A pilot with a comparison group tests causation. Rejecting or waiting indefinitely wastes a promising insight.

57. C The problem is consistency. Standard codes make data comparable. Narrative summaries remain inconsistent, and dropping or narrowing data loses insight.

58. C Scripted demonstrations against weighted requirements keep the comparison fair and expose gaps in must-haves.

59. B 0.27 ÷ 0.45 = 0.60, well below 0.80. The tool needs investigation and correction before use, and candidates should be told when AI is used. Ignoring gender data hides the problem, and a year of live use would harm many applicants first.

60. D Grounding answers in approved content, providing human escalation and monitoring accuracy address the risk while keeping the benefit. A disclaimer shifts risk unfairly, and a ban or manual checks lose the value. Accuracy checks should be repeated whenever the policies or the underlying model change.

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NOTES

My notes

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